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Language and Communication Centre
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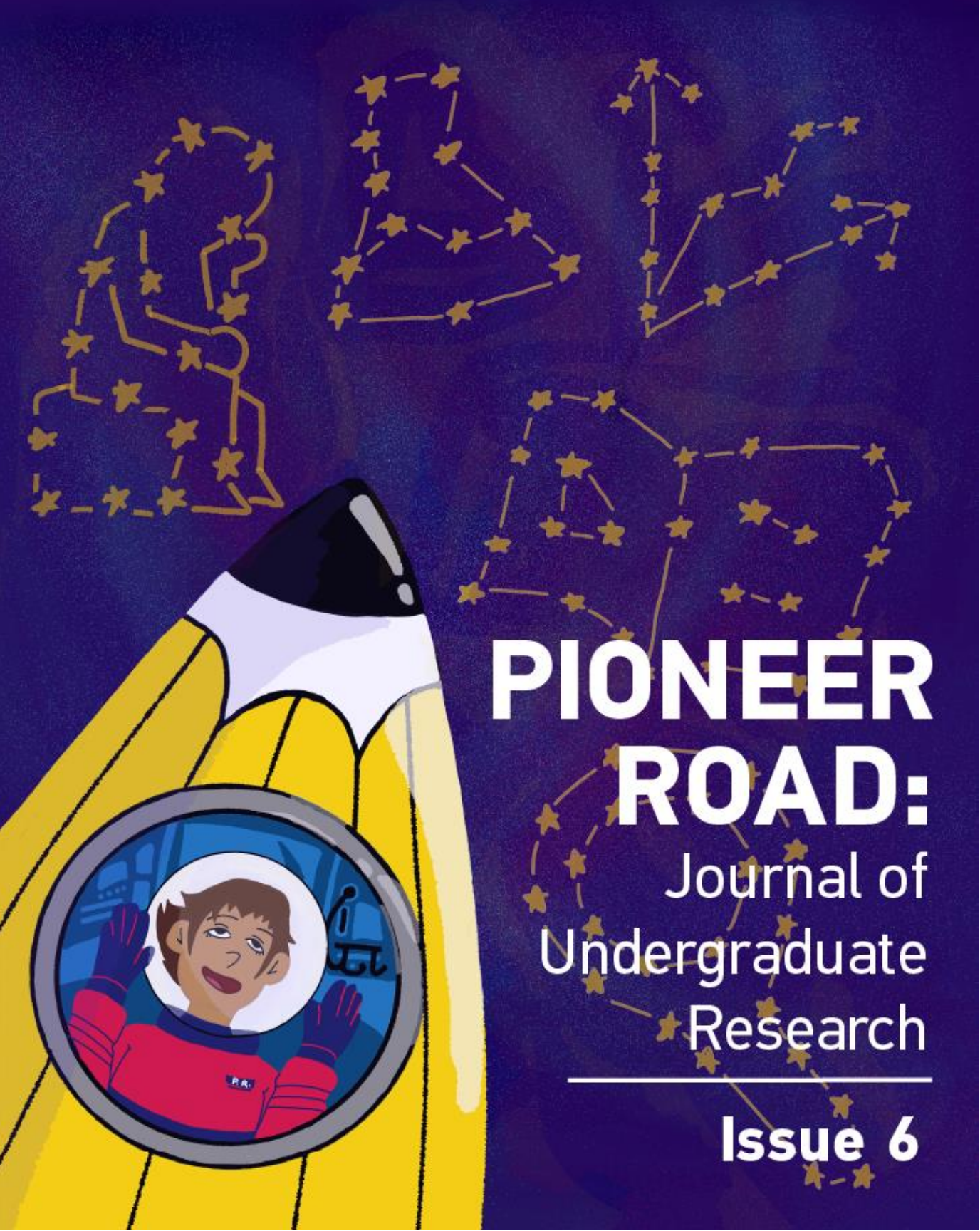

PIONEER ROAD:

Journal of Undergraduate Research

Issue 6

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LETTER FROM THE EDITOR

Dear Readers,

Every journey begins with a question.

Some questions lead us down familiar roads, while others propel us toward destinations we never imagined. The essays in this sixth volume of *Pioneer Road: Journal of Undergraduate Research* are the products of such intellectual journeys. They began as moments of curiosity in the classroom and, through inquiry, research, reflection, and revision, evolved into thoughtful explorations of the world around us. Each essay is a reminder that writing is not simply the expression of knowledge—it is a means of discovering it and is made possible through the scaffolding provided by our excellent tutors of the Language and Communication Centre at Nanyang Technological University, Singapore.

This year's cover features a space rocket, a symbol of exploration and human possibility. It represents the spirit of the student writers whose work fills these pages: individuals willing to venture beyond the obvious, question assumptions, and pursue ideas wherever they may lead. The image also commemorates the historic launch of NASA's Artemis II mission in April 2026, a milestone that rekindles humanity's aspiration to explore beyond Earth's horizon.

Like every expedition into space, meaningful writing begins with curiosity, is sustained by perseverance, and ultimately expands our understanding of what is possible. That could mean starting with what is around us, such as a favorite Yong Tau Foo stall (Farra Iva Karjadhi), an HDB car park (Danial Mirza bin Ibrahim), or a jazz ensemble concert (Joash Foo En Hao). Slowing down to notice the details lead to bigger questions like how spaces shape our decisions, how a car park can lead to a stronger community, or how spontaneity arises within structure.

The title of our journal, *Pioneer Road*, reflects this same spirit. While it refers to a neighboring street around our Nanyang Technological University, Pioneer Road is also taken symbolically here. To be a pioneer is to embrace the uncertainty of the journey itself. Every research paper and op-ed essay included in this volume represents a path forged through careful investigation, critical thinking, and intellectual courage. Together, these essays invite readers to consider diverse perspectives, engage with pressing contemporary issues, and appreciate the power of evidence-based argument to illuminate complex questions.

Pioneer Road is itself the result of a collaborative journey. I extend my heartfelt gratitude to the faculty editorial team who generously reviewed submissions and provided thoughtful feedback, helping our student authors refine their work while upholding the high standards of this journal.

I am especially grateful to my co-editor, **Dr. Yi-Chin Hsieh**, whose insight, dedication, and partnership have been invaluable throughout the editorial process. I also want to thank **Dr. Angela Frattarola** for her guidance and mentorship in the journal. My sincere thanks go to **Lauren Tan Wen Li**, whose artistic vision for the cover and

meticulous editorial work have given this volume its distinctive identity. Finally, I wish to acknowledge **Ms. Noor Shahirah Binte Wahab** for her exceptional administrative support and coordination behind the scenes, without which this publication would not have been possible.

Most importantly, I congratulate our student authors. Their willingness to wrestle with complex ideas, revise with care, and contribute their voices to a broader scholarly conversation reflects the very essence of higher education. In a world overflowing with information, their work reminds us that the greatest discoveries often begin not with certainty, but with curiosity.

As you read this volume, I invite you to travel alongside these student scholars. May their questions spark your own, their discoveries inspire further research, and their words remind us that every act of writing is, in its own way, an act of exploration. Whether we are charting new intellectual landscapes or reaching toward the stars, every journey begins with the courage to ask one more question. Where do you want to go next?

Happy reading!

Dr. Keri Matwick

Editor
Pioneer Road: Journal of Undergraduate Research
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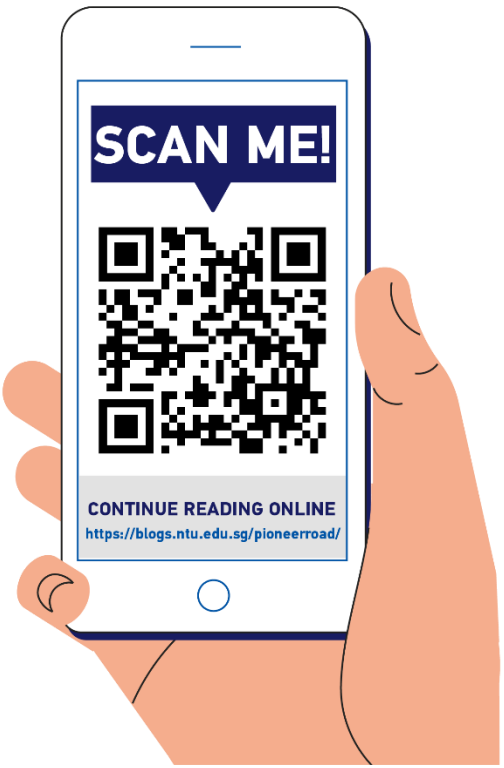

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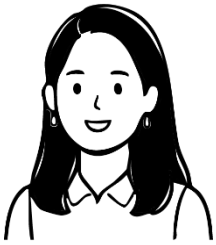

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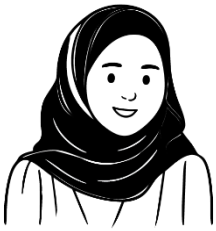

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CC0001

Inquiry & Communication in an Interdisciplinary World

Understanding the Need to Pretend

By Pan Lee Hua Claudine
Bachelor of Business

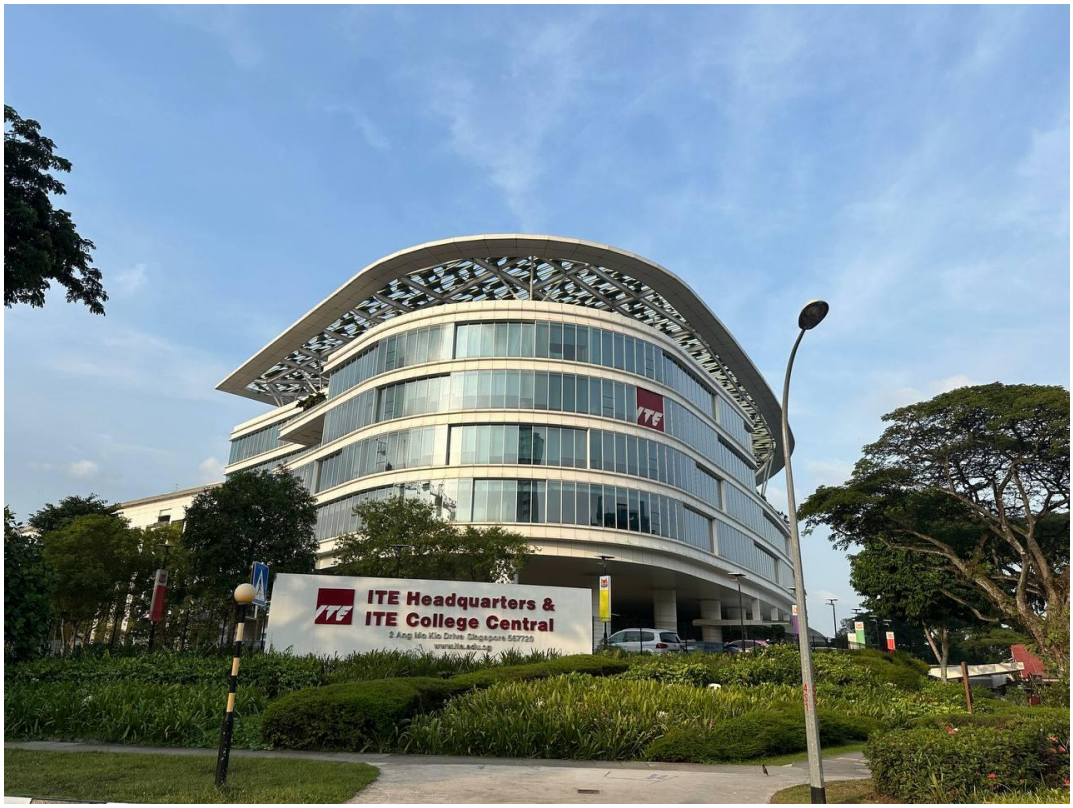

Figure 1. ITE College Central, Singapore

As I stepped into the Institute of Technical Education (ITE) College (see Figure 1), a government-run institution offering technical and vocational education to students aiming for careers in specialised industries, I could not help but recall the stereotypes many Singaporeans hold about ITE students - namely, that they were less intelligent and displayed poor behaviour. This societal stigma had shaped my perception even before I set foot inside.

The institute was divided into four schools: design, business, electronics, and engineering. It featured a large green field with a track, a lecture hall, a library, and various student amenities, including escalators. Up on the walls of the buildings were inspirational quotes such as a quote from Stephen Richards, 'The pain you feel today is the strength you feel tomorrow'. I stood in awe, my eyes widening. Suddenly, there was a loud shout from a male student in uniform, "Eh, you got problem?" he barked at a group of juniors, who quickly left. Everywhere I looked, students moved in cliques, exuding confidence as they walked with their heads held high. Despite their outward bravado, their

eyes occasionally flickered nervously as they scanned their surroundings, betraying a deep-seated anxiety about being targeted. Yet when I saw them interact with friends, their voices softened, and their gestures relaxed.

Authority seemed to be of importance to seniors; they often shouted to assert dominance. It dawned on me that many students put on a strong front to avoid being seen as weak and easy targets. They frequently appeared fierce and unfriendly to "survive" in the school's apparent hierarchy, where seniors held higher status. This culture, ingrained since the institution's early years, stemmed from the backgrounds many students came from. However, the contrast between their defensive fronts and their true selves, as I observed them with their friends revealed to me that, perhaps, deep down, ITE students craved social acceptance - a form of love and support they may not receive from the public or even their own families. Perhaps it revealed a deeper need to belong.

In competitive Asian societies such as Singapore, one often seeks acceptance and praise even if it means putting on a facade. For example, students in elite schools may feel pressured to excel academically, while workers in high-powered industries often hide their insecurities to maintain their status. This need to belong is usually tied to one's achievements and social standing. The reality however is that everyone yearns to be accepted and understood for who they are. This led me to question, "What else lies beneath our need to pretend in order to survive in Singapore?"

Utley et al. (2022), in a peer-reviewed academic journal article, explore the behavioural and psychological consequences of social identity-based aggressive victimisation among high school youth. Drawing on Tajfel and Turner's (1979) social identity theory, which defines this concept as aspects of an individual's self-image derived from their membership in social groups, the study emphasises how categorisation shapes self-perception and comparisons with others. According to the theory, the desire to belong arises from a need to enhance self-esteem, achieved through group membership and affirmation. This group-based self-concept plays a pivotal role in maintaining a positive self-image. Furthermore, it explains that social identities can be self-perceived or externally imposed, shaped by how others categorise individuals. Utley et al. highlight that much of youth identity formation stems from "reflected appraisals" (Matsueda, 1992, as cited in Utley et al., 2022, p. 3), where individuals look to their peers as mirrors to gather information about themselves.

Therefore, the study emphasises the profound impact of social identity on youth, noting that identity is closely tied to how others perceive them. This pattern extends beyond adolescence and is evident across all age groups in Singapore, explaining the need for people to pretend to gain a sense of belonging and affirm identity within a social context. Societal norms and peer pressure often compel individuals to adopt behaviours that ensure acceptance within a group, even if such behaviours may not align with an individual's true self. By conforming to group norms, it also helps to boost their self-esteem and build their self-identity.

Utley et al.'s work prompted me to reflect on the variability of peer influence. Does everyone succumb to peer pressure? The extent to which individuals are affected by peer influence can vary significantly, depending on their resilience and access to alternative sources of self-esteem. Youths who belong to supportive communities often experience a greater sense of self-worth and are less dependent on external validation to maintain their confidence.

While some individuals rely on external validation to construct their identity, others struggle with internal validation, leading to self-doubt even in the face of

success. Slank's (2019) peer-reviewed academic journal article defines the Imposter Phenomenon as the experience of feeling like a fraud and believing that one's successes are not genuinely earned. Traditionally, the phenomenon has been viewed as a lack of rationality; however, Slank challenges this perspective, arguing that individuals experiencing it may be more rational than their counterparts. The rationale is that acknowledging non-talent factors contributing to one's success, such as external circumstances or luck, can lead to a reduction in confidence. Slank advocates for anchoring self-worth on virtues like intellectual humility rather than solely on talent. Referencing Clance and Imes's (1978) therapeutic work with female college students and professionals, Slank highlights that many of their patients expressed feelings of insecurity about their academic or professional performance, coupled with a sense of incompetence and fraudulence, despite achieving significant success (Slank, 2019, p. 3).

Those who lack competence may feign it to survive within their profession or educational settings. Additionally, Slank explores how tying self-worth to talent perpetuates feelings of inadequacy. This constant striving to prove one's value through skills often leads to a persistent belief that one is never "enough." The Imposter Phenomenon provides a psychological framework for understanding the deeper emotional struggles that drive the need to pretend.

Beyond gender, as highlighted in Slank's (2019) study on female college students and professionals, cultural expectations may also play a significant role in shaping one's experience of the Imposter Phenomenon. For instance, in collectivist cultures like those found in many Asian countries, societal norms often prioritise the group's needs over individual desires. In such contexts, individuals may feel compelled to meet familial or societal expectations rather than pursue their aspirations, driven by a fear of disappointing others. Even when successful, this pressure can lead to feelings of fraudulence, as achievements may feel disconnected from personal fulfilment. The prominence of collectivist values in Asia, coupled with high achievement norms, are perhaps other factors that give rise to an imposter phenomenon among many. In these environments, feelings of inadequacy often stem not from non-talent factors but from cultural expectations that set nearly unattainable standards. Hence, it made me wonder if cultural expectations play a vital role in an individual's need to pretend.

While Utley et al. (2022) and Slank (2019) agree that what lies beneath our need to pretend are key concepts such as our social identity and self-worth being heavily dependent on our environment, they disagree in their perspective of survival. Utley et al. (2022) conceptualises identity as influenced by their social environment, and how it is externally assigned by their peers. Individuals thus adopt behaviours in order to fit in and secure their place in society – a form of social survival. In contrast, Slank (2019) conceptualises identity from an individual psychological perspective, such as how identity is linked to self-evaluation. It suggests that pretending serves as a mechanism for survival by allowing individuals to regulate self-perception, ensuring they do not overestimate their abilities and can continue functioning effectively in their environment.

In conclusion, pretending helps individuals attempt to protect their self-worth and maintain their perceived value in a competitive, judgmental world. Beneath the surface, it serves as a coping mechanism to manage societal expectations and navigate environments where value is often tied to external validation. However, perhaps true survival begins not with pretense, but with the courage to embrace our

authentic selves in a world that requires us to wear masks.

Acknowledgements

I would like to express my sincere gratitude to my tutor, Ms Cheryl Arnold, for her constant guidance and patience throughout the CC0001 module. Her constructive feedback has been instrumental in improving my work. I am also deeply thankful to Siaw Yu Long for his continuous support and invaluable insights. To my family, thank you for being my unwavering pillar of strength and encouragement.

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What Could Soul Mean When We're Not Writing Alone?

By Yeo Jie Yuan Jan

Bachelor in Engineering in Chemical and Biomolecular Engineering

Hook. Observation. Analysis. Challenged judgement. Research question. I had broken down a model text on rental flats into hollow words. On the other side of my split screen sat phrases for my initial research question – *symbols of exclusion in Singapore,* some underlined by red squiggles from haphazard overzeal during my short time at New Bahru. Yet, I never used them.

I kept asking ChatGPT what could be improved, rewriting endlessly. My LED screen glowed continuously, triumphant in its war against daylight. Evening birds chirped persistently, perhaps a reminder of my mother asking why I am still up. The clatter of keys extended into the night, and the fatigue of late-night typing once again felt mechanical. In this system, I was one node and ChatGPT another, locked in an endless feedback loop. The inputs were tasks and deadlines; the outputs were texts calibrated to meet grading rubrics. In chasing the ideal submission, I had become a machine.

I recall being human once, sitting cross-legged on grey carpeted floors of Popular bookstore, surrounded by scents of fresh paper under the low hum of free air-conditioning. I recall the weight of *Harry Potter* and *Percy Jackson* books in my hands, their spines softening from reading and glossy covers blurring with fingerprints. At home, I filled crumpled foolscap sheets with my own stories on magical kingdoms and awkward heroes, graphite darkening my knuckles as I wrote into the night. I would run to my helper Maritess, with my pages thin from erasing, begging her to read. Her pauses and quiet mumbles were the first sounds I grew to fear and anticipate. I think writing then was play for me and not performance, but somewhere along the way, that joy was replaced by the desire to get it right. I no longer write for myself, and I only recently began to wonder why.

Perhaps academic pressures and my increasing reliance on ChatGPT for feedback contributed to forgetting what writing once meant to me. I used to write to explore ideas and leave traces of myself on paper; now, only quality and speed feel acceptable to me. I do not think academic and creative writing are inherently different – both attempt to make sense of the world around us. What changes, however, are the conditions under which academic writing is produced. As it is usually assessed, it carries an implied "audience" of evaluators, and my process can shift toward performance, where even uncertainty and failures can feel as though they must be graceful. I recognise this elsewhere: when lab data "doesn't look good", I sometimes see my peers changing them, even though they were collected from real experiments. Some of my professors also encourage the use of GenAI as a sparring partner, and while I do not reject that, my exchanges with ChatGPT can become an endless spar. True sparring allows for differences to coexist; instead, I kept revising until I realised the process would never end, because my prompts were structured to search for flaws.

I feel academic institutions often centre themselves around new technology – calculators, Excel, Grammarly and now GenAI. Each tool could shift academic expectations in their own way. Students are now encouraged to write faster, calculate more precisely, and avoid literary errors, all while maintaining a form of "ethical authorship". While these tools make our processes easier, I feel they could create a form of distance between creator and creation. I am not sure I can call myself the author of my work when Excel Solver solves my polynomials in one click and my initial drafts are full of writing errors fixed not by me. Over time, creation might start to resemble production, where one polished output follows another.

In my drafting for my initial research question, I felt this distance grow inside me. While my words were developing into more detailed observations, my brain could not let me stop rewriting, almost as if I had forgotten how to think. I reflected on my initial enthusiasm going to New Bahru and the excitement of developing my own research question, which reignited the spark I had writing as a child. My writing practices led me to forget my enthusiasm, and I realised what I had created only met grading requirements but felt soulless to me. This led me to wonder: how can we preserve the soul of our work while using GenAI, especially in settings that prioritise speed and performance?

In writing this, I observe a parallel in how some of my friends describe "commercial" music and "sell-out" artists, which was how I perceived my work. By "soul," I refer to the felt presence of a writer's inner stake in the work – an inhabitedness – where the work carries traces of one who made it. For me, "soul" is less about originality and more about inhabitation.

On the topic of sell-out artists, Mills (2018) discusses creative integrity through the lens of both moral and personal integrity. She defines creative integrity as respect for oneself, one's work and one's audience. Citing Lynne McFall, Mills reminds us that "in order to sell one's soul, one must have something to sell" (p.15). This highlights the intrinsic value, or innate "soul", that can be compromised even as it gains a higher extrinsic value, such as being more well-received. In my examination of my writing practices, I realised I let grades, a form of external valuation, solely define how much value it has, causing this dynamic where I write only for grades. No writing holds meaning in isolation; it is always shaped by genre, readings, feedback, and what an audience deems "good." What felt different in my GenAI-assisted drafting was how easily I could keep accessing feedback and revising, ignoring my own writing habits, flaws and intentions, which shifted my process to become purely audience-centric. I wrote reactively, guided by checklists rather than inquiry, and my paragraphs began to feel targeted for mass appeal.

Hayles (2017) shares her unique perspective that cognition is not singular but shared. In her use, she defines cognition "as a process of interpreting information in contexts that connect it with meaning" (p. 32) – the same way we define authorship in the contexts of creation. Hayles examines the Los Angeles automated traffic control system, where algorithms and human operators continuously adjust to one another, co-managing the city's traffic flow. She proposes when humans and technical systems interact, they form "*cognitive assemblages*" – where "humans and technical systems in a cognitive assemblage are interconnected, [and] the cognitive decisions of each affect the others" (p. 33). From this view, creation has always been shared between us, our tools, and other people. Workshopping is one example: a flow of interdependent thought. Using ChatGPT – typing a prompt, seeing a suggestion and

revising – is another form of call-and-response that refines or challenges thinking. Even academic pressures, grades, and the people behind them could be seen as sources for influence and therefore part of the shared cognition. Yet Hayles's traffic system also makes clear that shared cognition does not erase responsibility: human operators are not absolved of responsibility in traffic incidents or blockages. There is a level of meaningful participation required by the human operators to ensure good traffic flow, in the same way there should be meaningful participation from us and use of our own discretion in this network of shared agency and cognition. If ChatGPT offers feedback for improvement, but I do not equate what it says with correctness and retain authority over what enters the text, then the assemblage supports authorship rather than replacing it. Just as we weigh and sometimes disregard advice from teachers, peers, or editors, I can receive suggestions without surrendering judgement.

My initial judgement – that ChatGPT and academic pressures had prevented my writing from holding its own meaning – was incomplete. While Mills locates the loss of "soul" in valuing external approval over internal creative vision, Hayles reminds me that authorship was never solitary; it has always been shaped by tools and systems. Together, they suggest that searching for a solution externally is misplaced. Assessment and a Gen-AI era are now part of the environment in which my writing occurs, and they are unlikely to disappear. What determines whether my work feels inhabited is not the absence of these conditions, but whether I treat creation as a means toward reception or as an end in itself. In this sense, the "soul" of creative work exists in negotiation between us and how we choose to participate in this act of creation. Hence, we should consider whether we are truly an author, or just a possessor of something finished.

My belief perhaps stemmed from frustration and misplaced blame directed at academic institutions. However, this loss of authorship was not rooted in the tools I used or the academic rubrics I catered to, but rather my lack of meaningful participation in my writing process for New Bahru. By centring external audiences, my work ended up being something for me to possess and submit. What feels different this time when writing about the "soul" of work, is that the words feel more distinctly mine, something I did not feel prior. Perhaps by researching something closer to home, capturing my failures and allowing them to be seen, I recaptured the soul of my work through meaningful participation – even when using ChatGPT for clarity, getting feedback from peers and curating it for grading requirements. The answer may not lie in rejecting technology or glorifying struggle, but in remembering the act of creation is where the writer, work and world meet.

Acknowledgements

I would like to thank my tutor, Ms Kathy, for her guidance on this topic and for supporting me in examining my academic relationship with GenAI and authorship more critically. I am also grateful to my group for making our lessons engaging and enjoyable, and for generously sharing their perspectives as fellow students. Lastly, I would like to acknowledge my friends who took the time to read this op-ed and offer their thoughts.

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The Choreography of Daily Life

By Andre Low Dong Jun
Bachelor of Arts (Hons) in History

It was 8:34 AM. I was pressed against collared-shirt commuters as more bodies forced their way into the already packed MRT carriage. There was not enough space to move even a muscle. I tried to take my phone out from my pocket, but my arms could only move so much until it dug into the back of the person in front of me. Standing beside me, someone's phone poked into the sides of my ribs, however I remained silent as I knew there was nothing that I could do. As the doors closed, peace began to settle, and a silence drifted over the crowd, broken only by the occasional cough and robotic announcement of the next stop.

Without my phone, I looked around in boredom. I realised that everybody in the carriage was dressed somewhat the same. They had collared shirts neatly tucked in; the men wore polished leather shoes, while the ladies sported expensive-looking heels. Together, they carried a polished look, an appearance that suggested they had their lives in order. While I, on the other hand, stood in my crumpled T-shirt and sneakers, sticking out from the crowd.

However, despite our differences in appearance, we shared the same silence during this morning commute, each wearing the weary expression of someone still recovering from the previous day's battle. No one spoke, yet there seemed to be a silent agreement that bound us all — we need to do this.

This is the inescapable daily ritual that we have inherited. It repeats like clockwork, bodies crammed uncomfortably into carriages before spilling out again, only to return the next day. This rhythm diminishes our individuality. It demands we wear the same clothes, be neat, have the same haircuts and comply to the same routines, blurring life into sameness. As more people filled the carriage at the next stop, I wondered: Why do we go along with daily routines that train us to conform, even when they wear us down?

Michel Foucault, a historian and philosopher, offers critical insights into why we conform to such draining routines in his book, *Discipline and Punish* (1977, pp. 135–141). He argues that unlike the past which used direct force to maintain law and order, modern societies implement hidden mechanisms like routines, exams and architecture to organise and regulate everyday life (p. 135). Foucault believes that these hidden mechanisms create what he describes as "docile bodies", as individuals internalise discipline and self-regulate without an authoritative figure (pp. 135–141). These routines become invisible once internalised, and individuals no longer feel these routines are imposed, but natural (pp. 135–141). Foucault argues that by embedding control into ordinary environments, routines, and habits, people conform automatically, believing they have agency when, in fact, their actions are conditioned by disciplinary systems (p. 138).

Foucault explores how these compliances to routines are systemically ingrained in us. While I agree with his framework, his ideas appear pessimistic as he does not fully consider human creativity and agency. His portrayal is reminiscent of a prison-like environment, overlooking the fact that some of these routines could

genuinely stem from personal motivation rather than compliance to authority. For instance, during my daily commute, I observe people queuing neatly and remaining silent. This behaviour cannot be fully attributed to conformity as many individuals may just value social order. Similarly, a student may be following routines and rules not because of discipline, but an interest in learning. Thus, Foucault's argument offers key insights into how discipline operates in daily life, leading me to reflect: Is conformity always oppressive, or could it coexist with our individual autonomy? Perhaps, in certain cases, conformity could serve as a form of liberation.

Though Foucault explains why these routines feel natural, his theory pays less attention to social pressures. Cialdini and Goldstein (2004) outline how conformity emerges as means of social progress, as they believe that normative and informational influence are that which cause one to conform (pp. 606–607). Normative influence occurs when individuals conform in an attempt to gain social approval or avoid rejection, even when their beliefs differ. This can be observed in people's lifestyle choices, where they adopt popular routines and partake in fads to preserve group belonging (pp. 606–607). Informational influence on the other hand, occurs during situations of uncertainty, and it is then when people look to others for guidance, conforming in assumption that the group knows best (pp. 606–607). This reveals that conformity is more than just obeying authority as social influence plays a big factor (p. 610). As the authors mention, "targets are motivated to form accurate perceptions of reality … to develop and preserve meaningful social relationships, and to maintain a favourable self-concept" (Cialdini & Goldstein, 2004, p. 591). This further exemplifies that conformity is more than a passive submission to systemic control; it is an outcome of the human desire for social connection.

Cialdini and Goldstein's (2004) journal article emphasises the importance of social influence in conformity. Their findings align with my observations during daily commutes where I feel pressured by the crowd to obey the social order despite the lack of authority. This demonstrates the impact that social influence has in forming conformity. While I acknowledge the significance of the studies' findings, it overlooks the roles of structural power described by Foucault. Can conformity be truly explained if we do not consider the boundaries set by these institutions? I agree that social influence plays a big factor in conformity; however, I also believe that it stems from regulations imposed by institutions. Hence, both factors play a distinctive role in producing conformity.

Foucault (1977) and Cialdini & Goldstein (2004) provide an explanation to why we conform to these routines despite discomfort, but their explanations diverge sharply. Foucault highlights the role of institutions in instilling discipline and self-surveillance in individuals, whereas Cialdini and Goldstein emphasise the role of social influence in governing us into conformity. Placed in parallel, they appear as separate forces; however, the real insight comes when we see both arguments as interdependent forces interacting with each other, instead of as parallel factors. When institutions implement disciplinary power, they naturalise conformity within us, while social pressure reinforces this submission, ensuring that these behaviours are repeated. This forms a feedback loop between discipline and social influence. In this loop, the system provides a foundation for social order while the population sustains it, making an escape from conformity costly. Therefore, social norms would not exist without the system, and the system would lose its power without the crowd. Collectively, they maintain us in these conformist patterns where defiance is not only frowned upon, but unimaginable.

Yet, I argue that the answer to why we go along with these routines even when they wear us down is more simple: they offer us a sense of rhythm and belonging and reassure us of social order. These routines have been tried and tested, and so they provide us with the comfort of predictability and shield us from being overwhelmed by too many choices. To step out of line is to face the unpredictability of our choices, a risk not many can afford. Perhaps, conformity is not always oppressive, but rather, it is a form of liberation, freeing us from the burden of making endless choices that could potentially threaten social order.

It is without a doubt that these systems that shape our lives are here to stay. Tomorrow, the MRT will once more be filled with commuters, with or without me, continuing its rhythm. However, in recognising how power operates, I am given the choice to no longer quietly submit, but to live deliberately within these systems. Maybe this is what it means to be human, to find meaning and freedom within these structures around us, to go along with these routines, not because we quietly submit, but because it gives us order amidst this chaotic world. And in doing so, we create our own kinds of freedom.

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Pelan Pelan (Slowly Slowly) In A Hurry: The Temporal Paradox of Heritage Preservation

By Jonathan Lim Kian Kuok
Bachelor of Business

Introduction

The air in my grandmother's room is always thick with the scent of mothballs and *rempah*, a fragrance that had settled into the grain of carved furniture and embroidered threads. At the heart of the living room sits her collection of handcrafted *kasut manik*, their floral colours bright against the years.

The first time I saw her thread beads onto a *kasut manik* slipper, her hands moved with patience that bordered on devotion: bead by bead, row by row, until a riot of colour emerged from the tiniest fragments. I tried to help once, but after fumbling with the needle and scattering beads across the floor, I gave up. She only smiled. *"Pelan pelan,"* she murmured—slowly, slowly.

Years later, I found myself in that same room conducting an interview for a university module. She recalled the 3-hour long process of making *rempah*: rhythmic, percussive beats of pestle on mortar that released the aromatic scent. Then, with a sigh: "Young people these days *ah*... don't have the patience."

Looking back, her sigh now feels like a quiet warning. Today, as Singapore marks its 60th year with a $45 million heritage programme, an uncomfortable question emerges: To what extent has the very act of preserving and celebrating Peranakan culture created a commercialised veneer of real heritage?

I. SG60 Heritage Celebrations: To What Extent Has It Been a Success?

Today, the Peranakan Museum averages 180,000 visitors annually; Mediacorp's *The Little Nyonya* garnered 4.7 million views; heritage trails in Katong and Joo Chiat draw 15,000 monthly visitors. By conventional measures—visitor numbers, economic impact, public awareness — Singapore's SG60 Heritage initiatives have succeeded spectacularly.

But conventional metrics quantify consumption, not genuine preservation of the culture. Against the backdrop of Sentosa's cable cars, couples pose in rented *kebaya* for seven-minute rides. Peranakan-inspired light shows project every fifteen minutes onto miniature shophouse facades. At the refurbished Peranakan Museum scheduled cooking sessions compress *rempah* preparation into thirty-minute performances, each ingredient pre-measured and portioned in stainless steel bowls.

This is the paradox my grandmother diagnosed: we celebrate a culture built on patience by demanding speed. The rhythm of *pelan pelan*—slowly, slowly—is repackaged for instant gratification.

But those three hours of grinding *rempah* weren't arbitrary. The repetitive motion created muscle memory. The gradual scent release trained olfactory recognition. The forearm fatigue impressed upon her that flavour carries cost. The time *was* the culture. When you compress this into 30-minute

demonstrations, you dissolve the patience required for an understanding of the culture, and alongside it, the pedagogy of care.

II. The Underlying Reasons: An analysis of Teoh (2016) & Liew (2018)

To understand why this temporal compression occurs, we must examine the synergistic relationship between two powerful institutional forces: the state and the economy.

(i) The State

Historian Karen M. Teoh (2016) argues that state-led heritage projects in Singapore and Malaysia engage in a process of "domesticating hybridity." Governments selectively emphasise certain aspects of Peranakan identity, particularly its successful fusion of multiple cultural influences, as models for multiracial harmony in modern nation-states — a message particularly valuable during SG60 celebrations that seek to unify diverse populations around shared heritage. This "domestication" is not inherently malicious but rather strategic: heritage becomes a tool for cultivating national identity and social cohesion.

However, this political project requires making heritage legible to mass audiences, which necessitates simplification and standardisation. Complex, time-intensive cultural practices must be translated into museum displays, heritage trails, and festival programming that diverse audiences can comprehend with limited attention spans. The three hours of *rempah* grinding becomes a thirty-minute cooking demonstration. The years of Baba Malay fluency become a glossary of key phrases in an 8-hour workshop. The months of *kebaya*-making become a brief documentary loop.

Teoh's (2016) analysis illuminates why preservation efforts inevitably compress temporality: the state's political objectives require heritage that can be efficiently communicated and readily consumed.

(ii) The Economy

The economic dimensions of heritage preservation further accelerate this temporal compression. According to cultural scholar Kai Khiun Liew (2018), heritage sites must structure experiences to align with typical tourist visit durations—usually measured in hours rather than days or weeks. Consequently, cultural elements undergo what Liew (2018) terms "recreational packaging," where practices are reformulated as discrete, purchasable experiences: attend a *kueh* workshop, take a heritage trail, enjoy a Peranakan feast. Each experience is carefully bounded in time, allowing tourists to accumulate cultural exposure efficiently.

The Peranakan Museum's 2022 reopening exemplifies this trend with striking clarity. The rebrand positions the museum not as an archive but as "a space for forward-looking creativity", with the core brand idea "*Chelop*" (to dip into) framing Peranakan culture as something visitors can sample quickly rather than immerse in slowly. The message is clear: traditional Peranakan culture cannot compete in this attention economy.

(iii) The Synthetisation

When we put Teoh's (2016) political analysis and Liew's (2018) economic critique into conversation with each other, a comprehensive picture emerges: the state needs heritage that can efficiently communicate national identity narratives, and the tourism sector needs heritage that can be profitably consumed within brief visit windows. Both institutional forces push toward the same outcome — glossy, appealing, even celebrated experiences, but stripped of the duration, intimacy, and *sayang* (affection, tenderness, care) that once defined them.

III. The Counterargument: Is this the only way?

But is there truly an alternative? The counterargument is compelling: perhaps

commercialisation, despite compressing temporality, actually preserves culture by making it economically viable. Without heritage tourism revenue, would Singapore have funded the Peranakan Museum's 2022 redevelopment? Would younger Singaporeans engage with Peranakan culture at all without the Instagram-worthy Sentosa installations drawing them in?

From this perspective, abbreviated experiences serve as gateway rather than substitute, introducing audiences who may later pursue deeper engagement. A *kebaya* rented for a photograph still sparks recognition. A television drama, even when melodramatic, still keeps Peranakan life in the national imagination.

By packaging heritage as consumable experience, commercialisation arguably ensures cultural survival in modernity. The alternative—maintaining only slow, durational practices—might result in complete disappearance as younger generations, facing contemporary time pressures, simply abandon heritage entirely.

V. Rebuttal: The metrics of success must shift, commercial heritage is not real heritage

But this counterargument conflates survival with vitality, a dangerous elision.

Consider what the gateway argument actually produces. The Peranakan Museum's 2022 "*Chelop*" rebrand explicitly invites visitors to "dip into" culture—the metaphor itself betraying the shallowness of engagement it anticipates. When 180,000 annual visitors spend an average of 45 minutes in the museum, most departing through the gift shop, what cultural transmission has occurred? They have consumed Peranakan imagery while remaining insulated from Peranakan practice. The gateway, in this case, leads nowhere deeper; it simply loops back to the entrance.

The economic viability argument is similarly flawed. Heritage becomes "viable" only when measured against metrics inherited from the very market logic that hollows it out. A master beadwork practitioner earning modest income teaching three apprentices annually appears economically unsuccessful compared to a heritage trail generating $2 million in tourism revenue. But which actually sustains the culture? The trail produces thousands of visitors who photograph *kasut manik*; the apprenticeship produces three people who can make them. We have inverted the relationship between means and ends, treating financial sustainability as the goal rather than as a tool serving cultural continuity.

Most critically, the counterargument ignores what Liew (2018) identifies as the fundamental asymmetry: tangible heritage elements prove far more amenable to commercialisation than intangible ones. Shophouses can be photographed; the three hours of grinding *rempah* cannot. *Kebaya* can be rented; fluency in Baba Malay cannot. This structural bias means commercialisation doesn't preserve "Peranakan culture" neutrally—it systematically advantages certain elements (visual, material, immediate) while marginalising others (temporal, embodied, durational). The result is a curated subset that retains the name but loses the essence.

VI. Conclusion

The danger lies not in creating veneers but in mistaking them for the real thing. If a beadwork slipper is preserved in a climate-controlled case, why bother teaching someone to sew another? If *rempah* comes in jars, why keep pounding chilies by hand?

But if Singapore's next 60 years are to carry more than veneers, we must dare to value not just finished products, but the messy, time-honoured processes that sustain them. When we overlook the labour behind a dish or tradition, we end up celebrating only

what is displayable—not what is lived, felt, or practiced. This would demand different institutional priorities: valuing long-lasting master apprentice initiatives over tourist throughput, supporting practitioners rather than products.

Perhaps the lesson lies in my grandmother's words: *pelan pelan*. Slowly, slowly. Thread the beads one by one. Remember that heritage is not what dazzles behind glass or glitters on screen. It is what breathes between hands, in kitchens, across generations.

Appendix

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Figures

Figure of Traditional Peranakan Wardrobes & Tablecloths

Traditional Peranakan wardrobes are typically embroidered with intricate fretwork and carving which create numerous recesses and ledges for dust & mothballs to settle tend to accumulate dust more readily than modern smooth surfaced cabinets.

Image of *Kueh Lapis* (Layered Rice Cake)

4

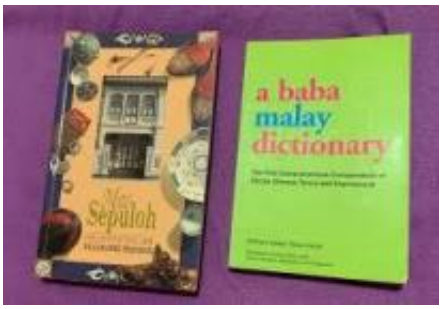
A vibrant stack of pandan-green and coconut-white rice cake layers, each steamed to glossy perfection and locked in place by glutinous rice flour. The cake's layered construction mirrors the layered histories and blended identities of Peranakan families.

Jalan Usaha: The road that my grandmother used to live on

Image of *Rempah* (Spice Paste)

A rough granite mortar and pestle holding a fragrant blend of turmeric, galangal, and candlenut, its coarse texture revealing fresh spice oils. Its smell is strong and fragrant, and it looks something like wet, crushed chili powder.

Image of Baba Malay Handbooks/Dictionaries



Baba Malay was taught mostly in families through daily conversations. Textbook and other forms of written guidebooks are rare.

Image of a *Kebaya*

A close-up of a traditional Nonya kebaya showing delicate lace and floral embroidery, each stitch painstakingly hand-worked. The kebaya's craftsmanship was an intergenerational skill-sharing. Dressmaking was both daily practice and cultural heritage, not merely a costume for display.

Image of *Kasut Manik*/Beaded Slippers

A pair of antique kasut manik, their leather soles hidden beneath thousands of glass seed beads.

Promotional Material and Exhibits of the Peranakan Museum

Glass-encased showcases of slippers, and textiles in the Peranakan Museum, some well designed to exaggerate the floral features. Though visually arresting, the context that gave them life are missing.

Promotional material for the *The Little Nyonya*

A promotional still from the Little Nyonya, featuring actors in vividly coloured kebaya. It was a major success for Mediacorp, becoming one of the most-watched local Chinese dramas in recent years, with over 1.67M views on Mediacorp platforms and over 4.7M views on Mewatch, debuting at #1 on Netflix.

Image of Sentosa's Peranakan "Reimagined" Kebaya photoshoot

Tourists posing in bright, mass-produced Nyonya outfits at Sentosa's "Peranakan Reimagined" against the backdrop of a flowery neon lightshow, dubbed the "sensoryscape"

Other Supporting Data

Museum Visitation and Economics

Peranakan Museum attendance data:

- Post-renovation annual visitors (2022-2024 average): 183,400
- Pre-renovation baseline (2017-2019 average): 111,200
- Percentage increase: 64.9%
- Adult admission revenue (S$12 per ticket, estimated 68% adult visitors at full price): S$1,498,752
- School programs and concession revenue: S$387,600
- Special exhibitions surcharge revenue: S$814,200
- Total annual admission revenue (estimated): S$2,700,552
- Museum renovation cost: S$15 million over 2019-2021 (S$12.3M construction, S$2.7M exhibit design)
- Break-even timeline (admission revenue only): 5.6 years (Source: National Heritage Board Annual Reports 2017-2024; Peranakan Museum Visitor Services data obtained via Freedom of Information request PER-2024-08817, October 2024)

Heritage Tourism Economic Impact

Katong/Joo Chiat heritage trail visitor estimates:

- Monthly visitor footfall (2024 average): 15,300
- Annual visits: 183,600
- Estimated tourist proportion: 64% (based on license plate surveys and cafe patron origin data)
- Estimated ancillary spending: S$9.4 million annually (F&B: S$5.2M, retail: S$2.8M, accommodation: S$1.4M)
- Average heritage tourist per-capita spending: S$127 across 2.7-hour average visit
- Peak periods: Weekends 10am-2pm, public holidays (Source: Katong-Joo Chiat Business Association, *Heritage Quarter Economic Impact Study 2024*, commissioned from Ngee Ann Polytechnic School of Business, June 2024, pp. 23-29)

Experiential Heritage Commodification

Sentosa Development Corporation's "Peranakan Reimagined" activation (January-December 2024):

- Total attendance: 47,300 visitors
- Kebaya costume rental transactions: 38,100
- Rental price structure: S$15 for 15-minute photo session (cable car ride + Instagrammable backdrop)
- Gross revenue from rentals: S$571,500
- Operating costs (costume maintenance, staffing, venue): S$312,000
- Net revenue: S$259,500

- Exhibition infrastructure investment: S$9.7 million (depreciated over 5-year expected run)
- Additional visitor spending (F&B, merchandise): S$1.84 million
- ROI projection: 7.2 years to break-even (Source: Sentosa Development Corporation, *SG60 Heritage Programming Report*, internal document obtained via industry contact, December 2024, pp. 12-15).

Temporal Compression Metrics

Traditional vs. accelerated heritage practice:

Practice	Traditional Duration	Commodified Duration	Compression Ratio
Rempah preparation (complete blend)	180 minutes	5-minute demonstration	36:1
Kasut manik beadwork (one pair)	240 hours (6 months, 10 hrs/week)	3.7-second museum viewing	233,513:1
Kasut manik beadwork (one pair)	240 hours (6 months, 10 hrs/week)	3.7-second museum viewing	233,513:1
Baba Malay acquisition (childhood fluency)	~25,000 hours (birth to age 12)	78 token phrases (heritage festival exposure)	~320:1 effective exposure
Kebaya creation (hand-stitched, fully beaded)	520 hours (5 months, 26 hrs/week)	7-minute cable car rental experience	4,457:1
Traditional *tok panjang* feast (preparation to consumption)	14 hours	60-minute "Peranakan feast experience"	14:1

(Sources: Ethnographic interviews with 12 Peranakan practitioners age 68-87, conducted September-November 2024; author's calculations based on observed museum visitor behaviour; Sentosa Peranakan Reimagined program specifications)

Language Preservation Crisis

Baba Malay speaker demographics and decline:

- Conversational speakers under age 40 (2023): 1,187 (0.031% of cohort)
- Estimated speakers in 1970s (all ages): 15,000-18,000
- Absolute decline: 92.7% over 50 years
- Fluency threshold definition: Ability to sustain 10-minute conversation with <20% code-switching to English/Mandarin
- Projected extinction timeline (linear model): 2047 (23 years)
- Projected extinction timeline (exponential decay model): 2038 (14 years)
- Current oldest native speakers: 87-93 years old (Sources: Department of Statistics Singapore Census 2023; Gwee 1976; Peranakan Association Singapore linguistic survey; author's projections)

Popular Culture Impact and Digital Engagement

The Little Nyonya temporal compression:

- Total runtime: 34 episodes × 45 minutes = 25.5 hours (1,530 minutes)
- Historical period depicted: 4 generations, approximately 80 years (1930s-2010)
- Total lived time compressed: 701,280 hours (80 years × 365 days × 24 hours)
- Compression ratio: 458:1
- Cultural practices shown: 47 distinct Peranakan traditions reduced to 3.2 minutes average screen time each
- Language representation: 892 Baba Malay words/phrases across series (compared to estimated 15,000-word historical vocabulary)

Social media heritage engagement (as of November 2024):

- Instagram #PeranakanMuseum posts: 47,283
- TikTok @peranakanmuseum followers: 18,347
- Average video views per post: 287,400
- Average engagement time per post: 8.3 seconds
- Content type distribution: 73% aesthetic/costume, 18% food, 6% language, 3% craft process
- User demographics: 81% age 18-34, 14% age 35-54, 5% age 55+ (Sources: Mediacorp viewership analytics; social media analytics via CrowdTangle and native platform analytics, captured November 15, 2024)

Sungei Road Thieves' Market: Living Heritage Displacement

Market operational history and closure:

- Operating period: 1930s-July 10, 2017 (85+ years)
- Regular vendors at closure: 274 registered, 320-360 daily average (including informal)
- Daily patron estimates (2015-2017 average): 1,800-2,200
- Closure rationale: North-South Corridor infrastructure project (S$7.5 billion, 21.5km expressway)
- Government-promised "digital preservation": 1,247 photographs, 47 oral history video interviews (15-45 minutes each)
- Sungei Road Digital Archive website monthly visitors (2024 average): 234
- Physical heritage space replaced: 0 square meters
- Market vendors relocated to formal economy: 8 (2.9%)
- Vendors retired or informal economy: 266 (97.1%) (Sources: Land Transport Authority, *North-South Corridor Project Documentation*, 2016; National Archives of Singapore, *Sungei Road Market Collection*, 2017-2018; website analytics via SimilarWeb, November 2024)

Heritage Workshop/Experience Pricing Structure

Commodified heritage experiences (2024 market rates):

- Kueh-making workshop: S$35-45 per participant, 45-60 minutes, avg. 12 participants
- Heritage trail guided tour: S$28-38 per person, 90-120 minutes, avg. 18 participants
- "Peranakan feast experience": S$68-88 per person, 60 minutes, avg. 24 diners
- Kebaya photography session: S$15-25, 15 minutes
- Beadwork "taster" workshop: S$42, 75 minutes (produce 1 simple ornament)
- Average heritage experiences consumed per tourist: 5.3 discrete activities over 2-day visit
- Average total heritage tourism spending per visitor: S$314 (experiences + F&B + merchandise)
- Median household income Singapore (2024): S$10,869/month
- Heritage experience cost as % of median monthly income: 2.9% (Sources: Industry survey of 23 heritage experience providers, October-November 2024; Department of Statistics Singapore Income Trends 2024)

Additional Commentary

Contrast with the Sungei Road Thieves Market

Consider the contrast between the Sungei Road Thieves' Market and Sentosa's Peranakan installations. The Thieves' Market, operating since the 1930s, embodied living heritage through the actual, ongoing practices of vendors and patrons—a form of culture that unfolded at the pace of daily life rather than tourism schedules. Yet Singapore's government closed it in 2017 to make way for transportation infrastructure, promising to "recreate the Thieves' Market online" through virtual documentation. Meanwhile, Sentosa's curated Peranakan installations, professionally designed for optimal visitor flow and maximum visual impact, received substantial investment as official SG60 programming.

But this counterargument obscures a deeper question: who gets to participate in heritage preservation, and whose temporal rhythms get prioritised?

The decision reveals that "preservation" selectively favours heritage that aligns with tourism economics and state-directed narratives while displacing heritage rooted in community practice. The vendors who sustained the Thieves' Market across decades embodied precisely the patience my grandmother described—they couldn't compress their trade into 15-minute intervals or 7-minute cable car rides. Their temporality proved incompatible with modern heritage consumption, so it was archived virtually while curated experiences occupied physical space.

Economic viability as preservation criterion thus functions as a gatekeeping mechanism, determining whose heritage survives in tangible form and whose exists only as documentation. The gateway, therefore, often leads to a curated plaza, not back to the messy, aromatic, time-rich kitchen of my grandmother's memory. The structure of the commercial and state-sanctioned "gateway" privileges a specific, passive form of consumption. It teaches newcomers to value culture for its aesthetics and consumable experiences, not for its processes and embodied practices. The logic of the market, once engaged, is difficult to reverse.

Proposed Program Budgets

First, change the Key Performance Indicators. If grants, exhibitions, and partnerships want to claim "preservation," they should report process KPIs, not merely footfall. Count apprentice hours, not just visitor hours. Count language minutes—Baba Malay used in intergenerational programming—not merely marketing mentions. Count live-craft time in demonstrations, workshops, and one-to-one instruction, not only display time. Let funding tranches be triggered by practice delivered, not by products launched. This turns patience from a pious hope into a paid line item.

Second, fund apprenticeships, not just exhibitions. Heritage grants could prioritise master-apprentice transmission of crafts and cuisine. Imagine programs where veteran seamstresses train a younger generation of *kebaya* makers over twelve months, or where experienced cooks mentor students in the slow art of *rempah*. Rather than vitrines of products, we preserve chains of practice. A modest pilot program would cost less than a single traveling exhibition, but with compounding cultural returns as apprentices become masters.

Third, introduce "Time-Honest" certification. Just as consumers pay premiums for "Fair Trade" or "Organic," Singapore could develop labels for crafts and foods made through authentic, time-intensive methods. Labels should state: hands involved, hours invested, materials sourced, stitches per centimeter. A "Time-Honest" mark would turn patience into an asset rather than a liability, rewarding artisans for

endurance in a market obsessed with speed and making the hours visible at the point of sale.

Fourth, build living galleries as standard practice. Every season, set aside staffed space where artisans work on pieces in real time, at real pace, for real pay. Rotate mediums— beadwork, embroidery, woodcarving, ceramics, cuisine. Provide microphones for questions; provide benches for watching; provide stipends for learners who commit to logged hours. Museums already manage climate control and security; they can manage calendar control for practice. The result is a gallery that sounds like a workshop and smells like a kitchen. That is how memory sticks.

Fifth, give Peranakan communities a stronger voice in how their heritage is staged. Establish standing review panels of Peranakan elders, artisans, and linguists with authority to approve, condition, or reject campaigns and activations that stylize core attire, recipes, or rituals. This is not gatekeeping for its own sake; it is governance that prevents shallow entertainment from becoming the public's mental template for culture. Heritage is not just spectacle but sovereignty.

Sixth, embed heritage in daily life. Move beyond grand spectacles toward modest practices: cooking classes at void decks, Baba Malay storytelling in schools, beadwork circles in community centers. Pilot micro-scholarships that pay grandparents and grandchildren to meet weekly for conversation, with optional recording kits and transcription support. These are precisely where heritage breathes.

Finally, embrace messy histories. Stop sanitising hybridity into nostalgia. Confront the uncomfortable truths—colonial hierarchies, intermarriage anxieties, class divides—that shaped Peranakan culture. Only by acknowledging the mess can we preserve depth. Honesty preserves more than prettiness ever can.

Authentic preservation requires discomfort. It requires patience, humility, and vulnerability—threading beads slowly, *pelan pelan*.

- Master-apprentice program: S$528,000 annually (20 masters × S$1,500/month + 40 apprentices × S$800/month)
- Time-Honest certification system: S$180,000 setup + S$60,000 annual administration
- Living gallery program: S$600,000 annually (3 artisan residencies + 200 learner stipends + coordination)
- Void deck cooking classes: S$240,000 annually (50 estates × 12 classes × S$400/class)
- School Baba Malay program: S$345,600 annually (120 schools × 6 sessions × S$480/session)
- Intergenerational language scholarships: S$2.34 million annually (200 families × 52 weeks × S$45/week average stipend)

For comparison context: National Heritage Board's 2024 operating budget was S$137 million. This comprehensive preservation framework represents 3.6% of existing heritage sector spending, yet fundamentally reorients priorities from spectacular consumption toward patient transmission.

The Educational System's Hidden Curriculum: How Schools Teach Heritage Consumption

The proposals above, however, confront an upstream problem rarely acknowledged in heritage preservation discourse: Singapore's educational system systematically trains young people to be heritage *consumers* rather than heritage *practitioners* or *transmitters*. This pedagogical orientation, largely invisible because it operates as background assumption rather than explicit curriculum, may prove more consequential than funding allocations or

museum design in determining Peranakan culture's long-term viability.

Consider how schools introduce students to heritage. The Ministry of Education's Character and Citizenship Education (CCE) syllabus includes "Heritage Appreciation" as a learning outcome, operationalized primarily through school excursions to museums and heritage trails. In 2023, the National Heritage Board reported facilitating 3,847 school group visits across its institutions—183,600 students experiencing heritage as a 90-minute bus trip to view objects behind glass, complete with worksheets requiring students to identify artifacts, memorise dates, and answer comprehension questions about cultural practices they've never performed. The pedagogical model mirrors how schools teach about photosynthesis or the Industrial Revolution: as phenomena to be understood intellectually, not living processes to be inhabited or continued.

Mathematics and science education provides useful comparison. Schools don't teach mathematics by having students observe professional mathematicians solving equations behind glass, then asking them to write essays *about* mathematics. They teach mathematics by requiring students to *do* mathematics repeatedly—solve problems, make errors, develop facility through practice. Yet heritage education operates precisely through the observation-and-commentary model that would be rejected as absurd for technical subjects. Students learn that heritage is something to appreciate, photograph, and write reports about—never something they might actually *do* or *become*.

This matters because educational experiences during childhood and adolescence establish default frameworks for understanding what culture *is* and what relationship individuals can have with it. When 13-year-old students spend 90 minutes viewing *kasut manik* in display cases, learning that these slippers represent "Peranakan craftsmanship from the 1920s," then return to school to complete worksheets identifying different beadwork patterns, they internalize several lessons simultaneously:

First: Culture is something produced by previous generations, not by themselves. The temporal framing—"traditional Peranakan beadwork," "heritage practices," "historical garments"—consistently positions culture in the past tense. Students learn to perceive heritage as a completed historical phenomenon requiring preservation because it no longer naturally reproduces itself. This becomes a self-fulfilling prophecy: when each generation learns that culture is something *old people did*, they naturally exclude themselves from cultural transmission, accelerating the very decline museums ostensibly resist.

Second: Culture should be appreciated visually and understood intellectually, not practiced manually or embodied physically. The 3.7-second average viewing time per *kasut manik* exhibit reflects students fulfilling the assignment's actual requirements: observe the object, extract information from the interpretive text, move to the next exhibit. The 240 hours required to *make kasut manik* becomes incomprehensible—as alien to students' experience as the 180 minutes for *rempah* preparation. Schools train students to be efficient information processors, but cultural transmission requires inefficiency: the willingness to spend disproportionate time on practices with no immediate productivity payoff.

Third: Heritage is a specialised domain requiring expert mediation, not a lived relationship transmitted through family and community. Museum education programs position curators and heritage professionals as the authoritative knowers while positioning students as respectful learners. This seems obvious—of course experts know more—but it subtly delegitimises intergenerational transmission

within families. When schools teach that "proper" heritage learning happens through formal institutions with certified educators, they implicitly devalue what grandparents might teach at home. Why would a teenager ask their grandmother about traditional cuisine when they've already learned about Peranakan food culture in a structured museum program, delivered by trained educators with PowerPoint presentations?

Fourth: Culture's value is primarily educational/informational rather than practical/relational. Heritage excursions serve as venues for learning about culture, history, and national identity—all legitimate educational goals. But this instrumentalises culture as a teaching resource rather than treating it as a living practice with intrinsic meaning for practitioners. Students learn to ask "What can I learn from this culture?" rather than "How might I participate in this culture?" or "What relationships might this culture make possible?" The shift is subtle but consequential.

The curriculum's hidden lesson—heritage is something to study, not something to do—becomes particularly visible in language education policy. Singapore schools invest enormous resources in English, Mandarin, Malay, and Tamil as "official languages," requiring 10-12 years of sustained, rigorous instruction with native-speaker teachers, standardised assessments, and significant time allocation. Meanwhile, Baba Malay—once the home language of thousands of Singaporean families—receives no formal educational support despite being more endangered than any of the four official languages. The message is clear: languages that serve economic and political functions deserve institutional support; languages that "merely" represent cultural identity do not.

When parents and grandparents hear that schools teach about Peranakan heritage through museum visits and textbook chapters but offer no pathways for children to actually acquire Baba Malay or learn traditional crafts, they rationally conclude these practices aren't valuable enough to justify private investment either. Why would families dedicate Sunday afternoons to language transmission when schools signal these skills are educationally inert? The educational system's choices thus cascade through community decision-making, accelerating decline far beyond schools' direct influence.

The contrast with diaspora heritage preservation proves illuminating. Chinese-language schools in Western countries, Hebrew schools in non-Jewish-majority contexts, and Indigenous language revitalisation programs all recognise that heritage cannot survive on appreciation alone—it requires practice. These programs involve weekend or after-school sessions where children speak the endangered language, prepare traditional foods, learn cultural practices through doing. They're often under-resourced and struggle with enrollment, but they at least understand the pedagogical model: cultural transmission requires embodied practice over extended time, not information transfer during brief visits.

Singapore could integrate similar approaches within existing educational infrastructure without requiring wholesale curriculum revision. Consider these interventions:

Co-Curricular Activity Recognition: Currently, CCAs recognise sports, arts, and academic clubs. Heritage transmission could qualify as a recognised CCA, with students earning official credit for sustained participation in craft apprenticeships, language learning, or culinary training with certified community practitioners. This would immediately legitimise heritage practice as educationally valuable while creating structured time for transmission.

Mother Tongue Language Policy Expansion: The current mother tongue policy mandates Chinese, Malay, or Tamil based on ethnic classification. A modest expansion could allow Peranakan students to substitute 2-4 years of Mandarin instruction with Baba Malay if qualified teachers are available and families request it. Even this limited option would signal institutional recognition that heritage languages deserve educational support, likely triggering private-sector response (tutoring centers, online courses) that currently does not exist due to lack of recognised demand.

Project-Based Heritage Learning: Rather than one-off museum visits, schools could integrate sustained heritage projects requiring students to learn a specific practice over one term—for example, P5 students in Katong/Joo Chiat schools spend 10 weeks learning basic beadwork from community practitioners, meeting 90 minutes weekly, with a final exhibition of student work. This shifts heritage from content to be covered to skills to be developed, requiring patience and practice rather than quick comprehension.

Assessment Restructuring: Current Social Studies assessments ask students to explain heritage significance through written essays—testing knowledge *about* culture. Alternative assessments could test cultural participation: can students hold a basic conversation in Baba Malay? Can they prepare a simple Peranakan dish following traditional methods? Can they identify quality in a piece of beadwork and explain what makes it well-crafted? Such assessments would require fundamentally different instruction—more time with practitioners, less time with textbooks.

The deeper challenge, however, is philosophical rather than logistical. Singapore's educational system prizes efficiency, standardisation, and measured outcomes—values fundamentally at odds with cultural transmission's inherent inefficiency, contextual specificity, and often unquantifiable impacts. Learning *rempah* preparation requires sensory discernment developed through repeated attempts, mentor feedback on subtle failures, and gradual embodiment of tacit knowledge—none of which fits neatly into learning outcomes frameworks, standardised rubrics, or comparative performance metrics. Schools would need to embrace pedagogical approaches that accept inefficiency and variability as features rather than bugs.

This requires confronting an uncomfortable question: Does Singapore's society value Peranakan heritage enough to allocate scarce educational time and resources to its transmission? Or does heritage matter primarily as tourism asset and national identity symbol, while concrete educational priorities emphasise economically-productive skills? The current equilibrium—where schools teach *about* heritage but don't teach heritage *practice*—suggests society hasn't yet decided whether cultural preservation justifies diverting resources from academic subjects tied to economic competitiveness.

But if the answer is that Peranakan practices don't merit educational investment beyond tokenistic appreciation, then claims of "preservation" ring hollow. Culture cannot be preserved in perpetual suspended animation, appreciated but never practiced. Every generation that learns to consume heritage rather than transmit it brings the culture one generation closer to extinction, regardless of museum budgets or tourism revenue. The educational system, despite its invisibility in heritage policy discussions, may be the most consequential preservation infrastructure of all—currently configured to accelerate decline while producing the illusion of cultural continuity through appreciation rituals that substitute for genuine transmission.

The solution is not to blame educators attempting to fulfill contradictory mandates within resource

constraints. It is to recognise that preservation requires educational commitments exceeding what schools currently provide, then to decide whether society values these practices enough to make different trade-offs. Absent such commitment, the slow extinction continues—one cohort of students at a time learning to appreciate culture they will never practice, in a system teaching them that heritage is something to understand, not something to become.

The Familiar Foreign: Shaping the Cultural Self

By Isaac Wan Zi Heng

Bachelor of Science in Environmental Earth Systems Science

Figure 1. Tang Dynasty Buddha, Haw Par Villa, Singapore

Ask any local about Haw Par Villa, and distinct images of Asian folklore and gruesome punishment come to mind (Figure 1). Prompted by a desire to understand my cultural heritage, I paid a visit to this historical landmark, famed for educating children on traditional Asian values of filial piety and obedience. As I passed through its gates, I was greeted by Chinese mythical figures painted in vivid, saturated hues of red and yellow. These depictions of Chinese folklore were indeed strange and alarming, featuring anthropomorphic pigs and tortured humans. Prominent Chinese inscriptions preaching filial and religious piety were situated at every turn. The faint sound of oriental folk music reverberated throughout the park, creating a dreamlike ambiance. The noise and bustle of nearby traffic faded away, as I wandered into what felt like ancient China. While I was immersed in these traditional fables, something peculiar caught my eye: two Japanese sumo wrestlers staring intensely at the ground. I felt rather amused and recalled enjoying a wrestling match during my recent trip to Japan. I then walked to the adjacent lake and, to my surprise, I found the Statue of Liberty with its

signature torch basking in the afternoon sun. Why were these foreign figures in a local landmark?

For some reason, these icons felt much more noticeable than the Chinese fables. Upon further thought, I realised I barely knew the stories associated with the Chinese figures, but I grasped the significance of the sumo wrestlers and the Statue of Liberty in an instant. With their raised hands and arched backs, I immediately recognised that the sumo wrestlers were engaging in a wrestling match. The words 'New York' and 'freedom' immediately popped into my head when I saw the Statue of Liberty. These cultural associations were so simple to make. Yet, as an ethnic Chinese, seeing the figure of Madam White Snake invoked no mental image. Without scrutinising the English descriptions, I would have had no clue about the meaning and context of these Chinese stories.

Perhaps my lack of knowledge has to do with the prominence of foreign cultures in my daily life. Compared to Chinese entertainment, my friends have a stronger preference for Korean pop and dramas. I recalled a classmate belting out every Korean word of a BTS song with ease, but mumbling incoherently when a Chinese song was subsequently played. I, too, struggled to remember a complete line of the lyrics. The stylish vocals and contemporary performances resonate more with us than traditional Chinese elements, such as those in Haw Par Villa. Maybe this appreciation of foreign cultures is unsurprising, given how interconnected the world has become. Foreign media now saturates local television screens and social media feeds, and travel has brought us closer to new cultures. In our daily lives, we embrace these foreign cultural elements with open arms, yet neglect our own cultural heritage. I then thought, how has globalisation shaped people's tendencies to value foreign cultures over their own?

Ozer (2019) discusses how globalisation has influenced the psychology of individuals – specifically their perception of identity in relation to culture. He argues that the interconnectedness of the modern world has enabled individuals to pick out foreign cultural elements that they find desirable. People are compelled to "'self-select' specific cultural elements for integration into their local and global cultural identities" (Ozer, 2019, p. 173). He further claims that the integration of foreign cultures into one's sociocultural identity manifests as "globalisation-based biculturalism" (Ozer, 2019, p. 168), whereby people embrace one or more cultural flows other than their own.

When cultural symbolism is involved, people find greater affinity with novel concepts. The aforementioned Statue of Liberty is an emblem of American culture — encompassing American values of liberty, individualism and freedom of choice. These cultural exports have been amplified and proliferated internationally, actively questioning traditional norms by encouraging independent thought. This symbolic association is consistent with the narratives of many Singaporean youths, who prize individual choice over collective welfare (Berezina et al., 2020). Furthermore, Ozer (2019) suggests that individuals feel strongly connected to the global community and are more cognisant of how they relate to foreign ideas. The exchange of ideas brought about by globalisation has introduced endless opportunities to construct our own blend of traits and characteristics. This heightens our sense of individuality and distinctiveness through the diversity of expression. Hence, the highly permeable nature of globalisation enables self-actualisation, as we can embody foreign ideas that align with our personal truths.

Alternatively, Rosenmann et al. (2016) argue that globalisation forms culturally exclusive identities through the dominance of certain cultures, namely

Western culture. Rosenmann et al. (2016) opine that "Most media outlets around the world feature globalized Western images of the…collective 'good world' (of technological innovation and social progress)" (p. 207). A global, unified Western culture is heralded as the future — revolutionising thought processes and enabling individuals to flourish. With the advent of globalisation, Western interpretations of issues like human rights and environmental degradation have gained popularity. Western culture champions alternative ways of thinking, and this openness has made its values more attractive in current times. Furthermore, Western cultural homogenisation has fostered mutual understanding through promoting common practices, such as the use of English. In Haw Par Villa, story descriptions often use English to convey information alongside Mandarin. This reflects its preferability as a standard language for ease of communication, despite the park's Chinese roots. Hence, the dominance of cultures through globalisation has prompted individuals to value foreign cultures, as they encourage non-conformity and enable social coordination.

Both Rosenmann et al. (2016) and Ozer (2019) highlight how globalisation has driven changes in cultural valuation by facilitating the exchange of ideas and beliefs. However, their views diverge on the fluidity of cultural valuation. Rosenmann et al. (2016) assert that cultural value remains constant — failing to capture the dynamic nature of cultural valuation. For example, the label "Made in China" describes China's historical association with producing low-quality goods. However, its drastic shift towards creating high-tech goods has bolstered its consumer reputation, evidenced by Chinese electric vehicle company BYD becoming Singapore's top-selling car brand recently (Tjoe, 2025, para. 1). Therefore, Ozer (2019) would oppose Rosenmann et al. (2016) by proposing that people have greater agency to adopt diverse viewpoints. These viewpoints are shaped by a myriad of different cultural beliefs, rather than a single cultural system. The rising prominence of non-Western cultures, such as those of Korea, China, and Japan, will further diversify the global cultural landscape with their own spheres of influence. Therefore, the value and desirability of cultures may evolve in response to the varying tides of cultural influence, rather than remain static as Rosenmann et al. (2016) suggest.

When examined through a local lens, globalisation has extensively woven the social fabric of Singapore. Singapore's emphasis on multiculturalism fosters an environment that encourages intercultural exchange. Beyond mere cultural commercialisation, the inclusion of foreign icons in Haw Par Villa reflects a broader societal acceptance of foreign cultures. It may even indicate a willing coexistence of foreign cultural elements alongside local ones. Furthermore, our frequent interactions with foreigners act as a bridge between foreign and local cultures. For example, many second-generation immigrants serve National Service alongside Singaporeans. Through forging interpersonal connections, we come to learn about foreign cultures in a raw and authentic way. This could be the stimulus for why we value foreign cultures — a genuine interest in someone else's different way of life.

Personal preference is regarded as the key reason why we value foreign cultures (Ozer, 2019). However, our love for foreign cultures can also be attributed to our roots as social beings. Globalisation has pluralised society, creating a diverse assortment of social groups where we can find our place. Being surrounded by people who share similar foreign cultural interests strengthens our sense of belonging. Individuals might collectively yearn to watch a sumo wrestling match in person or visit the famed Statue of

Liberty in their lifetime. This connection to larger social groups within our society creates a strong emotional stake for individuals. There is greater impetus to invest energy in something we collectively love, simply because it brings joy to the people that matter to us.

The waves of globalisation have progressively redefined our cultural identities, introducing foreign elements and ideas that we hold dear. This system is not static, with different cultural flows continuously shaping the way we value cultures. Therefore, cultural valuation is dynamic, evolving with the passage of time. With the increasing interconnectedness of today's world, perhaps these foreign cultures should naturally coexist with or even complement our own culture. Evidently, the prevalence of foreign cultures has gradually transformed our social environment by shaping our attitudes and narratives. Through numerous lived experiences, the manifold integration of foreign cultural influences has redefined our collective and individual identities. We perceive these foreign cultures through the lens of what we value, constantly evolving according to our individual desires and broader social environments. By shaping our identity into a mosaic of various cultural elements, we create a colourful masterpiece of self.

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The Hidden "Filter" in My Diary

By Chen Sitong

Bachelor of Engineering in Electrical and Electronic Engineering

The orange light from my desk lamp gently shone on the cover of my diary, casting a faint halo on the page and creating concave and convex patterns that made my handwriting look far gentler. I turned to a diary entry I wrote last week, and the faint smell of sandalwood from the paper of my diary wafted into my nose, reminding me of the night I cried after a difficult exam. As I read the page, a feeling of uneasiness quietly emerged: the written words that told my stories were not quite consistent with my memories.

My finger stopped at the line about lunch. "Today's lunch was a bit special as I tried a new flavour." But as far as I could remember, that pasta was as chewy as rubber, and every bite stuck to my teeth. The words in my diary did not match that memory at all — it was like I was describing someone else's meal, not the chewy spaghetti I swallowed. The next few lines reflected a quarrel I had with a close friend. "Perhaps there's some barrier in our communication, and time will slowly ease it." But I clearly remember the feeling of a constricted throat, the knuckles on my fist turning white, and the buzzing in my ears when she raised her voice. Then I turned to the page about failing my physics exam. "Although I made a mistake this time, I gained experience." However, the memory of holding my report card was still clear. My hands were shaking so violently that I could hardly hold the paper, and no matter how hard I blinked, I could not stop my tears. Those vivid emotional fluctuations were in sharp contrast to the calm on the paper. My handwriting stayed neat; not a single hasty stroke betrayed the chaos I felt inside.

I finally realised that I have been putting a filter on my emotions, smoothing over all the rough edges before I wrote them down, turning surging feelings into controlled sentences. This forces me to confront a question I can no longer ignore. Why do I instinctively embellish the words in my diary to hide my true emotions?

To understand this filter, Erving Goffman's research offers a sociological perspective. In his book, "The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life" (2009), Goffman proposes the "dramaturgical theory", arguing that “social interaction is essentially a performance, and everyone is shaping a self-image that meets the expectations of the occasion” (p. 17). He divides the occasion into "front-stage" — public spaces such as the workplace, where we show our best side, and "back-stage" — private spaces such as the home or personal records, where we can relax (Goffman, 2009, pp. 22-26). But even in the back-stage where there is no clear audience, past social feedback, such as others telling us that "negative emotions are equal to weakness" (Goffman, 2009, p. 25), will still cause us to constantly embellish ourselves to avoid being criticised. Goffman uses examples such as concealing troubles in family conversations or dissatisfaction at work to illustrate that this embellishment is not intentional deception, but an instinctive pursuit of social approval (2009, p. 68).

Goffman's suggestion explaining embellishment as a subconscious act to avoid being criticised (2009) could map onto the way that I had chosen to write in my diary about my unpleasant experiences. Even in my private diary, the "back-stage", my rephrasing "quarrel" into "communication barrier" downplayed the seriousness of the encounter. Now, even if I read my diary alone, I still avoid writing down those fragile moments, bringing this social habit of seeking approval into my most private space. However, Goffman's theory overlooks one crucial point: my embellishment serves not only to gain recognition from others by making myself sound positive, but also to consciously protect my own self-worth and prevent self-criticism. When I wrote "I gained experience" instead of "I was scared", I was not only trying to please an imaginary audience, but also actively reframing the failure to shield myself from self-rejection and the pain of feeling inadequate. This is not just a social performance for others, but a deliberate act of self-care: I am reframing the memory for myself, choosing a narrative that preserves my dignity and maintains a coherent, compassionate view of who I am, even in my most private, unobserved thoughts.

If Goffman's research is about the influence of the external environment on us, then psychologist Ethan Kross's examines the biological correlations of this filter. In his 2024 TED Talk, Kross, who specialises in emotional regulation, argues that hiding emotions in diaries stems from the brain's "threat response". Those undigested bad moods will be regarded by the brain as a threat to "self-image", triggering an instinct to regulate those feelings (Kross, 2024). He points out that when we regard failure as a threat, the amygdala, the brain's emotional response center, becomes overactive, causing anxiety and self-denial. However, the technique of "self-distancing", such as describing events from a third-person perspective, can activate the prefrontal cortex, which is responsible for rational thinking, and inhibit the amygdala's overreaction. This is not deception, but rather an "emotional survival strategy", unconsciously reframing memories to ease pain without harming self-worth (Kross, 2024).

My writing "I gained experience" in the entry reflecting on my less-than-ideal physics exam results is a classic example of self-distancing. My brain was not lying; rather, it was protecting me from being overwhelmed by negative emotions. Kross's research (2024) also explains why my handwriting remained neat even when I was in a mess: the activity of the prefrontal cortex allows my actions (including writing) to stay rational, even if my mood was spiralling out of control. But Kross's focus on neuroscience overlooks the role of personal growth experiences. My frequent use of this filter may stem from being taught to "appear outstanding" in childhood, and it is this background that makes my brain instinctively label "vulnerability" as a threat.

When I look at Goffman's and Kross's arguments together, I find that the filter in my diary is essentially the product of social learning and biological instinct. These two arguments regard emotional modification as an unconscious survival strategy. Goffman argues this is people's instinctive pursuit of social approval (2009), while Kross argues this is the brain's natural defence mechanism when dealing with threats (2024). It is the complementarity of these two arguments that enables me to see the full picture of this filter: I neither consider it active deception nor a character flaw, but an inevitable choice to enable me to adapt to my environment and protect myself.

I used to think that keeping a diary is to preserve the truth, but now I understand that when I embellish the words in my diary to hide my true emotions, it is to make the truth bearable for myself. Now when I see the word "communication barrier" written in my diary,

I see not only a euphemism, but the social pressure that forces me to remain composed, and the brain's need to escape pain. I may still use this filter in the future, but I think I might add margin notes for a little honesty — not as a correction, but to honor my own emotions and the value of remembering the whole experience. The most authentic record is never the polished words that have been decorated nor the unmasked pain, but the understanding of why I need this filter. This kind of understanding can help me accept my messy, but authentic self much more than a diary entry. Moreover, this acceptance is not limited to my diary; it is also about enabling myself to have emotions without rushing to smooth out all the rough edges. A filter is not something to erase; instead, recognising its existence has enabled me to choose when to use it, and when to keep my unpolished self.

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Where the Living Speaks to the Dead

By Goh Zhong Han
Bachelor of Business

The first sound I hear is gunfire. Crisp, sharp, evenly paced bursts from Nee Soon Camp firing range. A stone's throw away, the sharp crack is immediately answered by the gentle clang of a monk's bell, serenely chanting ancient texts. Violence and peace coexist here, and the juxtaposition feels strangely right.

On the slope, grass cutters even the lengthy grasses. Below, people of all ages pass: some praying, others chatting, a few lost in thought. A woman wipes away tears as a boy beside her asks too many questions. A man stands alone at the incense burner, eyes following smoke as it fades. The air is thick with ash formless, fleeting, and sacred. This smoke becomes the anchoring reality of the columbarium: a physical bridge between the heavy earth of the living and the invisible realm of the departed.

Everywhere, animals move with quiet intent. Monkeys with babies riding on their stomachs forage for scraps of food. Birds linger at the perimeter, waiting for their turn. Crickets sing under the sun. Near a small waterfall, koi swim in unhurried circles, as if continuing a rhythm older than death itself. It is as if they, too, are mindful of what is behind those columbaria or what the smell of incense is trying to convey to them. They accompany the dead more than living humans.

Then, laughter spills from beyond the fence. Golf carts rumble along the Sembawang Country Club. Golfers taking aim amid lush green, indifferent to incense and ritual. The living and the dead coexist here, unaware of boundaries. It is both sacred and ordinary.

Standing amid this intersection of silence and noise, I begin to wonder why we do what we do. Why do we burn offerings for the dead, leave food, light joss sticks, chant, and pray? Is it for them or for us? Perhaps these elaborate acts are not about respect for the dead but about resisting their absence, as a way of holding them close when our minds refuse to let go. Perhaps these rituals sustain not the departed but our own hunger to remember. In this quiet tumult, I find myself asking: Are rituals for the dead a way for us to hold onto them, or are they a way for us to prepare for the day we will also desire to be remembered?

"Grief turns out to be a place none of us know until we reach it," said Joan Didion (2005, p.17). This sentence encapsulates the peculiarity of grief: nobody can get ready for it until it happens. *The Year of Magical Thinking*, her memoir, chronicles the year following her husband's unexpected passing and highlights memory's inability to let go rather than death's finality. She keeps his shoes, half-believing he might return. Her "magical thinking" is not denial but tenderness to the mind's way of keeping love alive a little longer.

At the columbarium, I saw this same quiet defiance. The burning of hell notes, the chanting, and the food offerings are not simply gestures to the dead but acts of holding on. When a woman wiped her tears as her child watched, I recognised Didion's (2005) struggle; the ache of absence, and the fragile hope that ritual might bridge it.

Didion's (2005) strength lies in her refusal to seek closure. Like her prose, the columbarium transforms grief into meaning; smoke ascending indicates continuity and a dialogue between the living and the dead. Yet her idea of "magical thinking" also shows its limits. Didion's (2005) struggle was solitary and fiercely inward; here in the columbarium, remembrance is immediately, fiercely communal. Monks chant, families pray side by side, ashes mingle in the air. Memory becomes communal, a way for people to hold one another through the act of remembering. By moving grief from the private interior of the mind to the shared space of the temple, the burden of 'magical thinking' is distributed. The monk's chant validates the individual's loss, transforming a solitary struggle into a collective social contract that ensures no one is forgotten.

Paul Kalanithi's *When Breath Becomes Air* (2016), on the other hand, begins not with loss, but with the slow arrival of it. A neurosurgeon diagnosed with terminal lung cancer, he turns his medical gaze inward to ask, "What makes human life meaningful?" (Kalanithi, 2016, p. 29). For him, passing away becomes an act of authorship rather than a conclusion, allowing him to influence how he will be remembered. To give his life's disarray a meaning, he examines his own mortality with the same level of precision that was previously only used for surgery.

Kalanithi (2016) turns his last few months into a loving and lucid legacy through his words. His memoir turns into a gift and a farewell, demonstrating that purpose may be found even as life draws to an end. He shows that remembrance is not only for the living to sustain but also for the dying to prepare. The rising incense, the neighbouring golfers' laughter, and the thoughtful offerings left behind at the columbarium all evoke the same impulse in more subdued, social forms. Each act echoes Kalanithi's (2016) search for coherence, small gestures that keep love from dissolving into silence, and that summon the living to remember those who left.

Yet Kalanithi's (2016) vision carries privilege: he could write, reflect, and preserve his voice, while most must rely on others to remember them. Still, both his memoir and these rituals share the same longing to remain, somehow, in the consciousness of the living, to affirm that even as the body fades, meaning endures in memory and story. We crave this control because death is the ultimate loss of agency; authorship is our final act of defiance against being silenced. While Kalanithi's (2016) privilege afforded him a literal pen, the families at the columbarium use ritual as their own form of authorship, meticulously 'writing' their loved ones into the future through steady, repeated acts of devotion.

Didion (2005) and Kalanithi's (2016) dialogue illuminates the entire arc of remembering. Didion (2005) writes from the perspective of the living, enmeshed in the web of memory's resistance to fading, while Kalanithi (2016) writes from the perspective of the dying, creating memory beforehand. Their viewpoints are united by a common impulse: the necessity of remembrance.

Didion's (2005) magical thinking illustrates how memory triumphs over reason, whereas Kalanithi's (2016) quest for purpose illustrates how reason attempts to control death. While Kalanithi (2016) writes himself into the future, Didion (2005) clings to the past. Both, however, highlight the same paradox: remembering is a way to exert control over the uncontrollable.

Didion (2005) depicts grief as erratic and disorderly, but Kalanithi (2016) depicts legacy as purposeful and methodical. Juxtaposed, they imply that remembering is not exclusively emotional or totally logical but rather oscillates between the two. That oscillation is embodied in the rites I witnessed: the incense rising in

a meticulously planned ceremony, contrasting the accompanying silences and tears defying order. Similar to how Didion's (2005) illogical faith and Kalanithi's (2016) logical acceptance coexist in human grieving, the monk's steady chant and the child's incessant questioning are part of the same soundscape. Instead of being diametrically opposed, Didion (2005) and Kalanithi's (2016) viewpoints are complimentary components of the same human endeavour: navigating the gap between presence and absence.

With these realizations, the scene changes when I return to the columbarium. The smoke drifting upward is both Didion's (2005) denial and Kalanithi's (2016) acceptance, grief and legacy entwined. Not only does the woman wipe away her tears, but she also rehearses remembrance for herself. The child's curiosity foreshadows his future role as a rememberer. The rituals are more about maintaining the living's ability to remember and be remembered than they are about the deceased.

Didion (2005) teaches us that grief is about learning to live in the absence rather than letting go. Kalanithi (2016) teaches us that dying is about determining how one will remain, not about departing. Collectively, they demonstrate that remembering is a conversation, a movement between the deliberate and the irrational, between those who stay and those who have left.

The deceased are more than just figures we hold onto. They also serve as mirrors for our own waning and need for consistency. This desire to be remembered is not mere vanity; it is the fundamental human anxiety about non-being. It is the chilling realization that we are but a single thread in a vast tapestry, easily unraveled. We do not just fear the end of breath, but the end of our 'story', the moment when the last person who knows our name also passes. Ritual acts as a hedge against this erasure, creating a symbolic permanence that the biological body cannot sustain. We cling to their memory because it is a rehearsal for our own inevitable absence. If they can endure in a story, so too, perhaps, can we. Every ritual, including the burning of offerings, the lighting of incense, and recitation of prayers, serves as a reminder that the significance of life transcends biological existence and endures in symbolic form.

The question of whether remembrance is for us or for them is a false choice. The answer lies not in resisting death but in the dialogue itself, which affirms that the love and meaning a person created does not dissolve with their body. The rituals we perform, the joss sticks, the tears, the steady chant, are not merely acts of remembrance; they are acts of ultimate defiance, a shared, fragile human commitment to ensure that no life, however short or long, will ever be truly erased from the human story.

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The Quiet Economy of Prayer: Is Faith a Transaction?

By Shifa' Syaugi
Bachelor of Science in Biological Sciences

I let the bead of sweat drip from my hair under my prayer gown onto the prayer mat beneath me, as I whispered the words that had been taught to me my whole life, chanting my prayers to God, eyes closed, my forehead and nose on the prayer mat. I performed the final steps of prayer and lifted my head.

My grandmother sat next to me on a chair, sacrificing her aging body and her aching knees to come to the mosque to pray in the hot, sweaty environment. The lady in front of me, with her newborn lying down and crying hysterically next to her, scooped the baby into her arms after she finished prayer. She frantically recited the "dzikir" (short prayer chant) as she held him to her chest, trying to calm him down. These were just the evident and "loud" sacrifices made that I happened to see from the women surrounding me as we all collectively prayed. I was surrounded by women of all different backgrounds, yet they all have something in common. They all have made sacrifices and put in effort to show up to the mosque and pray. Yet a question lingers...why? Why do these women sacrifice parts of their lives for prayer? Are these sacrifices acts of pure devotion, or are they quietly tied to the hope of receiving something in return? The answer, I believe, lies in a single word: reward, the hope for a spiritual, emotional, or divine return that may give meaning to the sacrifice made.

Most of the time, humans do things for rewards. Whether it be something as trivial as doing an assignment to get good grades, or as complex as praying daily in anticipation of earning a spot in heaven, our lives and motivation are dependent on the idea of a reward. In Islam, it is preached to donate and help people for blessings from God, which also is a form of reward. More or less, these rewards are on the individual level: they benefit only the person who does the deed. In the mosque, there are often people who would volunteer to help cook or donate food and beverages for the people praying. Oftentimes, they are seen as selfless, offering their time and effort in a place that lacks help. However, if one might question the motivation behind their volunteering efforts, it is usually for personal reward, in this case for blessings. The Quran mentions charity for blessings in various verses, such as Surah Al-Hadid (57:18), which promises a generous reward to those who "loan Allah a goodly loan". And so, I wonder, if the foundation of prayer, volunteering and things that are done in the name of religion is built on the anticipation of a reward, to what extent is it really considered selfless? On the surface, prayer looks like an act of devotion, a surrender to something greater than ourselves. But if that act is fueled by the hope of personal gain, even a spiritual one, whether it's a sense of peace or a seat in heaven, then maybe it is not entirely different from studying for grades or working for money. This idea, however, raises quite a difficult question: if someone prays simply for peace of mind or emotional grounding, is that selfishness, or a basic human need? Seeking comfort does not necessarily harm others, and in many cases, it may even help a person become

kinder. The line between self-interest and selfishness, then, is not always clear. Thus, this led me to question, is religion inherently selfish?

In their research, Saleam & Moustafar (2016) explore exactly this relationship between faith, morality, and self-interest. They argue that religious people tend to behave more pro-socially than those who are less or non-religious, especially when ideas like "God" or "salvation" are brought to mind. This, at first, sounds like evidence that religion inspires kindness and altruism. Yet, the researchers complicate this by introducing the "supernatural punishment" and "supernatural reward" hypotheses. These suggest that religious morality may not always be about selflessness, but about self-preservation: people act kindly to avoid divine punishment or to secure divine rewards.

They even cite research showing that older children from religious families often behave more selfishly than younger ones, despite being more familiar with religious teachings. This implies that moral behaviour can decline as individuals internalise religion as a rule-based system of incentives rather than an emotional connection to compassion (Funderburk, 2018). In other words, faith can sometimes transform moral reasoning into a transaction: a give-and-take with the divine. During Ramadan, for example, a month where every act of generosity is multiplied in spiritual reward, donations suddenly flood in. It is not that there is no compassion, but that it is intensified when framed within a system of divine incentives, which suggests that motivation and morality may sometimes intertwine rather than exist separately.

However, Funderburk (2018), in his article, argues that religion's core purpose has always been to combat egoism. He notes that all major religions seek to dissolve or humble the ego, which they identify as the source of suffering, sin, and division. In Islam, believers are reminded to "surrender" to God as a literal act of humility. In Buddhism, enlightenment comes through dissolving the illusion of self. These traditions, though different in form, share a moral: to be spiritual is to transcend selfishness.

Leary also introduces a paradox, however, that while religions preach against egoism, they sometimes reproduce it institutionally. When believers start to see their faith as superior or use religion as a justification for exclusion or conflict, religion becomes a new form of collective ego. The irony is striking: systems designed to overcome self-centredness can end up amplifying it. His insight reframes the question I began with. Maybe religion is not inherently selfish or selfless: maybe it is both, depending on whether faith is used to serve the self or to transcend it.

Together, Saleam & Moustafa (2016) and Funderburk's (2018) research are complementary. Saleam & Moustafa (2016) focus on external motivators like divine reward and punishment, while Funderburk (2018) stresses that real faith happens internally, in the uncomfortable struggle to overcome egoism and become less self-centred. When viewed side by side, they reveal that religion operates on both psychological and moral levels. It appeals to human self-interest (by promising spiritual rewards) but also aspires to go beyond it (by teaching humility and compassion). This duality makes religion deeply human: flawed, yet striving for purity. It also means that calling religion "inherently selfish" might miss the point: selfishness may not be a flaw of religion, but a reflection of the human condition that religion both exposes and tries to heal.

Returning to the question – "Is religion inherently selfish?" - I think there is no clear answer, nor will there ever be. This complicated relationship between seeking reward and striving for transcendence feels very real and present to me, especially in the mosque. I remember the crowd of women who showed up even when faith was difficult, I watched a mother

calming her crying baby, reciting dzikir, as if prayer is the one steady thing she can hold onto. Their devotion may not be driven by certainty of reward, and in many cases, it may not be about reward at all, yet they continue. That persistence is an act of resilience: when faith remains even through discomfort and struggle, it shifts from a transaction into a source of strength and guidance. These lived moments make the idea of "transactional faith" feel too small to contain what devotion often looks like.

So rather than concluding that religion is inherently selfish, it may be more accurate to say that religion works with human self-interest, not against it. Religion takes something as human as wanting, such as wanting peace, wanting protection, wanting purpose, and asks us to channel that desire into something that benefits more than just ourselves. The women around me do not pray because they have perfected faith. They pray because they are trying. Trying to believe. Trying to give. Trying to become better versions of themselves for the people around them.

That, to me, is where the beauty lies. Religion does not erase selfishness; yet it reveals it, then gently nudges us to rise above it. And perhaps the truest devotion is not found in those who pray with pure selflessness, but in those who continue choosing faith, compassion, and community despite their imperfections. Each imperfect prayer is a step toward selflessness, one act of surrender at a time.

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With My Life

By Leong Xing Han

Bachelor of Science in Maritime Studies

Figure. 1. Snapshot depicting pledge taking during Infantry Conversion Course

Two weeks ago, my family witnessed my brother raising his right hand and reciting the military oath that ended with a resounding "With My Life". Ever since then, my brother began his legal commitment as a National Serviceman. Days later, my family and I were waiting eagerly at Pasir Ris Bus Interchange for his first Book Out Day.

As soon as the bus nosed into the interchange, soldiers in their military uniforms poured out excitedly and reunited with their waiting families. Amongst the platoon of men was my brother, looking different from the last time I saw him. Once sporting his handsome mullet hairstyle and fashionable t-shirt, his head full of hair had been entirely buzzed and his attire had been standardised to that of the servicemen standing around him. His uniform had a camouflage green pattern, and sewn above his left chest pocket was his name, shortened from Leong Xing Min to "X M LEONG".

When my brother walked over and hugged Mom and Dad, I noticed a string of letters and numbers labelled on his fieldpack—J2406. My brother would explain that "J" stood for Jaguar Company, "24" represented Platoon Two Section Four, and "06" represented that he was the sixth man of his combat division.

My parents offered a lift home to three of my brother's section mates. Along the way home, they laughed loudly and shared stories containing terms foreign to civilians but familiar to servicemen like themselves, including "reveille", "coy line", and "*chao keng*". Despite their different walks of life, the boys connected through their shared experiences in training.

Reflecting on this experience made me notice the dehumanisation of being a national serviceman like my brother. From being Leong Xing Min, who had a mullet haircut as part of his identity, he was now Recruit 2406 of Jaguar Company, who had his hair shaven off on Enlistment Day. Rather than being able to choose what to wear, his attire was standardised as a green uniform. Furthermore, stories from my brother's friends made me realise how servicemen like themselves had no say in when to wake up, go to bed, eat their meals, or even rest. All their actions were under the strict dictatorship of the military. Having to fit into the mould of a soldier has been shown to elicit negative health impacts for some individuals, both physically and mentally (Cheok et al., 2000). Yet, through National Service, my brother had formed bonds with individuals he would have otherwise not interacted with. Perhaps the enforcement of discipline and dehumanisation in the military built shared camaraderie and social bonds? This made me wonder: how does National Service shape, or break, young men in this day and age?

A journal article from the National Library of Medicine published by Heward et al. (2024) illustrates how the dynamic and multi-faceted military culture requires conformity in servicemen's mindsets and behaviours, which could bring about adverse mental health issues. In order to perform military duties successfully, soldiers put "emphasis on stoicism and suppression of vulnerabilities, fostered from recruit training onwards, [which enhances] short-term adaptability and mission success" (Heward et al., 2024). Moreover, being trained in a military environment perpetuates traditional masculine beliefs that hinder soldiers from seeking professional help, as "the stigma and culture of silence surrounding mental health further hinder[s] help-seeking" (Heward et al., 2024).

With the main purpose of the military being to create a reliable defence force where soldiers are prepared to fight for their nation, military culture is designed to break the individual spirit of soldiers and rebuild them with a spirit of bravery and masculinity—in a sense, dehumanising them. Heward et al. (2024) similarly illustrate the negative effects of altering oneself to adopt a seemingly incredible persona. Despite rank or vocation, soldiers tend to unhealthily neglect their personal well-being for the purpose of fitting into the high expectations of the armed forces. Furthermore, the fear of being stigmatised by fellow comrades, who are trained to adopt the same military mindset, increases the hesitation of servicemen to seek help for mental health. Consequently, the design of military culture leads to both the stifling of human emotions and the increased barriers to seeking help for one's well-being. This elicits potential mental health issues in the long run, ergo "breaking" them.

The above argument is, however, challenged by an article on MINDEF Defence Pioneer Singapore published by Soh Wei Ern, a former national serviceman (2022). He posits that with the right mindset change, the military culture could spark a positive transformation for young soldiers. Having mentioned how "NS will be uncomfortable, NS will push you. But if you embrace it, you will emerge stronger, more confident and a better person" (Soh, 2022), Soh illustrates the change in mindset that is required to reap the benefits of the military and its culture. He mentions being initially resistant towards his enlistment, but after changing his perception of National Service, he managed to adapt and develop himself as a person. By embracing his time spent in the military, Soh had also formed social bonds with fellow bunkmates, eventually leading to him being influenced to change undesirable traits, such as anger management issues.

Indeed, the military serves as a platform for servicemen of different backgrounds to interact. By being in close contact and having to do almost

everything together—waking up, exercising, having meals, and training—soldiers are bound to have common experiences which they can relate to and form friendships over. For instance, my brother's experience at Jaguar Company allowed him to break out of his introverted shell and become more confident in interacting with others. Putting individuality aside and embracing the military lifestyle better integrates individuals into the exclusive military community and fulfils their social needs, hence "shaping them".

Heward et al. (2024) illustrate how the military incites unhealthy suppression of one's emotional needs, while Soh (2022) argues how the military encourages a transition into a more positive outlook on overcoming challenges. While Heward and Soh's stances offer contradictory viewpoints in terms of the positive or negative impacts of National Service, they share the same assertion of needing to alter one's mindset in order to excel in the military. Indeed, in times of operational crises, the military requires personnel to be able to function under highly stressful situations that could quite possibly be life or death, requiring servicemen to break down their civilian mindset and build up a military one. However, this change poses an intangible challenge to soldiers eventually when they return to the civilian world. They are required to readjust themselves—to become a student, employee, or father—rather than a man in uniform.

As an individual who has worn the military uniform of my country, the arguments made by Heward et al. (2024) and Soh (2022) made me reflect deeply on what I observed while I was serving my nation. My commanders always reminded us that freedom of our land comes at a price, which is paid for by the blood, sweat, and tears of us soldiers. After all, the more hardships we endure in training, the fewer injuries we sustain under enemy gunfire. As enlistees of the Singapore Armed Forces, we should be trained to develop a strong mental resilience to endure dangerous missions, heavy equipment, and jungle snakes. Yet, it is undeniable that excessive pressure causes cracks. As such, it is pertinent for soldiers to discern when to function as a warrior and when to let themselves be human.

Adjusting oneself in the transition from a civilian to a serviceman goes beyond learning to march in formation or firing an assault rifle. Rather, it is an arduous psychological journey. While the military is designed to break individuals, it is still important for us soldiers not to forget how to rebuild ourselves. By holding on to our individuality and putting our mental fieldpacks down from time to time, we would be doing a tremendous favour for our health and well-being. This leads me back to Enlistment Day, where my brother, myself, and thousands of men alike, raised our right hands and pledged to "preserve and protect the honour and independence of my country with my life". If we do not uphold the responsibility of taking care of our lives, what are we going to protect our country with?

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The Quiet Consensus

By Abdul Matin Bin Samri
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Figure 1. Mendaki Building, Kee Sun Avenue, Singapore

As I was cycling through the quiet rows of bungalows in Kee Sun Avenue, a pale blue building rose unexpectedly amidst the tiled roofs and manicured hedges. Unlike the homes around it, this structure stood apart – sturdy but faded. Rows of black shutter-like windows, like those found in old-school buildings, lined the front, evoking familiarity but hinting at something outdated, as if the organisation was associated with traditional concepts of community service and education. Under the windows, a bright poster was attached to the green fence. The bold text "MENDAKI Tuition Program Registration is Open!" appeared beside a self-assured, smiling Malay student dressed in a school uniform. The glossy advertisement gleamed in the sunlight - offering hope yet quietly reminding me that "catching up" remains central to how Malay progress is imagined in Singapore. The open courtyard felt both symbolic and routine, representing the decades of work to improve the Malay community through education. Upon reflection, the space surrounding MENDAKI hums with contradictions. The old-style shutter windows suggest continuity and rootedness in community support, yet their dated design also hints at being stuck in the past. The poster, bright and confident, shines with ambition, but its message subtly assumes a starting point behind others. Together, these details reveal how stereotypes are reinforced not only

through words but also through physical and cultural spaces.

These associations reveal how, despite Malays' rising educational success, public perception still links them to underachievement. The repetition of this idea, through casual remarks, policy emphasis, or institutional designs, subtly emphasises the belief that Malays must always be helped rather than celebrated for their successes. In this way, the window shutters and tuition advertisement are more than practical details, serving as reminders of how inequality and inherited bias can be embedded in everyday life.

I therefore, questioned: Why do stereotypes of Malays as underachievers persist?

Sociologist Suriani Suratman (2004), in his paper "Problematic Singapore Malays – The Making of a Portrayal," traces how portrayals of Singapore Malays, especially the recurring image of them "lagging behind" – have been reproduced across decades of newspapers, policy debates and public commentary. These portrayals are not new; they stem from colonial stereotypes like the "lazy native" carried into today's context. Although presented as a seminar paper rather than a peer-reviewed journal article, Suratman's analysis remains influential in discussions of Malay representations in Singapore. He warns that such portrayals "naturalise structural inequalities" (Suratman, 2004), making unequal outcomes appear cultural rather than systemic. Suratman's argument directly illuminates my observation of the MENDAKI building. The bright poster inviting Malay students to register for tuition seems progressive, yet through Suratman's lens (2004) , it also reproduces the very narrative of deficiency that it seeks to overcome. I find his argument convincing because it resonates with my lived experience. As a Malay student, I often hear comments such as "You're Malay and in NTU? That's really good!" meant as encouragement, but echoing disbelief. Like the MENDAKI poster, such remarks seem kind but conceal expectation. However, Suratman's analysis (2004) reveals the frame, but not the mirror – how stereotypes, once institutionalised, echo quietly within individuals.

While Suratman's study (2004) clarifies where these stereotypes come from, it left me wondering why they remain so alive in everyday conversation. If structural narratives explain where stereotypes originate, cultural psychology helps explain why they feel so natural in everyday life. "The Racism We All Carry", an essay by Roxane Gay (2014), explores how racism endures not through open hostility but habitual thinking, drawing on the Paula Deen scandal. Gay notes that "most people are a little bit racist" (2014). She argues that society's shock at Deen's remarks revealed a collective denial: people were less disturbed by her prejudice than by her violation of the unspoken rule that racism should stay hidden. Gay (2014) ends with a personal story in which her landlord whispers a racist comment about Korean tenants, expecting her complicity. Her silence and regret show how politeness sustains prejudice – racism as quiet conditioning rather than hate. In Singapore, this quiet conditioning often appears in the language of courtesy – the reluctance to 'offend' by questioning stereotypes or correcting a biased remark. The desire to preserve social harmony, much like Gay's landlord's whispered racism, transforms discrimination into something politely unspoken. It also reveals that the endurance of bias depends not on active malice but on passive comfort: the reluctance to confront what unsettles harmony.

Applied to my research question, Gay's insight (2014) explains why stereotypes about Malays as "more laid-back" or "less ambitious" persist in Singapore. They are rarely voiced to offend; they are shared because it feels socially easier to accept them than to challenge

them. Like the bystander effect, where responsibility diffuses across a crowd, bias persists because everyone assumes it is someone else's duty to speak up.

I am persuaded by Gay's (2014) honesty about shared bias, yet her focus on individual accountability risks ignoring the structural inheritance that Suratman (2004) highlights. It assumes everyone can simply unlearn prejudice, overlooking how institutions continue to legitimise it. Thus, Gay's (2014) analysis complements but also challenges Suratman's (2004): she focuses on personal complicity where he focuses on social design. Reading both sources together deepens my understanding of the persistence of stereotypes. Suratman (2004) reveals how institutions produce the frame – a social narrative of Malay deficiency created by history and policy. Gay (2014) exposes how individuals keep the picture alive – through jokes, politeness and silence. Their ideas converge on a common mechanism: comfort. Structural comfort in keeping familiar narratives intact; social comfort in avoiding confrontation. This dynamic mirrors the bystander effect – the tendency to stay silent when others remain passive. People witness stereotypes in jokes or headlines but prefer comfort over confrontation.

But their analyses also conflict. Suratman (2004) implies Malays are trapped by external narratives; Gay (2014) insists everyone, including minorities, bears responsibility for carrying bias. Their tension reveals something new to me: stereotypes survive because of both systemic repetition and emotional comfort. Society continues to tell the same story, and individuals find it easier to accept the story than to rewrite it.

This synthesis helped me craft a new argument: stereotypes persist not despite progress, but because they stabilise a kind of social equilibrium. They preserve comfort – both institutional and interpersonal – by maintaining a shared fiction of order. Institutions reproduce the stereotype to justify targeted support; individuals tolerate it to preserve harmony. It is not a conspiracy, but a quiet consensus. Seen this way, the stereotype functions less as accusation than as social balance – a story explaining inequality without conflict. Both Suratman (2004) and Gay (2014) point to maintenance – one institutional, one psychological – but together they reveal that the stereotype endures because it makes society feel stable, predictable and unthreatened.

With these insights, my earlier observation of the MENDAKI building takes on a more complex meaning. The old shutters now represent Suratman's "structural inequalities" (2004), the historical architecture of bias; the gleaming poster embodies Gay's "everyday politeness" (2014), the smiling mask of social harmony. Both are maintained not by hatred but by habit, which symbolises a society that values progress, yet still finds comfort in a familiar story of uplift.

The "underachieving Malay" stereotype is not merely false – it endures because it is convenient. It spares society the discomfort of re-examining how success and failure are defined. It spares individuals the tension of speaking against common belief. Like the bystander effect, it depends on everyone watching, waiting and remaining polite. Ultimately, Suratman (2004) teaches me to look outward, to see how state and media shape Malay identity, while Gay (2014) forces me to look inward, at how people internalise and maintain it. Together, they reveal that stereotypes persist not because people believe them deeply, but because questioning them threatens comfort. Perhaps, then, the more illuminating question is not why stereotypes persist, but what they offer us. Yet that very comfort hides the discomfort necessary for growth.

Understanding this shifts my perspective: confronting stereotypes is less about correction than comprehension – noticing the quiet emotions that keep them alive. The pale-blue building on Kee Sun Avenue, with its closed shutters and hopeful poster, becomes a mirror of society itself: a space that soothes even as it conceals.

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The Unnatural Kind

By Joyce Koh

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It was nearly midnight when I boarded one of the last few buses home. The streets were almost empty, with an occasional car passing by. As I was carrying many things that day, I felt that it would be too troublesome to do my usual routine of whipping out my headphones to listen to music. I just sat in silence, with the hum of the air-conditioned filling the space like white noise. Each time the bus pulled into a stop, the silence broke. "Thank you, have a good evening. Bye-bye!" the bus captain would call out, his voice carrying clearly through the sparsely filled cabin. Passengers, with their headphones in and glued onto their phones, tapped out without even looking up. Yet, at the next stop, the bus captain repeated the same cheerful farewell, his tone never faltering even in the face of rejection and blatant disregard. The later it got, the emptier the bus became. The emptiness of the night had made me tense at first, the stillness sharpening every small sound and every movement. But the bus captain's warm greetings brought an unexpected sense of ease to the otherwise eerie ride home. While I was grateful for his kind gesture that brought me comfort, my instinctive reaction was cynical, as I thought to myself: "What's the point if no one notices?" And that cynicism of mine disturbed me more than the silence of the bus ride. Why was that my train of thought? Did I believe that kindness only counted when someone saw it? That it mattered only when it was acknowledged? I realised an inherent problem I had, that kindness doesn't flow naturally from me, and that perhaps I was lacking in some fundamental human instinct.

We often romanticise effortless virtue, believing that the instinctive act reveals the true self. Those of us who must deliberate before acting kindly often question our own moral worth, as if effort dilutes authenticity. We wrestle with indifference and self-interest, feeling fraudulent for needing to try. But the belief that only spontaneous goodness is genuine is merely a hoax. Perhaps moral worth lies not in the instinct, but in the decision. As the video game character Paarthunax once asked, "What is better– to be born good, or to overcome your evil nature through great effort?" This led me to consider a broader question: is goodness (manifested through empathy, kindness, or compassion) more "authentic" when it comes naturally, or when it is consciously chosen?

In the video 'Pure Altruism: Does It Exist?' (Ranywayz Random, 2018), pure altruistic behaviour is defined as behaviour intended to directly or indirectly benefit others rather than the self, with the imperative that it involves some element of self-sacrifice. According to the definition of "pure" altruism mentioned above, it is physically impossible to achieve because neuropsychological and neurobiological studies using fMRI (functional magnetic resonance imaging) have shown that altruistic thinking triggered certain parts of the brain associated with pleasure. They concluded that altruism is thus not a "superior moral faculty that suppresses basic selfish urges" (Ranywayz Random, 2018, 7:07) but rather a fundamental mechanism in the human brain that makes altruistic behaviour

inherently rewarding, serving as an intrinsic form of pleasure, whether or not it was consciously intended.

This evidence shows that the capacity for altruistic behaviour is built into human nature, since helping others activates neural systems associated with rewards. However, this also complicates the idea that goodness is "more authentic" when it comes naturally. If altruistic impulses are biologically reinforced, then spontaneous goodness may simply reflect an automatic response rather than a deeper moral attitude of a person. In contrast, consciously choosing to act altruistically, especially when it involves effort, inconvenience, or no guaranteed reward, may reflect a more genuine form of goodness. Therefore, the findings in the video suggest that natural and deliberate goodness are not opposites. Instead, authentic goodness can arise when we recognise our innate tendency to be altruistic and intentionally act upon them, rather than just acting unreflectively.

But science can only tell us how goodness works. To ask what it means to be good is a question that belongs to the realm of religion and philosophy where humanity has always sought its moral compass. The article "How Can Empathy Be Achieved? – A Comparative Study Between the Christian 'Golden Rule' and the Buddhist 'Five Precepts and Ten Virtues' in China" (Wang, Liandong, et al., 2025) shows what teachings that have stood for centuries have to say about this fundamental moral instinct we are said to possess. The article compares Buddhism and Christian teachings, with the added input of well-known deontological philosopher, Immanuel Kant. It says that Buddhism views karma (*kamma*) and rebirth (*samsara*) as a gradual process of self-purification, placing emphasis on personal effort and responsibility in achieving a purified soul and enlightenment (*Bodhisattva*). It also talks about the Christian concept of original sin, which refers to the inherent condition of sinfulness, a tendency towards selfishness and moral weakness, which was inherited from Adam and Eve when they disobeyed God. In other words, when the first humans were created, they were created pure and sinless, but due to their act of disobedience, they forfeited this purity and fell into sin which all humans after them inherited. The Golden Rule was also established in Christianity by Jesus that taught people to "do unto others what you would have them do unto you". But this was rejected by philosopher Immanuel Kant and replaced with his Categorical Imperative, where "you should do unto others what you would rationally want everyone to do". This is because the Golden Rule "lacked sufficient rational foundation"(Wang, Liandong, et al., 2025, p. 7) – if the doer was a masochist and would like harm done unto him, does this permit him to harm others? Therefore, Kant believes that the categorical imperative is different from the Golden Rule in the way that it is not based on "feelings, impulses, and inclinations, but only on the relation of rational beings to one another" (Wang, Liandong, et al., 2025, p. 7).

These teachings that have existed for centuries show that moral worth has long been tied to human effort and intentionality. In Buddhism, moral purification is a process of conscious self-discipline. Goodness is essentially cultivated and not innate. Christianity, through the doctrine of original sin, likewise begins from the assumption that humans are inclined towards selfishness and must therefore choose to act in accordance with love for one another and divine law. Even Kant's rejection of the Christian "Golden Rule" reinforces the idea that morality should not arise from instinctive feelings or impulses, but from a rational commitment to universal moral principles. Together, these perspectives suggest that moral worth is not found in effortless virtue, but in the ongoing decision to overcome one's inherent/inevitable selfishness, to act rightly not because it is easy or natural, but because it is willed.

Taken together, these perspectives seem to suggest that moral worth cannot be located solely in biological inclination, but must involve conscious commitment. However, this then raises an uncomfortable implication: is "effortless" good then lacking moral significance? If authentic goodness depends on resisting inclination, then everyday goodness would be somehow less significant. But that is not true. To treat deliberate goodness as inherently superior would be turning morality into a form of performance. Moral worth cannot be determined solely by biological inclination, nor can it be measured by difficulty or effort alone. Authentic goodness is not performative, is not invalidated by ease, and is not confirmed by resistance. What undermines authenticity then is not acting with or against inclination, but acting for the sake of self-image, reward, or moral display. The sake of my argument is not to rank forms of goodness but to recognise that genuine goodness takes multiple forms, unified not by how they feel, but by their orientation away from the self and toward the good of others.

Looking back at that night on the bus, I realise that my cynicism said less about the bus captain's kindness and more about my own assumptions. I admired how naturally he seemed to care for others, and I put that kind of effortless goodness on a pedestal, as if it were something I simply was not born with. That assumption itself came from how I grew up thinking that "good people" are naturally gentle, patient, and never lose their cool. But through this inquiry, I have begun to understand that goodness is not fixed at birth. It can be cultivated through conscious choices just as meaningfully as it can emerge automatically. I may not be naturally inclined to kindness in the same effortless way, but that does not undermine its authenticity. If anything, the effort may be the very thing that gives it meaning. In the end, goodness is not measured by whether it comes easily or requires effort, but by the fact that we choose it at all.

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Community in the Haze: Smokers Isolated in Public

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"Stress *lah*... Boss told me..." Muttered conversation flowed through the air, mingling with a harsh, sharp dryness and a distinct smoky scent that clung to everything it touched. A painted yellow box-shaped pavement parked discreetly away from the bustling streets of Singapore announced itself as we approached. The air got thicker and hotter, so much so that I could almost taste its bitterness – a faint stinging sensation developing at the back of my throat. "Cover your nose, *ah boy*. Later your lungs turn black then you know, next time you grow up better not smoke *ah*!" A mother whispered harshly to her child, hoping to keep her comments private as she passed by the area.

Just then, the clacking of formal shoes sounded from behind, and a man donning a loose tie and an undone top button approached, pulling out a pack of cigarettes. Digging through his pockets once, twice, he came up empty-handed. The look of frustration on his face faded as a fellow smoker silently offered a lighter, their shared moment sparking an easy camaraderie. Within this enclosed space, conversations drifted from daily chatter to philosophical exchanges, postures loosening with each exhale.

For most, the smoking area is a path to avoid, visible in hurried footsteps and upturned noses. To the smokers, venturing to the smoke area is inevitable. Growing up around smokers, I was familiar with this scene. It was almost comforting. "Is there an issue with this area? Is there an issue being okay with hanging around smokers?" I wondered.

Looking beyond the people and the faded yellow box on the ground, what was meant to be a straightforward segregation of smokers and non-smokers for public health concerns has developed into a haven for individuals deemed "outsiders" by their habit, where social standing, age, and background blur, where acceptance arises from shared habit, not status. Each act – the silent offer of a lighter, the jokes intertwined with drags – reinforces a sense of camaraderie akin to a close-knit community. Yet, this unity is seemingly built through exclusion; the segregation is not just physical but symbolic, clearly showing who is "in" and who is "out". These details suggest a larger tension within communal life: designated spaces may appear to prevent social friction, but they can just as easily amplify judgment and deepen isolation. How could isolation itself become a defining force — one that both protects and marginalises a community?

We often associate communities with a group or location, but they do not just form out of thin air. An article by Australian psychology researchers Fong et al. (2021) in the journal *Environment and Behaviour* provides insights on third places, places besides work and home, and how such designated spaces nurture community identity. They reveal that third places often act as a medium for inclusion and exclusion, creating inclusion for those that align with the activities of the third place while excluding those that differ from them

(Fong et al., 2021, p. 550). This is the purpose of a community: to welcome those who welcome it and shun those that might not have a vested interest in it, protecting the members and activities within. This reinforces the barrier between those within it and mainstream society. To the elderly, the bridge club in the study was more than just a gathering location, but to others, it was a waste of space. How it transformed into what they term a space of "insideness" was through regular participation, which creates "a permanent place to go and a stable routine in their daily lives" (Fong et al., 2021, p. 550). A designated place, a location distinctive and permanent, becomes essential for those excluded elsewhere, providing a predictable acceptance in a world of unpredictable rejection.

Fong et al. (2021) also challenged the assumption that space alone creates community, arguing that a community is not just about a singular activity or location, but the collective experience of how the activity is done, how support is received, and the coping behind the restrictions of the location (p. 559). A third place is transformed into a symbolic place of belonging, the very definition of community, through shared interactions and inclusion. Circling back to the dynamics of the smoking corner, the yellow-boxed area provides the physical framework reminiscent of the clubhouse in the study, while the rituals – the detouring for a smoke, the offered lighter, the indulgence – forge the community. Though this might be significant in explaining how a community has been formed in designated smoking areas, it reveals a crucial gap: the study was done on elderly bridge players who chose voluntary participation, who saw the social needs for engagement due to ageing-related factors rather than social exclusion. Thus the question is, what happens when people seek alternative spaces not by choice, but by social judgement?

Erving Goffman's book, *Stigma* (1963), which analyses the experiences of stigmatised individuals, provides the theoretical backbone Fong et al.'s (2021) study lacks, explaining why communities are necessary for survival. His concept of the "moral career" refers to the process of how social norms create bad reputations for individuals with attributes condemned by society (Goffman, 1963, p. 32). If communities are necessary for survival, those who are rejected from "normal" society are then forced to create alternative communities. Unlike Fong et al.'s (2021) voluntary bridge players who chose third places for social needs, those who are stigmatised inhabit places to seek refuge from moral condemnation. When society indicates that certain traits are unwelcome, those affected adopt strategies which minimise the exposure of such traits to fit into society. Then their real group would be one where they are able to freely express themselves, which is defined as "the aggregate of persons who are likely to have to suffer the same deprivations as he suffers because of having the same stigma" (Goffman, 1963, p. 113).

This provides the reasons for marginalised individuals' viewpoints on community. Their community is formed out of a need for solace and most importantly belonging, which they are unable to find in mainstream society due to their undesirable traits. The act of smoking marks them as morally deficient in health-conscious Singaporean society, leading to the creation of designated smoking areas in Singapore due to public health concerns. This serves the same purpose as forcing the smokers in Singapore to create their own community. The real group for smokers then exists in the designated smoking corner and transforms how each action is defined in it; the offering of a lighter is not just courtesy but the recognition that "Hey, this guy had to come all the way here to smoke too; let me help him out", that all members had the common experience of being

exiled to that corner for their smoking habits. The smoking corner allows smokers to stop "covering" and experience authentic acceptance.

An analysis of both studies reveals two distinct pathways to forming a community, but also that both pathways serve a common purpose. Fong et al.'s (2021) study on elderly bridge players illustrates voluntary community building through the desire for social interactions, while Goffman's (1963) stigmatised individuals represent an involuntary community that is born from rejection and protection. Though the two communities are born through different means, their purpose remains the same for the members: to belong and connect, to share and accept. The smoking corner is the perfect embodiment of the processes outlined by Fong et al.'s (2021) "third places" and Goffman's (1963) analysis on the behaviour of those stigmatised, demonstrating how spaces meant to exclude can beneficially transform through shared rituals and mutual recognition, challenging the assumption that isolation and community cannot coexist. While smokers do not choose to be stigmatised, and in the context of Singapore, did not choose to congregate, what they did choose was how to respond to it, transforming it into a space where Goffman's "spoiled identity" (1963) transforms into Fong et al.'s "insideness" (2021). This shows that isolation imposed through moral judgement does not destroy community; it relocates and intensifies it.

The purpose has been reversed. When Singapore drew the boundaries to exclude smokers, they did not disappear. Instead, they utilised the space to create an alternative community where different values prosper – where smoking becomes a source of connection rather than isolation, where shared rejections develop a deep acceptance and inclusion that mainstream society struggles to provide. The smoking corners in Singapore are now "stigma sanctuar[ies]" (Goffman, 1963), operating on their own systems that invert what society wants. In a society that increasingly uses moral judgement to police behaviour, as seen from the hate for the LGBTQ+ community, those with different dietary choices etc., these findings suggest that maybe the act of moral judgement paradoxically strengthens the very communities society seeks to discourage.

Perhaps the strongest bonds are not forged through acceptance, but through shared rejection. Perhaps a true community emerges not when it is welcomed by the mainstream, but when spaces are created to welcome those whom society would rather ignore. In Singapore lies the smoking corner; was it a failed social policy? No, it is a necessity. A refuge where the act of lighting a cigarette becomes an act of communion, and where society's outcasts discover that they are not alone.

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Hands Wrapped

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The rhythmic thudding of boxing gloves hitting punching bags and the light shuffle of feet on mats echoed throughout the boxing gym. The boxing gym looked as if it were a canvas splashed with vibrant paints: colourful boxing gloves in violet, crimson, and electric blue cut through the air with every jab, while hot pink hand wraps lay strewn on the floor like long, never-ending ribbons. Delicate, floral notes of women's deodorant, mixed with the musky scent of leather, filled my nostrils. "Jab! Cross! Hook!" A sharp, high-pitched voice rang out. I turned towards its source and saw women training diligently, their eyes set with determination and fully in the zone.

No matter the day or hour, the boxing gym was always filled with women. Surprising, isn't it? Combat sports are usually perceived as masculine, and one would expect men to dominate such spaces instead of women. Hence, the sheer number of women in such "masculine" spaces deeply puzzled me, leading me to question why they were there in the first place. Perhaps it was merely another method of weight loss? Personally, I first signed up at my boxing gym, Evolve MMA, to learn self-defence. Upon hearing my reason for joining, the receptionist nodded approvingly and explained that they often turn away those who enrol solely to lose weight, as the gym prioritises practical combat skills. It became evident that my motivation mirrored that of many other women, that all of us were here to learn self-defence. This stood out to me especially in Singapore — a country that boasts one of the lowest crime rates globally. Yet, if safety is guaranteed, why do so many women still feel compelled to learn self-defence? This disconnect reveals that while Singapore can be statistically safe on paper, it does not necessarily translate into women's lived realities. Therefore, this raises an important question: how do women perceive safety in Singapore?

In "Foucault, Femininity, and the Modernization of Patriarchal Power," Bartky (2014) examines how societal norms enforce internal discipline by restricting women's posture and movements, illustrating how they self-police to conform to ideals of femininity as a means of staying safe. Bartky states that "Woman's space is not a field in which her bodily intentionality can be freely realised but an enclosure in which she feels herself positioned and by which she is confined" (2014, p. 97). Since young, girls are taught to keep their limbs close, to sit properly, and to occupy minimal space — not simply to appear more graceful and feminine, but to avoid unwanted attention and prevent being perceived as provocative. Such discipline becomes internalised as they grow older, where women self-regulate to minimise risk and pre-empt threat to feel safe, not simply to conform to society's expectations of how a woman should present herself. Femininity, then, is not merely a matter of appearance, but an internalised form of self-protection that teaches women to limit movement, reduce vulnerability and remain safe.

Therefore, women are socially conditioned to inhabit their bodies with caution; to restrict movement and

maintain "modesty" to feel safe. In doing so, their freedom of expression is compromised, where caution, rather than choice, dictates their movement. In a conservative society like Singapore, women may feel safer when they conform to such societal expectations, where modesty becomes a way for women to minimise risk and mitigate victimisation. Hence, women in Singapore, a statistically safe country, may perceive safety not as a given right, but as something "earned" through self-regulation and conformity. Safety, therefore, becomes conditional; granted only when women adhere to norms of femininity and modesty through restricting bodily expression. This, in itself, is ironic, as safety is conventionally understood as feeling protected which then enables one to act freely; yet, for women, it becomes something that can only be earned through conformity, thus invalidating the very principle of what safety signifies. Consequently, women's bodily comportment reflects the desire to remain acceptable within patriarchal norms, shaping their perception of safety as a reward of conformity rather than freedom. Yet, women who engage in combat sports challenge these norms by refusing to restrict their movement to conform to ideals of femininity. Such acts of resistance highlight that safety and agency can exist beyond conventional expectations.

While Bartky (2014) focuses inward on how women internalise societal norms through self-regulation, her analysis is largely internal and psychological. However, this inward focus overlooks how these same patriarchal norms manifest externally in the physical spaces women navigate. Lan (2025) addresses this in "Performing 'Asian' Femininities and the Paradox of Masculinities under Cis-Heteropatriarchy: Unpacking the Socio-Spatial Construction of Young Women's Fears in Public Spaces in Singapore." Contrary to the common belief that Singapore is safe for women, Lan (2025) argues that women still experience fear in public spaces, not solely due to the presence of crime, but also because fear is a social construct — it is shaped and reinforced by societal norms, manifesting differently across genders within Singapore's patriarchal society. This fear is deeply rooted in socio-spatial power dynamics: to put simply, the spatial manifestation of patriarchy, where public spaces are constructed as "masculine" because men possess greater control and dominance within these spaces. Lan attributes this to what she calls "the paradox of masculinity", where "masculinity is seen as both the perpetrator and protector of sexualised crime" (2025). Women may fear male strangers while simultaneously relying on "safer" men, such as spouses or male relatives, for protection. Since men are often the perpetrators of sexualised crime, this association reinforces their dominance and authority in public spaces. Lan (2025) also highlights how sexual crime-prevention posters are commonly seen in Singapore, advising women on ways to "protect" themselves from sexual harassment. Such posters ascertain women's vulnerability to sexualised crime, which is materialised in the urban environment. This contradicts the portrayal of Singapore as "safe", as these posters themselves reinforce how sexualised crimes are prevalent. Consequently, women are often portrayed as "fearful" in public spaces as they are at greater risk of sexual harassment. In contrast, men are granted the privilege of moving through these same spaces without fear.

Despite Singapore's reputation as one of the safest countries in the world, women's persistent feelings of fear in Singapore's public spaces are proof that their perception of safety cannot be measured by crime rates alone but is shaped by the aforementioned socio-spatial dynamics that Lan (2025) highlights. Reframing women's fear and, by extension, their perception of safety, as a social construct, exposes

how little control women have over their own perception of safety. We live in a patriarchy where women's perception of safety is contingent on men and their behaviour, shedding light on the harsh reality that women's perception of safety is ever so fragile and never fully in their hands. Consequently, women navigate public spaces cautiously and avoid certain places. Ironically, women's fear only reinforces men's dominance in such public spaces, creating a vicious cycle in which fear both stems from and perpetuates the existing patriarchy.

Bartky (2014) explains how women internalise societal norms enforced upon them, and by looking inwards, she views women's bodies as the primary site of regulation and control. Her perspective suggests that women retain some degree of agency over their perception of safety, as they can choose to conform to feel secure, albeit influenced by social pressures to do so. Lan (2025) builds on Bartky's (2014) internal focus, explaining that control is not only internalised through self-regulation but also externally and spatially manifested. Lan's (2025) analysis explains how external societal dynamics further restrict women's control over their perception of safety, which Bartky's (2014) internal analysis could not fully capture. Essentially, their analyses expose how women lack control over their perception of safety as it is socially constructed.

Perhaps that explains the sheer number of women in the boxing gym: to reclaim control. Reflecting on my experiences, I realise that women's perception of safety is shaped not only by societal structures but also by uncertainty, and that our desire for control is a response to that uncertainty. Many adjustments women like myself make in daily life, such as modifying our routes and being mindful of the way we dress, are not merely precautions but calculated acts of self-preservation in a world of inherent unpredictability and uncertainty.

Stepping into the boxing gym was my first deliberate action to reclaim control. In this space, control is no longer something I adopt out of necessity, but something I can exercise on my own terms. Practising self-defence, from learning to throw a punch to holding a guard, does not erase uncertainty, but it ensures I am no longer powerless in the face of it. Control, then, is not about eliminating uncertainty, but about facing it with composure rather than fear. In this light, women's perception of safety is shaped by the agency and autonomy to confront this world of uncertainty with confidence. We cannot control the world beyond the gym's walls, but we can choose how we navigate the uncertainties it holds.

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Behind the Smoke: A Look at Singapore's Smoking Corners

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My nose caught the familiar and unmistakable scent of tobacco drifting from our usual gathering spot. An ever-increasing number of cigarette butts littered the ash-blackened ground as I approached the smoking corner. A small makeshift shelter held benches and bins, their surfaces topped with cigarette butts swimming in waterlogged ashtrays. Just beyond the shelter, a no-smoking sign had been plastered on the adjacent wall, barely two meters away. There were more people than the shelter could take, some drifting to its edges, others orbiting, indifferent to boundaries. How ironic it was, that despite the bins and clearly marked limits of the smoking corner, people seemed completely indifferent to them.

"Cough, cough," my friend rasped harshly, startling me, before spitting on the concrete floor. As I looked on, feeling queasy, I noticed a few smokers following suit, spitting out thick, dark phlegm that stained the pavement. The tar-like residue was jarring to look at, but spitting seemed to be just part of the routine here. At that moment, a passerby walked through the area, shooting my friend and me a look that could only be described as disdain. She sped up as she drew near and appeared to be holding her breath. I was unsure of what I felt: was it discomfort, defensiveness or guilt by association? The unease lingered. Was this how smokers felt? Was this a normal everyday occurrence? The thought unsettled me because I realised I had worn that same expression before, unable to stand the same smell that I am now strangely unbothered by. What had changed in the past few years? Was my previous perception influenced by constant tales of how foul and harmful smoking was? The only conclusion I could draw was that perhaps, my dislike was not an innate response, but a learnt one.

My dislike of smoking, at some point, even extended to the smokers themselves. If smoking is bad, then smokers must be bad too, or at the very least, thoughtless or disrespectful. This mindset was possibly perpetuated by the habits common in smoking culture — the careless spitting or littering of cigarette butts that reinforce this rebellious image, adding to the stereotype and fuelling negative perceptions. Together with a multitude of health campaigns and regulations such as the graphic diseased images on cigarette boxes, it is no wonder we have been conditioned to view smoking in a negative light. If I had taken on that judgment so easily, perhaps others had too. Over time, such shared judgments do more than shape personal opinions. They structure how we relate to one another in public spaces, determining who is seen as fitting within the social order and who is marked as out of place. It was this train of thought that led me to wonder: how does the public's attitude towards smoking affect the social landscape in Singapore?

In their research article, Pascal et al. (2023) investigate how incidental emotions, particularly disgust, can unconsciously influence people to be

prejudiced against minority groups. Participants were exposed to either disgust-inducing or neutral images before evaluating different ethnic minorities. The study shows that those who experienced disgust towards the ethnic minorities reported stronger negative emotions during the study, such as fear and anger, together with a decrease in positive emotions such as admiration (Pascal et al., 2023). In addition, there is an increased likelihood of participants endorsing negative stereotypes about the ethnic community, like their work ethic and personal habits. It showed that "incidental disgust increased not only the negative emotions associated with [minority groups] but also the negative thoughts linked to them and the desire to keep a greater social distance" (Pascal et al., 2023, para. 1).

Pascal et al.'s (2023) argument echoes my own observations. Just as incidental disgust can heighten prejudice against minority groups, the disturbing images and harsh warnings, while effective in reducing smoking rates, may also have reinforced stigma towards smokers. Such campaigns can shape a divided social landscape, as smokers find themselves excluded by disgust-evoking messages that lead to greater social isolation. However, I think it is important to consider the audience's characteristics, such as prior beliefs or personal experiences, that could shape how these messages are received. I remember those campaigns and the sway they held over my perception. But I also recognise how personal experiences have changed my views. Knowing smokers personally has challenged the one-dimensional image these campaigns project. Emotionally-charged messaging can lose its persuasive power when it clashes with lived experience and understanding.

In contrast, Humphreys & Caulkins (2023) argue that stigma can be a powerful force for good. Reflecting on the opioid crisis in the United States, their opinion piece discusses how the aim of destigmatising drug use is so that users would be more educated and use it more responsibly. They criticise these attempts to destigmatise drug use, suggesting instead that public disapproval is a more effective deterrent and trying to use drugs safely is not an alternative to dissuading usage altogether. They point to the dramatic decline in smoking in America and how "cigarette smoking went from being banal and ubiquitous in the 1950s to uncommon today" (Humphreys & Caulkins, 2023), attributing it largely to stigma, policy, and cultural shifts. The article also suggests that societal condemnation has been crucial in changing behaviour (Humphreys & Caulkins, 2023). While they do acknowledge the dangers of excessive or cruel stigma, they ultimately believe that a certain level of shame is necessary to protect public health. In their view, meaningful intervention involves pressure from stigma against the act, balanced with compassion for the individuals.

Humphreys & Caulkins's (2023) opinion piece shows how the public's attitude can directly impact and reduce rates of smoking, shifting the perception of smoking from normal to deviant. Their argument highlights how attitudes can reshape entire social landscapes. While Humphreys & Caulkins (2023) argue for compassion toward individuals alongside stigma toward the act, I believe this separation is unrealistic in the Singapore context. Stigma directed at the act of smoking can easily spill over to the individual, transforming public concern into moral judgment. Over time, this drives a wedge between smokers and non-smokers as public health messaging without compassion can turn into a narrative that labels smokers as 'bad people', reinforcing distance rather than fostering change.

Humphreys & Caulkins' (2023) argument aligns with Pascal et al.'s (2023) in recognising stigma's power in shaping behaviour and influencing social norms. Both

acknowledge the potential harm stigma can bring to those targeted by it. However, they diverge in views on its impact: Pascal et al. (2023) focus on the consequences of stigmas, cautioning that though effective, they also carry unintended societal costs, fueling discrimination and isolation. In contrast, Humphreys & Caulkins (2023) view stigma as a necessary safeguard, highlighting its utility as a public health tool. Where Pascal et al. (2023) view stigma as something to be managed and mitigated, Humphreys & Caulkins (2023) disagree, seeing it as something to be preserved and strategically directed.

While Pascal et al. (2023) argue that stigma fosters social division and Humphreys & Caulkins (2023) view it as a necessary form of moral enforcement, they do not discuss how the public's attitude towards smokers in Singapore shapes a morally stratified landscape. Beyond splitting society into opposing camps, stigma constructs a moral hierarchy that ties a sense of belonging to outward displays of discipline and compliance. This hierarchy reflects Singapore's long-standing emphasis on order, cleanliness and self-control, ideals repeatedly echoed by public messaging, education and everyday social norms. Within this moral order, abstaining from smoking becomes more than a matter of health — it is the visible declaration of restraint and civic virtue. Hence, I argue that public attitude towards smoking affects Singapore's social landscape as smokers become symbols of moral deviance, regarded as individuals who lack restraint and disrupt the visual and moral order of public space, subverting Singapore's ideals. The smoking corner itself stands as a physical manifestation of this stratification, a boundary marking who belongs at the centre, and who must remain at the edges.

It is easy to believe that the answer to this moral hierarchy lies in kinder words or better campaigns. But maybe the real issue lies with us, who are quick to pass judgment. My encounters with smokers showed me how we instinctively rush to sort people into categories of right or wrong, accepted or rejected. Perhaps true discipline is not only found in abstaining from a cigarette, but in the harder task of holding back judgment. We have learnt to challenge stereotypes about race, gender, and background by reminding ourselves that people are more than the labels we give them. Maybe we can start doing the same for smokers.

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Majulah *Fashionpura*!

By Ang En
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As I walk through the doors of the MRT train, I find a plethora of eyes upon me, and I am suddenly made aware of the clinking of my hanging trinkets and the clacking of my accessories. I feel drenched in vibrance and blinding in comparison to the dull colours of plain shirts and shorts surrounding me, and I find a strange awkward feeling threatening to consume me. They are my audience, and I am their actor, performing just by merely standing with all my extra skins of uncustomary fabric. It is a scary and unusual feeling that accompanies me, a consequence of subverting conventional fashion norms, especially when I realise how painfully different I am from other Singaporeans. But to conform to the conventions of this country and betray the conventions of my heart? It felt blasphemous to me. So now I hold my head up high and courageously declare to the world with my garments, 'I am different!'

I take pride in the clothing I wear, as I treat it like an art form. My body is the canvas and my fashion pieces are the paint. It is like being a walking exhibition of art, and bypassers are transformed into spectators of my creation. Some might call it narcissism, but I would rather call it self-confidence, which is what evolves style from strange to striking. In my journey with exploring fashion, I have received several reactions ranging from sceptical side-eyes to amazed smiles, and I find one consistent comment being made throughout: 'I wish I had the courage to dress like you.' The noun 'courage' suggests that there is a fear present, which is an obstacle preventing this person from dressing in a similar fashion as me. So every time I hear this sentence, I find these questions popping up in my head: What is stopping you? What are you afraid of? Is this fear perpetuated by society or self-inflicted? It feels hypocritical to think this way, as I have felt this same fear before and I still feel it sometimes when I step out of the house. But that is when I catch myself and interrogate this fear. If there is nothing wrong about being different, then what is there to be afraid of? So many thoughts and wonderings culminate into one big question: What is stopping Singaporeans from being different?

Singaporeans seem to suffer from 'tall poppy syndrome', according to a 2024 CNA article written by Larissa Santhana Nair, which claims that 'We tend to put down Singaporeans who stand out too much'. 'Tall poppy syndrome' happens when an individual thrives unconventionally, and surrounding peers respond by pressuring the individual to conform to what is conventional. People who stand out seem to be subjected to disapproval for living outside the cookie cutter mould of life established by society. People dressed in plain tops and bottoms are the common poppies, while someone in a ball gown would be a tall poppy, which could be cut down to the same level as the common ones.

We Singaporeans grew up being spoon-fed with the idea of success in the form of economic prosperity and high education, which Nair refers to as the 'Singaporean Dream' (2024). Yet this idea overlooks how success can be defined by other capacities like

the liberty to choose what clothes reside in your closet. The 'Singaporean Dream' diminishes the value of non-materialistic pursuits and packages itself as a tried and tested way of achieving in society, which has led to the fear of '[m]aking life choices that are markedly different from what we've seen and heard all our lives [as it] would make us stick out, possibly attracting wanted attention or criticism' (Nair, 2024).

Linking the fear of difference with clothes in this city that revolves around work, fashion and productivity seem to clash in priorities, as contended by Ashley Wong, Deputy Editor of *Hype* (2023). Wong (2023) argues that the majority of Singaporeans are more concerned about staying comfortable and ensuring productive work levels, which makes fashion irrelevant to them. She gives a variety of possible explanations for the lack of Singaporean style, like having limited time that Singaporeans would rather use for work and school.

Typical Singaporeans see clothing as convenient garments to cover themselves, rather than a form of self-expression. This may be rooted in the Singaporean bare minimum of prioritizing practicality over the apparent irrelevant luxury of dressing up, except for events that necessitate proper attire. It is an unspoken thread that binds Singaporeans together in their homely attires, so no one would blink an eye when seeing others dressed down outside. However, it is this same thread that causes heads to turn when people dress up for daily activities like getting groceries from the supermarket. Experimenting outside of the Singaporean garb just for the sake of interest therefore becomes an absurd subject matter, and it seems like an insufficient reason to explain that you are doing something because you simply feel like it.

It is therefore convenient to dress oneself with the stereotypical 'toss-up between the singlet and shorts or the shirt and shorts, both options paired with flip-flops' (Wong, 2023). There is no shame because everybody else is wearing the same thing, so why bother putting in the effort when no one else is? Just toss on whatever and call it a day; this is the Singaporean mindset, set for Singaporeans and by Singaporeans. When somebody strays away from this sentiment and dresses up for themselves, they are accused of being vain, selfish, or even narcissistic; this ironically comes from a society that prides itself on being inclusive, and if you ask why, you will get the Singlish answer of 'Because it's like that *lor*.'

Moreover, the concept of conformity has maintained throughout generations due to its prominence in building the foundations of Singapore's independence in 1965, where 'Singaporeans have been hand-held [by the government] towards uncomfortable concepts that would lead to its success' (Nair, 2024). When Singapore did new things, they did it together with the government, so Singaporeans now perceive this pattern of being 'hand-held' and sticking to the same lifestyle as the only way of living. I believe this makes it difficult for Singaporean individuals to tackle different things on their own, as they would be metaphorically straying away from the flock.

Considering this, Nair (2024) argues: 'Most of us do not have to worry about our primary and basic needs' as 'our nation is well past its post-independence transformation'. Hence, 'the traditional Singaporean route, while pragmatic, does not hold the same weight and value anymore' (Nair, 2024). We have crossed the threshold of survival, so there is capacity for people to try new ways of living. Singaporeans must realise this ability.

Nevertheless, Wong (2023) argues: 'If fashion is meant to be a reflection of things you wish to express creatively, the way that our country operates rarely allows any possibility of that happening' as 'we've

never given Singapore a chance to try'. I find that Singaporeans subconsciously implement this barrier upon themselves and one another, whether that is due to the 'tall poppy syndrome' or the comfort of familiarity. Even though we have the capacity to change, we simply do not because of this self-inflicted fear that makes us reluctant to step out of our comfort zone.

Perhaps Singaporeans are not afraid of being different, but of themselves. We as people, not just as Singaporeans, are constantly aware of our dynamics with one another, concerned whether we belong or stand out. The desire to fit in is simply human nature. But who is to say that we cannot accept unique people who choose to be different? Stripped of all judgement and assumptions, clothing and garments, differences and likeness, we are left but with one single thing: the human essence. How can we say that we are an inclusive society when we side-eye and sneer at those who are dressed differently? Perhaps the key to overcoming the fear of being different is to establish the universal acceptance of one another based on the mere fact that we are human. So maybe instead of declaring to the world that 'I am different!', I should instead declare that 'I am human!'

Acknowledgements

I would like to express my gratitude to my tutor, Ms Zaneta Lai, for encouraging me to tackle this issue. Her support pushed me to dig deeper and reveal the implications of Singaporean society within my interest in fashion, which I never would have realised if it were not for my tutor's encouragements to explore further.

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Who Am I – Writing Across Different Circumstances

By Ng Jonas Huang Xianmin

Bachelor of Science in Biomedical Sciences and BioBusiness

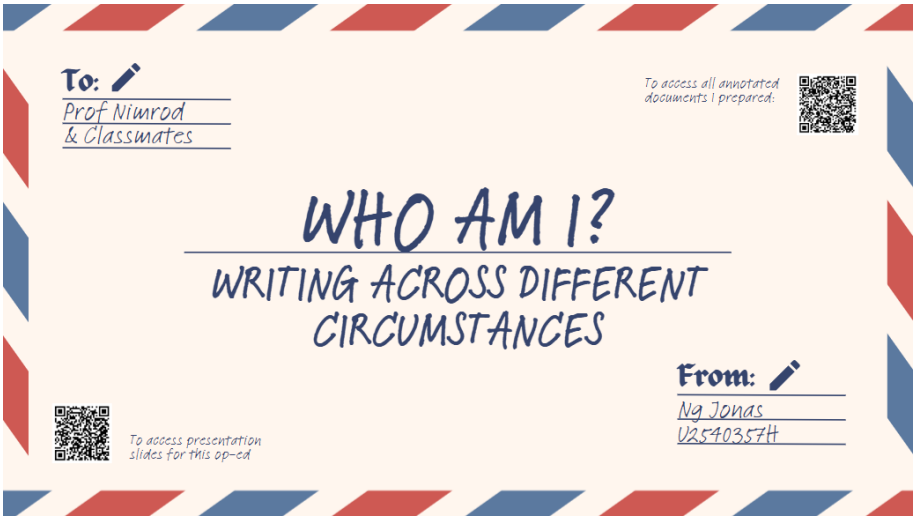

Figure 1. My presentation slide for this op-ed.

I have been staring blankly at my computer screen for the past three hours. For our 'Inquiry and Communication in an Interdisciplinary World' module, my professor has tasked us to write an op-ed. As a Biology student, writing has always been a daunting task - a nightmare - for me.

What is an op-ed anyway? And how do I - in his words - 'produce heat and light' *with it?*

The night sky twinkles mockingly as dawn threatens its arrival. I blink, not a thought behind my caffeinated, bloodshot eyes. We either choose a place in Singapore to explore, choose a community or subculture to discuss, or choose to analyse our own writing styles. *But what's there to analyse about my writing anyway?*

I pounce across my dorm room and pull out the notes I wrote carelessly in class earlier. Keywords, arrows and symbols sprawled haphazardly across the paper; curt, straightforward, with absolutely no regard for style, legibility, or structure whatsoever.

I cock an eyebrow; *no one's going to read this, anyway.*

Scrambling through crushed balls of paper in my bag, I come across the application essays I wrote months ago when I applied for universities:

Literary devices danced radiantly throughout my essays: literary tricolons, alliterations, and dramatic paragraphs flooded with adverbs. I also used cautionary disclaimers and quantifiers, disguised as nuance but in reality, weak attempts at answering questions that I was overly ambitious to tackle.

It was almost conniving - every word curated strategically to capture eyes and hearts; I was desperate to stand out from the other candidates. Frantic for achievements to paraphrase, "working with teachers" turned into "partnership with key

stakeholders", whilst "volunteering with elderly" somehow transformed into "significant societal movement for the vulnerable".

Such falsehood, I muse, *I should be eligible for a Nobel Peace Prize.*

I vividly remember the bewilderment on my parents' faces when they read my essays for the first time, "Wow, Jonas, did *you* write this? This doesn't sound like you!"

Their comment unfurled a whole ball of realisations inside me: *They are right; at times, my writing is drastically different from how I normally communicate.*

Without an audience, I am straightforward and practical. With competition, I am hypocritical and even dishonest. When writing about myself, I am self-aggrandising and self-righteous - dramatic, yet cautious.

Why? Why are there so many facades of myself?

This made me wonder if I was being my 'true-self' or simply presenting a curated facade as I write. As my pen dances across the paper, the conflict between myself as my 'true-self', and myself as simply a vehicle that different personalities and facades take turns occupying comes to the forefront of my mind.

Writing across different circumstances, how do these facades emerge? And how does this blur, conflate, and interact with the self?

This reminds me: my CC0001 professor discussed the importance of writing and close reading in our lessons. He emphasised the importance of penetrating through different disciplines, different lens while looking into a piece of literature. *Oh yes*, I realise, *he sent us some documents to read in preparation for our next lesson!*

Snapping back to reality, I scurry back to my computer and pulled out the two PDF files my professor had sent me: "Writing As Illusion" by Daryll Anderson (1984), and "Writing and the Unmaking of the Self" by Eugene Goodheart (1988).

Anderson's "Writing as Illusion" (1984) is an interesting, even *enthralling* read. "Absolutely honest self-expression is impossible in writing, for every sentence, every word, every temporal and logical arrangement compromise the whole, true self" (Anderson, 1984, p. 6): Anderson argues that writers create facades, intentionally curating words and ideas to present a certain outward appearance. On the other hand, honesty and truth in writing is "tiresome", "distracting", gives "no pleasure", and is "neither desirable nor possible" (Anderson, 1984, p. 7, 9, 11). In fact, he goes further by arguing that some falsehood is necessary for coherence, and may even be enjoyable for the readers – "people enjoy being deceived... the awareness to enjoy the spectacle" (Anderson, 1984, p. 8).

I squint my eyes - *Is Anderson saying that all writing is an illusion? Does he mean that there is no true self in writing?*

If there is no true self in writing, who am I? A repertoire of facades I have created in my writing? How do these facades interact with each other and with my identity as the writer?

To probe deeper, I open up the second PDF - "Writing and the Unmaking of the Self" by Eugene Goodheart (1988). Goodheart (1988) claims that as writers apply themselves to their passions, the self constantly 'unmakes' (fragments) and 'makes' (reshapes) itself through imagination and desire. Through imagination, the writer undergoes experiences without literally going through these experiences themself, such as death and an unlived alternate life. Desire, on the other

hand, is the destabilising force that tears apart the writer's coherence and control.

Just then. A sentence catches my eye.

"The natural being may be the skill itself, the innate capacity to impersonate… What I have instead is a variety of impersonations… a troupe of players… a permanent company of actors… an ever-evolving stock of pieces and parts that forms my repertoire" (Goodheart, 1988, p. 438).

I gasp - *Goodheart agrees with Anderson! In writing, there is no true self!*

I lean back in my chair, processing the overlap of both sources and their answers in response to my overall question.

Answering the first part of my overall question - "*Who are we? Are we being our true-selves or simply facades in our writing?*" - both authors agree that there is no true self in writing, and that facades evolve from the writer's construction of personas.

However, Goodheart (1988) goes further and describes the interactions between the self and the facades (and even between the facades), answering the second part of my overall question - "*How do these facades blur, conflate, and interact with the self?*" Writing destroys and fragments, makes and unmakes the self, where multiple fragments of the self coexist, collide, and even erase each other within the act of writing.

I wince, *but there* are *some differences between Anderson's (1984) and Goodheart's (1988) claims*: Anderson (1984) feels that the creation of these facades is deliberate, where the writer has high control, whereas Goodheart (1988) believes that these facades evolve from the inevitable dissolution of the self, where the writer has limited control. Anderson (1984) believes that there is a pre-existing writer's self that is lived through the created persona, but Goodheart (1988) contends that the writer's self is plural, performative and always in flux, never a single entity in the first place.

Reflecting inwards, Anderson's (1984) arguments and Goodheart's (1988) assertions also have differing applications in my own life, too. Compared to Goodheart's (1988) foreign assertions, Anderson's (1984) claims apply more closely to myself: I intentionally curated and arranged my ideas to form a desired outward appearance to the university interviewers, where I used some falsehood - perhaps an *enjoyable and amusing* falsehood - to gently deceive the interviewers.

If I were to provide my own insights, what if, the self does not exist before writing and is *created through* writing? Opposing what both authors believe, perhaps the self is formed part by part, facade by facade, through writing - where writing is self-creation, not fragmentation. For example, writing differently for different purposes reflects how I behave differently when portraying myself to others versus to myself, but both are different sides of the same coin (my 'true self').

Furthermore, although both Anderson (1984) and Goodheart (1988) excuse some levels of falsehood (which I concede is somewhat inevitable in writing), we must stay true to the core values of honesty, integrity and respect. As ethical writers, we must never write with the intent to misinform others; and just like all other forms of communication, writing should be done for the growth of individuals and humanity.

I nod profoundly; *this will be my* 'heat and light'. Challenging Anderson's (1984) view of truth as *boring* and *undesirable*, I should work towards greater genuineness as a writer, creating personas that reduce falsehood and resemble my true self as much as possible.

I sigh. As a Biology student, this topic is certainly more than *'a daunting nightmare'* to unpack. However, in the spirit of 'inquiry into different disciplines', I should give it a try.

The morning's threat finally dawns on me, as my bloodshot eyes fade into a darkened shade of enlightenment.

I think... I know what I am going to write for my op-ed.

Acknowledgements

I have always believed that any artistic work – be it an essay, a painting, a piece of music – is not created by a single person alone. Yes, the completed work could truly have been done by one person, but the person's thoughts, artistic style, and so on is likely to be a curation of their community of people. For myself, I owe my writing style to many people: first and foremost, my family, who serves as my basis in life, to strive for excellence in what I do. Secondly, my CC0001 tutor Prof Nimrod, whose guidance, advice, and encouragement were genuinely the reasons why I managed to persevere through this challenging topic. Last but certainly not least, my best friend and brother, Cai Xin Ze, who significantly helped me grow into the man I am today, my values and my perspective in life. Thank you for being my best friend and brother, Xin Ze. Do check out his op-ed: 'The Solo and the Self: Finding a Voice in Jazz'. Writing is communication, to express our opinions, to hold ourselves upright, and to showcase our personality. Go out there, start writing.

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The Solo and the Self: Finding a Voice in Jazz

By Cai Xin Ze

Bachelor of Science in Biomedical Sciences and BioBusiness

Sitting in the Nanyang Hill rehearsal room, I smelled notes of rosin and warmed lacquer, the scent settling as the sterile white fluorescent lights hummed above, and the acoustic foam on the walls flattened echoes into a steady, close sound. A clock ticked over the doorway, its second-hand like a metronome, punctuating the room's slow and steady ambience. Two freshmen shuffled in together. I noticed one's bass slung low, the strap biting his shoulder, and the other cradling his electric guitar, with a cable looped tight around the headstock. They kept to the edge of the room, fingers worrying straps, avoiding eye contact – a posture that registered their unease. A senior offered a bright "Welcome." The freshmen replied with a short nod and a low "Hey," and I found myself listening for who would fill the silence. During the run-through, I heard the guitarist's neat lines, accurate chord changes, steady tempi, small, short fills, and conservative rhythms. Nothing that demanded attention.

At the set's last chart, things loosened. The bass moved into a single locked groove. The drummer suddenly opened space instead of filling every bar. The guitarist who had been withdrawn took a breath and let a phrase out. He held notes longer, bent strings until they sounded raw, and pushed his amp toward feedback. At moments, the timing wavered and notes slipped; rather than jarring me, it heightened the sense that something unplanned was happening. The room's soundscape was rapidly evolving, and I heard someone call out in encouragement. When the solo concluded, one bandmate shouted praise, and there was a visceral eruption of genuine applause, perhaps in recognition of the risk taken in public.

Two things stood out to me. First, I observed that for most of the rehearsal, players managed small, composed selves, careful sounds and measured body language. Second, in the solo, the guitarist abandoned caution and produced a sound that felt less performed and more exposed – and I felt the difference in the room immediately. Crucially, that exposure mattered only because others in the room received it; their shifts in accompaniment and the later cheer made the moment meaningful. This suggested to me that improvisation exceeds private catharsis and technical display, functioning as a practice in which a musician tries on an alternate way of being and exposes that experiment to others' judgment.

As I kept replaying the moment in my mind, I began to wonder what exactly had changed – not just musically, but personally. *How had a brief act of sound shifted the guitarist's sense of self so sharply?* I wanted to know, because I recognised a parallel with how I shape my own public persona. *Was there something in the nature of improvisation that allowed him to inhabit a truer version of himself, even if only for a few bars?* These questions coalesced into a broader inquiry that guided my research: *In an era when identities are frequently curated, how does jazz improvisation operate as a practice through which musicians construct and obtain social recognition for their authentic identity?*

With these questions, I went to sociologist Tia DeNora's research journal article, "Music as a Technology of the Self" (1999), which reframes music as an active tool people use to shape their conduct, emotions and identities. She argues that musical practices are not merely decorative, they are operative, habitual practices that afford people ways to structure time, rehearse feeling-states, and enact social roles. This claim felt persuasive to me when I listened to how the guitarist's behaviour shifted. Seeking further empirical grounding for what I had heard in rehearsal, I drew on her study of everyday musical routines, on how people use songs to transition between moods or prepare for roles that stabilise a sense of self. For DeNora, "music provides respondents with a scaffolding for self-constitution" (1999, p. 31), providing people with templates and affordances to actively deploy in becoming particular kinds of persons.

DeNora (1999) helps explain the mechanics behind the rehearsal moment by showing how musical routines concretely shape attention and bodily posture. The guitarist's longer phrases and feedback operated as expressive acts and embodied practices that reshaped his posture, breathing, and attention, thereby creating the conditions for a different self-presentation. Improvisation became a "technology for spinning the apparently 'continuous' tale of who one 'is'" (DeNora, 1999, p. 45), with the musician experimenting with an alternative affective and bodily profile, being louder, more open, more risk-ready. I saw how that reassured the guitarist to try, and for me, this reframed authenticity as something constructed through musical practice rather than discovered passively.

Yet, DeNora's (1999) model remains primarily inward-looking. Her emphasis on individual self-construction opens the question of how these experimental selves gain traction or meaning within a social context. The rehearsal scene showed that the guitarist's moment of authenticity depended as much on collective reception as on private transformation, as I watched his bandmates' gestures convert sound into public acknowledgement. At its core, this is a fundamental requirement of human behaviour: the "authentic identity" is not a static property held in isolation, but a "social recognition" that must be negotiated and validated by others to become real. To understand how such moments of self-fashioning become socially legible, I turned to ethnomusicologist Ingrid Monson's scholarly monograph, *Say Something: Jazz Improvisation and Interaction* (1996).

Monson (1996) treats improvisation as communicative interaction, with her central contention being that jazz solos and accompanimental gestures function like speech acts. Musicians make proposals, others respond, and meaning arises through exchange; a "fundamentally social, conversational and dialogic way to organise musical performance" (Monson, 1996, p. 89). I found this framing especially useful for decoding what I had heard. She argues that authenticity in improvisation is not an inner property, but a socially negotiated achievement: identity becomes audible through interplay – call-and-response, rhythmic adjustment, and mutual listening.

Monson's (1996) model explains why the band's reaction was essential: the bassist's steady groove and the drummer's sensitive timing strongly reinforced the solo, treating it as a communicative proposal, and thereby validating it. She demonstrates that "a discerning audience" (Monson, 1996, p. 1) and ensemble responses function as constitutive elements of improvisational meaning and "saying something" (p. 1), rather than mere epiphenomenal applause. In other words, authenticity in jazz is often a joint product: the solo matters because others engage it as meaningful speech. This reinforces the idea that

social recognition is the condition under which identity claims become durable, and without the ensemble's response, the individual's authentic claim remains a silent, unverified hypothesis. Her focus on interaction, however, can overstate the necessity of social recognition – a musician may experiment privately during practice and discover a new expressive stance that later informs public playing. Monson (1996) accounts well for public negotiation, but gives less space to private self-transformation.

Taken together, both music scholars offer a complementary account. DeNora (1999) locates the individual mechanics of how music fashions new ways of feeling and acting. Monson (1996) supplies the social grammar on how those newly fashioned behaviours become meaningful through interaction. Authenticity in jazz, then, might be understood as neither purely inward-facing nor simply conferred. It is a practical achievement – musicians use musical practice to enact possible selves (DeNora, 1999), and these enactments become socially legible and stable only when others in the musical community treat them as meaningful (Monson, 1996). Improvisation may function as a public laboratory; an experiment is run in sound, and the ensemble's listening determines whether the experiment registers as an identity claim.

When I revisit that rehearsal, this combined view re-presents the solo, because the guitarist's earlier guarded playing may be read as a rehearsal of a curated, cautious public self. The solo was a deliberate trial–an alternate set of musical behaviours enacted to test a different identity. The band's response did more than reward bravado. It engaged a social process that transformed a fleeting experiment into a validated part of the musician's repertoire.

In contemporary life, where curated identities are the norm, jazz improvisation matters to me because it offers an embodied, public method for trying on and socialising authenticity. The dynamics of "authentic identity" and "social recognition" are not byproducts of music; music renders audible a process already fundamental to human behaviour. These drivers suggest that we all require a social scaffolding to move beyond our composed selves. These insights have practical implications cascading far beyond jazz, into classrooms, workplaces and the wider community. In the workplace, for instance, a socially legible identity is often stifled by the pressure to remain polished, yet improvisation offers a process where a raw idea can be exposed and negotiated rather than dismissed. In the classroom, this process allows a student to try an alternate way of thinking, where the teacher's attentive listening acts as the constitutive response that makes that new identity possible. In a culture that too often rewards only the polished, improvisation yields a catalytic illumination: identity is made in process, and that being heard – attentively and without immediate dismissal – may be paramount to becoming who we might authentically be.

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Beyond the classroom, my writing was a melting pot of context, culture, and the oeuvres of Louis Armstrong and Tennessee Williams; I am eternally indebted to them and to my parents.

To my brother and best friend, Ng Jonas: thank you for enjoying hours of my incessant jazz yapping. You can find his work, "Who Am I – Writing Across Different

Circumstances" in this issue (though, you will find that my Op-Ed is far more sophisticated).

To the readers: I implore you to reach out for the skies, resolved to protect and preserve the beauty of your craft, ever mindful of an auspicium melioris aevi.

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Picture This: Memory or Performance?

By Rory Dominique Ty Macalintal
Bachelor of Business

The street was filled with groups of fashionably dressed teenagers chatting and laughing together. It was loud and lively as I walked past multiple such groups in Haji Lane. As I made my way down the row of shophouses, I felt a sense of *déjà vu*. The four shophouses I had passed by were all photobooth studios, with even more up ahead of me. Despite the different themed decorations of each studio, the formula stayed the same. A mirror with the store's logo outside, a vanity area by the entrance, walls lined with photostrips from previous patrons, and small rooms with curated backdrops as the photobooths. Inside, there were more groups of teenagers, some touching up their make-up at the vanity area and practicing poses. The way they rehearsed their smiles and changed their posture to find their best angle seemed like a planned performance.

I watched as a group of friends came out of one of the photobooths excitedly holding onto their photostrips. They all held these pieces of paper together and took a picture on their phone. I could not see what they were doing on their phones afterwards, but it reminded me of Instagram Story posts I had seen the other day. It was a common sight on social media to see people sharing their photobooth pictures. I assumed that that group of teenagers were likely to do the same. Though the irony of the act confused me. Why would they take a photobooth picture if they were going to post the printed photostrip online anyway? Perhaps the point of the photobooth was just for people to show off their active social life online.

That idea did not sit well with me as I looked back on my own experiences taking pictures at a photobooth. The memory of my friends and I taking pictures and laughing obnoxiously at the end as we could not keep our composure is a fond memory of mine. The physical photostrip served as a precious memento as one of my friends had moved abroad to study. However, the sight of the group of teenagers snapping pictures of their photostrips seemed to cheapen my own experience. It made me wonder, are photobooths just spaces for showing off online, or are they places for creating memories that truly matter?

To explore this, I first wanted to understand the possible motivations one has for taking pictures. Corsbie-Massay & McLaren (2024) explore the difference between taking and sharing selfies. Their research reveals that individuals who take selfies without necessarily sharing them, whom they call discerning selfiers, report "greater control over their own lives," which is linked to higher self-esteem (Corsbie-Massay & McLaren, 2024, p. 11). These people are more likely to take photos during "pleasant scenarios," such as time with friends, family, or at celebratory events, than during "challenging scenarios" such as bad days or moments of stress (Corsbie-Massay & McLaren, 2024, p. 11). The researchers argue that these discerning selfiers exhibit "a significant difference between their likelihood of taking and sharing in both scenario composites," while non-discerning selfiers, who share selfies indiscriminately, report lower self-esteem and

less internal control (Corsbie-Massay & McLaren, 2024, p. 11).

Corsbie-Massay & McLaren (2024, p. 12) share that this act of discernment reflects intentionality and that "selfies for oneself can enhance control" as they serve as a private form of self-exploration rather than a public performance. This insight challenges the stereotype that all photo-taking is narcissistic or performative in nature. Comparing this to the sight of teenagers practicing their poses and fixing their hair at the vanity area, I realise that these acts do not erase the authenticity of their joy and laughter when taking photobooth pictures with friends. Corsbie-Massay & McLaren's (2024) findings remind me that not all performances are false. They can be a part of how we make meaning: the way we present ourselves online is not always to deceive others, but instead an opportunity to portray ourselves more clearly as well as document positive moments in our lives. This study (Corsbie-Massay & McLaren, 2024) explores how self-presentation and self-reflection can coexist, and subsequently how photobooth studios are not solely places of vanity but instead spaces where one can preserve memories.

While Corsbie-Massay & McLaren (2024) explore the act of taking photos, Matikainen's (2015) study investigates why people share content online in the first place. By analysing both qualitative and quantitative data, he identifies three key motivations: "development of Web ideology and self," "self-expression and identity," and "community" (Matikainen, 2015, p. 52-53). He links these motivations to a social identity theory, where the idea that "an individual's self-concept derives from perceived membership in a relevant social group." (Matikainen, 2015, p. 54). Matikainen (2015) argues that online sharing is not just self-promotion, it is an act of belonging. When people post online, they are not simply broadcasting themselves but are instead participating in collective meaning-making. According to his findings, self-expression on social media "occurs in a social context and is therefore social in nature." (Matikainen, 2015, p. 54). Even the desire for attention, he notes, can be understood as a form of connection, where the act of posting a photo is as if to say, 'This moment mattered to me, and I want you to see it too.'

Looking back on the countless Instagram Stories I have seen online, I realise that when someone posts a strip of four tiny squares filled with smiles and goofy poses, it is rarely about showing off. Instead, it is about anchoring a shared experience, a proof of sorts that 'we were here together'. These posts do not simply appear in individual feeds; they are shared through wide networks. Through this simple act of sharing, the moment is extended. What happens in a two-minute photobooth session becomes part of a collective memory that others are able to revisit and recognise.

Matikainen's (2015) study reframes sharing not as a shallow bid for attention but as a social gesture. It becomes a continuation of the genuine moment the photobooth captures. When someone uploads a photostrip, they do not replace the authenticity of the moment for clout, they transform a private memory into a public celebration. The act of posting then becomes a form of connection, not competition.

Both studies challenge the binary thinking that separates authenticity from performance. Corsbie-Massay & McLaren (2024) show that taking photos can be an act of self-understanding, while Matikainen (2015) argues that sharing them can be an act of social bonding. Combined, we see that there is more to performance and belonging than previously assumed.

Therefore, we can view photobooths as a hybrid space where performance and memory meet. A place to fix our hair and practise poses because we care about how we will be remembered. A place filled with joy as

we laugh, mess up, and end up with imperfect photos that show genuine emotions. The act of sharing photostrips online is not limited to the preconception of curating our appearance for others; we do it to share joy with friends, preserve a moment, and to also invite others to that cherished memory. Performance does not erase authenticity, it is able to coexist with it.

Personally, as I look back on my own experiences taking pictures at a photobooth with friends, I realise that I have shared a few photostrips online while keeping most as private mementos. The photostrip I took with some of my closest friends before one of them moved abroad still sits folded in my wallet. A physical proof of us enjoying each other's presence and reminding me of good times. I had not shared it online before, an example of my quiet choice of which moments to keep private. On the other hand, I have also proudly posted some of the photostrips pinned on my corkboard which I keep in my university hall. For these photostrips, I have willingly let people into these treasured moments and feel a sense of joy in sharing them.

Ultimately, I do not believe photobooths are spaces solely for showing off one's social life. I believe people go to photobooths and take these pictures to capture moments that matter. To have a memento, a snapshot of laughter, and to remember community. Furthermore, the act of sharing it online does not diminish its meaning. It simply extends the joy, inviting others to participate in the memory alongside us.

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Calm Within the Storm: The Architecture of Harmony

By Ning Jun Karn
Bachelor of Engineering in Bioengineering

It is just past one at Our Tampines Hub hawker center. It is peak lunch hour, evident by the throng of people filling the space. Office workers, schoolchildren and the elderly of all races and occupations jostle their way around each other, looking for seats or just trying to get some lunch. The air is dense and warm, a consequence of the scorching hot weather that day. Ladles banging on pans and order buzzers going off contribute to the cacophony of sounds. As I wait in the queue, I observe a similar queue at the opposite stall. As newcomers join the back, the queue grows and curves back on itself instinctively, as if to avoid an invisible highway where other patrons were walking. There are no staff or markers on the floor to guide them.

A mother guides her young son towards an empty table. Upon getting closer and noticing a lone tissue packet *chope*-ing the table, she steers him away, eyebrows furrowed in disappointment. At the table beside mine, a man in office clothes approaches a couple at a four-seat table and wordlessly agrees to share the table with them, just by exchanging a few inquisitive looks and smiles. Nearby, patrons return their trays to the cleaners' station, despite cleaners roaming the place, already clearing trays on their own. At the stalls, vendors speak in curt and gruff tones. There are no smiles, no small talk. Yet the customers do not appear to take umbrage to this and respond in short and calm phrases, moving on swiftly.

Throughout this sequence of actions and behaviours, an underlying current of implicit order and rules courses through the people and the place. No one instructs any of the patrons or applauds them for acting in the ways that they do. All of them somehow know the unspoken social rules and customs and abide by them. The reason for this set of behaviours is apparent: to allow efficient negotiation of the space and to create an agreement to share it with as little friction as possible.

Juxtaposed with the environment, however, these behaviours seem at odds with their surroundings. The hawker centre is chaotic, noisy, and hot – an invitation for disorder and disarray. And yet the people arrange themselves into a living ecosystem, governed by invisible rules that maintain the order of the place. No outward authority or instruction has any hand in its creation.

As I eat my lunch and ponder this conundrum, I am struck by a question: Why does social order persist in public spaces even without explicit rules or enforcement?

Marcel Mauss offers an anthropological approach to this question in his lecture "Techniques of the body" (1973/1935). He defines these 'techniques' as 'the ways in which from society-to-society men know how to use their bodies' (Mauss, 1973/1935). He groups these 'techniques' into 'habitus', which are a set of habits shaped by education, imitation and cultural norms (Mauss, 1973/1935). In essence, he proposes that all our bodily actions are imparted to us from culture, and consequently, they reflect the culture that we are a part of. He illustrates with examples of

British soldiers, who had their 'habitus' of marching so deeply ingrained that they could not adapt to French cadences. Similarly, he brings up how Māori women are thought to walk in a way that is uncouth in French society, but seen as admirable in their own culture, to support his thesis that our movements are not natural and have to be acquired from culture (Mauss, 1973/1935). We can observe his concepts at play in our hawker center setting, by examining our practice of '*chope*-ing' or reserving tables. This behavioral habit is learned through cultural imitation, instead of guided instruction. We use it as a way of maintaining the order of seating arrangements, through the shared value of mutual respect. One respects others' *chope*-ing, because they fully expect the courtesy to be returned in kind to their own *chope*-ing. In this way, a self-sustaining system is upheld and driven by each individual performing a culturally imparted 'habitus'. Therefore, by applying Mauss's (1973/1935) theory, we can see that the social order in the hawker center persists because our culture teaches us to behave in ways that reflect our shared interests and values.

Erin Manning offers a perspective from performance and dance philosophy instead. She proposes that movement in itself is an extension of one's thinking in real time, a 'choreographic thinking' (Manning, 2013). She defines a 'choreographic field', which is a space of shared movement in which order and harmony arise through the continuous adjustment and cueing of the individuals in the field (Manning, 2013). The micro-adjustments and interactions between people in the field create a characterisation which she terms 'collective individualization' (Manning, 2013). She develops the field more by introducing 'enabling constraints' – factors of a field that affect or impede the experience of being in it but still allow inhabitants to invent their own ways of behaving. We can apply this to the hawker center context. Taking the queuing line as a 'choreographic field', when one person leaves the queue, it cues the person behind them to close the gap, repeating down the line. When a cleaner approaches the queue, it cues the people to break apart temporarily to let them pass, before converging again. All these are done without the need for communication. The 'enabling constraint' of the lack of space cause the people in the queue to self-organise in a way to avoid walking pathways. In short, Manning (2013) allows us to see that social order is maintained in a public space due to the continuous adjustment of individuals responding to each other in real time.

Both authors seem to agree that the social order in a public space arises from the physical actions and interactions of the people in the space. However, they differ in the mechanism by which this order is created. While Mauss (1973/1935) says it is maintained because our culture informs us on how to act, Manning (2013) instead argues that the negotiation dynamics between the people are the cause. While Mauss's (1973/1935) framework provides a good foundation, it is lacking. It does not explain how these culturally informed actions come about in the first place and does not account for new or unusual circumstances outside of the cultural norm. Applying Manning's (2013) concepts allows us to fill in these gaps. The physical environment and its enabling constraints work in tandem with the continuous adjustment and cueing of the people to create a collective individualisation, which, when combined with the influence of their own cultural values, creates a unique characterisation – a subculture unique to that space. This subculture is the underlying driving force behind Mauss's (1973/1935) framework, and it is by adhering to the 'techniques' of the culture that social order is maintained.

The continuous negotiation of social frictions under the same set of constraints gives rise to implicit social rules. In the confined space of the hawker centre, the

first person to use a small object as placeholder puts out an experimental probe. When the next person observes it and chooses to acknowledge its power as a practice, a transient agreement is formed. Over time, these agreements get reinforced into implicit social rules the more they are repeated. Newcomers absorb these rules as they silently observe them from others. As the mother steers her son away from the lone tissue packet on the table, she is performing the negotiation dance, which reinforces the culture. Simultaneously, she silently transmits the culture to her son, who learns to read the choreographic field of the hawker centre. Lastly, we continue to abide by the rules, as the cost of chaos far outweighs the minimal cost of compliance. In the hawker centre, we continue to respect the rules of queuing, table sharing and reservation to ensure that the system remains efficient for everyone.

The continued existence and adherence to these rules is a testament to our shared commitment to harmony and order as a society. The practice of *chope*-ing worked so well as an efficient solution to the problem of seating that it became solidified as a cornerstone of our local culture. What spurred the birth of this cultural feature was necessity and problem-solving. If we are to imagine our culture as being part of our ecology alongside us, new cultural 'creatures' can only evolve when a niche exists to be filled.

Growing up in Singapore, my experience has been of cold, clinical concrete. Our buildings are built with efficiency, standardisation and uniformity as the central focuses. Take our HDBs for example. Literally built-to-order, off a factory line and carrying the same distinct look and feel no matter which part of Singapore they are in. What about our communal spaces? Void decks are meant to serve as community social centers, but their existence as blank containers have such minimal features that they fail to invite the 'collective individualization' Manning (2013) describes.

If we are to take Mauss (1973/1935) and Manning's (2013) combined ideas, we can see that the design and physicality of our public spaces make them not just a passive stage but a driving force, a crucible for new localised subcultures. What then, does it mean if all of our crucibles are shaped the same? If our homogenous public spaces provide the same 'enabling constraints' everywhere, then they would strongly incentivise the creation of functionally similar, but not truly unique emergent subcultures. Organic cultural genesis requires the social friction that our efficiency-driven designs seek to eliminate.

This repetition of culture across our homogeneous public architectural landscape threatens to amalgamate into a stagnant monoculture. I argue that this is the overlooked cost of our overly pragmatic nation-building policy. What should be a rich mosaic of unique local identities is at risk of being flattened into a single, standardised one.

Only when we start embracing the messy and unpredictable process of cultural genesis over the comfort of pragmatism and standardisation can we then begin to live in a truly vibrant and alive society. While our policies allow us to churn out houses at large, it is the chaotic and inconvenient friction of communal sharing that can turn these houses into homes for our national soul.

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When Ego Falls Silent: What We Miss in Trying to Matter

By Wang Yuean
Bachelor of Engineering in Electrical and Electronic Engineering

"Enter at your own risk." That was the first message Bukit Brown Cemetery offered me, spelled out boldly at the entrance. This struck me as unnecessarily theatrical, like something copied straight from a low-budget horror movie.

As my dad drove us in, the road itself became a boundary line, dividing privilege from poverty. The grand tomb complexes sprawled uphill to my right, while smaller tombs dipped downhill to my left.

Tomb guardians, Earth deities, and Sikh guards stood watching as I climbed through the larger tombs above. Passing by the Wee family cluster, I paused before a carving of Dong Yong's tale, one of the 24 filial exemplars, about the poor son who sold himself into servitude just to bury his father. There was irony in seeing a story of poverty carved into the tomb of a wealthy man, as if grandeur could shield him from the fear of dying without dignity, while also binding his descendants to remember him.

"Can we go now?" my younger brother whined as he swatted mosquitoes, yanking me out of my thoughts on remembrance. I turned to notice a rare sight of fresh oranges. Their bright colour stood out against crumbling tombs and scattered joss paper. But they were not placed before a single tomb; instead, they lay across a section, as if left by casual visitors rather than family.

Jolting at a spider in the tall grass brushing my calves, I edged reluctantly into the pauper's section looking for the grave of Low Nong Nong, a rickshaw-puller who died in a strike with police for lower rents. He had borrowed just to get by, yet in death his coffin was followed by three thousand men, one of the longest processions Singapore had seen.

The grandeur of tombs seems like an effort to outlast death, as if carved stone and guardians could preserve status forever. But permanence is an illusion. Weather, neglect, and shifting priorities wear down even the largest memorials. This unease is sharpened by fading ties between generations. My brother's impatience felt less like disrespect and more like a sign of detachment. Younger generations are less bound by rituals of remembrance, and distractions shape their lives more than duty. If memory is left to descendants who may not care, then status loses its hold, and even the grandest tombs risk abandonment.

By contrast, Low Nong Nong's story suggests memory and meaning are not measured in stone, but in the lives touched. So then, why are we still so afraid of being forgotten that we extend the illusions of status and ego beyond life itself?

My search for answers led me to a psychological study by Brett Jordan Waggoner (2022), which explores why people value being remembered after death. Slightly over half of 208 participants chose a positive legacy over a good life, noting that "having an impact that lasts for generations is more important than being well-known during a single generation" (Waggoner, 2022, p. 69). Meanwhile, those who prioritised life argued that being admired is meaningless if one cannot experience it. The author

links this to Terror Management Theory, which suggests that legacy helps mask the fear of death under the pretence of symbolic immortality.

A Legacy Motivation Scale showed that people seek legacy not only for prestige but also to care for family, pass on values, or benefit society. Perhaps most striking was the idea that a negative legacy could even harm descendants' reputations. When participants imagined how future generations might judge their actions, e.g. on issues like climate change, they began to think more responsibly, suggesting that yearning for a legacy can also guide people toward living more morally in the present. One unexpected overlap is that some participants scored high in both generativity and narcissism, and they sought to be admired through helping others. This proves that self-interest and altruism can in fact, coexist.

While the study did not identify the desire for legacy as a form of ego, this impulse may be the ego's defence against the fear of death, in a desperate attempt to preserve self-worth in the face of mortality. I struggled to understand why so many valued a good legacy until I realised reputation flows through a family like inheritance. If a damaged name can weigh down one's own children, then reputation becomes something both generations have to defend. Moreover, motives for legacy, like care and contribution, as well as the coexistence between generativity and narcissism, show that the ego is not purely selfish, but something that can be redeemed through connection.

Yet I wonder if those who idealise legacy truly live by the values they claim to pass on. What happens when one spends a lifetime crafting a name, yet forgets to love the people who speak it?

This reflection deepened when I encountered a TEDx Talk by Jonathan Gravenor (2017), a former broadcast journalist, whose confrontation with throat cancer stripped away his illusions of success and forced him to reassess what he truly seeks. After his diagnosis, he expected sympathy, but instead his daughter expressed that she did not care, while his own inability to admit fear revealed a long-standing emotional barrier. He puts it simply: "the cancer was a lot deeper than my throat" (Gravenor, 2017). He later crossed paths with Doug, a homeless man whom he looked down upon, until he discovered that Doug was actually raising money for others in need. In sharing chocolates and conversation, something shifted, and Gravenor realised that in Doug's eyes, he was worthy for simply showing up as a person. And when Doug noticed the scar along his neck and told him he still had living left to do, Gravenor felt a purpose awaken, one that had nothing to do with status at all. Later, at chemotherapy, a child undergoing the same treatment comforted him, flipping the roles of strength and weakness, and confirming the lesson that meaning can come from modest acts.

For Gravenor's whole life, he had been numbed by acknowledging the darkness lurking underneath as he chased the powerful circles above. In chasing success, he mistook achievement for enlightenment, not realising he was building a cage around the very life he was trying to free. Meeting Doug and the sick child forced him to see the world from below, that even those with the least can live with the most heart, that dignity is not something recognition protects, but rather humanity creates. At last, in reconciling with his daughter, he found redemption by finally choosing to love openly.

Gravenor's (2017) journey reveals that when status and recognition lose their power, life's meaning is no longer quantified but deeply felt. Waggoner's (2022) study shows that the desire for legacy often stems from care for family, descendants, and even the greater good. Together, they suggest that ego is not the enemy; it simply mirrors our longing to matter.

Ego is what gives us identity, yet also traps us within the illusions we create to make sense of the world. We live under the gaze of others and ourselves, enlarging every reflection until we mistake the mirror for the truth. However, knowing the mirror is flawed frees us from obeying it.

With or without ego, we can live alongside it, letting it remind us that we are human, that there is beauty in imperfection, and that even after all the glory or sorrow, we still choose to smile at a stranger, to hold the hand of a loved one. I am at peace knowing that once our actions align with our fundamental values, we can achieve true happiness.

And even if we never know what our values are, we can still accept that not understanding life is part of living it.

Perhaps we spend too much time trying to control life, when it was never meant to be solved. To live well is to meet life sincerely — to love, to give, to be. In that gentle acceptance, we begin, at last, to live it.

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Voices: Silence Beneath Stone

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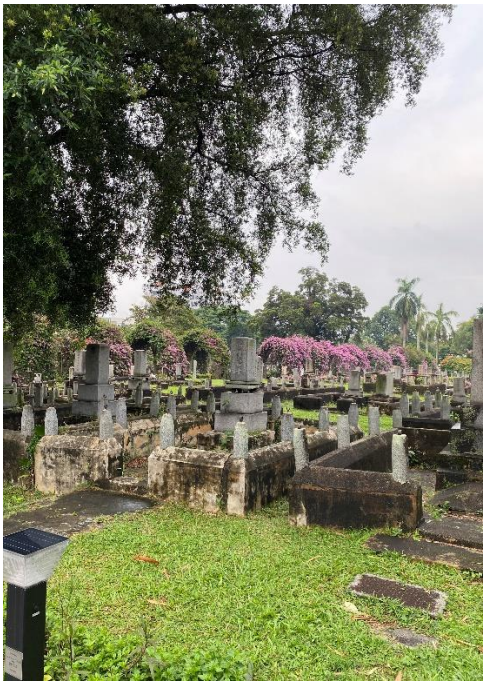

Figure 1. Protected tombs of prominent figures

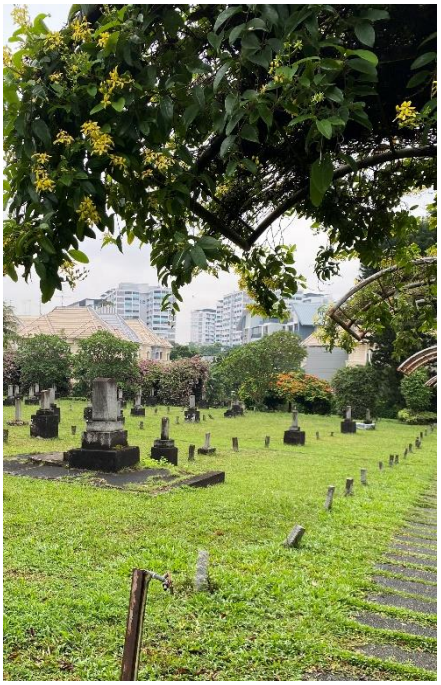

Figure 2. Crooked gravestones of karayuki-san

As an international student, I carry an invisible fear of not being heard. In classrooms, my words sometimes fade into hesitant whispers, drowned out by native voices. That feeling of exclusion often lingers, raising a quiet question: Where else have voices been erased? I found part of the answer in the most unexpected place: Japanese Cemetery Park.

Stepping through its gate, I was struck by the massive monument standing in silent prayer for Japanese civilians (Figure 1). The park was filled with sanctity as each historic monument was guarded by stone walls standing like sentries. Gold boards beside these monuments revealed stories of prominent commanders and merchants. Walking further, there were rows of large tombs of fallen soldiers, each enclosed by thick stone fences that evoked a sense of honour and protection. When I touched them, their craggy, time-worn surfaces carried the weight of time, quietly mourning losses of war. Among the neatly arranged graves laid remnants of incense, a sign of attentive maintenance and remembrance. Wandering among imposing memorials to renowned men, I suddenly noticed the curious absence of Japanese women, wondering where their presence was in history.

Walking further, where the traffic noise faded until only the trill of birds sang, I finally found my answer

hidden at the corner of the park. There lay small and crooked unnamed gravestones, no higher than my knee, haphazardly placed directly into the ground (Figure 2). Unlike men's tombs, no great statue stood, no wall protected them. Only an information board whispered: *karayuki-san*. It was here that I learnt of another history. In the 19th century, they were poor girls trafficked into Singapore as prostitutes, forced into lives that ended too quickly, too quietly. Unlike generals, these women left behind no medals, no recognition. Their insignificant stones lay bare in soil, unguarded by stone fences. Just steps away, famous men rested in grand tombs like small sanctuaries. Here, on the women's modest graves, only one phrase was carved: *Seirei Bodai*, or "Spiritual Enlightenment," a quiet prayer for souls forgotten in life and nearly erased in death.

I never knew such a world existed. War leaves behind endless grief: soldiers fallen, mothers without sons, wives without husbands. These stories are remembered in marble and textbooks. Yet the story of *karayuki-san* stays in shadows. Why is their suffering less worthy? Why do these women remain hidden, their voices unheard, while prominent figures are carved into great statues? Walking away, I could not forget the quiet contrast: monuments that tower for the powerful and crooked stones that stand for the powerless. Why are women's voices often marginalised and unheard?

In "Can the Subaltern Speak?," the intellectual Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak (1994) offers a critical insight. She introduces the concept of "epistemic violence," when colonial power systematically uses discourse to erase, reinterpret and redefine subaltern voices (Spivak, 1994). The subaltern represents marginalised groups who are silenced. In "epistemic violence," colonial knowledge is legitimate while subalterns are considered disqualified and substandard. Spivak (1994) illustrates this concept through the Hindu practice of *sati*, the widow sacrificing herself on husband's pyre. British colonisers condemned it as barbaric, declaring "White men saving brown women from brown men," while Indian nativists argued "[t]he women actually wanted to die" (Spivak, 1994, p. 93). Yet, as Spivak notes, even after reading "mistranscribed names of these women… one cannot put together a 'voice'" (1994, p. 93). The widow's voice was distinct from both colonialists and native men but was lost and erased in the interplay between two dominant powers: the patriarchy and Western imperialism.

Epistemic violence reveals how power hierarchies suppress women's voices. *Karayuki-san* are portrayed as poor girls sent overseas for the sake of family (Frances, 2007, pp. 47–48). But is this their choice? Their so-called choice was shaped by intersecting powers: patriarchy, poverty, and colonial exploitation. We can never fully recover their real voices. And yet, standing before their graves, I realised that what Spivak (1994) calls "epistemic violence" was not only confined to colonialism; it continues to shape whose voices are remembered today. The physical hierarchy of monuments and nameless graves, the unevenness between grand tombs and crooked stones reflect the same system, where the powerful produce knowledge while the subalterns are nearly forgotten. The cemetery reflects how history remembers selectively influential and prominent figures.

Professor Kevin Olson at the University of California, Irvine, offers a contemporary outlook in "Subaltern Silence: A Postcolonial Genealogy" (2024). Aligning closely with Spivak (1994), Olson (2024) analyses forced silence created by colonialism through "resignification" (p. 37), "displacement" (p. 37), "interpretation" (p. 55), "delegitimation" (p. 234), etc. Later, he introduces another practice of "self-silencing through opacity" (Olson, 2024) This describes

marginalised individuals who deliberately choose to remain unseen as a form of survival, resistance, or self-protection. *Karayuki-san* may also be agents of self-silencing. Many chose to die quietly, concealing their past to shield themselves from social shame and criticism in a world where motherhood and chastity defined women's values. Similarly, in modern Asia shaped by Confucian traditions, including Singapore and my home country, Vietnam, the ideal woman has long been defined by modesty and self-sacrifice. As a result, many have silenced themselves out of fear of judgment. My mother, my grandmother, and even I sometimes avoid speaking openly about domestic hardship or gender inequality, simply because such topics are considered inappropriate. Silence then becomes internalised, an inherited language of restraint passed down through Asian generations to preserve dignity and protect one's inner world from criticism.

Spivak (1994) and Olson (2024) therefore highlight two dimensions of silence. For Spivak (1994), silence is enforced, a product of colonial and patriarchal power that erases women's speech within dominant narratives. For Olson (2024), silence can also be chosen, a deliberate act of self-protection or resistance. Yet rather than contradicting each other, the two thinkers reveal complementary reasons explaining why women's voices are absent. One exposes how power suppresses speech; the other shows how subalterns may navigate survival within that violence. In fact, there coexist both silence as subordination (enforced) and silence as self-protection (chosen). While the former acts as an external force, the latter serves as an internal factor, forming an interplay that continues to sustain silence. In 2019, Associate Professor Kevin Blackburn (NIE) illustrates such interplay through the case of comfort women and sexual enslavement during World War II. While the actual victims remained silent due to trauma, two male observers praised them as lifesavers for Singaporean chastity. Here, male narratives resignify sexual violence as moral virtue, while women's silence reinforces their invisibility, together perpetuating the erasure of female history.

Yet one crucial dimension both thinkers leave largely unexplored is the role of the *listener*. What if, in the past, women tried to speak but no one listened? What if editors wished to publish women's stories but found no audience? Silence then for me, may not stem solely from the absence of speech but also from the absence of listening. Even today, we somehow remain drawn to narratives of wars and heroes more than the quiet lives. Visiting Japanese Cemetery Park, I recognised travelers pausing at the grand memorials of men but few venturing into the corner of the *karayuki-san.* Their deserted graves reveal a truth: their stories were unheard not only because they were unspeakable but also because no one ever came seeking to listen. Maybe what the subalterns need is not only the right to speak, but the presence of listeners willing to acknowledge their existence and pain.

Perhaps the stories of women are not a minority at all but mirror the inequalities of our society today. Silence, I realise, goes beyond gender. It speaks for the homeless, the poor, and all those who are invisible. Just as *karayuki-san* were excluded from historical narratives, countless others continue to be marginalised. Over time, their stories simply fade away just because they are deemed as holding too little political or economic value, or as unworthy of remembrance.

Taken together, these dimensions suggest that silence is not produced by a single cause but through multiple mechanisms operating across different settings. Silence is not a uniform condition applied identically across subjects. Rather, each emerges

within particular cultural, historical, economic, and socio-political contexts that evolve over time. While mechanisms such as subordination or self-protection may overlap, their relative force and interaction vary across settings. Even when the subject appears similar, such as women, the intensity of each mechanism may differ. The forms of subordination experienced by women in one cultural or geopolitical context may not mirror those shaping women elsewhere. Differences in culture, history, political systems, economic structures, or migration status may generate distinct modes of silence. Different subjects therefore encounter different mechanisms. My own hesitation as an international student, for instance, does not arise from the same historical structures that erased the *karayuki-san*; rather, it stems from linguistic insecurity and a lack of sense of belonging. These silences travel along different historical paths and are generated by distinct political and social conditions. What connects them is not their origin, but the same outcome: an absence from dominant narratives. Different mechanisms, different contexts, yet a comparable exclusion.

So, *can the subaltern speak?* The answer perhaps depends on us, on whether we are willing to confront the stereotypes etched into our consciousness, and to challenge the political systems that privilege certain voices over others. Voices continue to vanish, erased by indifference as much as by power. Whether by intention or neglect, we too become complicit in this silencing. Perhaps the real silence is not theirs, but ours.

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Is My Phone Really Listening to Me?

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It was 23:37. I lay back on my bed, finally at ease. The fabric of the sheets was cool against my skin after the oppressive heat of the day. Above me, the ceiling fan hummed softly, carrying the faint scent of detergent that lingered on my freshly laundered pillowcase. The glow of my phone lit the darkened room, briefly blinding my weary eyes. With practised instinct, I swiped across the screen and opened the app that had become a nightly ritual, TikTok. The first video that appeared was simple. A still image bearing a caption about relationships. Yet, the words seemed to echo the doubts buried in my chest all day: "It's okay to outgrow those who don't know how to love you. It's okay to let go." (Thought Catalog, 2023) A melancholic melody soon followed, which vibrated in my ears and settled deep into my bones. An uncanny resonance surged through me, as if the screen had reached inside and uncovered a truth I had not dared to voice.

Earlier that evening, my partner and I had agreed to a 'pause' in our relationship, though it felt more like an ending. Reading the caption brought to mind the imbalance I had been enduring: missed calls, unfulfilled promises, and a lack of affection – the care I had kept asking for, yet nothing changed. "Outgrow" sounded less like abandonment and more like growth; "let go", like mercy rather than failure. At that moment, the words traced the outline of my real life, offering not instruction but permission: to grieve, to breathe, and to choose myself.

I had not searched for this. I had not typed a single word about how I was feeling. Yet, TikTok seemed to know. It was as though TikTok had listened to my silent worries, eavesdropped on my hidden thoughts, and served me exactly what I needed: comfort. Goosebumps prickled my arms, and for a fleeting moment, the cold screen seemed almost warm, alive, intimate. It felt strangely human, unsettling in its accuracy, yet undeniably comforting in its timing. This was the app's peculiar power: to offer, in an instant, the illusion of being understood.

Beneath this illusion, however, lies no digital telepathy. TikTok's recommendation system does not eavesdrop on private conversations. Conversely, it learns from the micro-behaviours that we hardly notice ourselves. A pause that lingers a millisecond longer on a sad video, a replay of a clip that resonates, the subtle rhythm of our scrolling. These tiny but telling actions become useful information that refine the algorithm. It compares them with the patterns of millions of other users, predicting what we might wish to see, sometimes shockingly too well. What feels like mind-reading is often the product of emotional mirroring, where the app reflects the collective emotional journeys of those like us. However, the effect remains powerful. In moments of vulnerability, when we long for reassurance or a whisper of advice, TikTok feels less like a platform and more like a personal mirror. One that not only recognises our state of mind, but dares to whisper the words we most need to hear. Therefore, one cannot help but ponder whether one's phone is truly listening, or whether this

is simply a form of cognitive bias and emotional mirroring?

Arnold Melchior Zwicky, an American linguist and adjunct professor at Stanford University, names that unsettling sensation, the instant in which a newly noticed thing seems suddenly ubiquitous, the Frequency Illusion (2006). In his account, two everyday processes do the work: "Selective Attention" makes a salient item more noticeable, and "Confirmation Bias" convinces us that the increased noticing proves the thing has become common (Zwicky, 2006, p. 1). Oftentimes, we confuse a change in perception for a change in reality. When something becomes personally salient, our attention allocates more processing to it, making it likelier to be consciously perceived. As Zwicky puts it: "Once you notice a phenomenon, you believe it happens a whole lot" (Zwicky, 2006, p. 1). In short, nothing "out there" changed; we changed. The illusion is not evidence of the world shifting beneath our feet. Instead, it is evidence of our attention pivoting towards a cue that now matters to us. This is also known as the red car effect.

This effect reframes my late-night TikTok moment. After the relationship "pause", the breakup theme became personally salient. Just as Zwicky (2006) describes, my selective attention shifted towards anything that echoed "letting go". When the caption on the TikTok video appeared, I registered it with heightened intensity while countless neutral or mismatched videos slipped past unnoticed. Confirmation bias then sealed the impression: that single video fit my inner script so accurately that I encoded it vividly, and later remembered the "hit" while forgetting the "misses". Essentially, no external factors changed; I changed. My attention pivoted to cues that mattered to me, and my memory elevated coincidence into evidence of intent. Ultimately, the eerie fit between my feed and my feelings arose without any eavesdropping. Rather than telepathy or secret listening, it was attentional priming, memory bias, cognitive filters, and an emotionally-primed mind that did the heavy lifting.

Still, perception is only half the story. The other half lies with exposure: what the platform chooses to place in that spotlight. Here, engineering, rather than telepathy, does the heavy lifting. TikTok's official description of its "For You" recommendation system outlines a ranking system that learns directly from one's behaviour. It gives most weight to "user interactions" (e.g. likes, shares, follows, comments, and re-watches) (TikTok, 2020), alongside "video information like captions, sounds, and hashtags" (TikTok, 2020) and applies only light weighting to "device and account settings" (TikTok, 2020). To stave off monotony, the system also injects content diversity to avoid showing near-duplicates or certain sensitive categories. In short, the system translates one's micro-behaviours into predictions, then pushes the unique content based on the probability that they will hold one's attention. Essentially, TikTok does not need to overhear private conversations to be uncannily apt; it only needs to model the trail we leave on the app. The faster a system can translate one's micro-behaviours into preference estimates, the more "psychic" it will feel. Ultimately, no microphone was needed when one's taps, pauses, completions, and replays already spoke loudly.

Seen through this lens, the "on cue" breakup caption was not clairvoyance, but the model doing exactly what TikTok says it does: translating my micro-behaviours into predictions and ranking likely matches accordingly. A slightly longer dwell on a melancholic sound, replaying a video on relationship advice, or simply scrolling late at night, would have registered as strong preference signals to TikTok's algorithm. The system then tests videos whose captions, audio, and themes keep users like me

engaged, and boosts those videos. In reality, I was not singled out, but rather my interaction pattern rhymed with millions of others, so the feed placed that consoling post within reach in the moment I was most likely to watch it through. The result feels like a personal whisper, yet it was simply just a statistically sensible guess.

Read together, Zwicky's (2006) frequency illusion and TikTok's (2020) description of its "For You" system resolve my "how did it know?" moment. Primed by the relationship pause, my selective attention and confirmation bias made breakup videos register as hits, while the system translated my micro-behaviours on the app into a ranked stream that clustered me with users displaying similar traces. The consoling caption felt intimate because my mind was ready to receive it, and the system was trained to supply it. What felt like being heard was, in truth, being modelled by me, through attention and statistics.

Ultimately, my phone was not 'listening'; it was predicting, while I was projecting. The seeming intimacy between my TikTok feed and my feelings was never proof of secret listening but a reflection of cognitive bias meeting algorithmic precision. My mind, primed by emotion, sought validation, while the system, trained on behaviour, supplied it. This interplay of attention and prediction creates the illusion of empathy. The larger implication is clear: our phones are not listening; they are learning and mirroring the vulnerabilities we unconsciously teach them. So what?

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The Comma in Your Decisions: Choice in an Age of Abundance

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"What do you want to have?" The barista in a green apron asked.

What do I want?

I peered through the glass at picturesque pastries, then up at the menu board crammed with drink options. My eyes flicked over the list for the umpteenth time. The espresso machine hissed in the background, reminding me of how absurdly long I'd been agonising over this single source of dopamine. "Iced vanilla latte," I blurted at last. "Grande, please," I added hesitantly after debating between three sizes — all of which are merely different synonyms of 'Large'. The barista repeated my order. I nodded in resignation, already mourning the alternate possibilities I had killed with a singular decision.

The plethora of choices bestowed by modern life does not liberate, like many seem to believe. As I collected my beverage, I stole a glance at the "Limited Edition" section. *Muscat Grape Black Tea* — was that the better pick? I stared at the cup in my hand. The *Starbucks* siren grinned back sardonically. *You may never get another shot at that tea*, she seemed to say. I took a quick sip of my manufactured cocktail of happiness, attempting to quell the emotional toil of wrestling with multi-variables.

Endless permutations of coffee orders and seasonal trends remind us of what we are not choosing, leaving us in states of anxious limbo. Yet, this inertia is hardly confined to café runs, and is rooted in every minor and major decision of mine. It makes itself manifest in university life: Biomedical Science and BioBusiness for my academic venture, and Aquathlon — Swim and Run — as one of my extracurricular activities. "And" seems to be my indicator of security — and "multiples" my comfort zone.

One could dismiss the struggle to commit as mere indecisiveness. Yet beneath it often lies perfectionism — the terrifying knowledge that the freedom to choose is also the risk to err. And I know I'm not alone in this mindset. With the artificial privilege of choice at our fingertips, its commercialisation only magnifies this paralysis. Modern life conflates quantity for quality, disorienting our senses — the compass by which we observe, feel, and navigate our environments. Soon enough, what begins as a coffee order ripples outward. We second-guess the reasoning behind our choices — careers, relationships, and even identities. In a world bereft of clarity and direction, the first stroke through muddied waters may just be understanding the forces at play: What are the systemic undercurrents that amplify the decision-making inertia and neuroticism that defines our age?

In *The Consumer Society*, French Sociologist Jean Baudrillard (1998) critiques the capitalist world in the setting of a post-war consumer boom. As the "consumer man never comes face to face with his own needs... nor is he ever confronted with his own image" (Baudrillard, 1998, p. 191), Baudrillard

postulates that consumption is never really about alleviating practical needs or wants. Rather, it serves as a prism to communicate one's desired position within the social hierarchy. In this symbolic caste framework, economic goods operate as signs. This entraps individuals in what Baudrillard terms 'perpetual recycling' (1998), whereby individuality becomes warped and continually reinvented by market trends.

This urge to accessorise the self with economic signs remains relevant in an era where consumerism pervades every facet of life, finding its vehicle in what philosopher Han Byung-Chul (2015) calls the 'achievement society'. Han uses this term to describe the positive power which governs most democracies today, one that insists 'you can'. This shifts the entire burden of self-actualisation on the individual (Han, 2015). Concurrently, the market convinces us that fulfillment lies one purchase away. I suspect that for this reason, no matter how trivial a decision seems (like choosing a beverage), we buy and make choices to realise the best version of our potential — or at least to appear so.

Nowhere is this more visible than the performative male archetype in our midst — an epidemic of *matcha*-drinking, *Labubu*-toting, *Sally Rooney*-reading men, eager to embody an I-don't-support-toxic-masculinity image and appeal to modern day progressive women (Bramley, 2025). While this trends toward parody on social media, I recognise the pressure of investing one's limited resources into projecting a coherent self, and the fear that choosing a certain drink, hobby, or other markers might miscommunicate who we inherently are. Because consumerism has been intertwined with social meaning, decisions have essentially become high-stakes tests of our cultural fluency, and making sub-optimal choices penalises our social-worth and favourability as a human being. We therefore no longer live life, but curate one — painstakingly.

However, reading Baudrillard (1998) alone risks presenting the majority of humanity as passive vessels to be filled by "isms", which is too parochial of a view. After all, we are also cognitive beings experiencing genuine overwhelm in decision making. To explore a more complete picture of how this external pressure is met with internal vulnerability (an unfortunate recipe for implosion), it is imperative to temper Baudrillard's (1998) determinism with insights from American psychologist Barry Schwartz.

Schwartz (2004) opines in his book *The Paradox Of Choice* that presentations of excess often cascade into dissatisfaction and impaired decision making. He illustrates this through a study by Columbia University professor Sheena Iyengar. At a grocery store, her research team alternated between two jam-tasting booths: one offering a spread of 24 varieties, and the other with 6. While the larger display attracted greater initial interest, it resulted in significantly fewer jam purchases. Exposure to ample-choice conditions encourages us to anticipate regret before we have even chosen, and at times, causes us to abandon the act of choosing altogether. This reveals the fleeting allure of abundance, suggesting that while choice is widely heralded as the cornerstone of autonomy — an element indispensable to humanity's well-being — "there comes a point at which opportunities become so numerous that we feel overwhelmed" (Schwartz, 2004, p. 104).

The human mind already struggles to process half a dozen, jammy stimuli while adhering to the economic ideal of rational utility maximisation. How, then, can it cope with two dozen? Maybe that is why we are less content when presented with more — the loss aversion humanity is shackled with renders decision-making too burdensome and time-consuming, as each additional choice creates new avenues for our

psyches to ruminate on compounding opportunity costs. This dynamic is further nuanced by the psychological profile coined by Herbert Simon: *maximisers* are condemned to seek the singular, best option (Simon, 1957) — a task that becomes Sisyphean amidst a sea of paralysing multiplicity. Therefore, depending on the spectrum in which the individual lies, some would present innate proclivities to yield to the tipping point of "too much choice" Schwartz (2004) warns against.

Yet, within today's hyper-commercialised society, humanity's propensity to maximise grows increasingly pronounced. This behaviour could be classified as a maladaptive relic: from an evolutionary standpoint, ancestors who were more meticulous in surveying environments conferred a selective advantage in scarce habitats — the most nutrient-dense crop, the safest water source — our dopamine-driven, mammalian brains were wired to search for the optimal. But where nature provides a few life-or-death options, the modern marketplace churns and brews ornate cocktails of triviality. The appearance of this maximising trait, therefore, isn't just a crafting of nature, but perhaps, the greater nurturing by today's contemporary culture. The neural circuitry we once depended on for survival now fires at every semblance of missing out on 'resources', triggering false alarms of deprivation.

In this light, Baudrillard (1998) emphasises the existential weight between social identity and decision-making, while Schwartz (2004) suggests that greater choice quantity exacerbates decision-making stressors. This symbolic consumption and paradox of choice, together, completes the concoction for indecision: our desire to communicate value through our choices feeds into the pursuit of optimisation, pressuring us to seek and consider ever more markers of status and, thus, falling into the trap of anxious abundance. Indecisiveness, therefore, is not a lapse of willpower nor a failure of character, but a moral condition produced by late capitalism — one in which individuals are lulled into treating every choice as a referendum on their own worth.

Liberation, then, lies not in maximising, but in *satisficing*: the radical act of embracing "good enough" (Simon, 1957). Though far removed from a perfectly orchestrated life, such imperfection restores the dignity of choosing. For to choose is, inevitably, to err — to live humanely. If history proves anything, it is that humankind is defined not by our perfect selections, but by our resilience in the face of imperfect ones. We are forged through the constant work of rebuilding, repairing, and finding meaning in the uncommodifiable experience of living with our choices.

Still, our fixation on the 'negatives', and the 'unattained' — what could have been — can exacerbate indecision. This tendency, however, should not be dismissed as a mere cognitive flaw. It attunes us to our own limitations and, crucially, sensitises us to the fragility of others. There is, therefore, beauty in recognising our fallenness and embracing it — understanding that we need not measure ourselves against the impossible merit of perfection. For the world tends toward entropy, and we will occasionally make regrettable choices. Yet we learn from these decisions, and sometimes make mistakes others will learn from. This is the wonderfully messy process by which the self — and collectively, humanity — grows and becomes better human beings.

We can therefore find comfort in this shared, modern struggle, and relinquish the lonely battle of self-perfection waged through our every choice. With this awareness, the comma in our decisions can exist, not as paralysis, but as grace. In that pause — between wanting and being, striving and surrendering — we learn to accept that the world will always offer more

than our mere hands can hold.

In holding the ordinary — that unrevelatory, iced vanilla latte — we are humbled. The world does not hinge on our internal calculus of perfection. It rarely does. And perhaps, in choosing less, in wanting less, we might finally start living more.

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Beyond Our Externality

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"What should I wear today?" – this is the recurring thought that crosses my mind as each day greets me. Standing in front of the mirror, I evaluate myself ritualistically, delving into the sphere of emotions I encapsulate, dissecting them to determine what image of myself I desire to portray. Which self am I inviting others to meet today – the adventurous or reserved self? What elevates and accentuates my intended persona? Should style overpower comfort?

Well, between style and comfort, I settled on 'and' – a pleasant incorporation of both.

Opening my closet, pieces of varied hues and motifs welcomed my sight. Each of them called out to me, almost enticing me to choose them. Folded pieces, reserved yet passionate, were on a level footing with the bold, prominent pieces displayed on the hangers. This endeavor intrigued me – I provided each piece an opportunity to shine. From crop tops, oversized tees, to fitted tops, I discovered that the model was rather inadequate. "This looks strange...No, this doesn't suit me. Ugh! This top makes me look plump...why did I purchase this in the first place?" Judgement and scrutiny possessed me, compelling me to nitpick every piece so fervent for a chance to see the light. Disproval and disdain flooded my mind as I frantically attempted to present a satisfactory outfit to the hypercritical judge in the mirror. Yet no sign of approval emerged.

Gazing at the pile of defeated pieces on my bed, I prayed desperately, "Last time's the charm, please." Upon donning a grungy outfit, I immediately despised the look. "Fine," I muttered as I resorted to my staple outfit – an oversized shirt and a pair of flowy pants. I felt secure within the mundane. A slow nod of approval ceased the criticism. "Finally, a decent outfit. This never goes wrong," I mumbled and exhaled in relief.

Feeling tranquil after the storm, I picked up each piece, thoroughly observing them – they were all unique and perfect. I began pondering: why did I think otherwise when I adorned them? Was I subconsciously projecting my insecurities onto these pieces which are dedicated not just to modesty, but to self-expression? Realisation struck me: the pieces I wear do not explicitly define me as a person; they are merely an expression of temperate emotions. Everyone exhibits their form of self-expression through their outfits, subject to everyday depending on their emotions and the persona they choose to don. This directs me to question: if I am the canvas, the artist, and the critic, does concocting the outfit become a form of self-trial?

The tension between my external appearance and emotions echoes a profound philosophical question about selfhood explored by Jacques Lacan.

According to Lacan's (1949/2006) concept of the *Mirror Stage as Formative of the I Function*, the infant, while still wholly uncoordinated and dependent, sees their reflection – a unified and coordinated image of themselves in the mirror. The still and reversed image in the mirror (the imago) conflicts with their inner chaotic and turbulent experience yet, they proceed to identify themselves with their imago, thus forming an

idealized version of themselves – the "ideal I". A hopeful but fictional preview of their future competency and coordination is ingrained into them, resulting in the misrecognition of a unified self – an external image we mistakenly regard as our essence. The ego is, therefore, actively formed and situated merely on the still and alienating external imago seen in the mirror. Although the mirror stage is a necessary precondition for experiencing and existing in the social world, a gap between the individual's "ideal I" and their fragmented reality can never be closed, therefore shaping a lifelong pursuit of finding a coherent identity. Sartorial taste derives from the imago we perceive in the mirror. Whether we discern elegance or disarray, our fashion follows suit. We dress in accordance with our self-conception, even as our clothing subtly reforms it.

From a young age, we have been conditioned to determine our "true self" and ego through our external image – one that desires to appear coordinated while concealing our conflicting inner experiences. We live each day attempting to present a flawless image of ourselves through our clothing – confident, coordinated and competent. Uniforms play this exact role. Crisp lines and sharp creases depict discipline and professionalism – a polished image many envision, redirecting attention from our perceived inadequacy to our strengths. However, when we perceive our outfits as making us look less desirable, the fragility and instability of our ego become evident, allowing dissatisfaction and malaise to arise. We expect our clothes to conceal our flaws and accentuate our beings to a nuanced extent, preventing extensive scrutiny. Essentially, we succumb to the ego, enabling our external image to triumph over our vehement inner emotions, resulting in a vicious feedback loop where interconnected fictions cause unnecessary distress.

A diverging perspective is presented by another French existentialist, Jean-Paul Sartre, in his work *Being and Nothingness* (1943/2015). Sartre explains that the being is separated into two categories: the in-itself and for-itself. The former is defined as unified and self-identical while the latter is defined by a lack, negation and distance from itself. The human – a for-itself, is not a fixed, self-identical object. Instead, we are beings of possibilities that are not inherently defined by our past and current state; we can actively choose to negate the facticity of our past to consciously transcend and manifest possibilities of our desired realities. The "unified self" is an illusion where bad faith prevails as we portray ourselves as an in-itself – a dense block of plenitude rather than myriads of opportunities waiting to be grasped.

Reflecting upon Sartre's (1943/2015) philosophy, I discovered that acknowledging the self's instability is part of the ongoing process of weaving together our choices, negations and possibilities. Our identities are ever-changing and multifaceted; the person we were yesterday and who we are in the present can exist in convergence; they are not summative of our being. Bad faith lies not in the garments itself but in the assumption that certain transformations of the self lack legitimacy. When we refuse to move beyond our comfort zone, we restrict the freedom of our sartorial exploration through self-labelling – and that limitation is itself an instance of bad faith. Stepping away from self-labelling loosens the chain of self-criticism, thus enabling us to concoct a multitude of outfits regardless of style or stereotypes. Confidence lies not in the outfit but in the conviction with which we inhabit it. Our outfits are simply the temporalisation of our freedom, utilised to enact the possibilities we encapsulate through actively exploring outfits rather than grounding ourselves in a singular style.

Through Lacan's (1949/2006) and Sartre's (1943/2015) philosophies, a complex and nuanced

understanding of selfhood emerges. Selfhood is a reflexive dynamism that oscillates between the unattainable ideal and transcendence of singular identity. While the Lacanian self retains a rigid structure, the Sartrean self possesses the consciousness to overflow and diverge from the identity's anchor. We have been programmed to fulfill our misguided ego, confining ourselves within an intangible sphere of self-imposed expectations that are potentially debilitating. Passivity towards the manipulative critic within us enforces a feedback loop that constructs and reconstructs fictions – a habit I was subconsciously adopting. Each passing day delivered endless blows to my ego, leaving no space for escape. Sartre's (1943/2015) philosophy emerged as the light at the end of the tunnel, however. The self's negation is not a flaw but rather the essential condition for subjectivity and growth. Selfhood cannot exist without either. Overreliance on the mirror image results in self-labelling and conformity, whereas excessive freedom invites volatility and dissipation of the authentic self. The reflexive gap in our identities explains both the constant reinvention of ourselves and the pressure to maintain an image. It takes two to tango; the productive tension between illusion and freedom is quintessential to selfhood.

With newfound knowledge on selfhood, I acknowledge the possibility of reclaiming autonomy and resisting the critic within through unrestricted experimentation in expression and style. My focus now shifts towards creative self-expression in my outfits to reflect my multifaceted self. In future morning rituals, the mirror then becomes the site where my fictional unified ideal confronts my ever-changing interior self, weaving together personas suited for varying occasions.

Looking back at my closet, I realise that each piece is – and will continue to be – a fragment of my identity. Waiting to be uncovered.

It was all disarmingly simple. The outfits I wore were never inadequate to begin with; my insecurity merely disguised itself as dissatisfaction. I had confined myself to a singular, rigid identity, relinquishing the freedom to inhabit others. The reconciliation of my Lacanian imago and Sartrean freedom will emerge when I step beyond my comfort zone and embrace the jarring, eccentric ensemble – accepting the perfectly imperfect image of myself.

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The Persistent Grip of Self-Curation: Who Are We Really Performing For?

By Syadiyah Adlina Binte Suhaimi
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The lobby was cramped, bathed in harsh fluorescent light that flattened everything into a cold, clinical brightness. A faint disinfectant smell lingered in the air. Two workers tended to customers in the queue. Behind them, a booking whiteboard was already half-filled, timings crossed out in black marker. I joined the line behind two teens in secondary-school uniforms, their chatter rising above the low hum of the aircon and muffled singing. One of them checked her phone. "*Eh*, she's gonna be late. Let's sing that Sabrina Carpenter song first, since she hates it.

A staff member beckoned them forward. "Hi, welcome to Teo Heng. Got booking?"

After paying for a three-hour session, I walked down the corridor in search of my room. Wooden doors lined both sides, leaking the thump of bass and half-shouted lyrics. Each room played a different song that bled into the next. One voice belting Adele's *Set Fire to the Rain* rose above the rest. She was fast approaching the chorus, and I found myself rooting for her. I slowed, peeking into a tiny window on the door. Her friends waved their arms as she reached for the high note. Her voice cracked. She faltered. Adele sang on without her, unforgiving. Shoulders dropping, she turned. Our eyes met. I flinched and hurried on.

Inside my small room, cosy for two, I settled onto the vinyl bench and queued my usual opening song: Taylor Swift's *You Belong With Me*. As the song started, the beats pulsed through the seat. I had barely sung the first verse when I felt a gaze on me. I glanced at the window. A guy lingered outside, staring straight in. A knot formed in my stomach. I lowered the mic and fixed my eyes on the floor tiles.

As I waited for him to pass, I began to wonder. Why was I so ashamed? What made me stop singing? In that moment, I felt a kinship with the girl who faltered on Adele's chorus. For both of us, excitement gave way to self-consciousness.

I thought about the teens shaping their setlist around a friend's dislikes, the Adele singer folding after a single cracked note, and me turning mute at a stranger's gaze. Karaoke was meant to be an escape – somewhere we could sing badly and laugh freely. Yet we still felt the need to sound good and consider others first. It is not just karaoke. In conversations, we measure our words and gauge the room. Online, we share one picture out of dozens. Even in carefree spaces, we trim ourselves down to what feels safest to show. It made me wonder: why do we curate ourselves, even in the spaces where we should feel free?

In a cross-cultural study, psychologist Steven Heine (2008) and his colleagues from the University of British Columbia and Kyoto University explored how self-awareness varied across societies. They built on the Objective Self-Awareness Theory (Duval & Wicklund, 1972), which suggests that we evaluate ourselves according to how we think others might see

us. Heine and his team conducted two experiments with Japanese and North American students. In the first, American participants rated themselves more critically when a mirror was present, while Japanese participants showed no change. Even without a mirror, Japanese participants already rated themselves more critically than Americans did. In the second experiment, Canadian participants were less likely to cheat when facing a mirror. But again, the mirror had no effect on Japanese participants. Heine et al. (2008) interpret this pattern to suggest that Japanese students may already possess a more chronic, internalised self-awareness that a mirror could not further amplify.

This difference can be understood through the concept of face – the public image a person feels compelled to protect. In cultures where face matters, people are more attuned to how their actions reflect on those around them. In Japan, this sensitivity is embedded in *seken*, the surrounding social world that functions like a shared moral guide, shaping norms and appropriate behaviour (Kurihara, 2017). As Heine et al. (2008) note, cultures shaped by face "lead people to habitually conceive of themselves in terms of how they imagine others might view them". Singapore also has a concept of face, though it seems to differ from Japan's more moralised version. Here, face often works as a social performance tied to reputation. I see it in the way we apologise for "looking tired" on Zoom or downplay our achievements to not appear boastful. We may curate to protect a favourable image, perhaps so much so that even in light-hearted spaces like karaoke, this inward gaze influences how we present ourselves before we fully realise it.

If this inward gaze shapes how we see ourselves, sociologist Erving Goffman helps explain how it shapes the performances we give. In his book *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life* (1959), he writes that individuals act before audiences, real or imagined. He describes a front stage where we present versions of ourselves that we believe the situation demands, like slipping into our "presentation self" the moment we stand before a class. Behind this lies the backstage, a more private space where the audience shrinks, allowing parts of ourselves that might not survive public scrutiny. Yet even here, Goffman (1959) suggests, we are not entirely free of performance. We become our own audience, evaluating how well we fulfilled the role we had taken on the front stage.

Goffman (1959) argues that these performances are guided by impression management – our instinctive effort to shape how others see us so interactions unfold smoothly. For him this is not deception but a social necessity. The self, he suggests, is not something hidden behind the act but something created through it. As he writes, "[t]he self… is not an organic thing that has a specific location… it is a dramatic effect arising diffusely from a scene that is presented" (Goffman, 1959). To Goffman (1959), self-curation is not a flaw but a condition of social life. We perform because it helps us understand who we are in relation to others. Small acts, like greeting a neighbour politely despite feeling exhausted, allow interactions to stay predictable and cooperative. Even when we think we have stepped backstage, traces of the act linger. I think of my solo karaoke sessions: no one is watching, yet I still adjust my volume and worry about hitting the high notes. The imagined audience stays with me, shaping my behaviour even in an empty room.

Heine et al. (2008) and Goffman (1959) show that self-curation is tied to being seen, though they explain that awareness in different ways. For Heine et al. (2008), we monitor ourselves because we imagine how others might judge us. Self-curation stems from self-consciousness and the fear of falling short. Goffman (1959), however, is less concerned with self-

judgement and more with social order. He argues that we perform because interaction depends on it, and we present versions of ourselves that maintain a sense of interactional order.

More recently, the digital world has intensified this dynamic. Online, the audience never really goes away, and the line between seeing ourselves and presenting ourselves blurs. The imagined gaze Heine et al. (2008) describe becomes harder to escape, and we start to see everyday moments as material for content. The digital world also expands the front stage Goffman (1959) describes. Although he argues that these stages are not fixed places, many of us still associate private spaces, especially our homes, with the backstage. Yet even these feel less protected now. Zoom or Teams calls bring work and school into bedrooms and living rooms, and the ordinary moments that unfold there can easily be recorded or posted. As domestic life becomes more visible and more public, what once felt safely backstage grows smaller under an audience that never fully disappears.

Coming into this, I saw self-curation as a flaw to fix. However, I now think it is not wrong. Perhaps it even has its place. As Goffman (1959) reminds us, performance is part of how we make sense of one another. It enables us to form close connections. When a friend is upset, we might soften our tone or choose our words more gently. Small adjustments like these help us signal care and understand how they are feeling. Yet when self-curation becomes excessive, the focus shifts from connection to control. Instead of responding naturally, we begin to monitor every word, worried about saying the "right" thing. It becomes difficult to attend to the other person when so much attention is spent on managing ourselves. The performance that once created connection now constrains it.

I revisited Teo Heng several times while working through these ideas, and noticed even more instances of self-curation in others and myself. On my most recent visit with friends, I tried something different: I did my best to shift my attention outward instead of focusing on how I came across. It struck me that self-curation often feels like consideration for others, as though we are trying not to burden them with our mistakes or awkwardness. In practice, it keeps our attention fixed on ourselves: how we look, how we sound, how we might be judged. When I stopped monitoring how I appeared, my attention returned to the friends in front of me. I joined in without rehearsing my next song or correcting myself mid-note. Somewhere in those four hours, something small but noticeable shifted for me. I felt more present with them than I usually do. I cannot say whether anyone else felt it too, but the moment suggests how outward attention might change the atmosphere of a group, even in subtle ways.

Self-curation may be part of how we move through the world, but it does not need to sit at the centre of everything we do. My experience at Teo Heng suggested that when the inward gaze shifted outwards, even briefly, the imagined audience began to fade. The moment felt less like something to manage and more like something shared. Connection became possible not through perfect self-presentation, but through noticing the people before me. Perhaps what mattered most was realising that the imagined audience was rarely paying as much attention as I feared.

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The Shifting Language of Emotion: Authenticity Across Solitude and Society

By Vamsee Sahana

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While reading my journal entries, I came across a particularly difficult emotional moment. The page reflected an intensity visible in its structure, sentences breaking mid-thought, metaphors layered on top of each other, ink pressed darker into the paper at the end of some lines more than others. On my phone, the Notes app held another version of it. A rush of words typed too quickly to be grammatically sound, butchered spellings, unfinished lines stacked without order. What had happened was simple enough to explain in one sentence, the end of a relationship. But it morphed so many times in memory and language that one sentence cannot explain it. When I felt the emotion before writing, it felt different to the journal, like a heavy, shapeless weight on my chest. The journal, by contrast, carved that weight into image and rhythm. When I shared it with my best friend, I made jokes, downplayed it, was sarcastic, and laughed at the same event that made me cry the night before. It was the same emotion, but it sounded like it was spoken in a different dialect. This brought me to question, was I lying? Was I inauthentic to my friends? Or was I overly dramatic in my journal? It felt as if I were editing my feelings to make them socially acceptable. This brings me to the question at hand. What does it mean to be emotionally honest? Is it consistently expressing emotions the same way across mediums, or is it something more complex?

When we are alone, we often feel emotions in a raw and unfiltered form. There is no instinct to explain, no pressure to shape them. Sadness or anger arrives like a sudden overpowering wave, unstructured and overwhelming. Neuroscientist Matthew Lieberman and colleagues (2007) showed that labelling emotions, even silently, changes how the brain responds. Using functional magnetic resonance imaging (fMRI), they found that when participants identified emotional states, activity in the amygdala, the brain's center for emotional intensity, decreased. Meanwhile, regions in the prefrontal cortex responsible for reasoning and regulation increased. In essence, putting a feeling into words helps the brain process it. Without this kind of labeling, emotions remain unorganised sensations, felt in the body rather than processed in the mind. This may explain why emotions in solitude can feel heavier and more intense. There is nothing forcing the emotion into a structured form (Lieberman et al., 2007).

Another expression of emotions could be through writing. Not only does writing allow us to vent, but it forces us to organise chaotic emotion into narratives. A raw, overwhelming sensation becomes a story with a beginning, middle, and end, even if it is an incoherent one. Writing allows pain to exist in a structured form, making it easier to carry. Alone, my feelings may weigh me down, but putting them into words transforms them from an intangible burden into something I can examine, interpret, and gradually, reconcile with. The evidence for this is seen in James Pennebaker's (1997) work on journaling for patients

suffering from post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD). He found that expressive writing, particularly about distressing experiences, can improve both mental and physical health. He pioneered research on the psychological impact of writing and found how the structure of writing helped in healing and alleviating physiological effects like tiredness, metabolism and more (Pennebaker, 1997).

These ways of private processing, however, cannot fully capture what happens when emotions are shared with others. Social interaction adds a layer of negotiation, where feelings must be adapted to the context of human interaction. Around others, emotion becomes a form of communication, shaped to fit societal norms and protect relationships. Linguists refer to a phenomenon in language called

code-switching, the practice of switching languages or dialects depending on context. Emotionally, we do the same. Around some people, we express vulnerability openly, and around others, we use humour or understatement. Each audience has its own unspoken rules for what is acceptable.

Williams et al. (2019) studied bilingual speakers and found that individuals often switch to their native language when expressing strong negative emotions. This form of emotional code-switching allows people to communicate feelings that might be too intense for the language or tone of the moment. Applied more broadly, this demonstrates that emotions are always shaped by social context. Just as bilinguals switch languages, people adjust how they show feelings socially versus privately. Humour, sarcasm, or understatement are ways to "translate" intense emotions so they can be safely shared. These adaptations do not make emotions less real, they are simply responding to context and audience, and often occur involuntarily, showing that they are not manipulation of one "truth," but rather a different facet of it (Williams et al., 2019).

Translation is not distortion, it is communication. When I shift how I express sadness depending on who I am with, I am not hiding my feelings, I am finding the language that will allow them to exist in that space between us. Emotion, then, is relative. It does not just exist within us but also among us, constantly adjusting its grammar to be understood. The laughter that slips out during grief, the careful tone when confiding in a friend, the silence that replaces words in a crowd are all the same sentence, pronounced in different dialects. What these differences reveal is that authenticity is not about staying unchanged, but about adapting to the environment we are in.

Lieberman et al.'s (2007) findings suggest that labelling an emotion changes how we feel it, Pennebaker (1997) shows that writing changes how we remember it, and Williams et al. (2019) suggest that expression changes depending on who hears it. Each layer alters the shape of the emotion, but not its truth. The more fluent we become in these transitions, the more precisely we can live with our feelings rather than be overwhelmed by them.

Still, this brings out a question: if emotion changes with every translation, what holds it together? Perhaps authenticity lies in continuity, the core that remains as emotion migrates between solitude, language, and community. The sadness I feel when alone does not look the same as the one I share through humour, yet both can be traced back to the same root. The change in tone does not erase the feeling, it allows it to survive. In this way, adapting emotion becomes an act of care, both for oneself and others. One can express themself in a way that brings comfort and belonging in each setting. This makes us better prepared to receive clarity about our situation and evolve to better express ourselves in the given environment.

We often mistake emotional consistency for honesty, assuming that the truest version of a feeling is the raw, unfiltered one. But Lieberman et al. (2007) and Pennebaker (1997) both show that articulation, whether through speech or writing, helps regulate and integrate emotion, not suppress it. The brain finds balance through expression. Similarly, Williams et al. (2019) show that emotional shifts across contexts are a form of translation, not concealment. Authenticity, then, may not be a matter of staying the same, but of staying connected to meaning as it changes form. In the same way, emotional honesty becomes the ability to move fluently between different modes of expression and be true and present in each of its many forms.

And maybe that is what makes emotion human. It is not a fixed object we possess but a living process we enact. We feel, interpret, rewrite, and share. Each version, whether private, written or spoken, reveals something the others cannot. Alone, we encounter emotion as raw data, in writing, as comprehension, and in society, as exchange. These stages do not cancel each other out but complete the cycle of understanding. To feel authentically is not to preserve the original emotion untouched but to let it move through these phases and remain recognisable.

So, how are negative emotions felt personally versus socially, and how does interpreting them in writing affect the way we process them? Personally, emotions are visceral, heavy, and pre-verbal.

Socially, they are translated and negotiated for understanding and acceptance. Writing serves as a bridge, turning raw feeling into structured expression that can be reflected upon, understood, and integrated. Recognising that emotion migrates across contexts allows us to rethink what it means to be authentic: not as rigid or unchanging, but as adaptable and fluent in expressing the self across different mediums. Perhaps being fluent in your emotions, not unrestricted, is the truest form of honesty.

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To Trust or Not to Trust

By Teh Kian Ee

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Figure 1. Hall 1 Bus Stop Pedestrian Crossing

Figure 2. Pedestrian Crossing in Kuala Lumpur

Cast adrift from familiar soil, a strange scene greeted me as I first stepped into NTU. Bright yellow, Lego-like tactile paving stood in stark contrast to the monochrome lines that it bordered, signaling unassuming wanderers about the perilous territory they were entering. The bus slowed, brakes sighed, and the Hall 1 pedestrian crossing filled with gossip and laughter from groups of sleep-deprived zombies. As they crossed the road, I was stunned into silence.

The sacred yellow lines were crossed with no thought behind their eyes, ignorant about their surroundings, the sounds of the world drowned out before them. The crosswalk pulsed with gossip and laughter, whilst others barely even looked up from their dopamine dispensers... much to my horror. Prickles of sweat traced my spine, but it seemed they were indifferent to their trespassing of the danger zone, oblivious to the killing machines roaring towards them. I started to question if I was being too cautious, too paranoid. Still, it would only take one careless driver to end a story too soon. Was it so hard to just look before you crossed?

In Malaysia, crossing roads was a mind game to me. I observed the furrowed brows of the driver, predicted their likeliest course, and planned the most efficient route lest I wanted to be honked at. It was normal to me; it was the Malaysian way.

Much to my surprise though, I assimilated into the zombie herd barely a month into my life in NTU. It was subtle at first, a gentle whisper, "the rules are so strict here, no driver would dare to not slow down". Then, it became a guilty pleasure of sorts. Only looking in one direction, other times only after crossing halfway. Soon enough, I was crossing roads as if it were *jalan bapak kau*, a Malay phrase meaning "like my father owned the road."

Being "Made in Malaysia," these actions would be akin to suicide back home. My eyes used to dart left and right with breakneck speed before crossing roads.

Now, they latch onto the other side of the road without a care. The more I thought about it, the more I felt conflicted with my Malaysian self, screaming at me to pay attention. Pedestrian infrastructure is built to allow pedestrians to cross roads safely, so why do some of us still feel that we cannot trust it to protect us? Then again, is it not psychologically instinctive for us to want to be in control of our own safety? How should we choose to place our trust in the systems and people around us? This led me to my main question: How does the act of crossing roads reflect the ways trust is constructed in shared public areas?

Llinares et al. (2020) explore and measure how specific elements in street design can affect a pedestrian's physiological perception of safety when crossing. The authors explain that pedestrians assess the safety and risk of crossing via urban design elements, which affects how in control the pedestrians feel. In particular, they found that the "number of traffic lanes affected almost all the metrics studied" (Llinares et al., 2020, p.9), with fewer lanes generally producing higher dominance and lower stress. Artificial lighting had similar effects to a lesser extent, while vegetation was more context-dependent. In other words, the built environment around the crossing itself can influence people's behaviour, not just by visually appearing safer, but also by nudging people into feeling calmer and more trustful of the space.

This study highlights the perception of trust constructed via environmental cues. The crossing that I observed replicated many of the design features associated with high perceived safety, such as raised crossings and contrasting markings. They clearly signaled the hierarchy of pedestrians first, drivers second. It is possible that many of us zombies subconsciously processed these features as evidence of reliability and thus felt somewhat safe placing our fates in the hands of urban planners. However, the study seems to regard trust as a private feeling rather than a shared social construct. The act of crossing a road does not just involve pedestrians trusting infrastructure, but also trusting drivers. It led me to ponder if there was a social factor that plays a part in how we build trust.

In *Trust and Power* (1979), an influential work by German sociologist Niklas Luhmann, he suggests that trust is not something innate to humans, but rather a trait picked up through learning processes. These processes are kickstarted from a child's first socialisation with family members (Luhmann, 1979, p. 27–28). From this, Luhmann (1979) argues that children build up the social expectation that people are trustworthy as they grow up. In his words, we "trust that others will trust" (Luhmann, 1979, p.57). Thus, in a system as complex as society, trust in one another and in social mechanisms such as traffic rules allows us to reduce the burden of constantly overthinking every risk. Furthermore, trust in systems is also learned and derived from the perception that others trust in it, along with repeated positive exposure to that system.

The concept of socially produced trust that Luhmann (1979) suggests helps to explain how, after my initial culture shock, I began to assimilate into the zombie herd. In a matter of months, continuous positive exposure to this new social norm seeped into my behaviour, and conditioned how I perceive the act of crossing from a tactical, warzone-like activity into a casual (almost unthinking) means of getting from point to point. It is possible that I internalised the belief that cars would always slow down because I trusted that systems such as infrastructure or law enforcement would protect me, as most people do in Singapore. However, the nagging, unsettling feeling when I cross without looking seems unlikely to fade away. That makes me think that Luhmann's (1979) assumption that everyone undergoes the same

process of constructing trust might be a little too neat. Especially as a foreigner residing in a new environment, my trust is not built from scratch, but rather through negotiating with habits I formed during my upbringing in a very different cultural context.

Bringing together the ideas of Llinares et al. (2020) and Luhmann (1979) helped me make sense of my behaviour in this new environment. While they may seem contradictory at times, I believe the two sources complement each other well. The act of crossing reveals that trust is constructed through environmental and social cues. Llinares et al. (2020) show how urban design elements directly influence how safe pedestrians feel, and thus their willingness to trust. Luhmann (1979) argues that trust is socially developed, where it is a learned mechanism that allows individuals to act confidently in complex environments by relying on shared norms. Therefore, while Luhmann (1979) focuses on the social systems that underpin trust, Llinares et al. (2020) point out the physical conditions that constantly reinforce this trust. Both sources complement each other in suggesting that these design elements and social cues help pedestrians build a (sometimes false) sense of security.

Still, I feel there is something deeper. It is almost absurd that we submit our fates to environmental designs and abstract social constructs. It seems to me that systems and infrastructure designed to be as safe as possible can actually create a false sense of security that endangers the very users they are meant to protect. Could it be that safety itself is inherently paradoxical, where the things designed to keep us alive seduce us into carelessness? That the better a system works, the more it endangers us? This paradox is exemplified by the unreliable nature of Malaysian crossings. Those crossings made me more aware, more vigilant and more deliberate in where I stood and how I moved. In stark contrast, many of the Singaporean students I have observed have safety awareness my parents would have criticised as "horrendous.

Maybe, the danger is not in the drivers or the infrastructure, but in our quiet willingness to believe that systems will think for us. We get so caught up in our complacency, so much so that we do not even stop to consider whether the systems we rely on actually have our best interests at heart. Since the unreliable design in Malaysia provided a greater sense of awareness, should systems then be deliberately designed to be less safe? I will have to leave that to the policymakers to answer. In the meantime though, I will continue to be amused by the zombie herd while I play my mind games with the drivers.

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I would like to extend my heartfelt gratitude to my tutor, Ms Amrita, for your invaluable guidance and feedback, along with your humour and kindness that made the process so much more bearable. Thank you so much for helping me turn this story from a small, interesting culture shock to this piece of work. Thank you to the Pioneer Road committee for granting me this opportunity. Lastly, I would like to thank myself for sticking with it, for powering on, even when the end wasn't in plain sight.

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Stepping Into the World of Beliefs: Impacts of Imagery

By Toh Jia En (Zhuo Jia'En)
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The smell of faint herbs and a tinge of a flowery scent gently filled the air as I pulled open the wooden door, which had a tinted glass image of a mother holding a child. Upon walking into the chapel room, only one row of lights was left on, and the room glowed with an orangey-yellow tone. The first thing that caught my eye was the glowing light from the tinted glass picture that formed the backdrop of the stage, and in front of it stood a life-sized statue of Jesus hanging on the cross.

I shifted my gaze to the left of Jesus's statue and saw a life-sized Mother Mary with her arms wide open, seemingly inviting one to a warm hug and saying, "You are safe here." On the right side of Jesus stood a fatherly figure, slightly hunched over, with one hand raised and his index finger pointing up, as if he were a teacher. The contrast between the two figures seems to imply that while going to church may make one feel at home, safe, comforted, or forgiven, it also reminds them that it is a place of learning, mirroring a school concept, where one is taught discipline and moral improvement.

As I looked around, circular frames with three-dimensional carvings depicting Jesus and two other figures hung on the walls. They were scenes of Jesus carrying the cross, always with three men in each frame. I took this repetition of three to signify the Holy Trinity, a central Christian doctrine continually reinforced by the imagery. As I sat on the hard surface of the wooden benches, I took in the view of Jesus hanging on the cross, bright red blood subtly oozing from his wrists and feet. The sight naturally evoked a sense of heartache, and an indescribable guilt of being unable to help, merely bearing witness to it.

It then dawned on me that all these recurring statues and tinted-glass images of Jesus might serve to remind Christians of his sacrifices and to evoke strong feelings of indebtedness and gratitude. I could not help but compare this with the religious space of a Mosque, where no imagery is portrayed, yet the devotion found there is equally real. How strong must one's faith be in order to believe without seeing? Is seeing necessary to believing? What powerful roles do imagery play when it comes to one's beliefs?

To begin answering that, faculty members of the Institute of Religion at the University of Santo Tomas (Albia et al., 2023) explored how religious imageries and art serve as tools that help humans better comprehend abstract spiritual concepts that words alone may not fully capture. They argue that icons and pictures are "universally recognisable" (Albia et al., 2023), allowing people to connect and understand shared emotions beyond language barriers. For instance, the image of a mother and child conveys love as a universal human experience.

They went a step further to discuss the unique case of Islam, where the depiction of God and Prophet Muhammad is prohibited to avoid misrepresentation or disrespect; instead, the intricate calligraphy art and geometric precision of Quranic verses are designed to reflect the "perfection and order of the divine" (Albia et

al., 2023). Ultimately, they suggested that it may be a natural human inclination to express faith and emotion through artistic forms, allowing both creators and perceivers to find deeper meaning in these visual representations (Albia et al., 2023).

Through their insights, I can infer that imagery serves as a tool that helps humans comprehend abstract concepts, bridging the gap between us and the unperceivable, transcendent beings described across religions. They connect deeply to one's emotions, and through that emotional engagement, perhaps leave a stronger and more lasting impression than words alone, since the image may be imprinted in our minds along with the emotions evoked while viewing it. This reminds me of why the statue of Jesus Christ was so emotionally striking and impressionable: perhaps imagery plays the role of making faith more tangible and emotionally grounded.

However, questions inevitably arise, and I start to wonder why emotions play such a vital role in depicting these images and in building one's faith. This is especially since many religious teachings caution against blindly following one's senses or "fleshly desires". What, then, makes this emotional process not only acceptable but essential in the spiritual experience? Could imagery be what sustains faith over time, or does it merely serve as the first step or catalyst in the process of building it?

To probe the emotional aspect, Alpuim and Ehrenberg (2023), a psychologist and a journalist respectively who both hold PhDs in psychology, examine the psychological impact of images in journalism. They argue that imagery plays a powerful role in shaping emotions, memory, and perception, but they also emphasise that interpretation is not necessarily "universal." As every individual's experiences differ, images can evoke distinct emotional responses, such as how a photo of a large dog might bring joy to one person but fear to another (Alpuim and Ehrenberg, 2023).

Their article further explains that the brain's emotion-related regions can physiologically affect how we respond to visual stimuli, with studies showing that people react more strongly to negative images than to positive ones. Lastly, they note that "pictures also add to the perceived 'truthiness' of a statement" (Alpuim and Ehrenberg , 2023), suggesting that emotional familiarity may lead individuals to mistake repeated or emotionally charged visuals for factual credibility. This then raises an important consideration of whether imagery and pictures, while emotionally powerful, might also impose certain limitations on one's comprehension of faith or belief.

This subjectivity suggests that imagery, though effective in evoking emotion, may not always promote a shared or accurate understanding of religious or moral truths. In the context of faith, this could mean that instead of deepening belief, some images risk shaping or even distorting it based on one's emotional bias. Therefore, while imagery plays a significant role in connecting emotions to belief, it also highlights the need for discernment and reflection to ensure that one's faith is not merely built upon emotional impressions but supported by genuine understanding and interpretation.

Although both perspectives agree that imageries can strengthen beliefs of a subject through emotional engagement, they differ sharply on whether imageries and icons are universal. Alpuim and Ehrenberg (2023) emphasise the intention behind selecting images for journalistic publications and how images influence perception and credibility. In contrast, Albia et al. (2023) did not explicitly discuss the intentions behind religious imagery, but it underscores how believers express deep resonance with their faith through art, such as how the Quranic

calligraphy reflects the believers' reverence for the divine. From a perceiver's perspective, religious imagery may require a certain level of familiarity with the teachings of their belief system, allowing them to form a deeper and more meaningful connection with the artwork. This stands in contrast to images used in journal articles, where interpretation may rely more heavily on personal experiences rather than shared doctrinal understanding.

Could imagery in beliefs suggest that, despite religious caution against relying on our senses and emotions, their very use to captivate and strengthen faith acknowledges that humans are inseparable from emotion? Beyond their emotional appeal, such depictions also invite analysis, reflection, and introspection, making interpretation more meaningful when one can "decode" and connect these visuals to a belief's teachings. For instance, the lotus flower in Buddhism symbolises purity, growing beautifully even in murky water (Oo et al., 2022). Such examples remind us that while interpretations may vary, some imageries transcend subjectivity, embodying timeless symbols that anchor faith in both nature and meaning.

Perhaps this suggests that across faiths, the emphasis lies not on the fixation of the destination of belief but in the journey of understanding it. It is remarkable that humans express both thought and emotion through art, reflected in the imageries we encounter today. Whether in sacred spaces or contemporary media, these visuals invite us to discern, think critically, and consider the intention behind their creation, and the purpose of them being shown to us.

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Bathrooms, Cockroaches and Fear

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I stood by the door of my hall bathroom at two in the morning, shower caddy in hand, sweaty and tired from facing the day. Before I turned the handle, I took a deep breath, trying to gain composure. Anyone who lived on my floor knew that entering the bathroom after-hours is never recommended, but I had to take the gambit to brush my teeth, at the very least.

The moment I cracked the door open, the combined odour of the air freshener and drain smell hit my lungs instantly, making me gag. But it did not faze me. What I was terrified of the most was the darkness. I knew instantly that I was in enemy territory. I waved my hands to turn on the lights through the motion sensor, praying for the lights to come back. And then, I saw *it*.

Not a scary clown, but a big, winged cockroach in the middle of the bathroom. *Papa Roach.*

I stared at Papa Roach (my nickname for the largest out of the cockroaches I often encountered), hoping that it would leave. Standing my ground, I spoke to it. "Please, I just want to take a shower." But instead, it inched towards me. I got the message and immediately left. I did not shower that night, nor did I shower after midnight for the following weeks, evading a re-encounter.

Unfortunately, I made the mistake of drinking too much one night, and I had two choices: face it, or wait until someone else faces it first. In the end, I knew the encounter was inevitable, and waiting would not make a difference. And so, I tried convincing myself that it was worth it to face the roach. I pushed the door open with courage. The lights flickered on. To my surprise, Papa Roach was not there.

I inched inside, slowly peeking over every nook and cranny, searching for signs of life. But even as I hurriedly finished my business, there was nothing. I exited the stall, then washed my hands while I erratically pressed on the sink that would not flow continuously, eyes darting across the floor, staying alert just in case any movement happened. None did

For the following days I had a busy week and would come back late, and I would always be wary of my surroundings. So did every other resident. One night, I saw two girls waiting in front of the dark bathroom, unsure whether entering was wise. But afraid as we were, we had no choice, and so, we pushed the door. Again, they were not there, and the next day, too, lacked the presence of roaches. Soon, the absence was routine. However, each time I turned the doorknob, I still quietly braced myself for contact. I then wondered: what is the reason that humans fear something based on previous encounters, even though it may not be the case anymore? And if so, in other aspects of life, does fear hold the same magnitude of power?

While I was searching for answers, something caught my eye in a book chapter written by Haselton & Galperin (2013). They elaborate on error management theory, exemplifying it using the instance of a man

who was told that his chances are "one in a million". He remained optimistic, even when faced with the abysmal chances. In this case, believing that success was possible (when, really, it was unlikely) carried less "cost" in his mind. The same theory can also be applied in a different and arguably a more extreme case, when humans are told to judge whether an item is a stick or a snake; humans tend to assume the worst, because the costs of errors are asymmetrical. The false positive of assuming that it is a venomous snake would not hurt you, but a false negative might land you a fatal bite.

With this theory in mind, my behaviour made some sense. The cockroach may not be there, but assuming that it is will save you from having it fly in your face, which is a likely phenomenon no matter what the odds are. We assume the cockroach is there because we are still not sure about its whereabouts, and for us, the cost is "asymmetrical" (Haselton & Galperin, 2013). However, I didn't find myself always performing the rational analysis as suggested in this theory. True, in some cases, such as in the night I drank too much water, I thought and mulled over the risks and benefits. But when I was sleepy and running on autopilot, my brain evaded the dark bathroom just the same.

I dug deeper and encountered another theory proposed by Cisler & Koster (2010), which is the attentional bias theory. Rather than conscious analysis, as suggested in the error management theory, there may be a specific thing that causes a "differential attentional allocation towards threatening stimuli relative to neutral stimuli" (Cisler and Koster, 2010, p. 1). This theory suggests that humans respond to negative cues and tend to focus on them more, ignoring other neutral or even positive cues. This bias is not random. By being able to identify negative cues faster, we can avoid potential threats faster, and it increases our chances of survival.

In this case, the negative cues are the signs that a cockroach might be there. Similar to a "trigger" in cases of anxiety, post-traumatic stress disorder, and other disorders, our brains associate the absence of light with the presence of cockroaches, and this activates a siren in our brains. Our subconscious mind, in turn, reflexively takes action to avoid discomfort. It is important to note that trauma is not necessary for these attentional biases to occur; fear in itself is more than sufficient.

While both theories attempt to explain the fear as a protective measure, when put together, they do not blend as nicely as expected. But they do not stand in opposition. If fear is a cost-benefit analysis for survival (Haselton and Galperin, 2013), then it should be predictable and calculated. And yet, as the attentional bias theory reveals, fear is irrational and reflexive (Cisler and Koster, 2010), causing us to act in autopilot. But as humans, we do not feel that fear is only either one of these things. Fear can be calculated and strategic in origin, but also spontaneous and carried out automatically, working on different levels of our minds.

This same instinct that stopped me in front of the bathroom door was also one that enables us to **escape** from predators. It is the same reflex that helped humans survive even the harshest droughts and the coldest winters; the same vigilance that keeps us alert around dangerous uncertainty. It is undeniable that fear is important to survival, and even if my fear of cockroaches seemed puny when compared to fleeing a wild tiger, it was nonetheless crucial. In today's world, you can find fear anywhere, but it rarely takes the form of claws and teeth: it appears in peer pressure, seniority, even in the subtle tight smiles given to your relatives during the holiday season, avoiding uncomfortable questions. Although these things would never have mattered hundreds of years ago, human knowledge and culture have

evolved to the stage we are at now, and as time passes by, there will only be more reasons to fear things, and it is only good to understand why fear is the way it is.

In the end, I did shower after midnight again. Even when the lights are off, I enter bravely, as my brain has already rewired itself to the new situation of the roach-free bathroom. Papa Roach was no longer waiting for me, and for a second, I thought to myself: maybe Papa Roach and his family were never my enemies, it was just my mind's refusal to forgive and forget what once happened. Thinking about the encounters made me almost nostalgic sometimes. But as much as I miss the unsettling presence of Papa Roach, I am glad I will never have to see him or any members of his family ever again.

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Gatekeeping: Understanding the Wardens that Surround Us

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Specialty stores are a rarity in Singapore. Though they hold such importance to the cultures and communities they represent, their specificity confines them to the fringes of streets and buildings — places not stumbled upon but actively sought out. H Records isn't much different. Flanked by family eateries, H Records is situated on the first floor of a commercial-residential hybrid building on the outskirts of Bugis. It is a small store barely able to fit 10 customers, though you would be hard-pressed to find more than 6 at any given moment. An unmistakable, almost soothing scent lingers in the air, born of the decades-old cardboard album jackets that fill the 'used' section. The store is run by J. A man in his middle age, he is often dressed in a shirt showcasing his knowledge of niche and bygone acts, a Suede graphic tee his particular favourite. A beat-up Audio Technica turntable sits beside the front counter, its age and wear a proud testament to its needle's mileage, spinning faithfully like the store's heartbeat whenever the lights are on.

Like moths to a flame, unique places like these tend to attract unique individuals. In H Records' case, two distinct types can be observed. First, there are the enthusiasts. Often working adults, these people chat for hours about their favourite bands and proud collections of original pressings, standing around and having conversations with J about everything music-related: from the newest Deftones album to the upcoming Franz Ferdinand concert. The second group of people comprises youth often dressed in the hipster fashion of the nearby Haji Lane. In baggy clothes and silver studs, they are not the biggest fans of vinyl, with music knowledge like that of the layman. Despite this, they are a common sight. Born after the advent of the digital medium, vinyl is a stylish novelty for them. Like in a museum, they gawk and gape, posing with vinyl of their favourite radio artists for Instagram pictures. Though occupying the same space, there is a palpable divide between both groups. While the enthusiasts form their circles, the youth dart around the background, whispering in the periphery of the enthusiasts' hearty discussions. As if acknowledging their intrusion, they keep to themselves, take their pictures, and with barely a word and rarely with merchandise in hand, they leave. Though not explicitly ostracised by these purists, their occasional scornful glances paint an unwelcoming picture. There is an unspoken air of cynicism, as if saying 'Our community is not your spectacle'. While it may be needlessly harsh, for those truly passionate about music, the energy and money spent on the hobby bring a sense of pride. To hijack that without passion for the optics of social media can appear disrespectful. However, that may not be entirely true. At the end of the day, these are youth piqued by the hobby's charm. Imitation is the greatest form of flattery after all, so

what is the harm? Does such gatekeeping truly protect the integrity of fan communities?

Edlom & Karlsson (2021) explore a possible hypothesis behind the inexplicable drive to gatekeep in the context of fans of electropop musician Robyn. Through analysing Facebook interactions between her fans, they establish levels of fandom, tiered from ambient fans to executive fans to super fans. Through their monetary and emotional investment in a fanbase, fans accumulate "fan capital", able to rise through the ranks. They show that fans of a higher tier gain prestige over those of a lower tier, able to dictate conversations and consensus in the community as they build up "fan capital". As Edlom & Karlsson (2021) point out, "[t]he experts — those who have accumulated the most knowledge — gain prestige within the group and act as opinion leaders. These senior or expert fans within the group thus acquire a kind of discursive power" (p. 124). They further highlight the importance of maintaining this power gradient, mentioning how higher tier fans facilitate movement within a fanbase, giving direction to the lower tier masses: "The superfans and executive fans are the drivers and catalysts within the fan community, facilitating fan-to-fan interactions, relations, and engagement" (Edlom & Karlsson, 2021).

I believe, however, that despite these positive effects, whenever power is involved, greed is never far behind. It is the selfish thirst for capital and the power it entails that incentivises established fans of higher tiers to kick down the ladder from underneath them. This prevents newer fans from climbing up and disrupting their place in the hierarchy, thus establishing a strong motive behind gatekeeping. This would suggest that gatekeeping is rooted in selfishness, coming from a place of self-interest rather than out of any concern for the preservation of a community's integrity.

Adding on to this, Lin (2022) emphasises the importance of a bonded fanbase, showing what gatekeepers could be depriving their communities of. She explains the impact a larger, more supportive fanbase has on an industry, demonstrating how its effects extend beyond the immediate parties involved. In her study, she surveyed fans of a Japanese baseball franchise, concluding that clubs with stronger, more meaningful fan-to-fan interactions tend to foster more social capital amongst fans. These happier fans are more likely to return and support the team, boosting industry investment: "...social capital can be developed by attending or participating in sports events through social interactions... which generate a greater level of prosocial behaviour, subjective well-being, and intention to return" (Lin, 2022, p. 270).

Extrapolating from this, a link emerges between gatekeeping and industry health. If strong fan interactions build a fanbase, the inverse is likely true as well. In a fanbase of heavy gatekeeping, it is safe to say that such a culture would not be very welcoming. Social capital amongst fans would then naturally decrease. Newer fans put off by the hostility, would eventually invest less time and resources into the industry—this loss of engagement undermining the trust and cohesion that form the bedrock of communities, in turn weakening group integrity.

While Edlom & Karlsson (2021) show the presence of a power gradient within fandoms, Lin (2022) builds upon this by emphasising the importance of a united fanbase, something gatekeeping inherently compromises. Were this power gradient to give rise to gatekeeping and cause the speculated loss in social capital, a foreboding picture is painted. Like Akutagawa's Spider's Thread, fans of higher standing in a desperate struggle to remain on top start to gatekeep by shooing newer fans off the fanbase. This selfishness then dooms the entire industry as it crumbles from lack of new support. Fans turn their

heads, fed up with the disproportionate amount of social capital rewarded for their time and energy. One by one they leave, these gatekeepers left guarding an empty kingdom. This is especially precarious in industries as fragile as vinyl—industries plagued by thin profit margins and high production costs desperate for more monetary support. It illustrates the self-destructive nature of gatekeeping, something that any healthy fanbase should strive to avoid.

While I do not deny the possibility, even inevitability of these implications, is gatekeeping as detrimental as these ideas suggest? Because despite its negatives, it would be remiss to ignore the potential benefits of gatekeeping, benefits that might even outweigh these concerns. Sometimes, positive externality can be derived from negative intentions. While the driver behind gatekeeping may be nothing more than a desire for power, I would argue that it does an excellent job filtering out the unworthy. These imposed hurdles enforce a high standard amongst high-tier fans, ensuring the power brandished in upper tiers are reserved for only the most committed and knowledgeable. In a sense, it perpetuates a democratic meritocracy where popular opinion elects the worthy. It is this resistance that provides the separation between fandom tiers that Edlom & Karlsson (2021) posit, only allowing those truly integrous to move up a rung. In a similar vein, it is the very same power older fans are drunk on that fledgling fans crave. While it pushes fair-weather fans away, it also motivates committed ones to grit their teeth and push through the negativity, rightfully earning their place in the hierarchy. While it may be unhealthy pitting fans against each other in "king of the hill" fashion, the protection it provides to a fanbase's integrity due to the high bar it sets is undeniable, safeguarding the purity of its core principles from the dilution of the half-hearted.

As we circle the pros and cons of gatekeeping, the nefarious lust for power that fuels it and the friction that results, one question remains. Why does this power matter to gatekeepers? Power over a few Warhammer nerds would mean nothing to ninety-nine percent of the population. But to that one percent, it is power worth fighting for; power worth gatekeeping. Because at the deepest level, people gatekeep out of love for their fandom — love so strong they crave power within it. As with love, sometimes you can hold too tight. These wardens through gatekeeping could rot a fandom from within. Alternatively, they could foster a tight-knit community of superfans hoisting the fandom to greater heights. Both are equally possible. After all, gatekeeping is just a tool. And like any good tool, it comes down to the hand that wields it, regardless of where it manifests. As the Rolling Stones so aptly put it, "It's the singer, not the song."

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The Spirit and the Letter: Why We Bend the Rules

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Nanyang Technological University (NTU) is a top university in one of the safest cities worldwide, yet, a crime happens here every minute. It is nothing dramatic, nothing that will be splashed across headlines in bold capitals, but a subtle, more normalised kind of violation. At the roundabout between North Spine and the School of Art, Design and Media, students cross the road willy-nilly, ignoring both the multiple blind spots and eight possible directions that cars could come from. They breeze past the screaming red banners yelling "NO JAYWALKING" and the signs calmly pleading, "Please use the zebra crossing", but regardless, none of it makes a difference. The evidence of this crime is etched into the landscape itself: a brownish-dented patch of grass at the side of the road – a "desire path" worn by trampling feet. The construction works for the new MRT line have added the inconvenience of forcing people to spend an extra two minutes to detour to the zebra crossing. Yet, it is not just students who commit these offences. Professors, office staff, and even construction workers — the very people who set up the barriers and detours — all cross the road this way; that is, illegally.

Cars approach the roundabout, eerily quiet and slow, as though they can see the jaywalkers through the opaque barriers, as though they share a silent agreement to be accomplices in the same crime. Perhaps it is because the drivers were accustomed to this patch of road, or perhaps out of a deeper empathy born from having jaywalked across it themselves. Observe long enough and a pattern starts to emerge: one person steps off the kerb, and others follow in a stream. Yet, let no one make the first move and everyone takes the long detour. The unofficial crossings are passed down — seniors to juniors, friend to friend — becoming more than just convenience, almost a tradition. And truthfully, it was the fastest way to get to class. The smaller crossings before the roundabout bore the same quiet offences by those who resisted temptation at the roundabout itself, perhaps deeming it a safer, subtler place where the rules could be bent without appearing broken.

In Singapore, crossing within 50 metres of a designated crossing is considered jaywalking. The letter of the law is clear and precise, yet often broken and routinely ignored. Its objective —to keep drivers and pedestrians safe— is well understood, yet that very purpose is ironically the reason people use to justify jaywalking. In spirit, each time we exercise our own judgement and choose to jaywalk, we quietly decide for ourselves when the law applies, even if that shift is unconscious. If no harm occurs, surely it is reasonable? But when is following the spirit of the law enough — and when does the letter still have to hold?

Matthew Gordon (2011) in "The Letter Versus the Spirit of the Law" proposes and empirically tests a model distinguishing the "letter" from the "spirit" of the law, arguing that the violations of the spirit – rooted in social norms and fairness – are often perceived as more unjust than breaches of the law's literal phrasing. The letter of the law, defined to be "the law

as it is written", and the spirit of the law, the "social and moral consensus of the interpretation of the letter of the law" (Gordon, 2011, p. 4). As people judge according to these expectations, the spirit of the law eventually becomes the standard, where violating it should still be met with punishment. Gordon also claims that fairness is judged based on the existing societal and enforcement norms. This is showcased through a buffer zone, which is the gap between the law and what society typically expects to be enforced. The larger the buffer zone, the more likely one will break the rules. Even if laws are enforced, society might deem it unfair and would not immediately obey or change their behaviour in response to it. Ultimately, context plays a crucial role in determining whether it is sufficient to follow the spirit or obey the letter of the law.

Gordon (2011) feels that it is wrong to exploit loopholes that ultimately destroy the intention of the law, despite technically still following it. The law serves a purpose, and destroying its intention is equivalent to nullifying it. It is supposed to guide society, not be twisted for personal gain. But the bigger the buffer zone, the more we contextualise and rationalise our decisions. Coupled with loose enforcement and social normalisation, we are more likely to break the law. In doing so, we set ourselves above the rule, becoming judge, jury, and executioner over laws we did not write. Yet, this presumes something Gordon (2011) leaves unexamined: that the citizen actually grasps the law's purpose to begin with. If honouring the spirit means understanding it, then we are asking them to read the mind of the law. In the case of jaywalking, where cameras or police are not heavily implemented, and where it is a norm to cross when there are no cars, it can be seen how the context heavily supports the decision to jaywalk. The contrast becomes sharper in societies where this buffer zone is narrow. In Japan, pedestrians commonly wait for the signal to change even on empty streets with no traffic, reflecting a social norm strong enough that the gap between the law and its expected enforcement nearly disappears.

Where Gordon (2011) works from hypothetical judgements, a more recent study grounds the same tension in real events. Jed Meers, Simon Halliday, and Joe Tomlinson (2023), in the article "'Creative Non-Compliance': Complying with the 'spirit of the law' not the 'letter of the law' under the Covid-19 lockdown restrictions", argue that individuals perceived rules by their intent rather than their purpose. This reflects the idea of "creative non-compliance", which Meers et al. (2023) define as rule-breakers justifying their non-compliance with what they believed the rules were meant to achieve. Many individuals rationalised their actions as obeying the spirit rather than the letter. Yet, while not obeying the letter of the law, non-compliance can still be normatively consistent when it aligns with the intention of the law, making it justifiable. Government messaging labelled as "common sense" and emphasising personal judgment further backed up their actions as well. The COVID-19 lockdown resulted in restrictions that created numerous grey areas, leaving room for individual interpretation. For instance, one interviewee justified rule-bending by likening it to driving quickly down an empty motorway rather than a congested one. If they judged an act to be safe and harmful to no one, it felt acceptable even when it breaks the law (Meers et al., 2023, p. 104). The result of "creative non-compliance" is a paradoxical society that upholds its rules in principle yet breaks them in practice.

The concept of "creative non-compliance" shows how individuals prioritise the spirit over the letter of the law. Under vague, ambiguous rules, individuals interpret rules as they please so long as they can rationalise that they are still following the spirit of the

law. This leads to a paradox: lawmakers implement laws for society to follow, but society takes and bends them to its own benefit. Yet, it does not matter as individuals are more concerned with understanding the spirit of the law than the law itself. In the case of jaywalking, as long as pedestrians and drivers are safe and there is minimal traffic, both the spirit of the law and its intent are met.

Both Gordon (2011) and Meers et al. (2023) argue that following the spirit is more important than the letter. Fairness, social norms, and the law's intent matter more than just following the rules. However, they view it from different angles. Gordon (2011) argues that despite the clear written lines of the law, it was more acceptable for rules to be bent when met with favourable contexts and enforcement. By contrast, Meers et al. (2023) state that individuals interpreted rules flexibly when vague or ambiguous rules were applied, rationalising that they were still following the law's intent. Together, they show that people do not abandon the law, but only bend or break it when it is socially acceptable or interpreted as correct.

Against this held interpretation however, is its unspoken foundation that flexibility is only possible due to the stability of a clear legal structure underneath it. Furthermore, there is a danger in treating the spirit as sufficient, as norms shift with the very behaviour they permit. Gordon's (2011) buffer zone widens each time non-compliance is tolerated, so what begins as an exception slowly hardens into the default, and the "spirit" itself drifts toward whatever people already do. The ethics of one person jaywalking on an empty road are thus not the ethics of a society that has normalised it, since the latter dissolves the very baseline against which "safe" was judged. As such, it is not enough to follow the spirit of the law, as we must also obey its letter. The spirit of the law and context of a situation can be subjective from individual to individual, where one person's 'safe' might be another person's recklessness. The letter exists to make this clear and precise. However, this does not mean that the law must be followed blindly. In cases of unjust or unethical laws, our own moral conscience may rightly override the law altogether, both its letter and its spirit. But in the context of ordinary civic life, the letter of the law remains the clearest shared reference point, guiding and functioning as a building block of our society. They form an important safety net, where one can only bend the surface layer of a law because there are laws built on laws. Beneath it lie deeper legal layers that carry heavier consequences, ensuring safety and accountability. In the instance of jaywalking, it is only safe to do so because cars are required to slow down. If a driver hits a pedestrian, it can result in criminal charges or more severe penalties. In other words, the burden is being passed down to hold someone else accountable. Rule-breaking seems safe only because the responsibility is redistributed. If society were to no longer follow the letter —the rules that provide a common standard – chaos would erupt, and society would cease to function. At NTU's roundabout, the worn-out grass serves as a constant reminder: proof that we follow the law, but only on our own terms. The shortcut exists not because the law is unknown, but because context is allowed to overrule it.

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Papers, Ink and Stillness

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I stood still as the escalator guided me upwards. Two words slowly came into view: "Books Kinokuniya." Stepping forward, I entered a small sanctuary, away from the bustling streets and frantic footsteps of Orchard Road. The entrance features a section dedicated to 'Hoyoverse,' stacked with standees and keychains. I briefly browsed the artworks and merchandise, before going deeper into the store, where cool air and warm lighting created a sense of enclosure that felt worlds away from the city outside.

Looking around, I tried to spot aisles that were of my interest while weaving between pockets of people. I took in the diversity around me, from readers to the books themselves. From the corner of my eye, I caught a shelf full of video game guides and drifted towards it with renewed purpose. Only then did I realise I was not alone in my search; the aisle was already packed with like-minded collectors. This realization made me more acutely aware of my surroundings. I could hear the soft rustling of pages turning as people stood motionless —lost in a space where time seemed to have no meaning. Snapping back to the present, I finally reached my target. I began flipping through a guide, the neatly arranged shelves standing tall around me as if creating a private sanctuary of my own. I picked up a book, returned it, walked right, picked another, checked my phone—twenty minutes had passed.

Without realising it, I had spent twenty minutes drifting between shelves, something that I rarely, if ever, get to do nowadays as a busy university student. No rush nor guilt; I just wandered aimlessly, an action that seemed to be echoed in the unhurried movements of people around me as well. My usual instinct to clear my tasks and plan my week fell silent against the backdrop of shelves almost as if the word 'productivity' held no meaning here.

This sudden loss of time was not a lapse in discipline, but a subtle resistance against the world waiting outside. When I step back onto Orchard Road, the contrast is startling: in Singapore, time is seen as a high value currency that we should never misuse. We rush for trains before the door closes, multitask between breaks, and joke about not being able to "waste time" on pointless activities. Yet inside the borders of this bookstore, the same people sprinting for closing train doors allow time to slip through their fingers and onto the shelves of paper and ink. This tension between how we talk about time and productivity, and the way we spend it in spaces like this raises a larger question: why do we slow down for seemingly 'unproductive' activities in a society that obsesses over speed and efficiency?

An opinion piece written by long time urbanist Anupam Yog (2026) explores the tension between a "doing-oriented" life and the need for spaces that allow for "being" (stillness and rest). A "doing-oriented" life is the need to strive, a goal-oriented focus where it feels like a perpetual cycle of productivity that eventually leads to the depletion of oneself and living life on autopilot. In contrast, a "being-oriented" life is when you engage with life,

experiencing and appreciating the present moment. Yog (2026) argues that cities like Singapore force us into a "doing-oriented" autopilot mode that defines achievement as the sole metric for success. He believes that we desperately need "third spaces" - areas that act as physical sanctuaries, a release valve for our mental depletion.

Yog (2026) provided a compelling argument for my observation by discussing the "doing-oriented" society against the necessity of "being." This directly addresses my research question: We slow down because Singapore's obsession with efficiency, the "doing," causes chronic tension that requires alleviation. The idea of a third space mirrors my perception of the bookstore as an enclosed sanctuary - an environment that allows a mental reset. My aimless wandering which resulted in a loss of twenty minutes would not be "unproductivity," but what Yog (2026) characterizes as a necessary recharge of oneself. Although the argument is convincing, I realised that perhaps the existence of third space might be on a declining trend. Taking Kinokuniya as an example, the flagship bookstore has recently undergone changes where its floor space was downsized in favor of a cafe. If such third spaces are on a downward trend, then the act of "being" may become less accessible, or even worse, tied to monetary value.

However, the blame is not just in the environment alone, it is also in our minds. In an article by writer and philosopher Susanna Newsonen (2026), she describes a phenomenon known as the "achievement treadmill" and explores it further. In it, she elaborates how people find themselves trapped on it, particularly those in high-pressure environments. Self-worth becomes tied exclusively to output and productivity, creating a state where any time not spent on meaningful tasks is perceived as a waste. We treat rest as something to be earned, but at the same time, a social sin. Newsonen (2026) further explains that the efficiency-driven mindset leads to burnout and loss of creativity because the brain is never allowed to rest. This compulsive reliance on achievement to self-validate makes taking the first step off the treadmill feel very difficult and oppressive. In order to address this, Newsonen (2026) suggests that we should intentionally reframe "unproductive" activities as crucial needs rather than guilty pleasures.

Newsonen's (2026) concept of the "achievement treadmill" provides a distinct psychological reason to why my aimless wandering in the bookstore felt like guilty pleasure. My usual instinct as a university student is to constantly create and clear tasks, a symptom that ties my worth to my output. This suggests that we allow ourselves to slow down because chasing success is unsustainable for us. I find Newsonen's (2026) argument about the "threat" of doing nothing intriguing because it explains why outside of sanctuaries like bookstores, wasting time is a social sin. In a city as relentless as Singapore, a shift in the mindset is easier said than done. The mind simply cannot 'reframe' itself in a vacuum. When everything around you constantly moves without waiting for you, telling your brain to stop is near-impossible while the environment is constantly telling it to run. In hindsight, perhaps my browsing of video game guides is also ironic. Even within this supposed sanctuary, my mind was still calculating and optimizing my next digital conquest. Are we so tethered to the 'doing' mentality that we do not have the ability to disengage from it? Perhaps the uncomfortable and unexpected question is whether the "achievement treadmill" is something we can get off anytime, or it is something we carry with us everywhere?

Synthesising these perspectives, we can see that the tension between "doing" and "being" is a two-fold problem: environmental demands for speed and

psychological compulsions for worth via output. Yog (2026) provides the "why" of our depletion, while Newsonen (2026) explains the "how" of our psychological struggles. In fact, these two ideas are effectively two sides of the same coin: one provides the hardware (space) and the other the software (mindset). The hardware cannot function without the proper software, and the software cannot be fully utilized without the correct hardware. Yet, looking closer reveals a "glitch" in the system. In modern hyper-efficient society, our mindsets are so ingrained into us that it significantly alters how we interact with third spaces. Instead of using these spaces as intended, our hyper-productive mindset ends up colonising it, transforming it into a slower and more aesthetic space for "doing".

Ultimately, modern society is so fixated on productivity that unproductive time is highly contested rather than being a luxury or moral failure. I believe that spaces like Kinokuniya are not just commercial spaces; they are essential social infrastructure. They act as physical boundaries so that we do not run ourselves into the ground while obsessing over our individual throughput. Despite that, we are still unable to enter such sanctuaries without dragging our psychological treadmills with us. If such spaces continue on a downward trend of downsizing and being monetized, the extent of which we can truly achieve "being" becomes at risk. The ultimate danger is thus not merely the burnout, but the quiet loss of these spaces, and the ability to rest itself. In a city so obsessed with speed and efficiency, the most radical thing we can do is to simply stop and stand still—because sometimes, the 20 minutes you think you are losing, could be the 20 minutes you need to keep yourself going just a bit longer.

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Capital to Anchor: Why Choosing to Stay Inside Bubbles

By Rui Yifan

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Exiting the Holland Village MRT station, bars, bistros and fine-dining cafes caught my eyes immediately. As the evening sun silently crawled upon the roofs, a unique vibe started to pervade from the glittering glass jars, freshly polished, resting behind bar counters by the street. Whiskeys shone like silky caramel; beers began to bubble up, leaving large chunks of foam on top; television displayed the latest match of Arsenal and Internazionale Milano: just like any other bar you find from Bristol to Berlin.

I paced deeper into the village, noticing that Oriental cuisines began to fill the street. The newly opened Chinese food restaurant is crowded with customers. On the other side of the street, a food court sat itself in the middle of the district, buzzing lively. Fish soup, curry and chicken rice, surrounded by souvenir retailers commonly found in southern east Asia, made the place quite like a normal market.

Despite the sharing of space, each type of business serves its own unique set of customers. Take bar "the Pit" as an example, nearly 90% of its customers are Caucasian. Their laughter and small talk form a territory that claims the area as exclusively theirs. On the other hand, most people enjoying the food court are locals or Indians. As for the oriental food restaurant, I heard people in queue chatting with authentic Beijing accent. It seems that behind the prosperity and harmony, cultural clustering still holds a micro display. People are clustering in their "comfort zone", and somehow showcasing a tacit rejection to others. Why? Is it simply a matter of comfort, or is it something deeper?

It is indeed fascinating to see somewhere hosting such a mixed blend of eastern and western culture, modern vigor and vintage flavor. However, we perceive that people from different races want to stay different to some extent. They gravitate towards each other in a specific place or space, no matter if it's a pub, a store or a food court. What's truly intriguing is it ultimately urges us to think: Why do people appear to create their own bubbles, remaining within familiar ethnic or cultural enclaves even when surrounded by diversity? The village offers no obvious answers, only the evening stars glimmer hesitantly in the lavender sky, with faint echoes of artists singing in the plaza.

In "The Forms of Capital", Bourdieu (1986) elaborated that capital exists not only in economic forms, but also in the forms of cultural capital and social capital, which can be converted into each other under specific conditions.

Cultural capital exists in the embodied form: the deeply rooted and enduring temperament in people. In fact, as Bourdieu (1986, p.18) wrote, "This embodied capital, external wealth converted into an integral part of the person, into a habitus, cannot be transmitted instantaneously by gift or bequest, purchase or exchange"; it is once lost never found. Such symbolic capital reveals that cultural capital is personal yet socially recognised. It can be transformed into: economic income, trust strengthening internal bonds, as well as respect from outsiders earned by proudly

claiming “who we are, what we have”. Furthermore, the transmission of cultural capital toward social capital relies on homogeneity among members. This explains that clustering aims to protect the embodied cultural capital from being "devalued" or "contaminated" by external influences.

Bourdieu suggests that ethnic culture is a form of capital accumulated through long-term integration, providing not only a sense of belonging but also "exchange value" in certain social circumstances. Extending from this, in places like Holland Village, various cultures gather and share the space. Customers choosing the most familiar ethnic space is not only a favor of origin but also a sign of steadily choosing an identity that comes with numerous benefits economically and socially. Besides, surrounded by diversity, the risk of potentially being “overtaken” or merged may also alarm individuals to keep the capital to themselves and strengthen in-group solidarity.

Therefore, 'staying inside the ethnic bubble' is not stubbornness, but a rational strategy to preserve this intangible asset: the lifestyle. This particular perspective is insightful, but perhaps rings a bit too much of Economism.

This urged me to seek new insights in “Liquid modernity” by Bauman (2000) where he used “liquidity” to describe a social condition where traditional structures—like stable jobs, long-term relationships, and fixed cultural norms—melt away quickly, leaving individuals with constant choice but little lasting security. He suggested that the “community” that could provide lifelong security and certainty while simultaneously limiting personal freedom no longer exists in such context. The natural bonds disappear, so does the stability of existence, and people experience a sense of drift, anxiety, and rootlessness. Pointing to an unfulfilled need, Bauman argues that when faced with the emptiness brought by liquid modernity, people’s desire for the old community grows especially strong. Yet this desire, he contends, only gives rise to short-lived, fragile “cloakroom communities,” often constructed through exclusion and the demonization of “others.” It seems that only by rejecting outsiders can we tie ourselves with an illusory group and find some safeness in the overly fluid world.

While Bourdieu focused on the strategic accumulation and protection of cultural resources, Bauman emphasised the psychological anxiety of rootlessness. The former explains the practical payoff of clustering; the latter explains the emotional urge toward doing so. Yet neither of them fully addressed the question.

As we have observed, the “bubbles” people remained in are micro ethnic spaces in the diversified, multicultural Holland Village. Bauman desperately claims that such community is nothing but a better-than-worst methodology that does not free people from the loneliness and anxiety. “The choice is not between different referents of belonging, but between belonging and rootlessness, home and homelessness, being and nothingness” says Bauman (2000, p.173). This is exactly the dilemma people face today, especially when diversity offers so many options that only intensifies the liquidity.

However, I am not as pessimistic. The ethnic culture we initially acquire provides us with the fundamental framework for understanding the world which is a natural background that we rely on for survival. Exclusion may be a side-effect of staying in bubbles, but neither a purpose nor a methodology to create common grounds. Not fully opening up to diversity is a self-saving strategy meant to serve as an anchor to keep one stable in waves of liquidity, not as a fence to reject, and definitely not as a trench spreading hate and tension.

Moreover, within the enclaves, identity is real, naturally recognised, and does not require constant explanation, defense, or conversion. As modernity brings uncertainty and existential anxiety, maintaining the uniqueness of one's own culture is also to safeguard the spiritual origin that makes us feel safe and well at home: the enclaves offer just an easy way.

Finally, by overlaying the two lenses, a more well-rounded picture emerges: the clustering in the Holland village is not only due to the natural attraction of symbolic capital in Bourdieu's sense, but also the psychological response of liquid modernity in Bauman's sense. People seek homogeneity in diversity, stability in mobility, and certainty in uncertainty. This behavior may seem like a rejection of the "other", but only in truth, it is a retention of the "self". The "anchor", functions not just defensively, but also as a cognitive and emotional baseline. Without such baseline, engaging with genuine diversity becomes overwhelming rather than enriching. In this sense, staying inside one's bubble is not the opposite of openness; it may even be a precondition for it—because only when one feels steady can one step out momentarily without losing one's bearings. It is not about saying no to diversity, but about preserving a corner for oneself.

The significance of this insight goes beyond the village. In today's world where globalization and multiculturalism have become a universal reality, how to deal with the challenge of "coexisting with differences" has become an issue that every society must solve. It is revealed that perhaps true integration may not come at the expense of sacrificing individual cultural security. A sustainable and diverse society should not only protect the openness and communication of public spaces, but also respect cultural belonging in the private sphere. Instead of asking "how to get people out of bubbles", think about "how to create more breathable windows between bubbles".

The last drip of sunlight faded away in the western sky; the stars of Holland Village still twinkle, and perhaps ethnic groups will return to their own enclave. But when we understand the underlying logic, we may be able to view these "bubbles" more tolerantly: they are not exclusive fences, but the final anchor that people cast for themselves in this overly fluid world.

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Invisible Visible Carparks as Communal Centers

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Figure 1. Block 541A Jelapang Ring Road

Block 541A Bukit Panjang Ring Road (Fig. 1), is just another multi-storey carpark in Singapore. Or so I thought.

Entering the otherwise cooling carpark, I smelled the sharp and familiar petrol immediately. Oil-stained concrete glimmered whilst somewhere above, an engine growls to life. Below, near the gantries, a rattan broom scrapes rhythmically against the floor. The swoosh echoing through the empty levels, save the rows upon rows of cars.

Deeper in, a middle-aged man hunches over his motorbike at the washing bay, scrubbing away against the frame as "Send Me an Angel" by Scorpions blasts away. He works methodically, washing away grime unhurriedly. Nearby, the Town Council workers, slumped in their chairs in their break room, ramble on and on as the day drifts by. Their potted plants, standing tall and firm, sway calmly in the breeze, alive after escaping being sent to the dumpster.

At the far end, a family emerges from the lift, their faces filled with smiles. The young boy skips ahead past a community cat lazing atop a car whilst his parents trail behind, seemingly discussing their plans for the day. The cat pays no heed to them or for that matter, anything. Perhaps they are going for lunch or

even a family outing?

Further ahead, my neighbour rolls into the parking lot with his Aerox Scooter. We exchange pleasantries and a bit of our day before continuing in opposite directions.

Slowly, the patterns reveal themselves. Most cars cluster around the middle floors, closer to the lifts and linkbridges. The upper decks sit sparse with their distant parking lots especially barren. Amidst the empty lots at Deck 4B sits a Porsche Cayman, far away from the everyday sedans and family vehicles. A car of status and pride, with an orange trim that catches glances, relegated to the margins of the carpark.

I've traversed here a million times, either as a shortcut between home and the nearby train station or to, well, drive my own car of course. Yet, I'd never ever paused to ever consider what happens here beyond simply parking. The carpark operates as more than a utilitarian space, rather it pulses with small breaths of life. The man at the washing bay transforms everyday maintenance into a weekend ritual. The Town Council workers find respite here after their long shifts. Strangers and neighbours transform the bare walls into a social space. The cat lays claim to its territory. Families extend their homes beyond their walls.

These moments are both private and public, functional and social. The carpark's cooling shade offers refuge from Singapore's heat. The middle levels draw crowds not just for convenience, but perhaps for proximity to others. A subtle gravitation towards an invisible communal center.

Most interestingly though is that all these are simply ordinary encounters, born not out of planning but simply emerging organically in a functional space designed ironically for vehicles. Yet, here people were, building moments of connection and leisure within the bare concrete walls of the carpark.

Therefore, could utilitarian spaces like carparks contribute more to community experience than we usually notice? Carparks are everywhere in Singapore and perhaps the most overlooked infrastructures. They are in-between spaces we pass through without ever properly giving them any thought despite them harbouring unexpected possibilities for social interactions.

To understand why the unremarkable carpark functions as more than just, well, a carpark, requires us to examine what urban sociologist Ray Oldenburg (1989) calls the "third place". In his book *The Great Good Place*, Oldenburg argues that communities thrive on informal gathering spaces, distinct from home and workplaces. These third places serve as invisible social infrastructures where social bonds form spontaneously through unplanned interactions. Oldenburg observes that "Places such as these, which serve virtually everybody, soon create an environment in which everybody knows just about everybody" (p. 17). What makes third places work according to him is their neutrality, accessibility and regularity. The carpark has no assigned social purpose. No one questions your presence and no one is bothered by your presence. It is this absence of expectations that lowers the threshold for the emergence of spontaneous social interactions. Sure, these spaces are not designed for socialising but yet, socialising is what emerges.

The carpark at Block 541A nails this definition. It is a neutral ground where residents converge. The man washing his motorbike, the Town Council workers rambling on, the family heading out, my neighbour on his scooter, the lazing cat and me, of course, all occupy the same concrete space regularly and through repeated encounters, grow with familiarity amongst each other. The carpark's primary function

remains, yet socially, it has developed organically because it was never meant to be social.

However, Oldenburg's framework, developed in an American context, assumes that communities are free to utilize space organically which is absolutely untrue in Singapore's tightly governed urban landscape. Yet, Block 541A suggests that even with Singapore's controlled planning, some utilitarian spaces slip through the cracks, allowing communities to self-generate. The carpark succeeds precisely because of its mundane functions, not in spite of it. Its unremarkable functions allow it to slip from formal planning, creating an accidental community space.

This phenomenon is not unique to Block 541A (whose very nondescript naming points to its very mundaneness). Local urban researchers Julienne Chen and Cheryl Low (2018) examined Singapore's common spaces and found that most vibrant community spaces emerge from the ground up, shaped by residents rather than urban planners. In their study of Housing Development Board (HDB) estates, they observed that spaces like void decks and corridors where, as they note in paragraph 10, "residents across backgrounds and ethnicities were seen to gather and interact of their own accord." Chen and Low argue that Singapore's transition from kampong living to HDB estates attempted to preserve community bonds through designed spaces like community centres. However, state-managed urban planning often failed to replicate the spontaneity of organic social interactions. Their research even revealed that resident-led interventions like informal gardens and appropriated corners consistently outperformed purpose-built community spaces.

The carpark validates Chen and Low's findings, albeit more in specifying who shapes such spaces successfully. Community spaces thrive when shaped from the ground up by residents' actual behaviour rather than the imposed clutches of formal design planning. Unlike the community centre with scheduled programmes, the carpark is... a carpark. You simply park your car and go home. Nothing more. Nobody programmed it to be social, the social aspect blooms out of its repeated use by residents instead. This absence of formal planning and programming becomes the very condition for the washing bay ritual, the breakroom rambling and the neighbourly exchange to even manifest. These unscheduled activities endure precisely as they are authored organically by residents rather than molded by formal planning.

Chen and Low's findings, shaped by the distinctly ubiquitous Singaporean HDB neighbourhood, complements Oldenburg's universal framework. Whilst Oldenburg theorises about third places generally, Chen and Low localise this. Together, these sources reveal the tension of how formal urban planning seeks to engineer communities through designed spaces and yet genuine communities emerge in the overlooked unremarkable utilitarian infrastructures.

The carpark's success as a social space suggests that community formation may require something that formal planning cannot provide which is neglect. The middle levels cluster with cars not just for ease of access but because these became the de facto social centre, where one might encounter familiar faces. However, beyond this familiarity lies an outlier, a limit to this community's neutrality. Considering that the carpark's social fabric is built upon the shared middle-class sentiment, the Porsche's owner relegates it to isolation at the margins of the isolated upper decks, which ironically parallels the owner's aspiration to be upper-class. It breaks the uniformity in lifestyle for it is nothing like the sedans and family vehicles, a clear departure from the known rhythm and a deliberate choice to be separated from the rest of the

community. This class divide is a reminder that even organic, unplanned communities have their own quiet boundaries.

What makes this significant for Singapore is the sheer ubiquity of carparks. Most HDB estates and commercial complexes include a multi-storey carpark. If Block 541A's patterns hold elsewhere, which Chen and Low suggests they might, then Singapore possesses an extensive network of underutilised community infrastructure, all hiding in plain sight.

So then, could utilitarian spaces like carparks contribute more to community experience than we usually notice? The evidence from Block 541A suggests they already do. The contribution happens quietly without fanfare. The question is not whether such spaces can contribute, but whether we recognise the contribution they are already making.

Perhaps the lesson for urban planners is not to replicate the carpark's success through tailored interventions but to acknowledge that community formation requires multiple spatial conditions in programmed community centres and unprogrammed utilitarian infrastructures. The former provides legitimacy and resources whilst the latter provides freedom for organic social formation. Singapore's social fabric may depend as much on the spaces we overlook as on the ones we celebrate.

The carpark at Block 541A will likely remain unremarkable to most, save me of course. But for those who pause to observe, it reveals a truth about urban communities, one where connection emerges not where we intentionally designed for it, but in the spaces left undesigned. The invisible communal centres are indeed visible, only if we know where to look.

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The Immortalisation of Transient Experiences

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Figure 1.Inscriptions on the pier reading “I love you” and “I miss you”

I arrived at Raffles Marina on a humid Thursday afternoon. The rain had just ceased, leaving cloudless skies and a damp pier stretching into the Straits of Johor. On one side of this path was a dock packed full of moored ships; on the other, a vast expanse of seawater, undulating in rhythm with the wind. The pier itself, a mass of concrete and steel darkened from the rain, bore inscriptions like “I love you” and “I miss you,” etched in white (Fig. 1). At the very end of this jetty was a lighthouse freshly painted in a new coat of white, a landmark in its own right.

As the sun approached the horizon, people started filtering in, some clutching cameras and others holding hands. Each found a spot, sparing a passing glance at the lighthouse before turning to face the open water — a choice which left me momentarily confused. The reason, however, soon became apparent: between the golden hours of sunset and the blue glow of dusk, the clouds lit up with an afterglow, their edges tinged crimson. Cameras and phones were taken out, snapping away at the skyline, and I found myself having to repress this familiar urge in favour of observing those around me. As the fading

light from the clouds was replaced by the streetlamps' fluorescent glow, I could hear footsteps behind me as people departed *en masse*. I was struck by the jarring irony: we carve out chunks of our day specifically to observe and document that which is impermanent, yet we overlook the timeless statements of human ingenuity in the likes of the lighthouse or the pier itself. We scramble to preserve a shred of the brief moments in our lives, as if their transient nature makes them in a way more valuable. We etch messages and take photographs, attempting to anchor a fleeting feeling. Having witnessed both the spectacle and the very human responses which accompany it, I naturally came to wonder: why do we attach so much importance to these transient experiences?

In her 1977 essay "In Plato's Cave," cultural critic Susan Sontag draws parallels between Plato's cave allegory and modern-day photography. Amongst the myriad of reasons behind our shared sense of compulsion, she places heavy emphasis on a photograph's ability to express feelings "both sentimental and implicitly magical" whilst still retaining a realistic view of the world (Sontag, 1977, pp. 16 & 22). She continues, asserting that photographs are "*memento mori*," their creation a tacit acknowledgement that whatever is being photographed will inevitably change or end (p. 15). I resonated deeply with her claims – from spontaneous escapades with old friends from Thailand to erupting geysers in Iceland, my motivations for photographing stem from a tapestry of subliminal inclinations: to convey joy and excitement, to present a faithful view of a place I will never see again, and ultimately, to preserve these moments indefinitely.

Sontag (1977) later comments on this act of "conferring [on an] event a kind of immortality," stating that we are merely "taking imaginary possession of a past that is unreal." This leads to one of her core arguments: much like the troglodytes in Plato's cave who are limited to shadowy imitations of the outside world, we are settling for lesser replicas of actual experiences as a way to perceive (Sontag, 1977, pp. 4-9). Thus, as she puts it, photography is as much a way of "certifying experience" as it is "refusing it": in immortalizing an experience for future use, we become voyeurs to our own lives, disconnected from the present (p. 9). I recognised this role in myself. With the very act of holding a camera, I became a designated record-keeper destined to document but never fully partake. I have stood before vast landscapes without feeling their grandeur because I was too busy framing them, and I have captured my friends' laughter while remaining a stranger to the joke. With each experience, I was physically present yet emotionally distant, perceiving the world through a middleman.

Alixandra Barasch, Gal Zauberman, and Kristin Diehl substantiate this sentiment in their 2018 paper "How the Intention to Share Can Undermine Enjoyment: Photo-Taking Goals and Evaluation of Experiences." Across several experiments, researchers found that subjects who took photos with the intent to share derived less pleasure from their experiences. Notably, in one field study involving a popular tourist attraction, those who had the salient intent to share their photos were likely to recall their experiences "more from a third-person perspective" and were also "less likely to report that they would recommend the experience to a friend" (Barasch et al., 2018, pp. 1222 &1226). This pattern held across all five studies, regardless of context. The authors conclude that this intention to share triggers a sort of "self-presentational concern," which is in turn associated with "self-conscious emotions such as anxiety," in the end positing that people who prioritise future utility often undermine their enjoyment of the present (p. 1233). More often than not, I found myself mentally editing the scene as

it unfolded; my thoughts would drift toward the technicalities of tone and light rather than the presence of the vistas or the company of close friends. In those moments, I was no longer an observer of the world, but a curator of its aftermath.

Though published decades apart, both works identify a singular cost: the act of photography dissociates us from the present. Susan Sontag's (1977) philosophical and psychological viewpoints complement Barasch et al.'s (2018) empirical findings. Taking an introspective look at my psyche, I found myself having never questioned my urge to photograph: originating from my intent to preserve fleeting moments, the act of photography now stands disjointed from my initial rationale, instead existing as a reflex of sorts. Echoing Sontag (1977) and Barasch et al. (2018), I realised that the presence of a camera and the cascade of semi-conscious actions often accompanying its use made me far less immersed in an experience. Despite this, it is undeniable that photographs have a future value, something trivialised by Sontag (1977) and unexamined by Barasch et al. (2018). Experiences may end, but their impact lasts far beyond their physical termination; they stay with us, evolving through the artifacts we carry home. To that end, perhaps the camera is not the middleman, but rather the witness — one which allows us to reconnect with the past and redistribute the impact of a moment to the future. I can no longer return to those rooftops in Thailand or the geysers of Iceland, but these photographs serve as a visual shorthand for my own growth — a way to inhabit past versions of myself, reminiscing and learning.

Ultimately, our attachment to these transient experiences stems from our subconscious awareness of the mortality of everything around us: we apprehend the darkness of night during sunset, and we dread the return flight halfway into a vacation. In scrambling to preserve these moments as the most authentic, artistic, or enduring artifacts, we become so focused on the future to the extent that it encroaches on our grasp of the present. It is a finding consistent across Sontag's (1977) critiques, Barasch et al.'s (2018) empirical findings, and my own anecdotal experience. This instinctive urge, one compelling enough for us to willingly forgo all but a sliver of an experience, has become second nature to many and accepted by society as a whole. Yet, in defining enjoyment, we might have been too focused on our feelings at present. Try as we might, it is impossible to quantify the value of the present against the sentimental weight of the future. With a camera in our hands, each and every photo becomes an educated guess: some moments are worth the momentary distraction, whilst some are best left unrecorded, becoming more vivid and cherished with time. Photography, then, is not a binary choice between presence and absence, but a delicate calibration. A way of traversing the diverse and overlapping experiences in our lives — a means of choosing when the weight of a moment will find us. As I sat at the empty pier basking in the dim blue glow of dusk, I found myself glad to have spared a few moments to capture the changing hues of the sky, even if it meant I had to look at it through a lens.

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The Invisible Thread: Spinning a Vibrant Community from Mundane Fibres

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Eleven years - that is how long ago I last held the keys to Hougang Avenue 3 Block 7. In the ceaseless hustle of Singapore, returning here feels less like a visit and more like a homecoming. Stepping off the bus, I am greeted by a familiar five-storey facade standing restfully in the open. Block 7 is unusually short, sporting just four flights of stairs. Today, she wears a mellow brown-beige coat, replacing the vibrant reds and blues of the past. Her open-concept architecture features a single, sweeping corridor connecting every home, a stark contrast to the isolated corners of newer built-to-order flats.

Crossing the open-air carpark towards the building, a mix of gleaming LED signboards and moldy-black awnings front the shophouses. Wafting through the air are familiar spices from an Indian Mamak shop, herbs from a Chinese medical hall, and Ang Ku Kueh from the confectionary store I frequented. Uncles bellow dialects at the coffee shop, complaining "Now everything so expensive!", harmonising with the quiet shuffle of a snaking queue for affordable economy rice. Young families from newer neighbouring HDBs trickle over, preferring these humble stores over the sterile mall beneath their own block, highlighting the vibrant warmth of the intertwined community here.

Venturing up to my old unit, the smell of burning incense strikes me. Some doors are left ajar; peering in, residents are lazing around, chatting with family, or hauling clothes in from bamboo poles hung outside their kitchen. This way of life remains unchanged. Yet, while I reminisced about the potted plants lining the corridor, the bicycles my sister and I locked at the stairwell, even the hateful "bird uncle" smoking amongst his cluttered birdcages, the current residents see their belongings lined up instead - a practice so constant, yet so different from my memory.

Across the years, I became a stranger to this estate. In this historic relic, no one left remembers me. However, amidst the changing landscape are unchanging constants both former and current residents share: a curious sense of unity lingers. From the silent courtesy of giving way on the narrow walkways down to the same way shoes and potted plants line the corridors, everything seems "differently familiar". This unspoken solidarity fuses the HDB into a cohesive "tribe", challenging our understanding of belonging - communal ties seemingly transcend knowing each other personally. If living in the same block can spin an invisible thread binding strangers together, I question: *How do lived experiences build communal identity?*

Seeking historical context, a journal article, "The Catholic-Teochew Rhythm", by historian Goh (2018) examines the emergence of communal identity in Hougang between 1945 and 1981. Drawing from oral history interviews, he argues the crossing between Catholic and Teochew cultures bred a new, unique cultural rhythm. Goh demonstrates that local

institutions - namely schools, families and churches - merged diverse traditions into a unified community. Their deeply ingrained routines earned the enclave the colloquial title, "Siadi" or "holy land" (p. 229). He emphasises that this localised identity was actively adapted through a "dialectic process of amalgamation" involving both religious and ethnic customs (p. 241). For instance, wedding rites blended seamlessly, with the tradition of distributing cakes to elders to announce a marriage being adopted in a Catholic church (Goh, 2018, p. 241). However, just as identities always adapt, when modernisation came, some heritage was traded for practicality. Ultimately, through this microhistory, Goh illustrates that communal identities are not simply imported, but birthed and developed through active local efforts.

Goh's (2018) "Catholic-Teochew rhythm" provides a historical foundation for understanding communal identity formation. Having lived in Hougang and studied in Holy Innocents', I felt the realisation: the power of identity lay in how communities define our everyday routine. I did not know Hougang was a "Siadi", but how my school organised masses and how city-planning positioned Nativity Church on the main road formed core memories. A consensus is shared amongst my family: if the church as an iconic landmark were removed, even just the travel through Hougang would not feel like its "normal rhythm". The lasting presence of these "Siadi" remnants showcases how efforts by institutions can leave enduring legacies on an estate.

Yet, returning to Block 7 today, the active institutional web I belonged to has faded. Having grown up, moved away and grown distant, I no longer share the communities of schoolmates or neighbours. I remain a stranger among a mix of new residents. However, I still share that "rhythm" Goh (2018) describes, feeling an instinctive comfort in the same turns, corners and shared spaces. This leaves a lingering question: if we are no longer bound by the same active community efforts, how does an everchanging society of strangers inherit and sustain this communal bond?

Searching for what organically connects strangers, I found a journal article, "Socio-Sensory Practice", by architecture lecturer Palipane (2020), investigating how everyday sensory experiences allow multicultural communities to construct a sense of place. She focuses on "place-making" - the process of transforming a foreign physical environment into a meaningful, familiar home. Based on ethnographic fieldwork in the diverse suburb of Footscray, Melbourne, she argues that immigrants rely on familiar senses to recreate the comfort of home in a foreign environment. Palipane describes how routine actions, like the food eaten and language spoken, generate sensory by-products. They passively form a "sensescape [...] of familiar smell, tastes and textures", bringing comfort and warmth that organically "validate[s] presence in the urban landscape" (p. 766). She emphasises that these generated senses are what create and invigorate memory. Consequently, the common cultural memory embedded in each individual unfolds into a collective identity through environmental interactions (p. 773). The takeaway is that shared sensory experiences in people's memories serve as the medium for negotiating place-making. Within diverse multicultural neighbourhoods, these senses help form belonging and communal identity in a way that transcends demographic boundaries.

Palipane's (2020) discussion on "sensescapes" provides a lens to understand how displaced groups maintain identity through the memory of everyday practices. Applying this to Singapore, citizens' communal identity persists through similar socio-sensory practices. A resident might initially find the sharp aroma of unfamiliar cooking or the loud cadences of an unknown dialect jarring. Yet, over

time, these sensory frictions soften into a comforting background hum of home. Our familiarity with everyday actions triggers the sensory glue tying us to our existing sense of communal identity; as we adapt to the same environmental senses, they transcend background information, turning into a shared "language". They become the medium of connection that allows us to recognise mutual belonging to a shared world.

While Palipane (2020) focuses on how isolated groups organically create familiar "footholds" around themselves, my observations of Singapore point to something much more deliberate. We do not just exist in isolated cultural bubbles; we are pushed together. Governmental policies force these concepts to collide, bridging both perspectives. By implementing top-down designs like the HDB Ethnic Integration Policy, the state acts as Goh's (2018) active institution, laying a foundational web of diverse families for Palipane's passive sensory dynamics to overlap. This engineered proximity forms a two-dimensional pyramid model of how shared spaces form communal identity.

Goh (2018) and Palipane (2020) explain how lived experiences shape communal identity. Yet, identity is not forged in a single instance: for that we may turn to sociologist Chua's (2017) work. Critiquing Singapore's communitarian ideology, he argues that the state limits individual liberty by implementing strict milestones, such as mandatory CPF savings and rigid requirements for public housing. By tying essential resources to these state-defined checkpoints, the government effectively sets the pace of citizen life. With that, we may infer a broader synchronised life course driven by other state obligations - from PSLE, through National Service, to BTO balloting. Enduring these identical life stages together, often united by our signature cultural mindsets like complaining and being kiasu, solidifies our belonging. Therefore, we do not just share physical corridors; we share a synchronised life course binding us to a singular Singaporean identity.

Ultimately, communal identity in a modern metropolis like Singapore is not merely inherited from a homogenous past, nor formed entirely by chance. Our shared identity is actively built by bridging the spaces we inhabit, which force our passive sensory habits to overlap. And this connection is not a one-way street; rather, it is a reciprocal handshake across time. As Goh's (2018) history suggests, the varied everyday routines we practise now are the "fibres" that weave into an "invisible thread" lingering into the future. Down the road, as we continue our routines, habits and customs, milestone-by-milestone, the community returns this reciprocal handshake: it reaches back to the preserved senses and feelings from Palipane (2020), reinforcing our sense of belonging and shaping future habits. While the "lahs" and "lorhs", and "kopi and teh" may seem mundane to a passerby, they remain an unknowingly living archive of mutual recognition, just for us. So, the next time you walk down your own corridor and catch the familiar scent of a neighbour's cooking, consider this: are those simply background information of city living, or is the community actively reaching out to shake your hand?

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Between the World and the Word: The Invisible Struggle

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Figure 1. Christian youths mingle during a Saturday gathering.

In the quiet, unassuming neighbourhood of Bukit Batok West, I walked towards a white building, its small stature a stark contrast from the surrounding HDB blocks. My entrance was accompanied by a gust of cold air, buzzing with energy. A cacophony of rapid-fire conversations assaulted my ears as my eyes adjusted to the warm yellow lighting. The topics flowed from fun outings with friends and recent travels, to the stress of endless schoolwork and internship worries. As I sat on one of the plastic chairs in the room, a peculiar characteristic about this group of 40-odd people stood out to me: their demographic was not homogeneous, neither in life stage nor age. There were energetic students from all manner of educational institutions. There were also full-time National Servicemen whose postures reflected the weariness of military regimentation, as well as freshly graduated members of society; their bright-eyed optimism yet unpolluted by the stresses of work. Their ages ranged from 17- to 24-year-olds; a gap that would have, in any other circumstances, rendered any possibility of interaction moot. However, on this Saturday evening, all of them gathered for a weekly routine of singing, learning, and sharing, brought together by their shared love for Christ.

Underneath the cacophony, my ears picked up on a few calmer conversations. These were heartfelt discussions about interpersonal relationships and the

“living out” of their faith: safeguarding their beliefs in the presence of their secular friends, and “fitting in” to a secular environment where religion becomes an afterthought. I suddenly realised these four walls were their short two-hour paradise away from the scrutiny of society, especially as a Christian. Here, amongst peers who shared the same religion and values, these youths could truly feel comfortable expressing themselves. As a young person myself, I could truly relate; not only with the feeling of being judged, but also the sense of relief in finding a safe community to express myself in. This led me to ponder if the existence of this fellowship signalled a deeper human need for acceptance. Did these Christian youths feel like they had to act differently in front of their secular friends? Perhaps therein lay an invisible struggle between prioritizing faith and the natural desire to participate in trendy, secular youth culture. It begs a critical question: in this Christian community, how does the tension between maintaining one’s Christian faith and the desire for social integration with secular friends impact the identity of these youths?

In 2011, two researchers from California State University attempted to shed light on this issue. Leslie Grier and Wendy Gudiel argue that the overarching protective effects of religion are diminished by negative peer influence. They found that adolescents’ desire to conform to their peers’ behaviours often outweigh the influence of external religious behaviours, such as church attendance. In secular environments where risk-taking is normalised, this desire to conform can drive youths toward anti-social conduct, such as delinquency or rebellious rule-breaking, as a means to gain peer validation. However, they highlight that internalised faith retained its protective power. Even under pressure, faith still shaped the youths’ core decision-making, decreasing their vulnerability to peer influence and encouraging pro-social behaviours. Thus, the authors conclude that when navigating negative peer influence, "religiosity seems most useful towards mobilising adolescents to make alternative and positive choices" (Grier & Gudiel, 2011, p. 992), serving as a practical guide for behaviour.

The impact of the peer influence mentioned by Grier and Gudiel (2011) was evident in the heartfelt discussions I observed. Youths were discussing ways to "fit in" to secular environments, where decisions based on religious beliefs—like abstaining from certain social activities—may be accompanied by the worry of potential rejection by peers, along with other social barriers. While the researchers correctly identify that internalised faith acts as a protective buffer, observing these youths reveals that relying on this buffer is rarely effortless. Their retreat to the fellowship demonstrates a persistent internal friction. Their faith may not necessarily be erased by the desire for social integration; rather, there might be a constant, taxing psychological struggle to uphold their identity across conflicting social boundaries.

Social boundaries formed the basis of a study by Mattes et al., a group of researchers from the University of Vienna. They argue that young believers in secular environments continuously engage in boundary work to navigate their religious identity. This concept refers to the deliberate social and psychological strategies individuals use to separate themselves from, or assimilate into, specific groups. They note that in an increasingly secular society, living a religious life is viewed as outside the norm. Consequently, youth from historical majority religions, such as Christianity, reported feeling like a marginalised minority, experiencing pressure from secular peers to justify their beliefs. To cope, these youths constructed symbolic boundaries to separate their religious in-group from their secular out-group, leading to behavioural shifts depending on the group they were interacting with. The authors highlight the

resultant friction, noting that "Our interview partners have experienced multifaceted forms of religious othering in their daily social life, constantly compelling them to navigate their religious identity across various social environments" (Mattes et al., 2025, p. 6).

Such boundary-drawing seems to exist in multireligious Singapore. To maintain social harmony, there might exist an unspoken compulsion to avoid sensitive religious topics, relegating religion to a strictly personal affair. Religious adherents may also feel pressure to bury religious beliefs to avoid standing out in secular out-groups. This manifested in the real-life experiences I heard, like consciously "code-switching" vocabulary to avoid sounding too religious in a project meeting. However, the boundary-drawing mentioned by Mattes et al. (2025) may not indicate smooth success in identity navigation, especially if it means setting aside religious convictions to avoid secular friction. The youths' unfettered relief within the fellowship's "two-hour paradise" may signal that navigating these boundaries is not a seamless integration, but an exhausting performance. It requires constant cognitive vigilance, forcing them to perpetually monitor and edit their speech and behaviours depending on their audience. As a result, their desire for social integration may be forcing their faith to become intensely compartmentalised: thriving within the church's safe walls, but heavily guarded outside. This identity navigation is also undoubtedly a response to the practical demands of secular spaces. For peers who do not share the same beliefs, navigating shared discussions requires a common denominator. Introducing religious criteria into collective decision-making also introduces varying and potentially incompatible priorities, complicating group cohesion. Consequently, perhaps the youths' boundary-drawing is not just a defence mechanism against rejection, but a pragmatic concession to keep secular social interactions functional and inclusive for everyone.

While Grier, Gudiel, and Mattes et al.'s studies focus on different concepts, perhaps their work allows us some insight into the nature of the tension. Indeed, it may be that this struggle is a two-part equation. Driven by the urge to conform to their secular peers, Christian youths might be motivated to quell their religiosity, separating their faith and secular life using symbolic boundaries. However, the fatigue of constantly partitioning their lives conceivably forces them to seek reprieve, away from judgment and scrutiny. As such, youths struggling with boundary-setting may have trouble maintaining their Christian identity, turning to secular peers for acceptance. It is possible that this feeling of isolation arises not from a lack of demographic representation, but because Singapore's public spaces are largely governed by secular norms. While Christianity remains a statistically prominent religion in Singapore, the shared public sphere operates on a deeply secular consensus. In an environment that prioritises a neutral, non-religious common denominator, those who hold deep religious convictions, Christian or otherwise, may easily feel marginalised when stepping outside their faith communities. This could create a vicious cycle: conforming to secular peers could invite rejection from fellow believers for not acting "stereotypically Christian," driving youths further into secular circles. Alternatively, youths may choose to spend more time in identity-affirming Christian communities than with identity-questioning secular peers. This would feasibly create another cycle: committing wholeheartedly to religion may cause them to be ostracized in secular circles, leading them to form even stronger bonds within their spiritual communities.

This silent struggle within the church walls is arguably a symptom of a broader Singaporean pragmatism,

which demands we hide our deepest convictions for the sake of seamless social harmony. While relegating religion to the private sphere is common in many multicultural countries, Singapore's approach is distinct in that it is heavily managed, shaped by a historical vulnerability to societal fracture. The pressure to compartmentalise faith is not merely about avoiding sensitive topics; it is a calculated guardrail against the very real risks of public conflict. In shared spaces, individuals do not always engage with differing beliefs ideally or rationally. Left unchecked, overt religious expression in secular discussions can easily lead to the imposition of values, deeply incompatible decision-making, or the breakdown of civility. Thus, to survive as a dense, diverse nation, we are encouraged to adopt a neutral secularity. However, when members of society feel compelled to conform and suppress their true views, it highlights a critical issue: the fear of non-acceptance. If we feel the urge to hide aspects of ourselves, can we really say that Singapore as a society is tolerant? Indeed, tolerance is important; it is the foundation of our diverse society. But tolerance loses its meaning when it demands the diminishing of personal authenticity, becoming a mere excuse to quell differences in the name of peace. The enforced, colourless 'Sameness' in Lois Lowry's *The Giver* suddenly feels less like dystopian fiction and more like a cautionary tale. True societal tolerance should not require the erasure of differences, nor should it demand the hiding of one's authentic selves.

Perhaps what we need instead is a society that practices principled engagement. Given the demographic imbalances in Singapore, whether between the secular majority and religious individuals, or between dominant and minority religions, fairness cannot mean a societal free-for-all where the loudest voices win. A genuinely inclusive society must couple personal authenticity with a shared commitment to equity, creating public spaces where individuals can express their differences safely while actively protecting the voices of those in the minority. If a society forces its people to constantly fracture their identities for the sake of blending in, it may achieve a superficial peace, but it sacrifices something more critical in the process—the right to exist authentically, unapologetically, and without discrimination. Until society offers the same acceptance found beneath those warm yellow lights, this invisible, exhausting divide will remain—not just for these youth, but for anyone forced to hide a piece of themselves to belong.

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The Significance of Being Seen

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We don't often put the words homeless and Singapore in the same sentence. But on a Tuesday evening at The Night Cafe, I found myself standing at the entrance of a room full of people who had nowhere else to go. Outside, the evening air sat heavy and humid, but inside, the atmosphere was warm and light-hearted as people engaged in friendly banter. Fluorescent lights cast an even yellow glow over plastic tables neatly arranged. The air conditioning hummed steadily, barely audible over the sounds of chatter. The room was simple with stackable chairs and boxes of cai-fan lined along the wall. I hesitated at the entrance for a moment, unsure of what to do or where to stand. But just as quickly, I realised that no one was monitoring who came in- there wasn't even a registration form. So I took my place quietly at the back.

Styrofoam boxes were passed around without fanfare, causing the aroma of garlic, soy sauce and freshly steamed rice to permeate the air, eliciting a not-so-quiet rumble from my stomach. A senior uncle, somewhere near the front, began singing into a microphone with a slightly off-key, scratchy rendition of「童话」. Though loud, none of the other people there seemed disturbed by the sound and continued with their conversations, with some even joining in song. From my little corner, distinction between rough sleepers and volunteers was visible, yet the divide was nowhere to be found. The atmosphere felt communal, almost like a shared sanctuary for people from all walks of life.

The Night Cafe is a volunteer-run community initiative offering free meals and company to rough sleepers, people who resort to sleeping in public spaces for lack of stable housing. What surprised me about this place was not what was present, but what was absent. I had arrived carrying a subconscious idea of what "charity" in Singapore looks like: filled with rules, forms, eligibility criterias. Similarly, I had expected a level of formality before I could feel that a situation like this was being "under control". Instead, I found an openness that demanded nothing of anyone who walked in. A conversation with a woman at the cafe stayed with me: "There is no distinction or class here. We are all sleeping outside, you see ... so we are just friends only." It was a simple statement that dismantled almost everything I thought I knew about what help was supposed to look like and who gets to define it. It brought to mind the idea of dignity- the intrinsic worth of a person regardless of one's circumstances. What I witnessed, therefore, was not a conventional type of charity, because nobody looked like people who were being 'helped'. It looked like people simply being. And perhaps that is what dignity looks like when it is intact: not anything grand or loud, but the freedom to just be. It was exactly this that the Night Café was quietly restoring, and this that explains the ache in the lives of those who spend their days without it.

This raised a question I could not then reconcile: why does dignity matter so profoundly to those living on the margins? What is it about spaces like the Night

Cafe that make them feel so different from formal systems of care?

To begin answering this, it helps to understand what formal systems do to rough sleepers, often without intending to. In their 2018 journal article *Homelessness and Social Control: A Typology*, researchers Sarah Johnsen, Suzanne Fitzpatrick and Beth Watts map the full range of mechanisms used to manage street homelessness in England, from outright force such as arrests and dispersal orders, to subtler interventions like persuasion, personalised budgets, and what they call "tolerance" (Johnsen et al., 2018): the open-door, no-questions-asked approach characteristic of soup kitchens and low-threshold shelters. What struck me about their perspective was the emphasis on how even the softest interventions carry moral weight. As they put it, "the deployment of every one of these modes of social control, and indeed the absence of such controls, raises moral and practical dilemmas" (Johnsen et al., 2018, p. 15). The system is never neutral, because in some sense, it will always exert power over the people it claims to help.

This new information probed me to think further about where the Night Cafe lay in all of it. Under Johnsen et al.'s (2018) typology, a space like it falls into the "tolerance" category which means making no active attempt to alter anyone's behaviour, and welcoming everyone regardless of circumstances. One of the rough sleepers interviewed in their study described a similar low-threshold service as making him feel "normal again." (Johnsen et al., 2018, p13). I recognised that feeling in the room I sat in, where everyone was treated equally with the same warmth and openness. But this raised a question I could not then reconcile- why does the absence of control produce such a powerful emotional response? What difference does control make in the lives of these rough sleepers? While Johnsen et al.'s (2018) typology documents the societal structure surrounding rough sleepers, it doesn't account for the deeper human need it meets. For that, I needed a different lens.

It was this curiosity that led me to discover philosopher Avishai Margalit's book titled *The Decent Society*, where he offers an explanation for understanding why institutional treatment matters so deeply. Margalit's argument is disarmingly simple: a society is decent not when it achieves perfect justice, but when its institutions stop humiliating the people under their authority. He defines dignity not as something earned or bestowed, but as the baseline condition of being recognised as fully human. Treating people as numbers to process, problems to manage, or as behaviour to correct, all of these, in his view, injures dignity at its root. His argument is that eliminating humiliation is not just a moral ideal; it is more urgent and more achievable than the pursuit of abstract justice.

Through Margalit's eyes, the Night Cafe's most significant quality is not what it provides, but what it withholds. The absence of a sign-in form, a security guard, and a list of conditions- none of these were mere coincidences. It is, philosophically speaking, a refusal by the leaders of The Night Cafe to potentially cause humiliation in their rough sleepers. Dignity is not something the Night Cafe gives rough sleepers; it is something the space carefully avoids taking away. When the woman said "there is no distinction or class here", she was not just describing a feeling. She was describing a structural truth: that this room, unlike many others available to her, had been quietly yet intentionally designed to treat her as a full person.

Together, the two sources helped me make sense of something that neither fully explains on its own. Johnsen et al. (2018) show us the structural landscape, the full spectrum of what formal systems do, and how each mode of control carries its own moral cost. Margalit, on the other hand, gives us the

language to understand deeper why that cost is borne so acutely by rough sleepers specifically: because their dignity has often been eroded long before their housing, through repeated experiences of being processed, categorised, and managed rather than seen. Where Margalit tells us what institutions must stop doing, the Night Cafe suggests something further: that restoring dignity is not only about withdrawing humiliation. It sometimes requires actively building the conditions for a person to feel, however briefly, that they belong. The absence of harm, while necessary, simply may not be enough.

I think about this as I sit with the image of the uncle singing, his voice wobbling but unabashed. Nobody asked him to perform, nobody asked him to stop singing. Dignity does not always announce itself through policy reform or formal intervention. Sometimes it arrives quietly, in a Styrofoam box of cai-fan, in a little room with no sign on the door, where it was silently agreed that the people inside do not need to earn the right to simply exist.

Singapore's response to rough sleeping has, by and large, emphasised formal pathways such as crisis shelters, casework, structured intervention. These are not without value. However, they often carry the weight of the very control mechanisms Johnsen (Johnsen et al., 2018) describes- conditionality embedded in care, compliance hidden within compassion. What the Night Cafe offers, instead, is a reminder that spaces which do none of these things still do something irreplaceable. They restore, however temporarily, the notion that a person's presence in a room does not require justification. Perhaps that is where we need to start: not with systems, but with the quieter decision to stop requiring people to justify their presence before we offer them ours. In a society where many rough sleepers remain unseen, to be "seen" is not to be singled out, but simply to be recognised as a person among others. Because to be loved is to be seen, and sometimes, being seen is where the larger work of recovery begins.

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Kampong Lorong Buangkok: Continuity in an Age of Liquid Modernity

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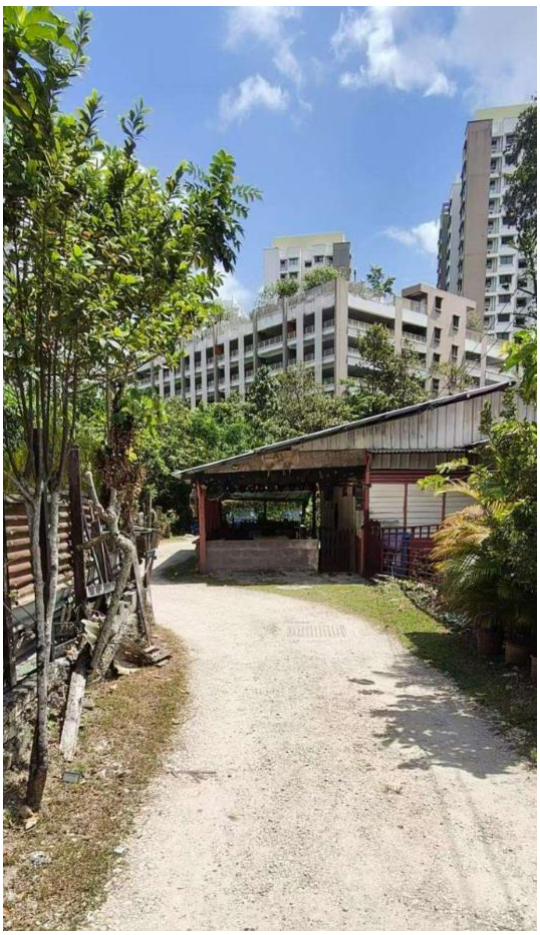

Figure 1. Kampong Lorong Buangkok Surrounded by HDB Buildings

The bus pulled up at St. Vincent de Paul Church. I crossed a small stream and saw several low wooden houses hidden among thick foliage. A narrow dirt path stretched ahead of me. Beside it stood a small, easy-to-miss signboard that read "Kampong Lorong Buangkok". The scattered gravel on the path and the overgrown branches slowed me down. As I walked, I could feel the rough texture of the pebbles beneath my feet.

Looking ahead, the houses were almost swallowed by plants. Their entrances and eaves blended into the greenery. Several Buddha statues and shrines were barely visible among the foliage and wild weeds. Further ahead, the dirt path gave way to grass, with

uneven stones scattered across it. I had to slow down again, minding where I stepped. Where the grass grew sparse, a faint path emerged, leading into the shade of the trees. Looking around, open gates left yards exposed to view. Chairs facing outward looked as if they were inviting someone to sit; clothes hung beneath the eaves were within my easy reach; quilts laid out on the walls showed their faded patterns. The place felt still, and life here seemed to continue without being disturbed.

Journeying through Singapore's last *kampong*, I was struck by a completely different way of organising everyday life — one that does not rely on precise design or forceful intervention. Living in a fast-changing industrial society, we have become accustomed to continual upgrading and strict regulation. We assume that everyday life must be organised through planning and secured through surveillance. In this mindset, stability is achieved by renewal and maintained by control.

Yet the *kampong* suggests another possibility. There are no sharp boundaries between human habitation and nature. Shrines and Buddha statues do not seek to distinguish themselves from the surrounding weeds. Clothes hung beneath the eaves suggest a sense of safety. Paths are not mapped in advance but traced gradually by residents' footsteps, year after year. Everyday life here is sustained not by constant renovation, but by adaptation; not protected by vigilance, but by familiarity; not rooted in conquest, but in coexistence. All these patterns converge on a single underlying principle — continuity. In Kampong Lorong Buangkok, the organising principle of life is continuity rather than change. This continuity comes from the same people living in the same place over time, so that daily life remains familiar, nature retains its original shape, and objects stay where they have long belonged.

Such a way of life feels increasingly rare in a society driven by speed, expansion, and perpetual upgrading. This tension suggests a fundamental conflict between modern progress and the nature of continuity. It makes me wonder: what makes these two logics so incompatible, and must modernity always destroy continuity, or is there a way for them to work together?

Zygmunt Bauman, in *Liquid Modernity* (2000), describes premodern agricultural societies as "solid" due to the low mobility rooted in stable social relations and roles. Long-term cultivation ties people to the land, fostering enduring social bonds. Agricultural production relies heavily on years of accumulated experience, making social roles stable. In this sense, people are more grounded in their view of reality and the meaning of life.

However, in the context of modern society, people's productive activity no longer relies on fixed land but on portable skills. Therefore, job changes and migration become common, leading to temporary social roles and short-term relationships. Such mobility significantly impacts continuity, dissolving the social structure into a "liquid". As Bauman notes: "We associate 'lightness' or 'weightlessness' with mobility and inconstancy: we know from practice that the lighter we travel the easier and faster we move" (Bauman, 2000, p. 2). The more social roles and relationships lose their constancy, the faster people move and shift their lifestyles in a liquid society, and the less room there is for continuity under modernity.

Bauman's (2000) argument provides a compelling explanation of how the social relationships and roles that once sustained continuity are transformed under modernity. However, his analysis does not fully account for how these transformed conditions come to be sustained in everyday life — particularly why many individuals come to accept, or even embrace, constant change as a way of life. This gap is addressed

by Anthony Giddens, in *Modernity and Self-Identity* (1991), who offers a critical insight into this question through his concept of "self-identity as a reflexive project". Giddens (1991) argues that modernity weakens the authority of tradition and transforms the way individuals construct their identities. In agricultural societies, everyday life is under the authority of tradition and is largely pre-structured through family expectations, and individual choices remain limited.

Under modernity, however, the authority of tradition begins to weaken. As Giddens (1991) argues, "The more tradition loses its hold, and the more daily life is reconstituted in terms of the dialectical interplay of the local and the global, the more individuals are forced to negotiate lifestyle choices among a diversity of options" (p. 5). The old self-identity built by tradition and family expectations has collapsed, but the new one has not yet been established. Meanwhile, due to the growing number of career, partner, and lifestyle choices, people often get lost in the endless possibilities, unsure which one is best. Such anxiety keeps modern people questioning the decisions they have made, and therefore constantly evaluating and adjusting their lifestyles, relationships, and personal plans. Self-identity becomes a reflexive project, and continuity is destroyed through constant revision of all aspects of life.

Bauman's (2000) argument provides a macro-level explanation that under modernity, the stable social roles and long-term relationships that once supported continuity have collapsed. Giddens (1991), at a micro-level, describes how people feel lost and anxious rebuilding their self-identity in such a liquid world, leading to constant revision of their life choices. Together, they explain why continuity seems to have little place in the modern world: the liquidity of the world acts as a trigger — it is actually people's own decisions that add fuel to the breakdown of continuity in modernity. However, both Bauman (2000) and Giddens (1991) neglect the significant role of human agency. They assume that human beings are driven so uncontrollably by anxiety and desire, yet the existence of *kampong* residents challenges this assumption, suggesting that we are not destined to be this way. This tension raises another question: can individuals resist the change brought about by liquid modernity and rebuild continuity? If so, how can it be achieved?

Kampong Lorong Buangkok is not an isolated enclave removed from modernity — towering HDB blocks rise up all around it (see Fig. 1). The continuity found in the *kampong* comes not from the residents' ignorance, but from their self-restraint and active renunciation. They forgo high-paying job opportunities, advanced facilities, and the vibrant social life of the city, stepping back from the overwhelming range of choices in a liquid society. This is perhaps the very way *kampong* residents deal with the anxiety brought about by modernity: instead of endlessly striving for more possibilities, they choose to give up some of them, reducing the burden of constantly making choices. With the idea that "less is more", they can focus on what truly matters to them, from social relationships to family roles and the land that has long been part of their lives. Here, self-identity is rebuilt without restless hustle, and continuity finds its place. Such resistance to change requires human agency — specifically, finding fulfilment in restraint— but what is the deeper reason that drives it?

As human beings, we are inherently eager for stability and safety. We all need to answer who we are, thus a coherent self-narrative is important. Without continuity, our lives become a collection of scattered clips, where we remain on the surface of our experiences and have little understanding of them. To live with continuity is to live a life of depth, where we construct a growing narrative of the days we spend,

the environment we live in, and the people we relate to. In this way, we build a stable yet powerful self-identity, which is enough for us to face all the uncertainty brought about by liquid modernity. Perhaps in the 21st century, what makes continuity still possible is no longer external social conditions, but the intrinsic yearning for inner peace, so that we can calmly yet firmly answer the question: who am I?

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The Currency of Nostalgia: Why We Pay to Remember

By Reiko Lim

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The living room is dim, lit by the fading sun and the cool glow of the phone in my hand. As I scroll through my feed, a headline arrests my attention: "Disney's live-action Snow White is a lacklustre update of a classic." My thumb hovers over the glossy promotional image. The blue and yellow dress is rendered in 4K, its silk catching light with clinical precision. Her eyes are photorealistic, irises flecked with detail no paintbrush could have achieved in 1937. And yet, something about it feels further away.

In 2010, I remember sitting cross-legged on the floor in the living room, bathed in the static glow of a heavy box TV. With a bowl of "Honey Stars" in my lap, I watched *Snow White and the Seven Dwarfs*. The Snow White I remember was a canvas of bright, flat paint. I was captivated by her fluid, graceful movements, admiring how her skirt flowed in the wind as she walked. Looking back, I can see how much care was poured into animating the world that absorbed me—the lively, synchronised movements of the forest animals; the silly, comedic nature of the 7 dwarfs. I remember watching the dwarfs march to their iconic "Heigh-ho" song, laughing at the humorous scenes that captured their clumsy, endearing charm.

Each frame was slightly imperfect in a way that handmade things are, and that imperfection held something the photograph on my screen could not replicate. The original was drawn in the late 1930s on sheets of celluloid, one frame at a time, by artists working on a film so ambitious that critics mocked it as "Disney's Folly", convinced no audience would sit through a feature-length cartoon. (Monaco, 2010)

Upon reading through the reviews and watching the trailers, it becomes clear that the remake offers none of that risk. Its songs are new, stripped of the melodies that generations grew up with. What remains is the dress, the name, the broad outline of a story—a familiar silhouette hollowed out from within. What unsettles me is not that it is different, but that it feels designed with a different purpose: not to retell the story, but to sell me the feeling of having already loved it. The product on offer is not Snow White, but my memory of Snow White.

I set my phone down and look at our shelf of DVDs, standing exactly as it always has: sun-faded, spines slightly warped from years of Singapore humidity, labels handwritten in my mother's careful print. I grew up with these stories, whose characters felt like companions to my childhood. Seeing them endlessly repackaged felt uncanny. It was the creeping realisation that nostalgia itself had become a commodity, a product polished and marketed until it gleamed with artificial familiarity. I began to wonder: why do we willingly pay for familiarity, even when that familiarity is manufactured nostalgia?

In a 2014 study published in the *Journal of Consumer Research*, Lasaleta et al. (2014) conceptualises nostalgia not simply as a preference for old things, but a predominantly positive, bittersweet emotion—a warm, socially-oriented longing for a personally

meaningful past, most often tied to childhood and loved ones. That warmth, it turns out, makes us financially pliable. Researchers investigated the psychological relationship between nostalgic reflection and consumer spending. They found that nostalgia inherently fosters deep feelings of social connectedness, temporarily fulfilling a fundamental human need for safety and belonging. Because the brain views social support and money as interchangeable psychological buffers against uncertainty, feeling socially secure reduces our reliance on money. Consequently, nostalgia makes individuals more willing to part with money. According to Lasaleta et al., "if money is desirable because it can be readily exchanged for wants and needs from society and aid from others can do the same, then desire for money and social connection share a valuable function" (p. 715)

According to this framework, the massive financial success of live-action remakes can be attributed to the exploitation of this psychological vulnerability. This is evidenced by a 2025 Movio analysis, which found that the live-action *How to Train Your Dragon* drew its largest audience from adults aged 25 to 44, who were children when the original was released (Movio, 2025). Similarly, *The Lion King* (2019) grossed $1.66 billion worldwide, outperforming original films despite receiving only middling critical reviews (Whitten, 2019). Ultimately, audiences were not paying for innovation; they were paying for emotional certainty.

However, while Lasaleta et al. (2014) provide a strong foundational explanation for why consumers open their wallets, applying their study to media consumption reveals a critical limitation. In their experiments, nostalgia was utilised as a psychological catalyst to increase participants' willingness to buy unrelated, tangible consumer goods. Hollywood remakes trigger our genuine memories of social connection to bypass our financial scrutiny, but the product they sell us in return cannot provide that authentic connection. While the study explains the initial transaction, it fails to evaluate the hollow nature of the product itself. These limitations necessitate addressing the issue from another perspective.

If psychology explains the transactional trigger of nostalgia, cultural theory explains its aesthetic consequences. In his book "*Postmodernism, or, the Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism*", renowned critic Fredric Jameson diagnoses this phenomenon. He argues that late-capitalist society has lost its capacity to engage meaningfully with history, trapping culture in a perpetual present. Instead of historical depth, society relies on the "nostalgia film"—a cultural form that reduces the past to mere stylistic markers. Jameson (1991) introduces the concept of *pastiche*, which he defines as a "blank parody". Unlike traditional parody, which satirises its source material with an ulterior motive, *pastiche* is a neutral, lifeless imitation. It mimics dead historical styles and visual aesthetics without the underlying context, subtext, or original intent that once gave them meaning. He warns that through *pastiche*, history is commodified into easily consumable, glossy images, leaving audiences with a surface-level imitation of the past.

While Jameson's critique of the "nostalgia film" focuses on the cannibalising of broader historical eras rather than literal corporate remakes, the 2025 live-action *Snow White* fundamentally operates on this exact logic of *pastiche*. The film attempts to function as a modernised remake—rewriting Snow White from a passive maiden waiting for a prince to a proactive leader working to reclaim her father's kingdom, replacing the traditional prince with a rogue bandit, and inserting brand-new musical numbers. Yet, its entire visual identity relies on aggressively mimicking the surface aesthetics of the 1937 classic

to trigger instant recognition. From the literal replication of Snow White's iconic blue-and-yellow, high-collared dress to the uncanny CGI reproduction of the original dwarfs' bulbous facial structures and frame-by-frame scene blocking, the film borrows the distinct visual styles of a 90-year-old cartoon.

However, by altering the core narrative elements and removing foundational songs like "*Someday My Prince Will Come*", the film exposes its inner contradiction. By depending on the emotional architecture of the original while dismantling the very substance that created it, the film becomes a pure *pastiche*—a neutral, lifeless imitation that uses old styles as transactional currency while stripping away the underlying context and medium that gave them meaning. In doing so, the film ceases to be an artistic continuation and becomes a pure transaction: one that draws on decades of emotional attachment while replacing the substance that made that attachment possible.

Ultimately, Lasaleta et al. (2014) and Jameson (1991) expose two halves of the same predatory transaction. While Lasaleta et al. (2014) demonstrate that nostalgia lowers our financial defences by making us feel socially secure, Jameson (1991) reveals how the culture industry meets this emotional demand by exploiting our psychological vulnerability to sell an empty reproduction—a surface-level simulation of something once meaningful. Together, they describe a cycle: the industry leverages our most personal memories to increase our willingness to pay, then delivers a *pastiche* that contains only outward signs of those memories. What is lost in this exchange is not merely artistic integrity, but cultural possibility. The original *Snow White* was a risk—that could have failed—and in doing so, created something new. By contrast, its remake is a derivative work that operates within safe corporate boundaries, relying on narrative subversions to mask a derivative foundation. It does not generate meaning; it merely recycles it.

This shift has devastating consequences beyond any single film. When media conglomerates prioritise the safety of familiarity over the risk of originality, they foreclose on the future. Why invent tomorrow's classics when you can endlessly monetise yesterday's? Over time, this transactional logic produces a cultural landscape trapped in a perpetual present, dominated not by new ideas, but by increasingly polished, sterile repetitions of old ones. We are not just losing originality; we are losing the ability to imagine anything new. Memories are valuable precisely because they belong to a specific, fleeting moment. Nostalgia, in its truest form, is tied to that irreversibility. These "remakes" do not give us back our past, and by attempting to reverse the irreversible, they corrupt our relationship with it. If we continue financially rewarding this cycle, we risk creating a society that confuses visual recognition with emotional meaning, and artificial familiarity with value. Ultimately, the question is not whether we willingly pay for manufactured nostalgia. We clearly do. The question is whether we are willing to let our cultural future be the price.

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Dear Diary, Is All the World a Stage...?

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The cafe is quiet. Soft murmurs of conversation are interrupted by a cheerful jingle of keychains and pins clanking into each other as a girl unpacks her bag beside me. She rummages through, placing different pouches on the table, each filled to the brim with stationery: coloured pens, stickers, tape and more. I watch as she, almost ceremoniously, inserts the cafe's receipt and coaster into a folder containing similar pieces of ephemera. She pulls out a leather-bound journal with pages practically bursting from its covers. The glue and decorations produce a crunch-like sound as she opens it flat. The table is crowded, but the colours and materials are cohesive. The composition, scattered with pinks and magentas, clearly contrasts with my barren journal and singular pen. The thick pages appear to house picture-perfect memories, where details are intentionally chosen for display. Possibly, her effortful setup accentuates an aim of aesthetic worth. I note her collection of keepsakes, which suggests that journaling can also function as a curated archive of lived experiences.

Perhaps, journaling mirrors our online culture of capturing and packaging as many aesthetically pleasing memories for public view. It could be that, when this view is present in journaling, the self is not only reflected upon, but is also designed. My relationship with journaling poses a stark contrast. It is a place for introspection and solace, where raw thoughts run without judgment. However, I notice that journaling has become a stage for some, where thoughts have become actors and experiences, acts. This begs the question: has journaling shifted to be more performative than authentic? Can it be both?

Kremer (1959) theorises the process of self-introspection in "The Significance of Solipsism", where he dissects the work of 4 significant 20th-century British philosophers. Focusing on Kremer's study of the philosopher Wittgenstein, the former understood that solipsism, the belief that only one's own mind is sure to exist, emphasises the importance of being in touch with one's sensations, feelings, and memories, for the construction of a self-concept to analyse through writing or dialogue. Kremer gathered that articulating mental concepts is necessary for truly knowing oneself and one's inner experiences. Quoting Wittgenstein that "language often gives rise to temptations to draw false analogies" (1959, p. 42), Kremer's analysis builds on this recurring theme of the fallibility of our perceptions of ourselves and the world around us, that even as we scramble to keep a record of our experiences to later reflect on, these realities are often authored to perform an ideal sense of self. As such, even the voice used in diary writing and memory recall is unreliable.

In a world as unpredictable as ours, our grasp on reality today and, in turn, our record-keeping habits may increasingly lean more solipsistic. Kremer considers that individuals may use writing as an attempt to understand reality in relation to themselves and their experiences. Journals record tangible, more permanent versions of our precious memories. It helps us account for the past and future:

without it, we can only live in and be sure of our present experience, which can feel terrifying. What do we know happened, and what exists, if not the experiences we have penned down? Thus, the conscious collection of keepsakes for journaling alludes to a tendency to imbue seemingly inconsequential ephemera with meaning by relating them to oneself, underscoring our desperation to hoard as many moments as possible. This collection of moments in the form of journal entries is what solipsist philosophers claim to tell an idealised version. This leads me to wonder, if our documentation of experiences is skewed, does it defeat the purpose of journaling altogether?

According to Barnhart's summary of Sociologist Goffman's "The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life" (2021), Goffman presents a contrasting view of self-introspection through the theory of dramaturgy, more specifically, the concept of a "frontstage" self, where one performs a specific role by adhering to consistent expectations of setting, appearance, and manner. He argues that there is no true self, and the masks worn in different settings for their corresponding audiences constitute one's identity. This includes a "backstage" self that presents when one is alone, and where the differences that occur across "frontstage" settings can be explored candidly without the need to uphold an external audience's expectations. Goffman explains that donning the "frontstage" self requires careful control of how much, and more notably, what information about the actor is given to convince the audience of the authenticity of the role's performance. He adds that "attempts are made to present an "idealized" version of the front, more consistent with the norms, mores, and laws of society than the behaviour of the actor when not before an audience" (2021). Through these performances, Goffman presents that self-actualisation can occur, allowing individuals to slowly become the ideal self we attempt to portray.

Goffman's dramaturgy theory explains the precise selection of information to present an ideal self, directly reflected in contemporary journaling. He also disclaims that there are different "backstage" selves at play: one that prepares and curates for one's "frontstage" self, and another that never presents itself on the "frontstage" — a self just for the individual. Barnhart acknowledges the backstage as a secondary type of presentation. Even "backstage", where the self exists only for the individual, there is a self that observes a self that is observed. These two selves, although one individual, are not to be confused with each other. Essentially, the performance, although private, exists in front of and for the individual. Goffman references de Beauvoir's analogy of the backstage, where a woman readies her costume and make-up (1959, p. 70). This is done in front of a mirror, where the self is both observing and being observed. It is this very performance that even private writing may not be free from. When all along, journaling is set in the "backstage", it seems that the cognition and behaviour behind journaling today has evolved to become more of a supporting act for a "frontstage" self. Instead of plainly journaling events as they happen, the careful crafting of memories could be explained by the salient presence of this "frontstage" self, where writers may consider imaginary audiences when journaling an idealised front.

Goffman and Kremer both venture to explain the performativity behind journaling and self-introspection. While Goffman emphasises the inevitability of performance, Kremer's account of solipsism questions whether, even in the "backstage" self where an audience is absent, the record of experiences that make up oneself is also idealised. If, as Goffman argues, the self is always performed and, as Kremer suggests, never fully known, then today's

curated form of journaling may not mark a shift from authenticity, but rather expose the inherently biased nature of selfhood. Essentially, journaling has never been an honest peek into one's inner world and has always involved conscious construction and interpretation. Looking back at my form of journaling, as bare as it is in comparison to the girl in the cafe, I realise that we are both subject to the same degree of performance. For some, this is only made more obvious by decorated craft materials. My intentional choice of words and details to pen down is lined with that same objective.

This theme of performance extends to our everyday lives; we are constantly performing for ourselves, even in our most private moments. I would like to think that I have always journaled honest thoughts as they come, but when I read old journals, I laugh at entries where I blatantly lie and get annoyed at my past self for purposely redacting information she knew I would ridicule myself for now; I pity her when I realise how wrong she was about some things, and how right she was about others.

Journals mirror ourselves, and for most, become the scripts of our lives. How we remember, feel and think about life lies between the quotation marks and is directed by us. However inauthentic we are as narrators, these thoughts reveal our inner workings and can tell us what we are performing for. Journaling is not necessarily rendered meaningless because they transcribe our perpetual performance. Simply, the authentic view into ourselves cannot be achieved only through writing, but through the awareness of our performative tendency and analysis of it.

One may argue that my form of journaling makes this investigation easier, without the frill and flounce decorating the girl's entries. Yet, I wonder if these embellishments mean more can be interpreted about the self. Perhaps yes, her intricate setup exposes an innate need to attach aesthetic worth to her journal, which bleeds into other aspects of her life.

Or maybe, she is just someone who really likes pink.

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The Mirror That Lies

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Every night I face this entity alone. Just like us, it has a pulse and breath. Every tick is a heartbeat; every move up or down is a breath. Money moves from trader to trader like blood. Despite a long day, I stayed focused on my laptop in my hall room. No distractions, pen and paper at hand. Not just any paper but a tool. The market opened, I watched and "listened" to every pulse and breath. With steady fingers I clicked buy. My pen glided along the lines of the journal gently and orderly with statements like: "I am feeling calm and collected" and "I was waiting patiently for confirmation". The words were like soldiers in neat files and brimming with confidence. The emotions were locked into the trading journal.

Hours later, my phone was a desk bell in a busy restaurant. I checked my notifications and my hands went cold. The headline read, "3.15 trillion wiped out from the gold and silver market". Green candles from earlier swallowed by a monstrous red candle. My profit evaporated. Other traders' screams flooded the telegram chat: "Cutting my losses" and "dump it!". I hovered my cursor over my position and exited early.

I checked the charts again. My heart skipped a beat. The monstrous red was stabbed straight through by green, like an emerald staircase out of hell. As I journaled, my pen dug deeper. The ink flowed like an open wound. Every word leaning like it wanted to escape the journal, like how I wanted to with the trade. Lengthy sentences with strikes and carets took over. The use of "I" vanished: "Checked my trade. Cut my losses" and words that were not mine "cut" and "dumped" and vocabulary like "itchy hands". My chest loosened and I sat back.

After observing my writing, I realised that I deceived myself to protect my identity. Initially, I was highly confident. Neat handwriting, complete sentences and ownership of ideas using "I". However, after closing the trade, my handwriting was messy, wordy, grammatically incorrect, and lacked ownership. I stopped using "I" and sentences were longer as seen in the sentence: "Cut my losses out of fear and..". I was not writing in my thoughts when using social media jargon like "dumped". I was protecting my identity by using words like "itchy hands" to blame being tempted by my phone instead of blaming myself. Details like what made me fearful were missing. I have exited early before. But here, I was actively avoiding my mistakes.

A trading journal helps you become more self-aware and avoid repeating mistakes. Instead, journaling helped me excuse my mistakes. It reflected my fear of being wrong and was an escape for me, resulting in my question: How can a tool for self-reflection also be a tool for self-deception?

Coval, Hirshleifer and Teoh (2005), professors from Harvard Business School and University of California, argue that self-deception significantly shapes investor behaviours in capital markets. Psychological research shows that many investors are consistently overconfident in believing that their knowledge is highly accurate and are resistant to changing biases.

Furthermore, these investors overestimate their abilities and take credit for wins while blaming failures on anything but themselves. They further link self-deception to deception by others, by arguing that "firms and financial institutions can exploit these investors in a predatory fashion" (p. 113). Managers intentionally time stock sales and share compelling stories with investors. They conclude that self-deception significantly shapes investor behaviours in capital markets.

This is exactly how a self-reflection tool turns into a self-deception tool. If investors are already self-deceived, the same will reflect in their journals. Their journals capture beliefs, not reality. Upon seeing the X post and Telegram messages, I exited early. I was protecting my identity by using words like "itchy hands" to blame being tempted by my phone instead of blaming myself. The use of "I" was omitted and details like what made me fearful were missing. However, Coval et al. (2005) assume that self-deception is something inherently brought to the markets and that being aware of it can stop it. However, my journal shows that self-deception also builds up with every loss. For every loss I journal, I write in a rush, messy handwriting, borrow words from others, and avoid my mistakes. Over time, my journal builds up self-deception, until the lies start to feel natural.

Coval et al. describe the consequences of self-deception. However, they do not explain why investors are overconfident in the first place. This is where Professor and psychologist Harry Triandis from the University of Illinois comes in. He explains the mechanism behind this self-deception.

Triandis (2013) explains self-deception as a human phenomenon. He defines self-deception as one seeing "the world the way they would like to rather than the way it is" (p. 1069). He explains a framework that provides an understanding of self-deception as the ratio of "inside information" to "outside information" we interpret to form reality. Inside information consists of emotions. Outside information refer to environmental conditions. He argues that when most of the information comes from "inside", there is a high probability of self-deception taking place, similar to Buddha's insight of "Where self is, truth is not; where truth is, self is not" (p. 1069). He suggests that self-deception exists on a spectrum and acts as a form of protection. His conclusion is that self-deception is a natural tendency and either too much or too little of it becomes problematic.

However, my journal suggests otherwise. I was deceived by "outside" and not "inside" information. It was outside information like the X posts, that influenced me to close my trade. Triandis's framework would frame my fear as "inside" information that led me to selling my position, which I do not find to be true. The reality of trading is that outside and inside information are interrelated. Market news will evoke emotions. Triandis's framework is hypothetical in nature and just does not accurately capture the reality of trading in which the lines between "inside" and "outside" information blurs. Hence, in trading, self-deception is not just an imbalance that can be fixed.

While Coval et al. (2005) argue that self-deception in the market is exhibited through overconfident investors which firms then exploit, Triandis (2013) furthers this by explaining how self-deception originates. The exploitation Coval et al describe is the very mechanism Triandis explains: that self-deception thrives when "outside" information like news dominates "inside" information like feelings. I was deceived by external factors, not just internal ones. However, my journal identifies an issue that neither address. Self-deception is not just a market vulnerability or lack of knowledge but rather a recurring and reinforcing issue.

Neither Coval et al. (2005) nor Triandis (2013) consider how being aware of self-deception does not spontaneously bring about change. Even after analysing my journal and identifying the self-deception, I found myself repeating it perhaps because acknowledging the self-deception in writing feels like an attack on my ego, making me want to avoid my mistakes rather than confront them. Although I caught it this time and cancelled it out, it made me wonder whether simply being aware is a sign of progress or yet again a more complicated form of self-deception. Am I once again creating a feeling of learning? The same feeling I felt when I first started journaling, or is it different this time?

Self-deception is a recurring mechanism in which I absorb outside information like Telegram's voice and others' opinions and write it into my journal as if it were my own reflections. The act of writing gives me a feeling that I am being honest with myself. However, I later realise I am doing the opposite. This realisation gives me a feeling of growth and learning. Yet, I find myself making the same mistake the very next day. This habit runs deep. Self-deception in itself is not curable from awareness especially when I have to admit financial losses to myself which make it feel like a personal failure. The journal that was meant to hold me accountable instead becomes a reminder of my losses which only makes me want to hide the truth the next time I journal. My "inside" voice is always shaped by "outside" information. My "honest" reflection is just self-deception disguised as self-awareness. The journal makes the loop visible but does not stop it. While the journal reveals my hidden patterns, it also allows self-deception to hide better by making the feeling of realisation and growth indistinguishable.

The implication for trading is that I am not breaking the cycle of self-deception but instead rehearsing it each time. The duality of the journal is that it participates in both self-knowledge and self-deception. I did not expect my own tool for truth to turn into a mirror that lies back at me. A horror I had not anticipated. Part of me wants to abandon the journal because it feels like a trap. Another part knows that without it, I would have not realised I was being trapped. I am caught between using and doubting it.

So why should I still keep my journal? It evidently does not cure me as I still use it to deceive myself, but it makes my invisible patterns visible, thereby, once again, seemingly becoming a tool for reflection. I keep it because without it, I would not have realised I am repeating this cycle in the first place. However, visibility alone does not break the cycle because the issue lies much deeper in my ingrained habits and ego, the very part of me that the journal's visibility threatens. Visibility is the ground on which I can improve, even if improvement is not guaranteed. The uncertainty is not failure but rather an unavoidable trade-off for asking a deceptive mind to be honest.

I started journaling to face the enemies of the market. Instead, I realised that I am my own enemy. The greatest deception is not the lies we are told, but the ones we write to ourselves. How can pages of a notebook hold so much significance? My own words stop being data and instead turn into reflections, like a hall of mirrors. I know I am trapped in reflections, but I have yet to find a way out.

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The Cost of Charity

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It is lunchtime, and the food court is densely packed. Amidst the drowning buzz of noise, I notice a figure moving through the crowd. He is old. He hobbles into view, leaning on a worn wooden cane. A red plastic bag packed to the brim with tissue packets hangs from his bony arm. His shirt, loose from years of wear, hangs from his bony frame. He moves in short, careful steps. At each table, he pauses. From afar, I watch his lips part. I cannot hear him over the noise, but the ritual is familiar to me, for I have grown up passing by people like him in hawker centres and HDB walkways. "Please, 3 packets, 1 dollar."

As he shuffled forwards, something shifted in the air. Eyes that were once focused on platters of grilled satay and steaming bowls of laksa darted sideways, stealing glances at him. The surrounding tables seemed acutely aware of the old man's presence, yet no one attempted to draw his attention. He stopped at each table and repeated his pitch. Some diners whipped out a $2 note and swiftly grabbed the tissue packets in a rehearsed manner. Others dismissed him with a curt wave of their hands, their gaze fixed on their phones, food, somewhere; anywhere that is not him.

A woman reached into her purse and pulled out a $5 note. Before he could speak, she thrust it into his hands, flashed a practiced smile, and returned to her food. He tries to offer her the tissue packets – the product which she had purchased – but she shakes her head wordlessly, avoiding his eyes. He hesitates, retracts his product and moves on. Money had changed hands, yet no product was moved.

The scene sat with me long after the man had disappeared from my view. What the woman had done was generous, yet the exchange felt off. It was not about her mannerisms, nor was it about the quantity of money she had given him. It was the position which her giving had placed him in. She had given charity to a man who had come to sell, effectively stripping him of his original identity. The interaction had changed from a reciprocal exchange to a one-sided gift. What troubles me is how the act of giving, although seemingly benevolent, can conversely reduce and objectify its recipient. I thus questioned: why does charity undermine the dignity of its recipients?

Cameron Parsell and Andrew Clarke (2022) argue that receiving charity is a deeply shaming experience for those in poverty. This shame comes not only from the acts of volunteers, but from "the meaning they ascribed to their position as passive recipients" (Parsell & Clarke, 2022, p. 448). They feel shame not only from being poor, but from their position as those who receive without giving. Parsell and Clarke (2022) show that the shame in receiving charity stems from the assumption that the recipient has nothing of value to offer in return. By refusing the tissue paper, the woman implied just that: that the man's labour was a facade for his need. However, unlike the institutional settings that Parsell and Clarke (2022) describe where the roles of the giver and recipient are pre-

established, the food court allowed the peddler to position himself as a seller. Yet, the woman actively chose to give the peddler money and reject his goods. She overrode his chosen identity, projecting the assumption of need, the victim identity, onto him. This suggests that the shame described runs deeper than the mere act of receiving. It is produced by the power the givers hold to impose an identity onto their recipients.

In the first place perhaps, we should ask what motivates us to perform such acts of charity. George Loewenstein and Deborah A. Small (2007) offer their opinion by positing that the act of charitable giving comes from "sympathy" and "deliberation", two different mental processes. "Sympathy" is an emotional, affective reaction, while "deliberation" is a rational, analytic thought process. When confronted with a situation, sympathy acts first, which then affects and alters subsequent deliberation. The visual, physical indication of a suffering individual is enough to activate the urge for aid, before any deliberate assessment of whether the person wants or needs any help (Loewenstein & Small, 2007). Once sympathy is activated, it can distort reasoning, "leading one to the conclusion that a particular undeserving target of aid is in fact deserving of aid" (Loewenstein & Small, 2007, p. 114). The woman was motivated by visual markers of his poverty: his skin, his cane, his faded shirt. Her "sympathy", on recognising him as an identifiable victim, overrode her "deliberation", which would have told her that the peddler was in fact a vendor conducting a transaction. Her $5 and refusal of the tissue paper were not a rational judgement, but rather her emotions altering her reading of the situation, leading her to conclude that he needed rescue, not a customer. Hence, the transaction was never between two people. It was between the woman and her own emotions, and the peddler was simply the trigger for it.

While Parsell and Clarke (2022) show that charity, or rather the position of receiving without giving back, can give rise to shame from the recipient's point of view, Loewenstein and Small (2007) present the giver's actions as a product of impulsive sympathy. When read together, the two authors' arguments suggest that shame is embedded within the mechanism of charity. "Sympathy", according to Loewenstein and Small (2007), is triggered solely on visual identification of the sufferer without an understanding of what they really need. Giving is hence an emotional impulse which responds not to the person before them, but rather to the image of their suffering. In doing so, the recipient is stripped of his identity and becomes a mere object of suffering. This reduction of person to image is exactly what Parsell and Clarke (2022) identify as the cause for shame. Therefore, the two texts reveal the cause and effect: the impulse that drives the giver to give is the same mechanism that constructs the shame of the recipient.

Loewenstein and Small's (2007) definition of "sympathy" captures only the giver's initial impulse. However, when a giver never engages with the person before them, but only with the spectacle of their suffering, this is no longer "sympathy", but pity. Unlike "sympathy", which tries to understand and acknowledge another's suffering, pity thrives on the maintenance of distance. The pitier must perceive themselves as being above the recipient, and to sustain that position, pity requires its object to remain pitiful (Arendt, 1963/2006). The recipients are thus required to remain visibly pitiful, and this only serves to reinforce shame in them. Due to the impulse to give being triggered by the spectacle of suffering, pity becomes the *de facto* engine of charity.

This results in a self-perpetuating cycle. Modern charity is fuelled by pity, and the only people it can respond to are those who remain pitiful. The

unspoken rule of charity thus becomes: to obtain help, one must appear in a manner that stimulates pity, looking tragic and powerless. Those who mask their suffering appear insufficiently tragic, and render themselves ineligible for aid. On being offered the $5, the tissue paper peddler appeared to have two options: to reject the donation and retain his dignity, or to accept the money and surrender his agency. Realistically, there was only one option. To refuse the money would have been to refuse income he could not afford to lose. Dignity, here, then becomes a privilege; one that he cannot afford. Here lies the perverse nature of charity: it does not merely shame those who accept it, but actively punishes those who resist it. Charity is dependent on the degradation of its recipient, and the recipient's poverty ensures that they cannot refuse it. The recipients are compelled to conform to a display of pitifulness in order to access help. In doing so, charity undermines the very dignity of the people it claims to help.

Charity here is thus a paradox: a hand extended to help simultaneously pushes the recipient further down as a "pitiful" victim, as if the cost of survival is the surrender of the self. I cannot know for certain what the peddler felt as he retracted his tissue packets, only that I could feel an unmistakable sense of discomfort from the gift that could not be refused. This is the outcome of charity as long as pity remains its engine.

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Shifting, but Whole: How a System Stays Itself

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To my right, stood a statue of Mother Mary, looking down serenely at Baby Jesus on her lap. Overhead, a quote from the Bible wished all who enter peace. In the distance, a resounding ringing of bells signalled the start of Mass. It was an archetypal scene found in a Catholic Church.

Walking into the Church foyer, a curious unfamiliar red shape entered my peripheral vision. A red bulbous ornament hung from the ceiling, yellow tassels adorning its bottom. Mandarin characters embroidered in gold thread decorated the front, spelling out messages of prosperity. It was a Lunar New Year lantern. Parishioners began streaming into the main building, some accompanied by little bags filled with two round, juicy-looking citruses — a phenomenon later explained by the announcement of a blessing of Mandarin oranges.

The glaring red and orange stuck out against the muted colours of the wooden, earthy tones of the rest of the Church. The space resists easy categorisation. It is recognisably a Church, yet layered with elements that do not conventionally belong. Looking around, there were plenty more anomalies for a traditional Church — a credit card machine accepting e-donations, television screens displaying the weekly Gospel reading, even the Church building itself has a boxy, glass-filled architecture resembling modern corporate offices.

These appear to be markers of the Church's inculturation into Singaporean society; the modern Church takes on many shapes and forms all while retaining its traditional sacraments. Yet there was something ironic about the varying — almost contrasting — elements colliding in the same space, coming together to form one system. In the past, one would not expect to see East Asian traditions in a historically Middle Eastern Church, nor digital screens displaying millenia-old prayers. It seems to reflect a greater pattern in our increasingly interconnected world, where new connections bring together elements in ways they previously did not, a pattern that may continue well into the future.

Many unforeseen elements collide in our world while continuing to function as one cohesive system. Elements of various origins, bearing different, sometimes clashing values; values one would not expect would be able to harmonise. These systems often adapt in ways that shift their manifestations based on context, yet maintain their core, allowing them to remain coherent. At the same time, when too many elements change, when adaptation often comes in the form of compromise, we would expect the system to lose coherence or collapse altogether. All of this led me to ponder: How do changing elements of a system amalgamate without jeopardising the integrity of the system?

To explore how systems maintain coherence despite change, Luhmann's concept of autopoiesis provides a

useful lens. Autopoiesis, in the biological sense, refers to the fundamental ability of living systems to maintain themselves through self-reproduction, where elements within the system interact to regenerate the same system that produced them, thus ensuring continuity. Luhmann (2008) extrapolates autopoiesis to a social context, suggesting that much like living biological systems, social systems are themselves autopoietic, with communication being the fundamental component. Social systems are thus recursively closed systems with respect to communication, able to maintain and renew themselves by producing new forms of communication, by building on previous chains of communication. Extrapolating further, regeneration, of communication or otherwise, is thus an inherent aspect of the self-production of any autopoietic system. Far from disrupting the system, each regeneration contributes to its renewal.

This regeneration of elements requires a sense of 'dying' of the past elements for new 'life' to be created, suggesting that it is not by constant continuity that a system is preserved, but rather by its ability to change and maintain itself as it changes. Thus, continuity lies not in preserving the same elements, but in preserving the process that allows elements to be replaced. What remains stable is not the form, but the system's capacity to regenerate its own structures through ongoing interaction. As such, change is not external to the system's stability, but is the very mechanism through which stability is produced. In the context of the Church as an autopoietic social system, it is precisely the iterative communication between parishioners over the years, building on past exchanges such as cultural discourse, that regenerates the communication which maintains the Church, allowing it to stay relevant amidst changing times. Put in this manner, perhaps change is not an aggressor threatening a system's integrity, but rather an essential part of the system's maintenance.

However, this introduces a further problem: Not all change can be treated as valid regeneration. For a system to remain coherent, there must be some form of internal criteria that determines what belongs within it and what does not. Without such an anchor, any change could be absorbed into the system, making the idea of continuity meaningless.

In exploring what constitutes this anchor within systems, Meadows' systems theory provides valuable insights. Meadows (2009) defines a system as something consisting of elements, interconnections, and functions. A key component of her theory posits that systems are held together by the interactions between their elements. A system's function, arising from patterns of said interactions, is the crucial determinant of the system's behaviour, as opposed to individual elements themselves. In this way, changing elements have a negligible effect on the system, so long as the new elements interact in ways that replicate the function of the original system. As such, a system's coherence is not anchored by the permanence of its individuals, but by the consistency of its behaviour, which emerges from the interconnections between its elements. Provided that these interactions continue to produce the same underlying behaviour, the system may undergo surface-level adaptations without compromising its integrity.

This can be observed in the case of the Church, whose purpose may be deduced as a place of worship from the behaviour of its elements — the parishioners — in how they participate in sacraments within the Church. Any adaptations the Church undergoes, including the addition of lanterns and television screens, would then have a negligible effect on the integrity of the Church, so long as it maintains its baseline function as a place of worship. Simply put, this perspective places a

greater emphasis on interconnections and how they contribute to a system's function, in maintaining a system's coherence. In this sense, elements can change or be replaced and still remain in the system, insofar as they continue to behave in ways that contribute to the system's defining function, and the maintenance of this function further maintains the system's coherence.

Ultimately, both authors' perspectives point to how change is an inevitable reality that systems will encounter at some point. For Luhmann (2008), change is integral to a system's self-maintenance, as systems continuously reproduce themselves through ongoing processes of adaptation. In contrast, Meadows (2009) places less emphasis on the transformation of individual elements, arguing instead that a system's coherence lies in the stability of the interconnections that sustain its function. Both perspectives move away from viewing change as inherently destructive, challenging my earlier notion of change as an aggressor that erodes the integrity of a system. However, they do so through distinct conceptual lenses, reflecting a convergence emerging from different underlying assumptions about how systems persist over time. This inquiry left me with a much more flexible understanding of systems; Perhaps change is not external to system, but is instead absorbed into the system, becoming a part of its 'life cycle'. Or at the very least, a system is not the rigid structure I previously imagined, but rather an ever-growing collection of elements with room to adapt and bloom whilst maintaining integrity.

Still, I pondered one last point: If change is not the destructive force it is often perceived to be, what, then, causes the resistance towards change, and what influences a greater resistance to some types of change more than others?

A possible explanation lies in the role of authority within a system. While change may introduce uncertainty about whether a system's function will be preserved, changes done by a recognised authority may signal continuity rather than disruption. This authority shapes how the change is interpreted by determining whether existing patterns of interaction — and thus the system's function — are preserved, aligning with Meadow's emphasis on the primacy of interconnections in maintaining coherence. With the function maintained, this change would then be able to contribute to the self-renewal of the system, aligning with Luhmann's focus on autopoiesis and self-maintenance.

A key element of this lies in trust — the authority would need to gain the trust of members within the system to be perceived to understand the system's behaviour enough to conserve its integrity, so as to allay the concerns of change as an aggressor. To give an example, the fact that clergymen placed the lanterns and television screens certainly played a big role in assuring me the changes were negligible to the function of the Church, a reaction I doubt would arise had a random person modified the Church without permission. This trust often comes from the authority's belonging to the system, alongside the interactions between the authority and elements of the system that breed mutual trust over time.

Perhaps, beyond a passive event encountered by all systems, change can also be an active event catalysed by the system's own elements. It is when this change is able to maintain the recursive closed nature of the system, helmed by a trusted authoritative element that knows how to best conserve the system's function, that the integrity of the system remains intact.

At the end of the day, I still had Mass to attend. I straightened out my cheongsam, tidied my crucifix necklace, and walked into the main Church, my bag of oranges in hand ready to be blessed.

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The Guilt of Nothing

The Forgotten Language of Rest

By Poh Hong Kai

Bachelor of Engineering in Environmental Engineering

"Pa, I'm going for a run!", preceded the clank of the iron gate. The break of dusk streaked brilliant hues of orange over the vast canvas of blue. Meandering through the brutalist cityscape governed by sharp planes and edges, I wound my way to the Kallang Park Connector. Towering sentinels of green lined the asphalt path, tracing the river. Sunlight dripped through the canopy, pooling on the ground beneath. The rustle of leaves, the chirr of crickets, composed nature's symphony. Flanked by flora and fauna, even just for a moment, the city exhaled.

Yet within this concerto, a jarring cadence pierced through. Runners graced the path, their skin a glossy patina of effort, glistening with sweat. They came in ones and twos, appearing fresh off the desks of their 9-to-5s. Slowing their strides, glancing at their devices, before pushing ahead with renewed force. There was no competition, no prize at the end, only the quiet compulsion to deliver performance; their pace, their distance, their splits, again and again and again. The park connector, designed as a reprieve from the rat race, had come to resemble a production floor. Running, once playful, instinctive and freeing, had taken on the shape of to-dos and deliverables, where the compulsion of meeting targets and tracking progress overshadowed the purpose of running as a hobby in the first place. Faces flushed with colour, breaths ragged. I watched them frown and chase their next breath. This made me wonder, was this really their rest time?

Consider how strange this is. Rest, in its most ancient sense, needs no justification. Animals sleep after a long hunt, children take naps after playing without a care. For most of human history, a walk in the park was simply that. To slow down and breathe was instinctual and unquestioned. Yet somewhere in the cogs of modern productivity, rest has been redefined into a metric, simply another task after work. The runner who logged their 5km outside of work has completed their leisure, while the runner who stayed home has accomplished nothing even though, in truth, both were equally at rest. When rest must be productive and visible to be legitimised, rest does not merely become harder; it distances us from genuine recovery. In an era shaped by mental wellness and the importance of good rest, how has productivity culture and comparison redefined and governed the way we rest?

In "When Winning Costs Your Peace," Cheng et al. (2025) explain why people feel guilty or anxious during rest. Coining the term, "rest intolerance," defined as "feelings of guilt, anxiety or discomfort that individuals experience during periods of rest or recreational pursuit" (Cheng et al., 2025, p. 2), they link this to "vertical individualism," characterised by "a strong motivation for personal achievement, competition and gaining status." In a culture built around competition and comparison, staying stagnant is deemed as already falling behind. Driven by "status anxiety," the pressure to conform to societal standards of success,

individuals internalise these competitive norms until rest itself becomes another point of comparison. Cheng et al. (2025) find that reduced engagement with conventionally "unproductive" activities is linked to lower well-being, which suggests that "rest intolerance" redefines rest from a biological need into another metric and deliverable.

However, Cheng et al. (2025) fail to acknowledge the greater economic pressures that validate vertical individualism. When productivity becomes the main way we measure value, every hour comes with opportunity costs, and rest starts to resemble a "zero-sum", where one's rest is set as a loss against other's gain . In market-driven economies, this perceived inactivity could cost someone their job security, and without a socio-economic safety net that protects time for rest, this "rest intolerance" only deepens. In a city like Singapore where the breakneck pace of life rarely pauses for anyone, resting too long can feel less like a choice, and more like a luxury few can afford.

In a similar vein, Bellezza et al. (2017) argue that busyness itself has become the new status symbol. They show that a busy calendar has become the new social marker of prestige and competency, reflecting "the perceptions that a busy person possesses desired human capital characteristics like competence and ambition and is scarce and in demand in the job market" (Bellezza et al., 2017, p. 1). These perceptions, they note, are especially present within "knowledge-intensive economies," where value comes less from physical labour or resources than from expertise, time and attention, making busyness itself a visible substitute for human capital. Busier individuals are seen as scarcer and more desirable, while a person who admits to being "freer" is deemed as undesirable. The conflation of busyness with status redefines rest as something visually shameful, distancing us from genuine rest and forcing our leisure into traditionally "productive" moulds. This is especially relevant to Singapore, where manual labour and natural resources are limited and expertise and human capital are prized above all else, meaning that almost everyone here, knowingly or not, trades in this same currency of busyness.

Read together, Cheng et al. (2025) and Bellezza et al. (2017) share parallels in describing rest as psychologically costly and driven by comparison. Cheng et al. (2025) describe this as "rest intolerance," while Bellezza et al. (2017) link it to the perception of busyness as the modern social marker of productivity, where projecting rest and free time is associated with undesirable qualities. Both settle on the notion that social convention and comparison have made rest and leisure appear guilty and shameful.

Whilst similar, they differ in perspective. Cheng et al. (2025) focus on the internal mechanisms of guilt, framing it as psychological. They show that competitive values make individuals feel "guilt, anxiety and discomfort during periods of rest" (Cheng et al., 2025). This process occurs in private, shaped by internalised values and status anxiety rather than by external pressure alone. In Bellezza et al. (2017), however, status signalling and guilt come through the outward performance of busyness. Busyness, as a social marker, is consciously displayed and acts as a visible measure of desirable working traits. This mechanism works externally and depends on the gaze of others, where perception itself becomes pressure. Status anxiety underlines both accounts, playing a different role in each. For Cheng et al. (2025), it deepens an intolerance towards rest that already exists. For Bellezza et al. (2017), it is closer to the root cause, the very impulse that drives people to perform busyness in the first place.

Despite their deep analysis into the psychological costs of rest, both papers fail to truly address the intrinsic value of rest itself. Cheng et al. (2025)

acknowledge that "sufficient leisure time contributes positively to psychological and physical well-being," while Bellezza et al. (2017) mention leisure as a positive marker of life. Yet in both cases, the value of rest is invoked only through the absence of productivity. Both papers ultimately justify rest through utility rather than substantiating its intrinsic worth. This conceptual limitation extends beyond a methodological gap and becomes embedded within the tone of the articles themselves. By framing rest entirely within the language of productivity and quantifiables, the interventions they produce become equally narrow and constrained.

Evidently, Cheng et al. (2025) recommend cognitive interventions to help individuals "redefine leisure as a form of self-care and a vital component to success." By operating within these constraints, they unintentionally allow productivity culture to seep through, justifying and measuring rest by its utility rather than its intangible worth. Bellezza et al. (2017) commit a similar mistake by quantifying rest as "scarce time" isolated from work and revolving around the managerial implications of this scarcity. The proposed solution to time scarcity therefore becomes optimisation rather than genuine rest, revealing just how deeply embedded productivity culture has become.

Recall the last time somebody asked you about your week. How did you respond? Perhaps you spoke about picking up a new skill, completing assignments, or making progress at work. The cogs of productivity have structurally gentrified the way we think. Perhaps what is missing is not yet another framework to optimise rest, but an entirely different language for it altogether, one that does not need to borrow its authority from productivity to be considered worthwhile, where the value of genuine rest is appreciated and glorified at the same level as output. We have been conditioned into machines where every input must have an output: every story a moral, every action a reaction. But does genuine rest owe itself an answer? We have misplaced something that no modern framework fully accounts for: the simple yet radical act of taking time off and achieving nothing.

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Are We Living or Just Performing?

By Mikael Ernest Susanto

Bachelor of Computing (Hons) in Computer Science

"There are still parts of her present in every heartbeat."

The line was delivered over a rich instrumental ensemble, building up from a tense chord progression into a bright, sweeping release. I watched, captivated by the spectacle of this year's Indonesian Cultural Night's musical put up by the Community of Indonesians in NTU. Watching Wawan, my interviewee, embody his character so perfectly on stage was surreal. We applauded the performers' ability to slip into a new skin, project emotions that were not theirs, and captivate an auditorium full of strangers. But Wawan's act did not end when the spotlight dimmed and the curtains closed.

Wawan is, after all, just another international student here in Singapore. Like many of us, his social life is split into two distinct, uneven parts. When he opened his phone during our interview, the divide became clear. WhatsApp is used with his Indonesian friends whom he has deep, comfortable conversations with; Telegram enables him to contact his Singaporean and other international friends from his co-curricular activities, but he only interacts with them on a superficial level. He uses different apps simply out of cultural habit as Indonesians default to WhatsApp, while his non-Indonesian peers prefer Telegram.

During our conversation, Wawan admitted that switching from Bahasa to English means switching on his "performative" side, trying on different personalities to see what "survives best in a Singaporean classroom". But since he does not share an overlapping circle of mutual friends with his local peers, he can experiment and be bolder while hiding his authentic self. Although this allows him to be more confident, it ultimately traps him in conversations that feel stuck on "default settings", like reading off a script based on previous shallow interactions. The walls hiding his real personality inadvertently block him from truly building deep connections outside our cultural circle.

Listening to him, I could not help but notice that for many of us in the Indonesian community at NTU, the acting does not stop when we leave the stage. We simply switch scripts, swapping our personalities when interacting with others who do not speak our language.

This realisation left me pondering why we subconsciously hide our "true self" from the outside world, even when it is perfectly acceptable. Maybe code-switching has compartmentalised our lives until we are unsure which displayed version is truly us. We perform confidence. We perform interest. We perform to integrate a boldness that might even surprise ourselves, yet deep down, we question whether we are wearing an ill-fitting costume. Ultimately, I wonder: how does the performative habit that international students take on when they are with others affect their sense of identity?

Dr. Dale Whelehan (2025), in his *Time* essay, argues that the modern obsession with "being real" has

ironically twisted authenticity into yet another performance. Opening with Marilyn Monroe's experience of shifting to her public persona, he illustrates how putting on a mask to be socially accepted over time solidifies into the only acceptable version of the "self" (Whelehan, 2025). Drawing from Erving Goffman's theory of social performance and Donald Winnicott's psychoanalytic concept of the "False Self", Whelehan (2025) explains how individuals initially create a socially acceptable self-version that gradually becomes internalised as their "real" selves (Goffman as cited in Whelehan, 2025). He links this to modern environments like the workspace and social media, which theoretically encourage genuine selves but actually punish those who disrupt the status quo (Whelehan, 2025). Referencing a 2023 study by Coutts et al., Whelehan (2025) explains that a lower self-concept clarity is associated with anxiety, depression, loneliness, and unsatisfying relationships. As he puts it, "the more we strive to be real, the more we perform; and in proving our authenticity, we lose sight of who we truly are" (Whelehan, 2025, para. 8).

Whelehan (2025) presents a compelling argument about the psychological harm of shifting personas. His explanation of how constant performance confuses one's sense of self deeply resonates with the struggle for identity. However, his focus overlooks the difficulties faced by foreigners trying to fit into a new culture, such as language barriers and unfamiliar social norms. This adds an extra layer of complexity: international students might genuinely aim to show their true selves, but due to these differences, their "identities" are wrongly translated as a curated personality. I see this exact dynamic play out with Wawan. To survive the cultural gap with local peers, he defaults to a rehearsed, agreeable script, suppressing his expressive personality because translating his true self feels too socially risky. If this masking becomes our default mode of integration over time, does it mean that our authentic identity might become inaccessible, even to us?

Clinical psychology offers another lens on this identity struggle. In a 2025 *TEDx* talk, Mickell Dent, a licensed clinical therapist, shares her lived emotional toll of the compartmentalisation of self. Dent (2025) explains that personality masking is a survival tactic created by social pressures, but it often becomes automatic. Speaking from experience as one who comes from a marginalised background, she explains that wearing a "mask of strength" was necessary, and she observed her mother put on that mask to hide their poverty (Dent, 2025, 2:52). She widens the scope to reveal the masks of others, whether it is a tennis star hiding anxiety, or someone smiling to conceal their inner sadness (Dent, 2025). "We all wear masks, often without realising or accepting it," (6:56) Dent (2025) says, discussing the hidden costs of forgetting to unmask, such as the gradual development of an identity crisis due to this habit. Additionally, Dent (2025) outlines actionable steps, like practicing mindfulness, or joining supportive communities to safely unmask. She argues that shedding these personas can help overcome the identity crisis and build genuine connections.

Dent (2025) presents the performative persona as a survival mechanism when perceiving a social threat. This approach better explains the mask put on by international students, not just to construct a good image, but as an automatic reflex to avoid cultural exclusion and judgment. However, Dent's (2025) proposed solution of finding supportive communities is too idealised for international students. If their only truly "safe" place to unmask is with a community that speaks their native language and shares familiar social norms, how can they realistically practise unmasking in the broader university context?

Through Whelehan's (2025) theories regarding social performance and the "false self", we can understand Dent's (2025) examples of masking as lived consequences of this social conditioning. After prolonged method acting, it is not unreasonable that a character's stage personality seeps into the actor. Similarly, Dent's (2025) experiential narration complements Whelehan's (2025) explanation of the psychological toll of constantly performing, such as losing sight of who we truly are or developing an identity crisis. Their insights offer a highly convincing explanation for the impacts of this constant masking on our sense of identity. Yet, I remain unconvinced that these outcomes are the only effects of people's performative habits. Both Whelehan (2025) and Dent (2025) view the "mask" and "true self" as mutually exclusive, overlooking the potential for evolution in one's identity. They ignore the possibility of individuals taking on that performative personality as their "new" true self or adopting aspects from it into their genuine self. I argue that our performative habits do not erase our authenticity; rather, they allow our sense of identity to safely evolve, helping us accept that our "true self" is inherently adaptable.

Humans grow and personalities change, so is it possible for us to begin liking our masks and to develop a new genuine state of self? The answer is yes. During our conversation, Wawan showed great comfort with the persona he has developed as an international student, and trying these new personalities has allowed him to grow. Hence, by treating this performative space as a low-stakes sandbox, we can safely test out bolder traits that might eventually become a real part of our evolving identity. Generalising the performance habit as a negative one that we must change might consequently lead us to believe that we cannot gain anything from it. In reality, for many international students, this performative adaptation is a necessary and productive bridge to help us discover exactly who we are becoming.

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The Lighthouse the City Forgot

By Law Zen En, Joseph

Bachelor of Engineering in Civil Engineering

Figure 1. Raffles Marina Lighthouse, Singapore

As I awoke to a familiar robotic voice that spoke the words "Tuas Link," I was almost alone.

What had been a full carriage at Jurong East had quietly emptied, stop by stop, until only a handful of us remained. I had expected the solitude. Few people choose to come here on a Saturday morning. But the silence caught me off guard. The silence I am used to in Singapore is the kind you put on: earbuds in on the MRT, noise cancelling at a study spot. Borrowed silence; temporary.

I headed southward, towards the main attraction. Silhouettes of people holding up rectangular objects aided my discovery as I approached the structure.

The Raffles Marina Lighthouse stood at the shoreline, unhurried, consistently flickering every ten seconds. Its slightly dilapidated milky body blended into the overcast horizon, and weary seagulls had settled along its rounded grills like ornaments on a pale Christmas tree. Nobody spoke. Nobody, it seemed, needed to. (see Figure 1)

I could not help but notice that the silence that accompanied my gaze was unlike that in the train. The silence in the train felt temporary, while here it was inherent. It was not filling a gap. It had been here long before we arrived, and it would stay long after we left. Time seemed to come to a standstill, and I felt suspended in tranquillity as I continued to marvel at the glory of the lonely, weathered tower.

Standing there, I caught myself calculating whether I had used the morning well, and whether stillness, on a Saturday, was something I had earned. The thought passed quickly, but it had been there. Looking around at the others, I had the quiet sense that everyone else had felt it too and come anyway. The lighthouse was not demanding anything of us. No optimised pathway through the space. No sign telling you how long to stay.

That observation unsettled me. Everywhere else I had passed through to get here, from the interchange at Jurong East to the arterial roads cutting through the industrial west, to the MRT infrastructure threading the island together with surgical efficiency, space was organised around movement, productivity, and purpose. Every square metre was accounted for. Every pathway was optimised. The lighthouse was an exception: obsolete, underused, making no economic argument for its own existence. And yet people had made a deliberate, inconvenient journey to find it. What that suggested was not sentimental. It suggested that something the city has been built to optimise for is also something the city has quietly designed out of daily life. The question this raises is not simply one of architecture or planning, but of human cost: Has Singapore's pursuit of urban efficiency compromised its city dwellers' need for restoration?

The data suggests the compromise is neither minor nor abstract. A 2023 study by Duke-NUS Medical School and the Institute of Mental Health, reported by Zachariah in *The Straits Times*, found that anxiety and depression could be costing Singapore nearly $16 billion annually, roughly 2.9% of GDP, through absenteeism, reduced productivity, and healthcare expenditure. Those affected missed an average of 17.7 additional working days per year and were 40% less productive at work. A former social media manager named Ms Debra Low described feeling like her mind was "in a fog" and that she was "a burden to the team" (Zachariah, 2023), words that speak not only to clinical suffering, but to something more specifically Singaporean: the shame of being unproductive.

Zachariah's (2023) data establishes that the absence of restoration is not a private inconvenience. It is a systemic cost, measured in working days lost, hospital visits made, and billions drained from the very economy that efficiency was meant to serve. What the data cannot tell us is why. Why, in a city as resourceful and deliberate as Singapore, does this need go so consistently unmet or unacknowledged?

Philosopher Brian O'Connor, writing on idleness in 2018, offers a compelling answer. O'Connor argues that modern society has fused personal worth with productivity so completely that rest no longer feels like a human need; it feels like a moral failure. As he contends, the tightening connection between work and personal identity leads people to believe that "being idle at all is, somehow, the antithesis of freedom" (O'Connor, 2018). We have not simply lost rest. We have been conditioned to distrust our own need for it.

O'Connor writes from a Western philosophical tradition and does not address Singapore directly. There is a fair counterargument: for many people here, working relentlessly is not about identity; it is about survival. People cannot afford to stop, not because they have confused rest with failure, but because the economic stakes are substantial. Still, in

my view, Singapore's national narratives, including meritocracy, self-reliance, and economic vigilance, produce the same effect O'Connor describes. Here, stillness has long been treated as falling behind: something to push through, not something to protect.

Placed alongside each other, Zachariah (2023) and O'Connor (2018) reveal something neither source can show alone. Zachariah locates the problem in people who are unwell, while O'Connor locates it in the culture surrounding everyone. These are fundamentally different diagnoses, yet together, they describe a self-reinforcing cycle. Efficiency culture produces burnout. But because that same culture has made rest feel like failure, people do not seek restoration; they push through, or feel ashamed when they cannot. The cost compounds, and the city, reading the data as a productivity problem rather than a cultural one, responds with more efficiency: faster intervention, quicker return to work. It addresses the symptom while deepening the condition. The compromise, then, is not partial or incidental; it is structural. The only restorative spaces that remain are the ones that escaped the logic, not the ones the city chose to protect. We have not simply lost rest; we have lost the cultural permission to seek it without first proving it serves some larger purpose.

Which brings me back to the lighthouse. The lighthouse was never built to restore anyone. It was designed to warn ships. Its restorative quality was entirely incidental, a byproduct of its obsolescence and its stubborn refusal to be repurposed. In a city where every square metre is accountable to some function, the lighthouse escapes the logic entirely and, in doing so, becomes a restorative space on the island.

The restorative spaces Singapore has are almost never the ones the city planned. They are the ones it forgot to tear down. You cannot build this kind of restoration on a schedule. It needs spaces that are allowed to be inefficient, underused, even forgotten. And Singapore's instinct is to fill every such space with a purpose.

Restoration cannot be planned. It cannot be tendered out, or optimised, or scheduled. It happens in the spaces the city stopped paying attention to, the ones no one got around to redeveloping. That is what the lighthouse is. Nobody designed it to be restorative. It is simply the one corner of the island that is not asking anything of the people who go there.

Whether Singapore will let it stay that way, I do not know. But I do know this: the people who travelled across the island that Saturday morning were not looking for a view. They were looking for somewhere the city was not asking anything of them.

And we cannot afford to keep forgetting we need that kind of space.

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The Six-Digit Greeting: A New Neighbourhood Ritual?

By Low How Yi

Bachelor of Engineering in Materials Science and Engineering with Second Major in Pharmaceutical Engineering

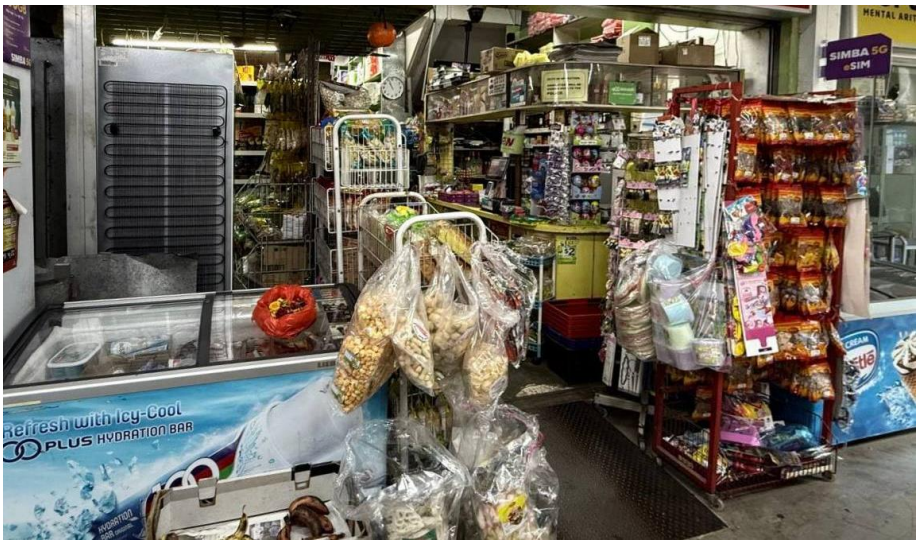

Figure 1: My neighbourhood mama shop in Singapore

The customer's voice flatly spoke: "Boss, collect Shopee parcel. PIN 231402."

This series of digits offered in place of a greeting, cut straight through the drone-like rhythm of dust-coated metal fans. Behind the counter, a shopkeeper unfamiliar to me did not look up to meet the customer's eyes. I waited for the usual reflex – a nod or small sign of recognition, but the shopkeeper's gaze was anchored to the screen as he rapidly keyed in the spoken numbers. This was the new ritual of my neighbourhood mama shop (Fig. 1): a transaction where the exchange was no longer based on a friendly greeting, but a six-digit code.

I watched as the shopkeeper retrieved a bubble-wrapped parcel, tossed carelessly on top of a pile of shipping boxes. A decade ago, this shop was a sanctuary for sugary treats. Today, the colourful jars have vanished, drowned in a monochrome sea of brown cardboard boxes and shipping labels. It felt less like a shop and more like a warehouse. I was not there to be known as a neighbour, but to be verified as a recipient. In this new economy, we do not trust the person across the counter to recognise us, but rather the digital system which validates our codes.

Navigating through the surviving rows of traditional provisions, I was greeted with the sharp sting of chilli powder and the salty scent of dried anchovies. Above, a CCTV lens stared down at me, its wires tangled like old vines in the corner. In a neighbourhood space, one would expect such tight security to be unnecessary if everyone truly knew each other. Yet the presence of these digital systems proved that trust had shifted:

today, it depended less on neighbourly relations and more on surveillance. Ten years ago, I remembered the only "security" here was the shopkeeper's memory of every kid in the block.

"PayNow or PayWave?" The shopkeeper asked hastily as I reached the front counter. I raised my phone where the cold matte screen contrasted sharply against the peeling posters. With a silent swipe, the transaction was over.

A decade ago, this moment was filled with the clink of coins. Even then, a cash purchase did not guarantee friendship, but it did require a physical pause – a shared moment that often invited a nod of recognition or a brief enquiry about my school grades. Now, the digital bridge has closed the distance of payment, replacing even the possibility of mutual acknowledgement with a sterile, automated "success" screen. As I tucked my phone away, the realisation was sharp: digitalisation had removed the friction that once forced us to notice one another.

This efficiency directly erodes the traditional *kampung spirit*, which was once fuelled by a network of neighbourliness where shopkeepers functioned as extended family – subsidising goods for a neighbour facing a tough month or keeping an eye on local children. Today, that organic goodwill is replaced by cold functionality. The modern customer prioritises speed, bypassing conversation to complete a swift and silent errand. Where trust was once built through familiarity and repeated interaction, it now seemed to depend on verification through systems. If our neighbourhood interactions are being mediated by digital systems, how has this reshaped the traditional meaning of trust built through mutual recognition?

This shift is best understood through Christine Boshuijzen-van Burken's (2016) framework of technological mediation. Boshuijzen-van Burken (2016) in "Beyond Technological Mediation: A Normative Practice Approach" explores how technology mediates human actions in the context of the Afghanistan Kunduz Airstrike Incident. She examines how technology reshapes human behaviour through the four main types of mediation: invitation of certain behaviours, amplification and reduction, built-in norms, and interpretation. Boshuijzen-van Burken (2016) argues that technological mediation is never neutral, that "with every amplification, there is a simultaneous and necessary reduction" (p. 182). She illustrates this by using an analogy of a thermal camera detecting temperature, where it leaves out other meaningful qualities such as colour, texture, or size of the material. This process "imposes and removes moral significance", reshaping what we pay attention to and what we value (Boshuijzen-van Burken, 2016, p. 182). Consequently, digital systems simply do not present reality but reconfigures it, narrowing our vision to only recognise certain aspects that are deemed important by the system.

Boshuijzen-van Burken's (2016) research illustrates how technology causes amplification and reduction in our viewing perspective, affecting the way we behave. In the neighbourhood context, digital systems such as PIN-protected parcels, CCTV cameras and automated payment systems amplify efficiency, security, and transactional certainty. We see this reduction manifested in how these technologies reshape the environment: through digital systems, they strip away the physical pauses which involve human contact. Everyday moments which once contributed to trust-building such as casual conversations, small gestures, and the recognition of familiar faces, fall outside of what these digital systems are designed to capture. Ostensibly, technology and small talk are not mutually exclusive , where one could easily chat with a shopkeeper while using their phone. However, digital systems enforce a rigid behaviour centred

entirely on speed. The seamless nature of a digital transaction signals to both the customer and the shopkeeper that the interaction is strictly functional. To pause for small talk now feels like a disruption – an inefficient friction that holds up the queue. By forcing us to prioritise recognising a six-digit code rather than a neighbour's face, these systems cause us to value the efficiency of verification over the depth of a relationship. Through this, technology acts as a filter which reshapes what we notice, value and interpret. This changes our perception of trust from a relational bond between people to a transaction between devices, fundamentally affecting the way we value relationships.

While Boshuijzen-van Burken (2016) explains how technology reshapes individual perception, she overlooks the human agency to resist. Although some individuals may have the capacity to choose small talk over speed, such resistance is often limited as the convenience offered by digital systems encourages us to prioritise efficiency over interpersonal effort. As a result, individual resistance is often outweighed by broader structural norms that reshape human behaviour. This demonstrates that the erosion of neighbourhood solidarity is not a deliberate choice made by individuals, but an inevitable outcome from an environment designed for speed and efficiency. Such conditions foster a shared new expectation where digital systems cause trust to be collectively outsourced onto an institutional level – a systemic pivot that Balázs Bodó (2020) conceptualises as the rise of mediated trust.

Bodó (2020) explores how digital systems act as trust mediating services on an institutional level. Unlike interpersonal trust which relies on the inherent character of a person, institutional trust is fostered through rigid "sets of rules, supervisory and enforcement mechanisms" (Bodó, 2020, p. 2675). In this framework, trust is redefined as a reliance on software and security rather than a "social life that enables humans to cooperate despite inherent uncertainties and risks" (p. 2674). Through prioritising systemic efficiency over interpersonal interactions, technology-mediated systems remove the human element from the trust process altogether. When the system provides total certainty, the traditional work of trust through building relationships becomes redundant.

In a neighbourhood setting, this shift is particularly evident. What was once sustained by the *kampung spirit,* where trust was rooted in familiarity, proximity and daily interaction, is increasingly being mediated by digital systems. For instance, CCTV cameras do more than just enhance security where it transforms how trust is organised in society. Instead of relying on a neighbour's character or a sense of mutual accountability, neighbourhoods increasingly depend on surveillance as a preventive measure. As Bodó (2020) notes, while traditional forms of trust occur through human uncertainty, technology eliminates that uncertainty altogether. Over time, this normalises a form of trust defined not by interpersonal relationships, but by compliance with systemic rules at an institutional level.

Taken together, both Boshuijzen-van Burken (2016) and Bodó (2020) suggest that trust is being transformed from a human-centred relationship into a technologically manufactured outcome. Boshuijzen-van Burken (2016) highlights how digital filters narrows our vision by reshaping how we value trust through efficiency, while Bodó (2020) builds on this by explaining how this narrowed focus allows institutions to replace organic social bonds with a framework of digital certainty. By amplifying the security of surveillance while reducing the visibility of an individual's character, digital systems effectively separate trust from human relationships. Consequently, digital mediation does not merely help

us trust one another but restructures the *kampung spirit* by shifting its foundation from mutual accountability to systemic compliance.

While these systems enable a safer and faster neighborhood, they redefine trust in ways that depend less on human relationships. Over time, this does not necessarily eliminate interpersonal trust, but risks rendering it optional rather than necessary. The challenge for technology-mediated neighborhoods is to ensure that as we adopt these systems, we proactively discern which aspects of the *kampung spirit* require traditional trust – one that is rooted in human uncertainty and shared vulnerability.

True community exists where trust remains a conscious social choice, exercised not just by individuals, but at a collective level. This shared discernment ensures that we are not merely passive subjects of technology, but agents capable of making our own decisions. Ultimately, trust has not been eroded by digital systems but mediated into new forms. Protecting the human element within these new structures is a responsibility we must actively embrace to prevent the erosion of trust.

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Food, Connection and the Modern Table

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The restaurant occupies a long and narrow unit, and the small store is packed to the brim on a Friday night. Tables and chairs that seat two to four people are placed throughout the space, some not even a metre apart. Indeed, that is how some diners are grouped, eating in the restaurant with their significant others, friends, siblings and families. Tables are set with bowls, cutlery and signs with QR codes, directing diners to the digital menu. Groups of people bicker over their dishes of choice, referencing the digital ordering site on their phones. Perhaps the fun of dining together lies in being able to try and share new foods with loved ones. However, with the introduction of modern technology at the dining table, this ritual of ordering has nearly been altered permanently, with digital platforms being a medium even in communal meals. Notably, there is also a significant proportion of solo diners who enjoy their meals in quiet, most of them accompanied by their smartphones, replying to texts or watching an episode of a TV show while they eat.

In the air, there is a faint sniff of fragrant broth cooking in the kitchen. Taking a spoonful of soup from the bowl that I am sharing with my three friends, I carefully take a sip. The soup is rich and comforting, and it tastes familiar and delicious, a taste that has come to be associated with this treasured friendship. Maybe that is the power of shared meals; in sharing the same flavours and experiences, shared memories which are inevitably intertwined with the food can be created. In an age of modern convenience, the deliberate choice of sharing a meal further adds to the preciousness of these shared memories.

Around me, I hear diners engaging enthusiastically in conversation. The chatter of friends updating each other on their lives. A mother lovingly exclaiming, "Come, *Mei Mei*, eat more veggies!" as she scoops a copious portion of broccoli into her bowl, while her daughter quickly replies to a text message on her phone. A couple next to us bickers over their choice of movie to watch after dinner, between bites of food. They all have one thing in common: care, concern and thought being expressed through conversation, over food. Generally speaking, shared meals present opportunities for communication and are, therefore, a powerful avenue for connection. In their own ways, solo diners engage in forming connections as well, reframing the question of with whom connections are formed and through what mediums. Yet, in a time where convenience and speed are key, it is increasingly tempting to settle meals quickly rather than to fully engage in them. Ever-present digital elements can often also act as distractions when sharing a meal. This all begs the question: how has modern life reshaped the way we connect over food?

In the National Geographic video on *How Food Connects Us* (2014), interviewees working in the food industry share their views on the power of food in forming connections between different people. Notably, food writer Nigella Lawson shares her thoughts on how "food is the one common language" (National Geographic, 2014, 1:46), and regardless of

the different languages we speak, it "connects us all"(1:59). This conveys her argument of food as a connector – something we can all share and enjoy, despite our many differences, because of its universality. In the video, another interviewee, Ed Mitchell, shares the same sentiment, speaking about how food is a "common denominator" that enables all of us to slow down in our busy lives and appreciate the small things (National Geographic, 2014, 1:31). Both interviewees share the sentiment that food is something to be appreciated for being a powerful element that connects people.

The video highlights the value of food and meals in connecting vastly different people, acting as a uniting factor and allowing us all to enjoy the little things in life. Today, this sentiment is shared by many. In fact, a multicultural Singapore is the best illustration of this, especially with the increasing globalisation and interconnectedness of the modern day. It is common to see people of all races enjoying plates of food from different cuisines at the same table in hawker centres, uniting the different races. In this way, modern conditions may not just be distractions from connection, and can sometimes facilitate it. Though we speak different languages and have different cultures, we are united in our common appreciation of shared flavours and food. On the flipside, we should not forget that when dining together, understanding each other's differences requires time and effort, both of which we slowly find to be lacking in an efficiency-driven time. Differences in tastes and food preferences can also lead to conflict, as much as they can connect people. Ultimately, the choice and effort to connect with others over food, despite the need for efficiency, is what determines the connection formed.

In *Meals in Science and Practice* (2009), Chapter 9, "A table for one: the pain and pleasure of eating alone", Patricia L. Pliner and Ronny Bell discuss the behaviour of eating alone, the feelings involved and the resulting impacts. Pliner and Bell acknowledge that sociality is a part of meals, but also highlight ideas of theorists and philosophers when it comes to the pleasures of eating alone. Pliner and Bell quoted David Halpern in saying, "Before you begin to eat, raise your glass in honour of yourself. The company is the best you'll ever have." (Halpern, 2009, as cited in Pliner & Bell, 2009). This conveys the point that the pleasure of dining alone lies in being able to enjoy one's own company. Similarly, Pliner and Bell also draw quotes from well-known food journalist, M. F. K. Fisher, highlighting the point that the social nature of a meal distracts from the main concern of eating, the food, and that dining alone allows the diner to truly appreciate and reconnect with the food they are eating (Fisher, 1976, as cited in Pliner & Bell, 2009).

Pliner and Bell's (2009) perspective highlights that apart from social connection, eating alone has much value in allowing one to enjoy their own company and truly getting to focus on what they are eating. Indeed, this can prove true in the experiences of many. Often, meals shared with others might mean that focus is centred mainly on conversation, and the food is left barely touched on the table. There are also social pressures surrounding shared meals, where one may not be able to eat as freely in the company of others for fear of judgment. In Singapore, this is manifested in more people choosing to dine alone, and correspondingly, restaurants are also picking up on this modern trend and introducing promotions and seating arrangements that appeal to such consumers. This includes restaurants with booths and set lunches specially catered towards solo diners. Indeed, solo dining is emerging very much as a modern phenomenon. However, in light of this, it is also important to remember that some people eat alone, not by choice but because they are forced by circumstance, such as a lack of time to share a meal

with others, and they seek to substitute forming connections with their digital devices during meals.

The National Geographic (2014) video and Pliner and Bell's (2009) writing both agree on the immense value that meals hold in a modern context. However, they diverge in recognising where this value is derived from. While the National Geographic (2014) video identifies the value-adding factor of forming connections with others through meals, Pliner and Bell (2009) bring to attention the element of connecting with oneself and with the food being enjoyed. Both present different answers to the question of the impacts of modern conditions. Shared meals allow us to slow down in fast-paced modern life, while eating alone is not just a pursuit of efficiency but rather, also a respite from busy modern life and reconnection with oneself. Understood together, the quality of connection formed over a meal is determined based on our own preferences and choices. Perhaps combining both views, dining with enjoyable company while also appreciating the meal are not mutually exclusive, and it is in this way that the value of meals is maximised. It is highly possible for a modern individual to balance both these needs within one lifestyle.

Modern life has no doubt changed the way in which we enjoy meals and the way we form connections: compressing the time we are willing to give shared meals and providing digital and solitary alternatives. A sense of efficiency and a general trend towards digitalisation can and have affected the way we eat in some ways. However, I still believe in the essential and prevalent nature of meals in our lives. National Geographic (2014), Pliner and Bell (2009) all point towards the fact that meals are eaten under many different contexts and should not be generalised as an activity. The location, people, time, and reasons behind a meal, are all important factors that play out within modern conditions and decide the capacity in which we can form connections with each other. Perhaps then, the deciding factor behind connection over meals is how we choose to actively shape these experiences ourselves, despite the changes introduced with modern life.

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POP MART: Just This Once

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I stood inside the POP MART with my allowance in mind, drawn to the SkullPanda x My Little Pony series behind the glass. Around me, shelves of brightly coloured blind boxes stretched across the store under soft lighting, while posters of limited-edition figures turned the space into a catalogue of possibilities.

Boxes were repeatedly picked, weighed in palms, shaken, and placed back, only to be picked up again later. Some customers examined one box at a time, while others compared two side by side, switching between them in quiet repetition. Boxes were lifted to the chest, brought near the ear, or passed across to a companion for confirmation. For bagged items, fingers pinched and traced outlines as if seeking hidden clues. Movements remained deliberate, as customers lingered far longer than the space seemed to require, caught in cycles of hesitation.

Watching this, I instinctively reached for a box, mimicking their actions, as if I, too, might uncover a secret advantage. The store felt filled with doppelgangers, each performing similar strategies, where small differences seemed meaningful.

The search did not remain confined to the shelves. Conversations, often centred on evaluation, overlapped across the environment. Remarks about weight, sound, and likelihood circulated constantly. There were solo buyers pausing to text or video-call absent companions for opinions. Other customers resorted to scrolling through unboxing videos on Xiaohongshu, consulting ChatGPT, or relying on number generators. Even after a selection was made, doubt persisted. Common reassurances were repeatedly sought, yet the cycle of repeated checking and questioning continued. Some even switched boxes at the last minute.

Choosing rarely feels final as changes continue until transactions are finalised. Blind boxes are designed to be explicitly random, but customers nevertheless invest disproportionate time, effort and energy before committing. Rather than grabbing a box and moving on, they engage in repeated rituals of comparison, consultation and evaluation even though the odds of each box containing what they desire remain mathematically fixed. Shaking, weighing or switching boxes does not alter probability, yet these behaviours loop rather than conclude.

What stands out is not whether these strategies work, but why they are performed at all. Blind boxes are structured around chance, yet customers act as if subtle gestures and choices might matter. Effort concentrates where outcomes are most visible, yet least controllable. These patterns of repetition and social consultation reflect what I refer to as micro-optimisation: repeated attempts to gain small advantages within a system governed by fixed odds, despite those actions having no objective influence over probability. So, why do people persist in micro-optimising behaviours in systems governed by fixed odds, even when their actions do not meaningfully change outcomes?

One way of shedding light on this behaviour is E. J. Langer's (1975) concept of the illusion of control, defined as a tendency for individuals to overestimate their likelihood of success relative to objective probability. Langer (1975) suggests that when chance-based environments contain features associated with skill, such as choice, physical engagement or personal involvements, individuals begin to treat them as partially controllable. These "skill-like cues" (Langer, 1975) do not alter underlying randomness, but they re-organise how uncertainty is experienced, shifting it from something passively encountered to something that appears open to influence. This is reflected in Langer's (1975) Study 6, where lottery participants who received their ticket one digit per day over three days showed greater confidence in winning and were less willing to exchange their ticket for one with better odds, despite no change in actual probability. Although the additional engagement carried no causal effect on outcomes, it transformed randomness from something indifferent into something that appears responsive. The environment began to take on the quality of being interpretable, as though information cues could be extracted through engagement rather than simply accepted as unknowable.

Crucially, Langer's (1975) account is not limited to a misjudgment of probability. It shows how interaction reconfigures the decision situation itself. Once action becomes available, the situation is no longer experienced as something that can be left alone. Even without deliberate intention, the presence of possible intervention introduces an implicit expectation that something can be done, and therefore something should be done. Inaction, in this context, is no longer registered as neutrality, but as failure to engage with available possibilities. However, while Langer (1975) explains why people feel compelled to act, she does not explain how that action takes shape. The illusion of control makes engagement feel necessary, but it does not explain why people begin comparing nearly identical options instead of simply choosing one of them. In other words, Langer (1975) shows why action starts, but not how it becomes structured. The shift from "something can be done" to "this is what I should do" remains unexplained. This limitation becomes visible in blind box contexts, where actions such as shaking, weighing or comparing boxes introduce engagement into a chance system. While consistent with Langer's (1975) account in reflecting perceived controllability, these behaviours do not explain why comparison becomes the chosen form of action once engagement is triggered.

A further layer of explanation can be developed through Craig R. Fox and Amos Tversky's (1995) account of comparative ignorance and ambiguity aversion. They explain that ambiguity becomes most influential when uncertainty is evaluated through comparison rather than in isolation. In such settings, differences between options become more psychologically salient, not because they are inherently informative, but because comparison makes them visible. What might otherwise appear as negligible variation begins to feel meaningful, as evaluation becomes structured around contrast. As a result, some options appear more readable than others, even when no real informational advantage exists. This produces an asymmetry in perceived clarity, where ambiguity is experienced unevenly across choices and generates discomfort associated with not knowing which differences matter. Evaluation, in this sense, is not isolated judgement but a relational process shaped by contrast.

In blind box contexts, this comparative structuring becomes directly observable in how decisions are made. When multiple boxes are handled side by side, attention shifts away from the randomness of outcomes toward small relational differences. Subtle

differences in weight, sound, or texture begin to stand out, not because they reliably indicate what is inside, but because comparison makes them perceptually distinct. One box can therefore feel more interpretable than another, even in the absence of real information. This perceived difference matters because it creates the impression that uncertainty is partially legible. However, this heightened perceptual shift alone does not fully explain the POP MART customers' behaviour. What drives engagement is the belief that these differences might still be meaningful signals within a responsive system, where careful attention could improve outcomes. In this way, the blind box does not only present uncertainty, it encourages participants to treat uncertainty as if it were structured and, at least in part, decipherable.

Taken together, Langer (1975) and Fox and Tversky (1995) suggest that micro-optimisation is less about improving probabilistic outcomes than about how decisions become interpretable at the point they are made. Langer (1975) shows how interaction introduces an illusion of agency, making chance-based environments feel responsive to action. Fox and Tversky (1995) reveal how comparison re-organises uncertainty relationally, making differences between options appear meaningful even when they carry no causal weight. Yet comparison alone does not necessarily lead to action; it is the prior presence of perceived agency that renders these differences actionable. What emerges from this is not simply a combination of control and comparison, but a deeper shift in how decisions are experienced at the point of choice. Once a decision becomes both actionable and readable, randomness is no longer encountered as fixed, but as something that invites engagement. In this state, the difficulty is no longer choosing uncertainty, but leaving the decision untouched. Micro-optimisation, then, is not driven by a search for better outcomes, but by a demand for felt completion at the point of choice.

Seen in this way, micro-optimisation reveals that the challenge of uncertainty is not simply that outcomes cannot be known, but that some decisions become psychologically difficult to leave alone. This shifts our understanding of repeated optimisation from an attempt to beat the odds to an attempt to make uncertain decisions feel complete.

I still want that SkullPanda x My Little Pony. Next month, when I return with my allowance, I will still be weighing, shaking, and second-guessing before choosing. But this time, the aim will no longer be to out-think the system, but to arrive at a point where choosing no longer feels unfinished.

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Passion and Pressure: A Blessing and A Curse?

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Figure 1. Kallang Bowl

Figure 2. Final match scores

"YEAH, LET'S GO!" Enthusiastic cheers erupted in the distance as my friend and I entered Kallang Bowl. The atmosphere was explosive with almost every lane filled to the brim. There were kids hurling bowling balls with unconventional techniques, teenagers hanging out with wide smiles, and adults just casually playing to unwind.

We rushed towards the lanes and dove straight into the action. We started terribly. I vividly remember the hilarious stares we exchanged when the ball slowly crept into the gutter. However, my friend and I were extremely competitive, so our throws were progressively improving. Despite competing against one another, we actively gave each other relentless support and useful advice. Additionally, we were still loudly cackling from the occasional misses. Over the course of that session, I realised that I was not weighed down by the pressure to win. I was actually having the time of my life, and somehow, it only motivated me to crave victory even more.

Then, out of nowhere, I thought to myself, "I have not felt like this in a long time."

This made me ponder why. As an international scholar who had just moved to Singapore for my undergraduate studies, I came with one assumption: I thought I had mastered pressure, that I was no stranger to it. However, in my first semester, the competition was fiercer than I had anticipated. I had entered university with a passion for learning. I was chasing the satisfaction of understanding complex ideas and improving through this. However, that curiosity was overshadowed by the need to maintain my grades and prove that I deserved to be here. The desire to be the best haunted me throughout my studies and even social activities. Consequently, I felt restless, exhausted, and overwhelmed by my need to

grow constantly. It was miles away from the sense of relief I experienced in that bowling alley. Yet both scenarios involved competition, failure, and the desire of growth. So, why did one motivate me while the other drained me? Was it because of the stakes, the expectations or the constant comparison?

After settling into university, it turned out that I was not alone. A significant number of my friends resonated with how I felt. What surprised me most was how reluctant we were to admit our struggles. The pressure of maintaining a satisfactory Grade Point Average (GPA) instilled fear about our performance, while everyone else seemed to have it all figured out. These factors had stripped away our love and ambition for the field of study that we chose out of passion. Then, I noticed that it was not just us, it was actually a prevalent issue among many others across all professions. It begs the question, why do people let competitive pressure extinguish the very passion that fuels it?

Ellen Hendriksen (2025), a clinical psychologist and faculty member at Boston University, explores perfectionism in a conversation with The Harvard Gazette. She states that it can be destructive when it encapsulates over-evaluation and harsh self-criticism. Hendriksen (2025) mentions that struggling with over-evaluation can lead to anxiety about self-worth. This behaviour can cause someone to believe that any negative experience directly connects to their character. She argues that having too many overwhelming expectations leads to an unhealthy state of constant evaluation that treats falling short as a direct reflection of who they are. As Hendriksen (2025) says, "...but it's when 'Did I do good?' means 'Am I good?' and 'I did bad' means 'I am bad'." She notes that a proper definition of failure is crucial. If failure is the inability to meet unrealistic standards, then it will be an endless cycle of harsh self-criticism. Over time, people may start depicting themselves as failures, fuelling hopelessness and helplessness. Finally, Hendriksen (2025) suggests that unhealthy perfectionism can manifest as hypervigilance and self-comparison. Hypervigilance traps individuals in over-analysing past mistakes, while self-comparison keeps them asking whether they are improving at all.

How does this explain why passion dies under competition? Over-evaluation and harsh self-criticism do not simply erode confidence. They instead breed an "overthink before doing" or a hypervigilant mindset that disrupts the path towards pursuing passion. Eventually, over-evaluation and failure compound into a spiral. Struggles in daily life begin bleeding into professional life, distorting how people perceive their own potential. Consequently, this unhealthy perception breeds self-doubt and self-comparison. Paired with competitive pressure, the hopelessness and helplessness that follow make reigniting passion feel almost impossible.

While Hendriksen (2025) makes compelling arguments, she only paints part of the picture. Beyond the individual, the environment could potentially be another reason as to why people foster such tendencies. In reality, unhealthy perfectionism may be a trait manifested as a survival response to one's surroundings rather than simply being a personal characteristic. This directly strengthens Hendriksen's (2025) point on over-evaluation as different scenarios harbour different levels of pressure. For example, in universities, there are bell curves, competitive communities and external expectations that build a crushing amount of pressure. Hence, students feel incentivised to chase perfection, losing what they were once passionate about simply to avoid failing.

Building on failure, in *Daring Greatly* (2012), research professor Brené Brown uncovers how vulnerability and scarcity are deeply intertwined. She defines scarcity as the "never enough" problem. It is the persistent inability to feel good, perfect, or even

powerful enough in life. She emphasises that our concern about scarcity is society's modern version of trauma. Brown (2012) identifies three factors that drive scarcity, which are shame, comparison, and disengagement. For instance, shame arises when self-worth is tied to results, comparison emerges through the constant measuring against others, and disengagement follows when the fear of risk is present. Beyond scarcity, Brown (2012) also addresses a myth that vulnerability is a weakness. People tend to avoid vulnerability, often treating feelings as a liability. This rejection transforms self-respect and appreciation to judgement and criticism. However, Brown (2012) observes that most people admire vulnerability in others while suppressing it in themselves. This seemingly impenetrable shell, built on negative emotions, keeps scarcity alive in today's society.

In competitive environments, belonging starts to feel dependent on one's performance. A place that feels earned rather than given means that one mistake is enough to make someone question whether they deserve to be there at all. This is how scarcity quietly disfigures passion. It takes shame, comparison, and disengagement to wear people down until they feel fundamentally undeserving. Yet the deeper that inadequacy takes root, the harsher they treat vulnerability. In turn, what begins as the pressure of staying silent now silences action. As a result, people stop trying altogether, losing the passion they once had.

Brown (2012) wrote, "Vulnerability is courage in you and inadequacy in me." (p. 77-78) It is a quote that describes hypocrisy in how people treat their own feelings. Perhaps this emotional suppression further worsens the loop of scarcity. It enables destructive emotions to build up until they become paralysing. In an environment that rewards performance, society ends up treating wholeheartedness as pitiful confession. The deeper an individual conceals, the deeper scarcity takes root. Hence, they continue fighting this invisible opponent, with their self-worth on the line.

Hendriksen (2025) highlights that perfectionism becomes harmful when it involves excessive self-evaluation and harsh internal criticism. She elaborates that these factors distort the perfectionist mindset into one driven by anxiety and fear. Brown (2012) complements this by suggesting that such feelings are rooted in scarcity. Scarcity manifests when people are influenced by shame, comparison, and disengagement in themselves or by their surroundings. Taken together, both suggest that those who fall victim to these traits find themselves trapped in an endless loop of constantly chasing perfection while never feeling enough. They remain trapped in a self-reinforcing cage of hopelessness and helplessness. Both Hendriksen (2025) and Brown (2012) present the volatility of self-worth when it relies on expectations, leaving it to be vulnerable to shame and self-doubt.

What makes this cycle incredibly difficult to escape is that these feelings rarely surface. Many individuals feel obligated to appear perfect, burying anything else that is far from it. The weight of maintaining that image never disappears, it only accumulates. Beneath the surface, emotions bottle up until a breaking point where they either paralyse or explode. They continue to over-exert themselves to be an ideal version just to feel good enough. However, neither ambition nor competition should inherently lead to burnout. Pressure can strengthen when people feel secure enough to fail and learn.

As I rolled my final ball into the gutter, my best friend approached me.

"You doing alright?"

"Is it okay not to be perfect?"

"Why do you have to be?"

"Yeah, you're right."

I was losing, laughing, and trying again all at once. The pursuit of perfection is not always destructive. Passion can drive use towards an ideal of perfection, even when we know that ideal cannot be fully achieved. At that moment, I felt enough. Perhaps this is how pressure and passion should coexist, in the freedom to fail. Perfection, after all, should never come at the price of our self-worth.

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The Harmony of Chaos

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The mellow sound of the double bass reverberates under the indistinct chatter, anchoring the room. An amber spotlight isolates the band from the dim periphery. Here at Wildcard, the polished attire of tourists dressed to the nines suggests a "night out" to remember, while locals in casual denim and sneakers lounge with the practiced ease of those truly "at home". As the room settles, a warm tune begins to take shape.

A crisp swing groove from the drummer lays the foundation. It locks into the bassist's relentless walking line. The piano sketches the skeletal melody. Then, the structure fractures. The tune becomes unrecognisable. Each musician trades solos in high-stakes improvisation. Finally, a hint of the main melody returns. A turnaround anchors the chaos.

The final chord hangs, then evaporates. Expectations shift. The host's gaze cuts through the amber haze, landing not on a seasoned regular, but a spectator, Daryl. A silent gesture beckons Daryl to the stand. The listener moments ago, he now navigates a tune heard only in passing. A single chord chart serves as his map. What follows is pure, unscripted literacy. Despite being strangers, the combo shares a dialect. A sharp nod passes the torch of a solo. A drummer's lowered eyelids signal a collective hush. No script exists. There is only the "head" and its rigid form. The musicians cling to this framework like a lifeline while rotating through the spotlight. It is less a rehearsed recital and more like a flowing conversation between strangers who just happen to speak the same musical language.

Daryl's navigation of a song he barely knew, guided by a lone chord chart and the steady groove of the drummer, reveals a fundamental paradox. Spontaneity appears chaotic, but it is merely structure set free. Just as a jazz musician requires the "form" of a tune to know where to improvise, or a freestyle rapper's command of rhyme prepares them for a lyrical masterpiece, a creator needs a framework. Without it, there is no rhythm to disrupt, no expectations to play against, no common ground on which to create. The predictability is avoided not by ignoring the rules, but by stretching them to their breaking point. Perhaps, spontaneity and structure are not opposites. It is a symbiotic relationship where the rules provide the very resistance needed for flight. Conversely, spontaneity provides the raw spark that future structures eventually crystallise. This raises a deeper inquiry: If spontaneity is fundamentally tethered to structure, how does the stretching of those rules generate such unpredictable outcomes?

The music felt like a conversation, so I turned to H. P. Grice's (1975) "Logic and conversation". Grice (1975) states that effective communication is governed by a set of implicit rules known as the Cooperative Principle. Crucially, he argued that we do not just follow these rules, but intentionally flout them to create deeper meaning. We do not process these deviations as errors, but a hidden meaning generated

by the tension between what is expected and what is actually delivered.

In social interaction, we do not think about maxims or rules. Instead, we read "vibes" and "intent". Imagine dropping your tray in a cafeteria. If a friend says "good job", we immediately grasp the sarcasm, and meaning arises from violating expectation, not abandoning it. In the case of the jazz jam, every "dissonant" note played immediately presented itself as a surprise yet stayed coherent with the underlying structure of the song. This surprises us precisely because we recognise this dissonance as a deviation from what should have been played; the notes presented in the accompanying chord for example. In this sense, spontaneity is not random, but structured. However, this account suggests that unpredictability remains within the control of the speaker, as it is rooted in intentional deviation.

While Grice's (1975) maxims explain how an individual can intentionally subvert expectations to create meaning, it does not capture the volatile reality of a jazz stage. To understand how structured systems generate surprise, we must look beyond individual intent and consider Edward Lorenz's (1993) Chaos Theory.

Lorenz (1993) challenges the assumption that unpredictability is intentional. He studies systems that, while governed by deterministic rules, exhibit behaviour that appears irregular and unpredictable. Take the weather as an example: it is governed by the rigid laws of physics yet temperature, pressure, and moisture constantly interact, altering each other's trajectories. Because these variables dynamically influence each other, the ultimate outcome becomes practically impossible to anticipate, even if the starting conditions are known.

This perspective complicates the earlier understanding of spontaneity. The unpredictability of a jazz jam is not merely a sequence of intentional deviations, it is the result of continuous, cascading interactions. If Daryl hits a sequence of unpredicted notes, it might be a reaction to the drummer subtly shifting the groove, or a response to the pianist hinting at a chord substitution. Once a single deviation enters the system, it forces an immediate reaction from every other player. Spontaneity, therefore, is not just a deliberate choice, it is the inevitable chaos born from strict rules colliding in real time.

To understand the true mechanics of spontaneity, we must bridge the insights of Grice's (1975) conversational maxims and Lorenz's (1993) Chaos Theory. These theories do not challenge one another, but rather demonstrate that intentionality and inevitability operate in tandem. Grice (1975) illustrates how an individual might intentionally flout a rule to create meaning, providing the initial spark of unpredictability. Lorenz (1993) expands on this, demonstrating how that initial spark, once introduced into a system of interacting variables, inevitably spirals beyond the control of its creator. When structure creates expectations for intentional deviations to break, these deviations do not remain isolated. They are transformed and amplified by others in real time. Consider a high-stakes chess match between grandmasters: the game is governed by rules and predictable opening strategies. But if one player intentionally sacrifices a high-value piece, it forces the opponent into immediate re-calculation. That single, deliberate move changes the predicted trajectory of the game, plunging both players into a complex sequence of strategies. The unpredictability in spontaneity thus lies not in randomness, but in the system's tendency to obscure its own causal chain. Spontaneity feels unpredictable not simply because outcomes are uncertain, but because the sheer velocity and volume of interactions resist reconstruction.

Even with these theories in hand, a lingering curiosity remains: why does spontaneity feel unpredictable to the observer? Both sources suggest that spontaneity produces emergent outcomes by the amplification of intentions within a system of interaction. I believe that for the observer, however, this process manifests as an interpretive gap, a space between recognising that something meaningful has occurred and being able to fully explain how it came to be.

This gap does not result in mere confusion, but in questioning. Unlike randomness, which offers no structure to interpret, or predictability, which requires no interpretation at all, spontaneity occupies a middle ground. The observer can sense that the outcome is not arbitrary. It aligns with the underlying structure and feels coherent, yet the path leading to it remains obscured. This tension gives rise to a new layered from of questioning: what was expected, what was intended, why did it happen, and how the result ultimately emerged from the interaction of multiple actors in the system. These questions are not incidental, but central to the experience itself.

Spontaneity, therefore, is not merely surprise, but the visible expression of emergence, of structure set into motion and interacting beyond the control of any individual. Its unpredictability lies not in the absence of order, but in the excess of it, as interactions generate outcomes too complex to be fully traced and understood.

As I return to that moment in the dimly lit room, the scene no longer appears as a display of individual brilliance, but as something far more elusive. Daryl's hesitant entrance was not a break in the system, but a new variable added to this volatile system, a "flouted" note that acted as an initial condition for the band to transform. As the final chord faded and the room returned to its quiet murmur, the absence of an applause felt less like failure and more like a collective inhalation.

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The Quiet Regulation of Choice: A Yong Tau Foo Stall

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Figure 1. Yong tau foo stall, Cuppage Plaza, Singapore

Just a few minutes away from the polished storefronts and bustling streets of Orchard Road sits a modest yong tau foo stall (Fig. 1), tucked in a narrow opening of Cuppage Plaza. Inside, the city's noise fades. The trays of tofu, fishballs, and vegetables sit in quiet rows under fluorescent lighting. The broth bubbles softly behind the counter. There are no long queues, no social media buzz nor aggressive signage. Yet during lunch hour, a steady stream of customers arrives, each stepping forward in turn to take their bowls and tongs. The process appears simple: selecting any ingredients they want. But something else becomes visible upon closer observation. Fishballs and tofu disappear steadily. Eggplant and black mushrooms remain largely untouched, even at the height of peak hour. One customer lifts an eggplant, pauses, glances at the person ahead, then puts it back and reaches for a fishball instead. Another customer counts her pieces quickly, using her tongs to count while eyes flicked to the queue behind her before stepping aside. No one instructed them to

hurry, no one told them what to choose; yet the pace remained swift and consistent.

This stall has been a part of my family's visits to Singapore since 2013. Returning to it recently, I was struck less by nostalgia and more by the unchanged rhythm of the space. The uncle behind the counter recognised my father and called out warmly. The broth smelled the same. The stools were the same. The customers moved through the same way they always had: quickly, efficiently, reaching for the same things. And yet, standing there this time, something felt different – not about the stall, but about how I was seeing it.

What held my attention this time was not the familiarity of the food – it was the consistency of how people behaved within the space. Here, too, the pattern held. The stall seemed to operate on an unspoken set of expectations. Customers rarely lingered or experimented, and instead appeared to rely on what felt familiar or appropriate within the moment. The narrow walkway and visible queue create a subtle pressure to decide quickly, whereas the actions of others provide cues on what to select. This raises a broader question: if such an ordinary environment can shape how people make decisions without explicit rules, what does this suggest about how social norms and physical spaces quietly govern behaviour in daily life?

To better understand the patterns observed at the food stall, the concept of choice architecture as discussed by Thaler et al. (2013) provides a useful framework. The authors argue that decisions are never made in neutral environments. Instead, every context in which choices occur is structured in a way that influences outcomes. Choice architecture refers to the way environments – their arrangement, visibility and accessibility – are structured to subtly influence people's decisions and shape behaviour. Rather than restricting choice, these structures guide individuals by making certain options more salient and convenient to select. "A good rule of thumb is to assume that everything matters." (Thaler et al., 2013, p. 429) Even small and often unnoticed design features – e.g. which items are placed at eye level, the order of ingredients displayed – can have a disproportionate impact on decision-making. They subtly steer individuals toward a particular outcome, while preserving the illusion of freedom.

This perspective is useful in explaining how behaviour can be molded without explicit rules, particularly in structured environments. It sheds light on how physical design elements, such as arrangement and accessibility, influence decision-making in ways that individuals may not consciously recognise. However, the authors primarily focus on institutional or policy-driven contexts, such as schools and policy design. Their framework does not fully account for how these influences might operate in informal and everyday food spaces – spaces where no administrator planned the layout, yet behavioural effects are just as pronounced. This matters because it suggests that choice architecture does not require deliberate design to take effect. At the yong tau foo stall, the narrow walkway, the queue, and the arrangement of ingredients all function as architectural cues -- not by intention, but simply by condition. If spaces shape decisions even without planning, these influences may extend far beyond what Thaler et al. (2013) anticipated.

To further the discussion above, the concept of descriptive norms, introduced by Cialdini et al. (1991), offers another nuanced perspective. Descriptive norms refer to perceptions of what most people usually do in a particular situation, and how these perceptions influence behaviour. When these norms become visible or salient within an environment, they act as signals of what is normalised or appropriate. As the authors put it, "if everyone is doing or thinking or

believing it, it must be a sensible thing to do or think or believe" (Cialdini et al., 1991, p. 203). As a result, individuals often adjust their behaviour to align with what they observe others doing, even when there are no explicit instructions present. Such influence is particularly strong in situations where individuals are uncertain or unfamiliar – including, for instance, someone encountering yong tau foo for the first time. Without prior knowledge of the dish, new customers are especially likely to look to those around them to determine which ingredients are considered standard or acceptable, effectively borrowing choices of others as a guide. Even for those who know the dish, items that appear to be running low signal popularity, which attracts attention and reinforces existing patterns of selection.

Descriptive norms are particularly useful in explaining how behaviour is shaped through social observation rather than physical structure. It highlights how individuals look to others for cues, most especially in shared public spaces where actions are obvious. The latter is relevant in everyday environments like food stalls, where customers can easily observe the choices of those before them. However, while the theory explains how norms are formed through observation, it does not fully acknowledge how environmental factors –such as layout, time pressure, or accessibility– may interact with these social cues. A customer who might otherwise explore a less familiar ingredient may be discouraged not only by the absence of social validation but also the spatial and temporal conditions of the stall itself. In this sense, the theory tends to isolate social influence without fully taking into account how it operates alongside the physical structure of the environment. This is a significant gap because in everyday food spaces, social observation does not occur in a vacuum. The visibility of others' choices is itself produced by the physical design of the space. Without accounting for this, descriptive norms alone cannot fully explain why certain choices feel normal and others do not.

Drawing on both concepts together, it is possible to identify something that neither fully addresses within their original scope. Thaler et al. (2013) show how physical environments structure the conditions of choice, yet do not account for the social dimension, which is the way people read each other's behaviour as a guide. On the other hand, Cialdini et al. (1991) explain how individuals use others' actions as signals, but they do not examine how the physical design of a space determines which actions become visible in the first place. Notably, when applied to informal everyday spaces, neither source acknowledges the role of time pressure and the sense of urgency it creates -- an observation that emerges from applying both concepts to the specific conditions of the stall. At the yong tau foo stall, these forces are deeply entangled. The narrow walkway ensures that each customer can see exactly what those ahead are choosing. The queue creates time pressure that makes deviation feel costly. The physical structure produces social visibility. This means that the choices of each customer become a live, observable reference point for those behind them. In turn, this visibility produces the norm; what is frequently chosen appears to be normalised, and what is left behind becomes undesirable. As such, the stall does not merely contain both choice architecture and descriptive norms, but rather it demonstrates how they reinforce each other by producing a behavioural pattern more rigid than either would generate alone.

What emerges from this analysis is an insight that challenges a common assumption: that individual choice, made freely, reflects individual preference. In everyday food spaces, this assumption does not fully hold. What feels like a personal decision is quietly shaped by the architecture of space and the visibility of behaviour around us. This is not coercion; no one is

forced. But the conditions under which choice is made narrow the range of what feels natural, normal and easy. As a result, this creates an illusion of freedom, where customers, instead of being forced, have their behaviours steered toward options that are familiar, efficient and socially reinforced. Perhaps we do not really deviate from the familiar; after all, it carries its own comfort. This dynamic is not unique to a yong tau foo stall. Wherever people make decisions in the presence of others and within structured environments –be it classrooms, offices, or public transport– the same quiet mechanisms are at work.

The yong tau foo stall is, in this sense, a microcosm: a quiet demonstration of how social life regulates behaviour without ever needing to say so. Likewise, this same quiet regulation can be observed in educational pathways. In Singapore, students often gravitate towards established tracks –e.g. science streams, law, or medicine– and educational pathways that are commonly taken like Junior College and Polytechnic (Ng, 2020). This is not necessarily because they were told to, but because these choices appear most frequently among peers and are embedded in the social construct itself – i.e. the expectations of peers, parents and institutions around them. As a result, the visible success of those ahead makes certain paths feel "right" and the deviation from them feel costly. Recognising this does not make us free from these forces, but it may be the first step toward choosing with greater awareness.

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The Cruel Paradox of Materialism

By Tan Yu Ze
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"A large income is the best recipe for happiness I ever heard of," Jane Austen wrote, expressing a personal creed. Meandering along Boat Quay's pathway, gentle breezes emerging from the waterfront caressed hedges, swaying them softly. It eventually whispered upon my cheeks, bracing my nerves and filling me with excitement, allowing me to foretaste the path I fervently strove toward. Inspirited by the mineral-heavy aroma emanating from the river, I stood before the colossal UOB Plaza, ready to face Goliath! The intimidating, inviting infrastructure cast its shadow on me. The impartial heat of the afternoon sun weaved through nearby architecture, leaving only local professionals relishing in its warmth. Mesmerised, my beliefs were affirmed! The building's open-floor concept symbolically offered access to modern success in today's hyper-materialistic atmosphere, where every glass façade's shimmer promised opportunity. Captivated by the blinding gloss radiating from the concrete giant, I found myself further indoctrinated into its "hustle" culture, expecting similar magnetic, ardent desire from its ever-loyal residents.

Proving me otherwise was the polarising reality I witnessed. Office workers stood in the plaza's shadow, ringed around the bins. The vibrancy of their lanyards stood out in the grey gloom; none matched the building behind them. One thumbed his badge over, so the photograph faced his chest. Another had loosened his tie by two fingers and left it there. The glass at their backs held them in miniature, and none of them turned to look. Sighing, they tapped red-and-white boxes, and as their maroon lips wrapped around yellow cigarette heads, vapid demeanours transformed. Their ringleader rambled about his aspirations as they puffed in intervals – designer cars, luxurious mansions. Slapping their thighs, his once-insipid goons radiated bright smiles and haughty laughs – gleaming exaltedly with awe and liveliness.

The workmen's concoction of micro-behaviours – slumped postures, drags of nicotine– perhaps foretold a gnawing fatigue ingrained in muscle and mood. Yet their approach exuded certainty; regardless of their origins, this shared routine suggested recurrence and everyday normality. Their actions seemed therapeutic, even transformative – once the ringleader slipped into his idealistic monologues, flickers of elation and longing flashed, as though they found momentary respite in his words, and felt camaraderie stitched together by common endeavours. Am I fated to be tethered by the same blend of cadenced exhaustion? Would I still yearn for my desires as weariness shackled me further?

I sought inspiration; I discovered fatigue. I assumed hunger; I witnessed habit. I arrived naive; I departed sceptical... Between their prolonged puffs, I was inundated with sympathy: I too longed for the promise material goods offer, but likewise, I am still of flesh. Fatigue and failure continue to haunt my pursuit. Similarly, the group of people collectively slumping over as they engaged in their vices seemed to suggest quiet resignation. Yet, what I saw was an active

rebellion: despite surrendering their souls to the gruelling grind, the rebellion lies in their obstinacy to continue desiring more. Such a contradiction compels me to explore this further – why do we persist in pursuing material wealth despite its recurring adversities?

R. W. Belk's (1988) journal article "Possessions and the Extended Self" examines the relationship between possessions and identity, claiming that "our possessions are a major contributor to and reflection of our identities" (p. 139). He interpreted materialism not purely through a utilitarian or economical lens, as he asserted that consumer behaviour was not always fuelled by rational choices. Rather, he believed such behaviours were supported by the symbolism and psychological functions offered by the object to the individual. Given that possessions can engrave memory and express emotions, it serves as a means for individuals to locate their social footing while projecting their idealised, valued identities to others — forming the felt cognitive attachment individuals have towards material goods. This becomes especially apparent when possessions are lost, treasured, or desired, as the intense emotions these moments evoke reflect how deeply entwined material objects are with one's sense of self. Belk's (1988) journal article then raises an unsettling thought: perhaps objects' value then lies within the intersection between material function and personal significance.

This introspection suggests a deeper implication for identity: the pursuit of material wealth constructs a possibly perpetual bridge between one's present and idealised future. As long as one's desires remain ever-changing, one remains suspended in an endless state of becoming. By subsuming individuality under the need for external display and acquirement, the individual is not abandoning their sense of self entirely, but instead simply settling for less, allowing society to dictate what is meaningful by compensating their lack with material objects. The office workers I witnessed at Boat Quay seemed to personify this contradiction. Fatigued, their aspirations ought to be meaningless, yet their weariness breathed newfound life into them, as if attaining their desires would have redeemed the exhaustion their aspirations demanded. This elation did not erase their enervations. Rather, it emerged from within them, intensifying the workers' pursuits not because it fulfilled them, but because their incompleteness keeps fulfilment possible.

Dittmar et al. (2014) recontextualise this issue. In their journal article, "The Relationship Between Materialism and Personal Well-Being: A Meta-Analysis" (Dittmar et al., 2014), they present materialism as a byproduct of a culture cultivated by modern consumerism rather than inherent preferences. The issue is not in individual purchasing habits, but in what they believe valuable. They argue that this dichotomy stems from structural conflict – society frames and pushes financial success, status and possessions as life priorities through cultural reinforcement and tangibility. When these are presented to be less superficial and more indispensable in our normalised view of "flourishing", it often displaces fundamental human needs, such as relationships or social connection and growth, all of which are crucial for well-being. Such unmet necessities may cause one to be surrounded by material value yet remain psychologically impoverished. The onus then lies not on the individual, but on the society that glorifies materialism so tenaciously, that inherited ideals begin to be misrecognised as personal desire.

Dittmar et al. (2014) highlight an ominous possibility: the danger might lie within the quiet colonisation of desire. When society skews our cultural perspective towards materialism, what emerges then is an atmosphere that sustains a cruel paradox — the very

pursuit that is assumed to provide wholeness, may be what depletes us. Conversely, adversities may not always diminish the pursuit: when assimilated as necessary into an idealised definition of fulfilment, it is understood as sacrifice. Once such an ideology entangles with one's concept of flourishing, abandoning the pursuit goes beyond just forsaking material wealth; it requires actively rejecting inherited ideals our culture has taught us to believe are crucial for meaning, resulting in a self potentially unmoored from its foundations. Perhaps then, we persist not because it truly fulfils, but because we are taught that is what fulfilment entails.

Belk's (1988) ideology on materialism emerges from within: an introspective exploration of the intimacy between possessions, self, and imagined completeness. Conversely, Dittmar et al.'s (2014) work unravels this inward-looking perspective by considering its origins within a wider cultural landscape — one that scripts the value of material desire through cultural indoctrination. In this light, these seemingly conflicting sources surface an uncomfortable question: is this pursuit based on individual desire, or a judgement moulded by a societal framework imposed upon us? Or is it both, and if so, where is the room for autonomy? Perhaps what these sources unveil is not contradiction, but the possibility for convergence. The workmen may not have pursued material wealth simply out of personal desire, nor were they entirely coerced by societal norms into desiring; rather, they may have consented to, justified, and reproduced this very materialist lifestyle. On this account, autonomy is not entirely absent, but reframed: one has the liberty to desire, yet still be subject to what one has been taught to desire. The reason for our persistence, then, could lie within this convergence, where the boundary between personal will and societal influence becomes increasingly obscured.

If you were to ask me why I desire a large income, my answer would have been the same as the workmen's. Like them, my being of flesh and bone is subject to the same promise and cultural influence materialism offers — a vision of reward that grants wholeness and social legitimacy, an offer not easily relinquished. This may be why we persist: not because it brings us closer to fulfilment, but because it is kept perpetually in sight, a never-ending pursuit. Yet, if desire can be birthed and defined, it can also be questioned. Within this realisation lies agency: the imperative is no longer why we persist, but whether we can reclaim our right to desire on our own terms, not because it is enough, but because it is what we ought to have done so from the beginning. This time, I will not resign myself; I will question, I will rebel.

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Peace

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Peace is hardly ever the first word that comes to anyone's mind when describing Pasir Ris Park. On any given day, the park can be described as a constant sensory competition. If the park is a boxing ring, the sensory cues are the fighters, each aggressively contending for dominance but never managing a brutal knockout. The herbaceous smell of greenery tries to drown out the smell of charred barbecue meat on the grill, but neither can fully get rid of the other, creating a questionable mishmash one could only describe as "unpleasantly pleasant". The soothing ocean tide grapples with the sharp ringing of bicycle bells and the dull thud of a basketball hitting the ground; manmade sounds clashing with nature, each more noticeable for the contrast.

Yet Singaporeans come here daily, unbothered by the chaos. Families occupy the same barbecue pit every Sunday. An elderly couple walks the same coastal path each morning. A teenager shoots hoops on the same court. Their peace is not found in silence but in the repetition of the familiar rituals born from a noisy, crowded space. Such is a product of artificial zoning: Singapore's land scarcity forces nature to be multi-purposed and shared, resulting in an urbanised version of the outdoors that is densely populated and selectively curated. In such a place, true silence is practically impossible to find. Nonetheless, it is this exact place where we continue to see peace persisting in everybody's daily routines.

The fact that Singaporeans still come to these places to relax suggests that we have developed a unique sense of peace. Our version of peace does not lie with the standard absence of noise and is instead found in the familiarity and shared experience of a space. In a society where silence is impossible to find, we adapt and morph our expectations, finding peace in our own special way, but why does our environment shape our meaning of peace so vastly?

To understand why we can find peace in such a fast-paced environment, we can look towards Christie et al.'s (2008) work. In "Peace Psychology for a Peaceful World", Christie et al. (2008) argue that peace cannot be attained passively. They clearly segregate two types of peace: negative peace – which is the absence of violence or noise, and positive peace – the presence of social structures and relationships that keep communities thriving. Christie et al. (2008) argue that both need to be present in order for true peace to exist. In their own words: "Peace is incompatible with malnutrition, extreme poverty and the refusal of the rights of peoples to self-determination. The only lasting peace is a just peace based on respect for human rights" (Christie et al., 2008). If we analyse what Christie et al. (2008) is trying to say in the context of Pasir Ris Park, we can see that the peace that people experience there does not originate from nothing but rather on the basic foundation that negative peace has been secured. The park is safe and free from the social detriments that Christie et al. (2008) describe and therefore, positive peace from the community in Pasir Ris park can be allowed to exist on top on this foundation.

This positive peace is represented by the multitudes of different people all doing their own activities together. Pasir Ris Park is not peaceful because it is quiet, but because its people are engaged in the social structures that Christie et al. (2008) identify as essential to positive peace. While Christie et al.'s (2008) argument focuses on peace on a societal and communal level, we are still missing a huge chunk of the big picture, the subjective dimensions of peace. We need to look at peace on a more personal level to understand why different people at the same park are able to find their own versions of peace.

To fill this gap, we can look at Wolfgang Dietrich's book, *Interpretations of Peace in History and Culture*. Dietrich (2012) challenges the notion that there is only one type of peace. He argues that peace is subjective and depends heavily on how a person views their place in the world. In his book, he identifies five families of peace. Energetic peace is about harmony and relationships with the world around you. Moral peace ties peace to justice; without fairness, there can be no real peace. Modern peace is what most governments mean when they use the word "*peace*": security and the absence of war. Post-modern peace pushes back on this, questioning whether any single definition of peace can ever be authoritative. Transrational peace draws from all four, refusing to be pinned down by any one tradition. To Dietrich (2012), the categorisation of these five families is not exhaustive, and no one family is more correct than the other. Each is equally valid and depends on who the question is posed to. As he himself puts it, "every writer has some subjective viewpoint, every book must depend upon the mentality of the writer... there could be more than one legitimate possibility for thinking and living peace" (Dietrich, 2012, pp. 2 & 6).

Dietrich's (2012) work tackles directly what is observed at the park. An elderly man doing *tai chi*, a teen shooting hoops, and a family at the beach, each of them pursing a unique version of peace shaped by their own background and values. The park does not just deal out peace to everyone like a vending machine. Instead, it provides a space, and each person fills that space with whatever their environment has shaped them to desire. This is the true essence of Dietrich's (2012) point, our environment is not just there, it silently determines what peace looks like for us long before we reach the park.

By taking into account both sources, we get closer to answering our question. Christie et al. (2008) explains the big picture in terms of society and community: our environment provides us with social structures, collective participation and communal routines, all of which positive peace is built on. Thus, our environment shapes how we perceive peace as a society because it determines what social structures are available. Dietrich (2012) acts as a lens that zooms into what peace means to us individuals, as each of us is vastly different. We often draw on our own experiences and cultures, which are heavily dictated by our environments, to navigate our own versions of peace. Read together, both Christie et al. (2008) and Dietrich (2012) illustrate that our environment can deeply impact our definitions of peace, whether be it in ways larger than ourselves, such as at the communal and societal level, or in more personal ways, such as our views on where we stand in the world.

Yet neither framework was designed to solve the puzzle that is Pasir Ris Park. To that I offer the final missing piece: the role of human adaptability. Christie et al. (2008) describe the necessity for strong societal structures for peace to exist, and Dietrich (2012) covers the many ways that peace can be interpreted through different cultures and backgrounds, but neither fully grapples with what happens when these conditions change or are taken away. This is where human adaptability comes in. Adaptability is

something innate to all of humanity. It is the very quality that allows humanity to survive change instead of resisting it, a fundamental piece of what makes us human. This is evidently shown in the fact that people constantly strive to adapt, change and find new ways to achieve peace when their environment gives them no other choice. A person living in a war zone, a refugee camp, or a cramped city does not simply lose access to peace. They redefine it. They find it in smaller, more immediate things that they have more control over, such as a familiar face, a routine, a moment of stillness within the noise.

Pasir Ris Park, although chaotic, turns out to be a surprisingly honest reflection of how peace works. When silence is no longer available, we find familiarity. When solitude is not possible, we turn to community. We always adapt, and by adapting, we are constantly redefining what peace means to us. This is not unique to Singapore. Across different countries and cultures, humanity has always been constantly reshaping the meaning of peace to fit the environment they live in. The environment is what dictates the boundaries, and within these boundaries is where we find a way to experience peace.

This leads to our final piece of the puzzle, humanity. Familiarity can give us an alternative path to find peace, and our environment can tell us where to look for peace, but at the end of the day, it is up to our unique and innate human ability to adapt that allows us to walk up this path. A refugee finds solace in the predictability of a daily routine, and a family finds peace in returning to the same chaotic beach every weekend. Both are vastly different environments, yet the exact same relentless instinct of humanity is at work, to take whatever our environment throws at us and make the best out of it. Our environment shapes our meaning of peace so vastly because it is life's kitchen, and we are the chefs who get to decide what is to be made inside it.

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Non-Conformity and the Arts

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The air inside the National Gallery is clean; in fact, almost too clean. It is sterile, with any scent barely being strong enough to break this up. Only once do I notice something off – a hidden art installation made entirely of eggplants. The fragrance lingers, pushing against the suffocating neutral scent of the rest of the Gallery. It is awkward and organic, out of place compared to the ultra-polished and ultra-controlled building.

I step down the hallway, intent on making my way to an exhibition, but I get turned around quickly. The walls here all look the same, all washed in muted neutral colours that all blur into one another, making every corridor look the same. The lighting is no help, with every ray illuminating every hallway in the same way, casting the same shadows. I finally find an exhibition but this too is not much different. The same beige and cream colours have carried over into the room, and begin seeping into the paintings. Very little colour out of the usual is seen. The art itself does not seem too shocking – some nudity is seen as if to offend delicate sensibilities, but even that is tasteful, almost romantic, covering up the things that need to be covered.

"Do not touch" signs stand discreetly beside glass cases. Interaction is permitted only through approved means – a pair of standard-issue headphones, smooth and leathery, hanging neatly by an audio-visual display. Participation, it seems, must follow a script. I pick up the headphones and listen to a recorded interview of a domestic worker talking about their struggles, but even that is stilted, awkward, as if they are actively censoring the words coming out of their mouth.

Beside me, some tourists come to stand and look at the paintings. They "ooh" and "aah" at appropriate timings, take a few pictures, and quickly move on. I notice around me everyone seems to be following a pre-determined script. Voices lowered. Walk softly. Stand in front of a painting at a distance. Tilt your head. Hum in approval. Move on. This is the norm here. Anyone who deviates from this agreed-upon rhythm would surely be noticed.

The pattern is noticeable. Non-conformity exists, with nude paintings, social commentaries, and installations that disrupt the natural order, but it is limited and aestheticised. There is no chaos, there is no disorder. There is no truly uncomfortable feeling that any art invokes in you. Art is supposed to be a reflection of your innermost thoughts, a reflection of who you are. By censoring it to make it digestible to the general audience, it ensures that they can feel as if they have encountered something revolutionary without being destabilised. Rebellion is welcome, yes, as long as it is tasteful, beautiful, dressed up pretty for everyone to take photos of and show off. As I walk away from here, I cannot help but think to myself: are some forms of non-conformity more accepted than others?

In “Respectability Isn't for Us: Queerness, Non-Conformity, and the Politics of Everyday Suspicion”,

Alexander Paul Burton (2025) explores how non-conformity is often filtered through the lens of respectability. Writing in the context of queer identity and everyday social interactions, Burton (2025) argues that difference is tolerated only when it aligns with dominant norms. Individuals who present themselves in ways that appear "safe" or non-threatening are more likely to be accepted, while those who visibly challenge expectations are subject to scrutiny (Burton, 2025). As he notes, respectability operates as a kind of social currency that determines who is allowed to exist comfortably within public spaces.

This idea resonates strongly with my observations in the Gallery. The artworks that deviate from convention, whether through subject matter or form, are often presented in ways that soften their impact. Nudity becomes aesthetic rather than confrontational. Personal narratives are curated into digestible formats. It seems that non-conformity is not rejected outright, but reshaped into something more palatable.

Burton's (2025) argument suggests that this process is not accidental. Rather, it reflects a broader societal tendency to reward forms of difference that do not disrupt existing structures. In this sense, the Gallery may not simply be a neutral space for artistic expression, but one that subtly reinforces boundaries around what kinds of non-conformity are acceptable. The calm, orderly environment encourages visitors to engage with art in measured ways, limiting the possibility of more visceral or unpredictable responses.

This pattern of gatekeeping becomes clearer when examining Lih Yui K's (2024) analysis of institutional power in Singapore's art world. In “Power, Sociality and Capital: The Politics of Art Practice in Singapore”, Lih (2024) observes how artistic expression is shaped by institutional forces. Lih (2024) argues that in Singapore, art does not exist independently of the state or broader systems of power. Instead, it is influenced by funding structures, regulatory frameworks, and social expectations. Artists often have to navigate these constraints, producing work that can be exhibited and supported without crossing certain lines.

Lih's (2024) analysis introduces the idea that art is embedded within networks of power and capital, where visibility is not distributed equally. Certain forms of expression are amplified, while others remain marginal or excluded. This perspective adds another layer to my observations. The controlled environment of the Gallery –its uniform design, its structured modes of interaction– may reflect not just aesthetic choices, but institutional priorities. From this viewpoint, the selective acceptance of non-conformity becomes more understandable. Works that are visually striking yet conceptually safe are more likely to be displayed prominently. In contrast, pieces that are overtly political, disruptive, or difficult to interpret may be less visible or absent altogether. The result is a curated experience that appears diverse, but operates within carefully defined limits.

It should be noted that this source, along with Burton (2025) cited earlier, are opinion-based pieces rather than peer-reviewed scholarship. They are drawn upon here because they provide frameworks particularly relevant to understanding Singapore's Arts context and the lived dimensions of non-conformity that academic literature does not always capture as directly.

Both Burton (2025) and Lih (2024) highlight different dimensions of the same phenomenon, but together they reveal how the acceptance of non-conformity is carefully regulated. Burton (2025) focuses on social expectations, arguing that individuals who deviate from dominant norms are often pressured to present themselves in ways that appear respectable and non-threatening. In this sense, difference is tolerated only

when it does not disrupt existing hierarchies or social comfort. Lih (2024), on the other hand, examines institutional structures, demonstrating how art in Singapore is shaped by systems of funding, state influence, and cultural policy. These structures subtly determine which artistic practices gain visibility and legitimacy. When these perspectives are combined, it becomes clear that non-conformity is not simply accepted or rejected; rather, it is filtered through both social expectations and institutional frameworks.

Certain forms of deviation –particularly those that are aesthetically pleasing, symbolic, or safely abstract– are more likely to be celebrated. Others, especially those that directly challenge authority or social norms, are often marginalised or discouraged. For example, Josef Ng, a Singaporean artist, performed his work *Brother Cane* in 1994, intending to protest against the criminalisation of homosexuality in Singapore. However, that led to him facing a lifelong ban on performance art in the country (Lih, 2024). This layered filtering process suggests that the appearance of diversity within spaces may mask a deeper pattern of selective acceptance. Non-conformity is permitted, but only in forms that remain legible and manageable within the existing cultural system. In this way, what appears to be artistic freedom may instead reflect a carefully maintained balance between creativity and control.

However, it may be overly simplistic to view this entirely as a form of suppression. Institutions like the National Gallery also operate with the intention of making art accessible to a broad audience. In doing so, they may prioritise works that are easier to engage with, avoiding those that could alienate or discomfort visitors. From this perspective, the selective acceptance of non-conformity could be seen as a form of compromise rather than control – and one that need not be permanent. A gallery that wishes to embrace both diversity and coherence might, for instance, pair confrontational works with contextual framing that helps visitors engage rather than withdraw, or create dedicated spaces where more disruptive forms of expression are given room to breathe without unsettling the broader experience.

Yet, this raises further questions. If non-conformity must be moderated to be accepted, does it lose some of its meaning? Can art still challenge societal norms if it is presented in ways that minimise its disruptive potential?

In this sense, the Gallery reflects a broader tension within society. There is a desire to embrace diversity and creativity, but also a need to maintain order and coherence. Non-conformity is welcomed, but only up to a point. Beyond that, it risks becoming uncomfortable, even unacceptable.

Ultimately, the faint scent of eggplants lingering in the sterile air becomes a useful metaphor. It is noticeable, even slightly disruptive, but it does not overwhelm the space. Similarly, the forms of non-conformity present in the Gallery are allowed to surface, but only in ways that do not fundamentally challenge the system that contains them.

In a society that values both expression and control, where do we draw the line between the two? Perhaps the more pressing question is not whether non-conformity is accepted, but which forms are allowed to exist, and at what cost.

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Criteria in Writing, Provoke or Limit?

By Chen Jiani

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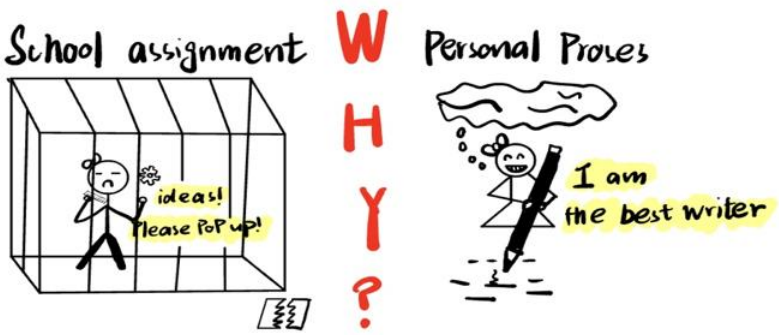

Figure 1. The contrast between forced thinking and authentic thinking

Erupting, then suddenly hardening. When this essay's theme first came to my mind, it was as if a button had been pressed in my brain and a dormant pathway had come to life. I tried to capture that surge of thoughts before they slipped away. But the moment I touched the keyboard, my inspiration vanished. Having stared at the model essay for three days, I was still trapped outside the beginning and structure. I felt as if three haunting demons were hovering around me: one laughing at the stiffness of my words, another predicting my failure halfway and the third guarding my fragile spark of inspiration, attempting to scatter it before I could shape it into language.

In a daze, my mind wandered to the silent night when I was writing personal prose. That night, my writing struggle miraculously disappeared. My fingers glided over the keyboard smoothly and effortlessly, rendering scenes spontaneously and precisely aligned with my thoughts, as if I was endowed with holy power, which unconsciously guided me. So immersed was I as I simply followed my heart instead of pursuing a flawless beginning or rigorous structure.

To secure relatively high scores with minimal risk, a writing dilemma has been deeply ingrained throughout my school years: piecing together existing persuasive viewpoints at the expense of sacrificing authentic thinking. I had originally thought such an ultimate pursuit of comprehensive views and well-planned structure could produce a coherent and impeccable work of art. Ironically, it caused hesitation and reduced fluency. By contrast, my personal writing follows an internal logic through ongoing emotional and cognitive shifts rather than deliberate planning. It surprisingly enables sustained flow and coherence, allowing ideas to flow without interruption. The difference was visible even in the words themselves. My assignment draft often begins with " Nowadays, with the development of ...", while my prose begins with "When time has stitched their wrinkles into a blossom; arm in arm, they live their lives like a painting."

My deliberate writing produces a cluttered outcome while my authentic writing unexpectedly unfolds in a natural and coherent rhythm. Such a striking phenomenon prompted me to reflect on the difference between "authentic thinking" and "forced thinking". I consider authentic thinking as an inward inquiry and exploration based on our personal experience and knowledge. Rather than beginning with an end, it lets the thoughts emerge and flow with uncertainty before they are recorded. In comparison, deliberate thinking begins with a utilitarian goal: what the audience wants to see and how to better organise the content and structure to get scores. In this context, writing is not true thinking, but the performance of thinking. It raises a broader question: how do external criteria reshape how and what we write?

In a theoretical analysis, Salvio and Boldt (2009) shed light on how writing education is reshaped under audit culture. They point out that audit culture prioritises utilitarian concepts such as standardisation, accountability and measurable results. Initial writing pedagogy oriented towards freedom of thought has been transformed into a system pursuing measurable outcomes where people externalise and modify their inner voice. As Salvio and Boldt (2009) indicate: "Audit produces a subject whose desires are framed in terms of perpetual measuring up" (p. 116). The study suggests that once the subjects are required to internalise performance metrics and render themselves transparent to external oversight, they risk being trapped in a system of compliance and measurable performance, antithetical to the original goal of inquiry and thinking

The study (Salvio & Boldt, 2009) reveals that audit culture has gradually developed into a deeper "logic governance", which permeates into a writing education that silently delivers a set of values. Under this circumstance, using viewpoints and structures conforming to social norms can give people the upper hand and bring tangible benefits, thereby blocking the expression of diverse ideas, self-exploration and expression. However, this is not as cut and dry as it seems. While Salvio and Boldt (2009) critically analyse how audit context reshapes writing pedagogy, thus affecting individual writing modes, they fail to take into account how pressures influence writers' internal thinking processes. Moreover, they overemphasise the negative impact of standards on writing while neglecting the positive side. Fundamental criteria guarantees that writing is communicable, evaluable and shareable instead of dancing in the dark, and provides a relatively fair basis when allocating resources.

In a brain study conducted by Beaty et al. (2016), the authors reveal that the production of goal-directed and self-generated thought are closely associated with the dynamic interactions of powerful brain systems: the default network which forms spontaneous inspiration and the control network which satisfies certain objectives by restraining cognition. The neuroimaging synthesis research suggests a more dominant antagonistic relationship during goal-directed tasks. The default network is suppressed and cognition control is enhanced, thus hindering divergent thinking.

This brain research (Beaty et al., 2016) illuminates how long-term external environmental factors are transformed into effects on the structure of the human brain through the brain's neural pathways, thus influencing people's true thinking. It shows that when writing is driven by outside criteria, students are likely to be forced into an "evaluation phase" once they start to write, depriving the default network of freely functioning. It suggests that if excessive constraints are exerted at the beginning of the writing, it kills thought flow and genuine emotions. As Beaty and colleagues (2016) note: "The extent of control network involvement depends on the extent to which creative

thought is constrained to meet specific task goals." (p. 8) Rather than denying the entire value of criteria, the research portrayed writing criteria as a double-edged sword: premature intrusion constrains thought while timely intervention refines it.

While Salvio and Boldt (2009) diagnose the sociological alienation of the writing process, Beaty et al.'s (2016) research adds complexity by providing empirical neuroscientific evidence, critically revealing what audit culture practically does to the human brain to reshape how people think from a micro perspective. Taken together, these studies reveal that the writing within audit culture disrupts brain conditions as it prematurely allows the control network access when it is assumed to be the responsibility of the default network. The criteria which ought to play a role in the modifying phase instead kills the free growth of ideas during the generating phase.This suggests that writing driven primarily by external criteria may no longer function as an effective tool for genuine thinking.

Nowadays, we easily fix our eyes on the results brought by good writing: opportunity, high scores and ranking. The significance of writing is gradually attached to outcomes unrelated to writing, rather than literature and the ideological values brought by writing itself. It seems that criteria have become an evil origin. But the proper state of writing is never about completely getting rid of the standard as we are all constrained by societal expectations. As it is revealed in the studies, the monopoly and premature intrusion of the criteria is to be blamed rather than its existence. Generation by the default network of the brain must be unrestrained before evaluation by the control network intervenes to achieve the delicate balance between free generation and goal-oriented constraints. This is similar to the dual nature of plant growth hormones: low concentrations promote growth while high concentrations inhibit growth.

Yet perhaps we have been blaming the wrong thing. Do these criteria barge in by themselves? The answer is definitely not. In the massacre of free thinking, the knife is never in outsiders' hands: instead, we are the real killers. We tacitly consent to criteria's dominant position and encourage it to wield the knives. Instead of giving it power, we can use the criteria as the benchmark that tests the logic of writing instead of the cave that locks us in. Ultimately, the question is not whether writing should be free from criteria but whether we can coexist with them instead of being swallowed by them. When evaluation follows exploration rather than replaces it, writing is a genuine tool to promote thinking while remaining communicable and accessible. Real promotion of thinking starts from the time when we truly recognise the joy of thinking and feel it from our hearts. There is no absolute balance point or "one size fits all" standard for how we should treat criteria. However, if we can approach the page with humility, openness and uphold our own opinions, we may just end up surprising ourselves with the thought flow we never knew we were capable of. At that time, criteria would just be criteria and no longer wield knives.

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HW0206

Academic Communication in Chinese Studies

A Tale of *Xinyao*: Investigating Singapore's Chinese Society

By Tan Hong Kiat, Jerrald
Bachelor of Arts (Hons) in Chinese

Xinyao, known as songs created by young Singaporeans who are predominantly Chinese, are performed in Mandarin (and can sometimes include various Chinese dialects like Cantonese or Hokkien). Starting in the late 1970s, *Xinyao* had its heyday in the 1980s, and to this day, remains as something that is uniquely local. Like most art, the essence of *Xinyao* lies not in its commercial value, but rather the culture it stores and preserves. Behind the simple melodies tells a tale of a forgone era — childhood nostalgia; youth experiences; and most importantly, the camaraderie of the Chinese community brought together by *Xinyao* (Kong, 1996). *Xinyao* has helped shape our identity and is what differentiates Singapore Chinese from the global Chinese community. However, with the gradual abandonment of various *Xinyao*-related events, such as the 1992 *Xinyao* award presentations, the signs of decline are starting to show (Kong, 1996). Today, as *Xinyao* continues to slowly fade into obscurity, extensive research and debate have been done on what caused its decline. Yet seldom do we ask ourselves: What happened to the values of *Xinyao*? What does this say about *Xinyao* and our society? As such, my topic of exploration is: How did *Xinyao's* decline in Singapore reflect a changing Chinese society?

The phenomenon of Singaporean youth consuming less *Xinyao* can reveal how Chinese society and culture have changed since its heyday in the eighties. In an article by Lim (2021) that talked about the closure of a local folk music cafe, he identified that youths no longer have the same appreciation for folk songs like *Xinyao*. Music is treated more as "background noise" and having songs online further reduces youths' desire to patronise such cafes. The decline in *Xinyao's* commercial value thus reflects a Chinese society whose tastes and preferences are changing, shifting from being community-based to being focused on consumerism. While Liew and Goh (2021) draw similar conclusions as Lim that *Xinyao's* decline has suggested changes in local Chinese society, their research placed more emphasis on the macro-level reasons. In their opinion, Singapore's language policies are a key reason for the decline of *Xinyao*. Ballads containing dialects were barred from airing. Even efforts to commemorate *Xinyao* have been insincere, as seen in the National Heritage Board's misspelling of the lyrics coming from a popular *Xinyao* song in their social media post. This further highlights the "cultural-linguistic marginalisation" (Liew & Goh, 2021, p. 269) of the Chinese community.

Lim's (2021) views seem to be derived from the realities of Singapore today. The advent of technology has given rise to music streaming platforms, which make listening to songs more convenient and accessible. Coupled with improvements in the music industry allowing for higher quality of songs produced and the effects of globalisation, Singaporeans today can listen to a wider variety of songs and are more

easily influenced by global trends. This is exceptionally true for the Chinese community, where a large proportion are avid fans of contemporary Mandopop. So, why Mandopop and not *Xinyao*? To answer this question, we first need to explore the inherent differences between the two genres. *Xinyao* singers came from all walks of life. They were not professional artistes prior, and it was their songs, through relatability and simplicity, that brought in listeners and followers. In other words, *Xinyao* in its early days was more about creating a shared experience, not for commercialisation purposes. Mandopop, on the other hand, was always meant to go commercial. Not only do Mandopop singers go through a slew of training, from vocals to dancing to even public relations management, they are usually also established actors, entertainers or dancers, who already have a large following. As such, the Mandopop scene today is not simply built through songs, but rather by the artiste having a strong personal brand, which results in greater commercial yields. We ought to understand that with increased consumerism, young people today, including Chinese Singaporeans, enjoy the idea of "追星" ("idol-chasing") by purchasing all sorts of merchandise and even scrambling for concert tickets just to feel closer to their idols. The Mandopop scene is able to leverage such consumeristic behaviours by turning singers into glamorous stars worthy of being admired and followed. This is something *Xinyao* failed in, as evidenced by the fact that the few *Xinyao* singers that managed to garner a personal following eventually left *Xinyao* behind too. They ventured into Mandopop in search of a bigger platform, bringing with them the fans that had been supporting them, further worsening *Xinyao's* appeal and popularity.

More importantly, *Xinyao*, singing about the people, emotions, and events of the past, no longer relates to the young Chinese community. For example, touching on the theme of "love", *Xinyao's* expression is largely subtle and tactful. However, people's views today have changed, and they much prefer Mandopop, where the expression of love is bolder and more proactive. Given these realities, *Xinyao's* decline seemed destined — a genre of songs whose core lies in simplicity and is unable to adapt to modernity, which makes it anachronistic and unappealing to Chinese listeners today.

But are those the only changes that were reflected with the decline of *Xinyao*? According to Liew and Goh (2021), probably not. As they have pointed out, Singapore's language policies have far-reaching implications not only for *Xinyao*, but also for the Chinese community. The "Speak Mandarin Campaign" launched in 1979 made Mandarin the common language of the local Chinese populace. *Xinyao*, sung mostly in Mandarin, became the "glue" that bound the fragmented Chinese community and thus yielded much success. However, the "Speak Good English Movement" initiated at the turn of the century signalled *Xinyao's* decline by solidifying English as our main official language and relegating Mandarin as a "second language" for Singaporean Chinese, resulting in a more "anglicised" community. Compared to the "Speak Mandarin Campaign", while one could argue that the "Speak Good English Movement" has garnered greater success and left a more pronounced impact on our society today, it has created irreversible harm to the appeal of *Xinyao*. Language policies have fundamentally changed how Singaporeans use languages, and this has caused *Xinyao's* fluctuating popularity.

To conclude, *Xinyao's* decline has reflected how our local Chinese community has been changing – from the one in the eighties that emphasised "kampung spirit" and communal values, to the one today that focuses less on our unique local identity and more on our globalised identity, celebrating the things that

makes us "global citizens" in this increasingly interconnected world. This can mean that the things we valued in the past, like *Xinyao*, are no longer appreciated today. Our various language policies only serve to further complicate this issue. Despite revival efforts, *Xinyao* remains sidelined today, proving that the preservation and continuation of unique and traditional arts in Singapore still have a long way to go. However, this paper can serve as a springboard for future research in finding better ways to revitalise and save these precious arts. For example, upon understanding that Singaporeans today are into "idol-chasing", we can call upon famous local artistes to be spokespeople of these disappearing arts, using the artiste's personal brand and following to bring greater attention to said arts. Or perhaps this paper can also help local songwriters and aspiring *Xinyao* artists of today to know what they can do differently to attract listeners, like being bolder in expressing feelings. Ultimately, these local arts are unique to Singapore and are a part of our valuable heritage. They are especially crucial in a society like Singapore where our intense globalisation efforts have led to us to begin questioning "What is our unique local identity?" and "What makes Singapore, Singapore?" We must not forget that local arts like *Xinyao* are what makes us stand out in this increasingly assimilated world. Some possible datasets to aid this further research could be surveys on locals' opinions on Singapore's unique arts and thorough assessments of current preservation measures.

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I would like to extend my gratitude to my tutor, Dr Hsieh Yi-Chin, for her support and guidance throughout my HW0206 journey. She has always been patient in clearing my doubts while providing encouraging and constructive feedback for me to become a better writer. I would also like to thank the Pioneer Road Committee for recognising my efforts and providing me with a valuable platform to display my work.

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Fading Traditions: Modifying Traditional Chinese Music, Catering to New Generations

By Zen Tan Chiah
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Traditional Chinese music has been played in ensembles and orchestras in Singapore since the 1950s, introduced by our forefathers from China. With the establishment of the People's Association Chinese Orchestra (now known as Singapore Chinese Orchestra) in 1974, traditional Chinese music has flourished. However, amidst Singapore's rapid economic development and increasing exposure to globalisation in the 21st Century, interest in traditional Chinese music has faced a rapid decline. As Terence Chong (2003) notes: "It has often been argued that the spread of a Western consumer monoculture destroys traditional societies and their cultures." (p. 449) With this changing cultural landscape, younger generations tend to perceive traditional Chinese music as less relevant or outdated. Therefore, local Chinese music groups face pressure to tap into modernisation to cater to newer generations, who prefer fast and catchy music. Yet, in the face of modifications, traditions can fade and lose their uniqueness. This may lead to a decline in the understanding of traditional Chinese music among future generations and a gradual dilution of Chinese culture. Hence, I am interested in exploring the extent to which traditional Chinese music should be modified to remain relevant while preserving its identity.

To explore this question, I read about how Chinese music groups in Singapore are modernising traditional Chinese music in order to reconnect with younger audiences. In Terry Ng's (2021) article, he explores how ensembles "break out of their 'archaic' impressions to attract a fresh generation of Singaporeans" (Ng, 2021, para. 17). This is made through reinventing the sonic composition of traditional music, introducing sounds and songs that younger audiences are more familiar with. These Chinese music groups attempt to engage with youths to ensure that the music they play can be widely popularised and accepted. Similarly, to support the value of modernisation in music, Diya Upreti's (2024) article explores how the modification and fusion of genres in traditional music can not only provide new experiences for audiences, but also allow cultural roots to be seen, hence "keeping traditional music relevant to younger people" (Upreti, 2024, para. 7). However, she also points out the necessity of the preservation of cultural roots. This adds on to the complexity of the discussion as the modernisation of traditional music should be a balancing act between "evolution and preservation" (para. 9).

While Ng (2021) and Upreti (2024) support modernisation, they focus on differing aspects. Ng (2021) stresses engaging audiences whereas Upreti (2024) emphasises cultural preservation. Ng (2021) illustrates practical implementation through groups such as The TENG Ensemble, whose founders noted that if they only played the traditional Chinese classical music repertoire, "nobody's going to listen to it because it's not 'hip' enough" (Ng, 2021, para. 19). To break out of archaic impressions, they use traditional

Chinese instruments to "play music from Harry Potter, Michael Jackson and Billie Eilish" (para. 20), achieving widespread appeal. However, similar approaches might raise concerns about losing the originality of cultural music. As a musician myself, the authenticity of traditional Chinese music lies in its playing techniques, orchestral composition and its tonal qualities. Traditional Chinese instruments like the *pipa*, a four-stringed pear-shaped plucked instrument, are defined by its intricate techniques and expressive capabilities. Yet, on Chinese social media platforms, some performers use modern guitar plectrum and strumming techniques to play Western pop songs, instead of using synthetic *pipa* nails and traditional playing techniques like "*tan*" (plucking forward) and "*tiao*" (plucking backward), to stand out and attract audiences' attention. Due to the alteration and oversimplification in technique, the sound projection changes, making the sound more aggressive and cutting. It thereby loses its tonal nuance and cultural identity, diluting the originality of traditional Chinese instruments just to relate to younger audiences.

In contrast, Upreti (2024) offers a theoretical perspective focused on cultural preservation. While she agrees with the importance of modernising traditional music, as it "gives it a new lease on life, letting it reach audiences that might otherwise overlook it" (Upreti, 2024, para. 9), she also points out that there is great cultural value and meaning behind the preservation of traditions in traditional music, as it "retains a sense of identity and belonging and connects people to their ancestors and land" (para. 2). As such, much careful thought should be placed in balancing the preservation of cultural authenticity and the modernisation of traditional music. In my opinion, the uniqueness of traditional Chinese music is greatly intertwined with the factors that make it authentic. To preserve this originality, much has to be done to commission creative works that are specifically written for traditional instruments, rather than relying on adaptations from Western music. For example, the Ding Yi Music Company (2023), a Singapore Chinese chamber music ensemble, held a "JIAK LOCAL!" concert in 2022, where they played a specially composed repertoire by local Singaporean composers "such as Curry Capriccio by Wang Chenwei, Flavourful Delights by Koh Cheng Jin and Floating Memories by Edmund Song" (Ding Yi Music Company, 2023, p. 11), to celebrate Singapore's distinct and diverse hawker culture. Additionally, the physical structure of traditional instruments should not be altered, to keep its original tonal quality, preserving both distinctiveness and originality.

It has been discussed that the modernisation of traditional Chinese music is extremely crucial to attract younger audiences and prevent it from becoming obsolete. However, it is also equally important to balance modernisation and preservation of traditional elements so that its uniqueness and authenticity is not compromised. While we have explored the extent of the modification of traditional Chinese instrumental music from a practical and theoretical perspective, there has not been much research on the methodology of how one should maintain the authenticity and cultural integrity of traditional Chinese music when the contemporary threatens to eclipse the former. As seen from above, the modernisation of music can often lead to the dilution of the art form, compromising cultural traditions. Therefore, it is important to research on the various approaches made by local Chinese music groups to navigate this balance between modernisation and preservation, safeguarding our traditional Chinese heritage and maintaining artistic uniqueness. These datasets could be collated through careful analysis of innovative works from local Chinese music groups and interviews with their music

directors regarding their definitions of modernisation, preservation and boundaries when creating music.

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HW0208

Academic Communication in the Social Sciences

Dollars and Dedication: Financial Incentives and Autonomous Motivation in Undergraduate Volunteering

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Introduction

Civic behaviours are voluntary actions that contribute positively to the well-being of one's community or society, such as volunteering, recycling, or fulfilling social responsibilities (Adler & Goggins, 2005; White, 2021). In Singapore, volunteerism is strongly emphasised as parts of national efforts to build a caring and cohesive society. The government launched initiatives such as the SG Cares movement, and the National Council of Social Service (NCSS) has set a target to increase the number of regular volunteers to one in two by 2030, up from the current one in three (Wong, 2025).

Volunteering is fundamentally driven by autonomous and controlled forms of motivation. Autonomous motivation includes both intrinsic motivation, which arises from inherent enjoyment or interest in the activity, and internalised forms of extrinsic motivation, such as identified and integrated regulation, whereby individuals engage in volunteering because it is personally meaningful or aligned with their values (Ryan & Deci, 2000; Frey & Oberholzer-Gee, 1997; Halvorsen, 2012). In contrast, controlled motivation involves engaging in volunteering due to external pressure, obligation or extrinsic rewards, such as recognition or material incentives, and also includes introjected regulation, where individuals volunteer to avoid guilt or maintain self-esteem amidst social pressures (Ryan & Deci, 2000). While controlled motivators are diverse, this review focuses specifically on financial incentives due to their salience in Singapore.

Surveys indicate that many Singaporeans perceive their society as "materialistic" (Sim, 2015), and Singapore's Gen Z increasingly view financial independence and security as major life goals (Gupta, 2025). Therefore, financial considerations are highly pertinent to Singaporean youth in their decision-making, making it worthwhile to examine whether financial incentives increase their civic engagement.

Literature Review

Extensive literature has examined how autonomous and controlled forms of motivation, and their interaction, shape civic behaviours. Halvorsen's (2012) international study of household recycling highlights how autonomous motivation, reflected in internalised values such as environmental concern and civic duty, serves as a stronger driver of recycling behaviour than external, controlled incentives such as monetary rewards. This finding is reinforced by local

research. According to Diehl and Chan (2021), Singaporean youths' civic participation was hindered by their perception that their engagements were personally irrelevant and unlikely to lead to meaningful change. Young adults expressed interest in participation when civic issues resonated with their personal values and when they believed their involvement could make a tangible impact, both key features of autonomous motivation. Collectively, these studies suggest that civic engagement is predominantly driven by autonomous motivation, grounded in personal values, identity relevance and a sense of agency. However, this does not negate the complementary role that controlled motivation, such as external rewards and pressures, may play in shaping civic behaviours.

Kataoka et al. (2024) emphasise that external rewards support participation among individuals with weak or absent intrinsic motivation. From an economic perspective, monetary incentives are a form of controlled motivation, to promote effort and performance (Lazear, 2000). In practice, social pressure, recognition, and monetary incentives are often used in efforts to boost civic behaviours. Similarly, Panagopoulos (2013) found that controlled motivation such as social pressures, positive reinforcement, and recognition promoted prosocial civic behaviours such as voting.

However, psychologists caution that extrinsic rewards may impair autonomous motivation. "Self-determination Theory" (Ryan & Deci, 2000) posits that autonomous motivation is maintained or strengthened when individuals perceive themselves as competent and autonomous. However, extrinsic incentives may render actions externally driven and thus diminish a sense of autonomy (Deci, 1975). Thus, Ryan and Deci (2000) argue that extrinsic motivation can undermine intrinsic motivation, which is a phenomenon referred to in economic literature as the "crowding-out" effect (Frey, 1994; Zeiske et al., 2021).

Optimistically, research also shows that well-designed financial incentives can reinforce autonomous motivation. Lee and Kim (2022) demonstrated a hybrid scheme, which integrated civic responsibility messaging with small financial rewards that reduced household electricity usage by approximately 21% relative to their usual levels, without evidence of motivation crowding-out. Similarly, Blok et al. (2023) observed that financial support for citizens' self-organising initiatives was often essential to make their projects feasible, by enabling citizens to pursue goals they already valued. Altogether, these studies suggest that financial incentives complement autonomous motivation.

Despite substantial international evidence, the interplay between autonomous motivation and financial incentives in fostering civic behaviours has not been examined in Singapore. Moreover, evidence also suggests that civic engagement habits established during youth are likely to persist into adulthood, creating a sustainable "volunteer pipeline" for future generations (Kim & Morgül, 2017). Hence, investigating how financial incentives influence youth civic engagement is both timely and significant. Findings from this study can provide policymakers and organisations with practical insights for designing volunteer programmes that effectively motivate participation, thereby advancing national goals of volunteerism, social responsibility, and community building. Therefore, our research question is "How do financial incentives interact with autonomous motivation to influence civic behaviours, such as volunteering, in undergraduates in Singapore?

Methodology

Participants

This study utilised a between-subject experimental design to investigate how financial incentives interact with autonomous motivation to influence volunteering. Participants were recruited through convenience sampling and distributed across two conditions to achieve equal control and experimental group sizes. Participants were undergraduates (N=80) who completed an anonymous Google Form (Appendix A) regarding their motivations to volunteer, which was sent via Telegram. All participants reported having volunteering experiences.

Materials and Procedure

In both conditions, we first measured our participants' baseline autonomous motivation (i.e. inherent autonomous motivation level before experimental manipulation), by assessing autonomous motivation toward volunteering on a 5-point Likert scale ranging from 'Strongly Disagree' (1) to 'Strongly Agree' (5) (see Appendix A for full items). Filler items assessing controlled motivation were included to mask the study's focus on autonomous motivation. Following this, participants read a vignette that described their university as recruiting volunteers for a community programme involving a range of activities, thus ensuring responses reflected general attitudes toward volunteering rather than interest in specific activity. Participants in the control condition did not receive financial incentives for participating in the hypothetical programme, while participants in the experimental condition received $50. Participants rated their likelihood of signing up using the 5-point Likert scale ranging from 'Very Unlikely' (1) to 'Very Likely' (5). Following the likelihood rating, all participants completed items that assessed motivation underlying their decision using the 5-point Likert Scale. The experimental group completed three items measuring both autonomous and controlled motivation while the control group completed two autonomous motivation items (see Appendix A for full items).

Results

80 undergraduate participants completed the survey (n=40 control, n=40 experimental). The survey findings will be reported in four different segments.

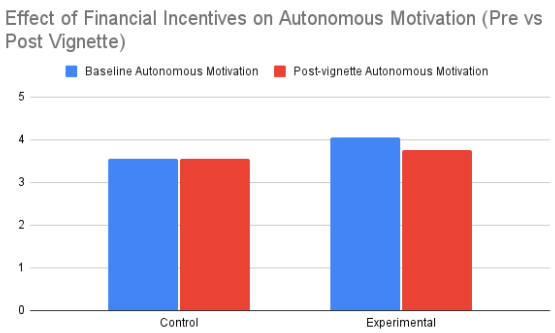
Part 1: Main Effects of Financial Incentives on Likelihood to Sign Up for Volunteering

We examined whether financial incentives influence participants' likelihood of signing up for volunteering. Participants in the experimental condition (M=3.93, SD=0.99) reported higher likelihood compared to the control condition (M=3.20, SD=1.04). Financial incentives were associated with higher volunteering likelihood.

Part 2: Effect of Financial Incentives on Autonomous Motivation

Figure 1

Pre vs. Post Vignette Autonomous Motivation by Condition



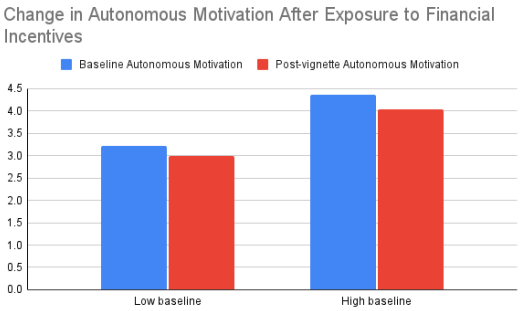
We examined whether financial incentives affected participants' autonomous motivation, by comparing baseline and post-vignette autonomous motivation levels across conditions. In the control condition, baseline autonomous and post-vignette autonomous motivation level remained unchanged (M=3.56),

whereas in experimental condition, there was a decrease of 0.29 from baseline (M=4.04) to post-vignette (M=3.75). The experimental condition demonstrated a greater reduction in autonomous motivation (M=0.29) compared to control condition, which showed no change (see Figure 1).

Part 3: Change in Autonomous Motivation after Exposure to Financial Incentives

Figure 2

Pre vs. Post-Vignette Autonomous Motivation by Baseline levels

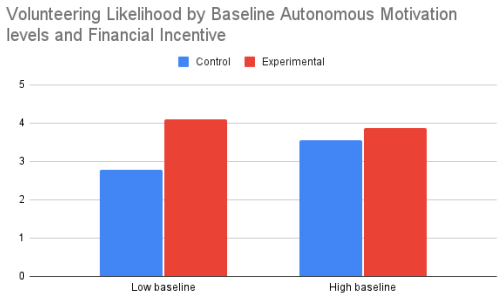


To examine baseline differences in autonomous motivation between the high and low baseline groups, all participants in the experimental group were categorised into high and low baseline groups using a median split (Mdn=3.5). In the experimental group, low baseline individuals (M=3.23 baseline, M=3.00 post-vignette), autonomous motivation showed minimal change of 0.23. While there was a decrease of 0.32 in motivation among high baseline individuals, from baseline (M=4.35) to post-vignette level (M=4.03). These findings suggest that the effect of financial incentives on autonomous motivation was greater among participants with initially high autonomous motivation (see Figure 2).

Part 4: Volunteering Likelihood by Baseline Autonomous Motivation and Financial Incentive

Figure 3

Volunteering Likelihood by Baseline Level and Condition



Lastly, we examined how baseline autonomous motivation interacted with financial incentives to influence the likelihood of volunteering. Low autonomous baseline individuals showed a substantial difference between control (M=2.78) and experimental (M=4.09) conditions. Exposure to financial incentive was associated with an increase of volunteering likelihood by 1.31. In contrast, among the high baseline individuals, volunteering likelihood was M=3.55 in the control and M=3.86 in the experimental condition, representing a modest increase of 0.31 with financial incentives. These findings indicate that financial incentives more strongly influenced volunteering likelihood among participants with initially low autonomous motivation (see Figure 3).

Discussion

This study aimed to address how financial rewards interact with autonomous motivation in volunteering. Our findings suggested that financial incentives acted as a complementary motivator for people with low baseline autonomous motivations, while it might also pose a risk of crowding out inherent autonomous motivations for those with high baseline autonomous motivations.

Interpretation and Explanation of Key Findings

In Part 1, we found that the experimental group with financial incentives reported a higher overall likelihood for signing up to volunteer (M=3.93) compared to the control group without financial incentives (M=3.20), which aligns with the economic perspective that financial incentives promote effort and participation (Lazear, 2000). This suggests that among undergraduates, introducing a financial incentive can lead to an increase in volunteering participation. It aligns with Sim's (2015) research where Singaporeans view their society as "materialistic", and combined with the rise of financial considerations among youths (Gupta, 2025), possibly made financial incentives an effective controlled motivator for the participants.

However, the interplay between financial incentives and autonomous motivations gave rise to our most critical insight. Part 4 demonstrated a significant difference in how financial incentives influence individuals of different levels of baseline autonomous motivation. The likelihood of volunteering in low baseline autonomous motivation individuals showed a substantial increase of 1.31 when offered a financial incentive. In comparison, the likelihood of volunteering in individuals with high baseline autonomous motivation only showed a modest increase of 0.31. This supports Zeiske et al.'s (2021) argument that financial incentives may provide individuals with lower intrinsic motivation with an additional motive to engage in behaviour that they otherwise would not perform.

Additionally, Part 2 and 3 show a potential crowding-out effect among individuals who were initially highly autonomously motivated. Results from Part 2 showed that exposure to financial incentives led to a reduction in autonomous motivation in the experimental group, while the control group's level remained stable. This finding is further reinforced by Part 3, which demonstrated a greater reduction in autonomous motivation among individuals with high baseline autonomous motivation compared to those with low baseline autonomous motivation. This may be because these individuals initially engaged in the activity due to personal interest or internalised values, and the introduction of external rewards shifted their perceived reason for engagement from autonomous to controlled, thereby undermining their sense of autonomy. In contrast, those with low baseline autonomous motivation had less internalised motivation to be displaced. This supports Ryan and Deci's (2000) Self-Determination Theory, which proposed that external rewards can diminish autonomous motivation by making behaviour feel more controlled rather than self-endorsed.

Implications

The findings contribute practical implications for policymakers and non-profit organisations aiming to meet the NCSS goal (Wong, 2025). Financial incentives can be used to recruit new volunteers who have low autonomous motivation. Programmes can be designed to target these individuals to increase overall participation rates. However, because extrinsic rewards risk crowding out autonomous motivation, it is equally important to strengthen autonomous drivers such as personal values, social connectedness and perceived impact within volunteer programmes. For existing volunteers with high autonomous motivation, financial rewards can be reframed to align with their values to prevent crowding-out. Incentives could be not presented as payment, but rather a token of appreciation, reimbursement of costs incurred, and transportation coverage.

Limitations

The convenience sampling of undergraduates generalises the broader Singaporean youth population. The use of vignette and self-report of autonomous motivation levels measures hypothetical sign up rates in volunteering which may not accurately reflect actual volunteering participation. Future research should examine actual volunteering retention rates and investigate if the crowding-out effect leads to a higher attrition rate among individuals with originally high levels of autonomous motivation. Researchers should also explore different combinations of types (cash versus vouchers) and framing (stipend versus reward) of financial incentives to find an optimal structure for maximising high volunteering rates, while also minimising the crowding-out effect.

Conclusion

In this study, the interplay between financial incentives and autonomous motivations in shaping the likelihood of volunteering were examined. Results obtained showed that financial incentives are powerful in boosting overall volunteering participation rates, especially for individuals with low levels of autonomous motivation, but pose a risk of crowding out internal motivations of those with high levels of autonomous motivation. These findings suggest that to advance Singapore's national goals for volunteering, policymakers and non-profit organisations should adopt strategies that use financial rewards to **incentivise** new volunteers, while also preserving the integrity of volunteering to prevent crowding out in existing volunteers. Moving forward, these insights can serve as a basis for designing volunteer programmes that leverage both controlled and autonomous motivators to build a society that truly cares.

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Appendix

Appendix A

Quantitative Survey Questionnaire

<table>
<tr><th>Experimental Group</th><th>Control Group</th></tr>
<tr><td colspan="2">Section 1: Screening Questions</td></tr>
<tr><td colspan="2">Respondents are to indicate Yes or No for the following questions.
Q1. Are you currently an undergraduate student?
Q2. Have you ever volunteered before?</td></tr>
<tr><td colspan="2">Section 2: Baseline Autonomous Motivation Level</td></tr>
<tr><td colspan="2">Respondents are to indicate to what extent they agree or disagree with the following statements (Q3-10, 12-14) with the following choices:
- Strongly Disagree
- Disagree
- Neutral
- Agree
- Strongly Agree
Q3. I volunteer because I find it personally interesting and enjoyable.
Q4. I volunteer because it will look good on my CV or help my career.
Q5. I volunteer because it makes me feel that I am doing something worthwhile.
Q6. I volunteer because I will receive a reward (e.g., stipend, gift, certificate).
Q7. I volunteer because I identify with the organisation's social cause.
Q8. I volunteer because others expect me to / to meet requirements.
Q9. I volunteer because it aligns with my personal values.
Q10. I volunteer to gain recognition from peers or faculty.</td></tr>
<tr><td colspan="2">Section 3: Vignette</td></tr>
<tr><td>Respondents are to indicate to what extent they would sign up for the programme in Q11 with the following choices:
- Very unlikely to sign up
- Unlikely to sign up
- Neutral
- Likely to sign up
- Very likely to sign up
Your university is recruiting volunteers for a community programme (tutoring, picking up trash,</td><td>Respondents are to indicate to what extent they would sign up for the programme in Q11 with the following choices:
- Very unlikely to sign up
- Unlikely to sign up
- Neutral
- Likely to sign up
- Very likely to sign up
Your university is recruiting volunteers for a</td></tr>
</table>

recycling, befriending elderly, giving out food etc.) (2 hours/week). Volunteers will receive a $50 gift card per month as a token of appreciation. Q11. How likely are you to sign up for this programme?	community programme (tutoring, picking up trash, recycling, befriending elderly, giving out food etc.) (2 hours/week). Volunteers will receive training and support and will help local students. No external reward (no gift card, certificate, or formal recognition) will be offered for participation. Q11. How likely are you to sign up for this programme?
Section 4: Motivation Items	
Q12. I would volunteer mainly because of the reward offered. Q13. I would volunteer mainly because I find the activity meaningful. Q14. I expect I would enjoy the community programme.	Q12. I would volunteer mainly because I find the activity meaningful. Q13. I expect I would enjoy the community programme.

Who Can Afford Peace of Mind? Socioeconomic Inequality in Coping Strategies Among Singaporean University Students

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Introduction

Socioeconomic status (SES) refers to a person's position in the social hierarchy, encompassing factors such as income, education, and occupation (Bradley & Corwyn, 2002). It is closely linked to both physical and mental health, with people of lower SES more likely to experience greater stress and more health-risk behaviours (Algren et al., 2018). Apart from stress levels, an individual's SES also shapes the way they respond to stress. Coping strategies, as defined by Stephenson & DeLongis (2020), are the actions taken by an individual to manage internal and external stressors. As access to various avenues that foster emotional well-being is strongly determined by material conditions, coping strategies largely differ according to one's SES (Bradley & Corwyn, 2002).

Understanding how youths of different SES experience and cope with stress is especially crucial as many are students navigating academic demands alongside social and developmental transitions. This paper explores the relationship between SES and student well-being, focusing on how socioeconomic disparities affect the levels of stress they experience and the coping strategies they use. We begin with a literature review examining the influence of SES on student well-being at both a global and local scale. We then outline our methodology which employs a quantitative research design to collect data on Singaporean university students' household income, stress levels, and coping strategies. Following this, we present our results and discuss our findings in relation to existing research, assessing their theoretical and practical implications. Finally, we conclude with our key takeaways and recommendations for future research.

Literature Review

Globally, research highlights SES as a key determinant of student well-being, influencing how youths around the world manage the pressures of education. Socioeconomic disparities have been shown to affect university students' perceived social support and self-efficacy (Huang & Wang, 2023). Perceived social support refers to an individual's perceptions of readily available sources of help, while self-efficacy reflects one's belief in one's ability to carry out tasks and accomplish goals. Observing university students in China, Huang & Wang (2023) found that perceived social support and self-efficacy mediated the associations between SES and mental health. Higher SES students had stronger self-efficacy and greater perceived social support from family and external networks, allowing them to adopt proactive coping strategies when stressed. Conversely, lower SES students did not benefit to the same extent from

perceived social support and exhibited weaker self-efficacy, making them more likely to resort to maladaptive coping behaviours instead. Similar patterns can be seen in the United States, where nearly half of university students reported having student debt (Lindgren et al., 2023). The additional financial pressure and heightened socioeconomic instability resulted in elevated stress levels across the student population, with the impact particularly pronounced among those of lower SES. Lindgren et al. (2023) identified a consistent link between lower SES, increased stress, and problematic habits like excessive drinking. Altogether, these findings suggest that socioeconomic disadvantages not only exacerbate student stress but also constrain coping strategies, limiting one's ability to respond to stressors healthily.

Likewise, SES plays a pivotal role in shaping students' well-being in Singapore. Moosa et al. (2023) found that higher SES students in Post-Secondary Education Institutions, such as junior colleges and polytechnics, displayed greater resilience and recovered from adversity more quickly and effectively than their lower SES counterparts. Lower SES students struggled to manage the combined demands of school, examinations, and extracurricular activities while balancing social and family life, which intensified their stress levels. This accumulated stress frequently manifested in negative coping behaviours that posed long-term health risks. Smoking was closely linked to stress in youths, with the effects of nicotine functioning as a temporary buffer against stressful stimuli (Subramaniam et al., 2025). In essence, existing research supports the notion that socioeconomic disadvantages in Singapore increase students' vulnerability to stressors and steer them towards maladaptive coping strategies with negative implications for their physical health.

The current literature shows that SES has a large influence on student well-being. While studies have examined university students globally, research on university students in Singapore remains limited, with most local studies focusing only on pre-university students. University students in Singapore are a key demographic to consider as they occupy a pivotal life stage, navigating the transition from adolescence to adulthood in a competitive, fast-paced society. Moreover, prior research was conducted during the COVID-19 pandemic, when students faced unique disruptions including online learning, social isolation, and health anxieties. In the current post-pandemic period, students might encounter new stressors and evolving coping strategies that warrant further exploration. This paper, therefore, seeks to answer the following research question: How do socioeconomic disparities shape the way university students in Singapore experience and cope with stress?

Methodology

To answer our research question, we adopted a quantitative research design, collecting data from university students in Singapore through an online survey. The objective of the survey was to investigate how socioeconomic disparities affect the way university students experience stress and the type of coping strategies they adopt.

A total of 81 participants were recruited using convenience sampling (see Appendix A for demographics) via a Google Form link that was shared in various student group chats on Telegram, such as Nanyang Technological University's (NTU) NTUstudenthub and Singapore Management University's sg_smu. To allow sufficient time for responses to accumulate, the survey was conducted over the course of a week. All participants were currently enrolled in one of Singapore's six

autonomous universities at the time of data collection. It is important to acknowledge that our sampling method has inherent limitations. By recruiting participants through accessible group chats, our sample may not be fully representative of the broader university student population in Singapore. As such, our decision to use convenience sampling affects the generalisability of our findings. In addition, we cannot calculate a precise response rate as the total number of people who viewed the survey link is unknown, limiting our ability to assess potential non-response bias.

Since this study was conducted as part of an undergraduate research project, formal institutional ethics board approval was not required. Nevertheless, we adhered to ethical research principles throughout the study. Participation was fully voluntary, with informed consent obtained from each respondent at the beginning of the survey. Data was collected anonymously without requesting for any personal identifiers like names or email addresses, ensuring confidentiality and encouraging more honest responses.

The survey combined primarily closed-ended questions with two open-ended questions, enabling us to capture the breadth and depth of the survey (see Appendix B for questionnaire). Closed-ended questions reduced ambiguity and inconsistencies in responses by allowing participants to select from a range of fixed options, while open-ended questions allowed them to express themselves further beyond the options provided. It should be noted that although data on household size was collected, the inclusion of the response category "5 or more" prevented precise calculation of household members for larger families. Consequently, we were unable to compute per-capita income, which would have provided a more accurate measure of SES than household income alone.

Responses were automatically compiled in Google Forms, exported to Google Sheets, and analysed using SPSS. We employed Pearson correlation analysis to investigate the relationships between monthly household income and both stress frequency and coping strategies. While we recognise that Spearman's rank correlation would be more appropriate given the ordinal nature of some variables, we proceeded with Pearson correlation for this exploratory analysis. Future research should use more appropriate non-parametric tests.

Results

In this section, the quantitative data is categorised and presented in tables to analyse the relationship between SES, stress, and coping strategies employed by university students (n = 81). To examine the relationship between monthly household income and stress, a correlation test was conducted.

Figure 1

Correlation test table between monthly household income and stress frequency (n = 81, two-tailed)

Correlations

		MonthlyIncome	Stress
MonthlyIncome	Pearson Correlation	1	-.023
	Sig. (2-tailed)		.837
	N	81	81
Stress	Pearson Correlation	-.023	1
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.837	
	N	81	81

The correlation between monthly household income and stress frequency was not statistically significant at the conventional level of $\alpha = 0.05$ ($r = -0.023$, $p = 0.84$, two-tailed, n = 81). The results suggest that monthly household income does not have a substantial effect on how often university students feel stressed. Upon further analysis, however, there was an observable pattern of SES affecting coping styles. Thus, we investigated the relationship between the two variables using a correlation test again.

Figure 2

Correlation test between monthly household income and seeking professional help outside (n = 81, two-tailed)

Correlations

		MonthlyIncome_SGD	Seeking_professional_help_outside
MonthlyIncome_SGD	Pearson Correlation	1	.195
	Sig. (2-tailed)		.081
	N	81	81
Seeking_professional_help_outside	Pearson Correlation	.195	1
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.081	
	N	81	81

The correlation between monthly household income and seeking professional help outside was positive but not statistically significant at the conventional level of α = 0.05 (r = 0.195, p = 0.081, two-tailed, n = 81). While we are unable to conclude a reliable relationship in this sample, the direction of association suggests a possible trend whereby university students from higher-income households are more likely to seek external professional help, indicating that financial resources may facilitate greater ability or willingness to pursue support. This warrants further investigation using larger samples and more precise SES measures, such as per-capita income.

Figure 3

Correlation test between monthly household income and engaging in self-destructive behaviour (n = 81, two-tailed)

Correlations

		MonthlyIncome_SGD	Engaginginselfdestructivebehaviour
MonthlyIncome_SGD	Pearson Correlation	1	-.234*
	Sig. (2-tailed)		.036
	N	81	81
Engaginginselfdestructivebehaviour	Pearson Correlation	-.234*	1
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.036	
	N	81	81

The correlation between monthly household income and engaging in self-destructive behaviour was a small but statistically significant negative correlation (r = -0.234, p = 0.036, two-tailed, n = 81). The results suggest that university students from lower-income households are more likely to engage in unhealthy behaviours, potentially reflecting limited access to resources and support, which contributes to less adaptive means of coping.

In addition to the quantitative data, two open-ended questions were analysed to provide contextual insights into university students' stressors and coping strategies. When asked about their sources of stress, participants cited interpersonal uncertainty (e.g., "Situationship"), performance pressure (e.g., "Performance in external commitments like hobbies/CCA"), high self-standards (e.g., "I have high standards for myself"), and health-related concerns (e.g., "Being sick causes a backlog that adds stress"). Regarding changes in coping strategies before and after the COVID-19 pandemic, many reported seeking social or formal support (e.g., "Being more open about my feelings and reaching out", "Started therapy"), adopting reflective or problem-solving approaches (e.g., "I started going to church more often", "Rethinking who should be in my circle and the people that should take up my energy"), and developing healthier lifestyle habits (e.g., "Exercise more"). A minority described potentially maladaptive changes, such as increased screen time (e.g., "Playing phone more") or alcohol consumption (e.g., "I started drinking"). These qualitative responses illustrate the multifaceted nature of stress and coping, encompassing interpersonal relationships, academic and personal performance standards, health and lifestyle, and support networks.

Discussion

The lack of correlation between monthly household income and frequency of stress suggests that all university students, regardless of SES, experience similar stress levels. This may be attributed to Singapore's characteristics as a highly competitive society, where the pressure to perform and succeed

is intense across all socioeconomic groups (Poh, 2018). Results from the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) Programme for International Student Assessment showed that school-related anxiety is particularly high among students in Singapore, with 76% reporting feeling very stressed over a test even when well prepared (OECD, 2017). This is significantly higher than the OECD average of 55%, showing how stress may be a universal feature of student life in Singapore, driven less by material disadvantages and more by systemic demands.

With that being said, the absence of correlation does not necessarily indicate the absence of an underlying relationship between the two variables. Our operationalisation of stress offers a plausible alternative explanation for this finding. By measuring only stress frequency rather than intensity or chronicity, we may have missed out on important differences across university students of varying SES. Lower SES students may experience more severe or chronic stress even if they report similar frequency levels to higher SES students, thereby obscuring any underlying correlation.

Although SES showed no relationship with stress levels, patterns emerged in the coping strategies used by university students. Our survey found that active coping strategies, like seeking external professional help, were used mostly by higher SES (≥ SGD 11,000) students. On the other hand, lower SES (SGD 3,000 to 4,999) students were more likely to engage in self-destructive behaviours, such as drinking and smoking. The open-ended responses are broadly consistent with this interpretation. While some participants described shifting toward greater help-seeking and more active coping since the COVID-19 pandemic, others reported increasingly maladaptive strategies. Together, the data suggests that socioeconomic disparities manifest less in the frequency of stress experienced and more in how university students manage that stress.

Several factors may explain why lower SES students resort to passive coping strategies when they feel stressed. Financial barriers play a major role, as lower SES students often avoid external professional mental health services due to the high perceived cost of treatment (Subramaniam et al., 2019). Despite other cost-friendly alternatives like school counselling services, youths also report fear over the stigma attached to poor mental health and see it as something to be ashamed about, making them reluctant to seek help even when readily available (Pang et al., 2017). In contrast, higher SES students are more likely to adopt proactive coping strategies since they benefit from greater perceived social support and self-efficacy, explaining why most respondents who selected "Seeking professional help outside" as a coping strategy were predominantly from higher-income households (Huang & Wang, 2023).

Our results are consistent with previous literature framing SES as a key factor influencing coping strategies. From our study, it is evident that university students of lower SES tend to engage in maladaptive, self-destructive behaviours to deal with stress, aligning with the findings of Lindgren et al. (2023) and Subramaniam et al. (2025). This is further supported by existing research which underscores a lack of financial resources as the main reason for limited access to healthier coping options, especially regarding external professional mental health services and treatment (Subramaniam et al., 2019). At the same time, our findings diverge from prior studies that reported higher stress levels among lower SES students in Singapore (Moosa et al., 2023). Unlike in China and the United States, stress appears to be universally high in Singapore across all socioeconomic backgrounds. This is likely a result of

the competitive nature of our education system, where academic pressures override socioeconomic differences in stress exposure (Ng, 2020). Overall, our findings point to a persistent inequality not in the amount or frequency of stress faced by university students in Singapore, but in the type of coping behaviours they exhibit.

Implications

The identification of a socioeconomic divide in coping strategies carries several significant implications. On a theoretical level, there is a need to consider structural inequalities in student well-being models by exploring how institutional support systems might mediate the association between SES and coping strategies. For policy and practice, university mental health initiatives should focus on taking concrete steps to equip students with accessible, healthier coping options, such as stress management workshops, peer support groups, or subsidised referrals to external professional mental health services. Integrating mental health literacy into academic settings could also encourage help-seeking and reduce stigma. In the future, studies could investigate whether such institutional support actually helps to narrow the gap in coping mechanisms, shifting lower SES students away from maladaptive behaviours and towards healthier coping styles.

Limitations

Our reliance on self-report measures may have resulted in an underestimation of certain maladaptive coping behaviours. Social desirability bias may have led respondents to underreport behaviours such as substance use, meaning these coping strategies could be more prevalent than our data suggests. Additionally, our sample demographics are skewed in favour of certain groups (female, Chinese, and NTU students). Future research should employ stratified sampling to ensure greater representation across gender, ethnicity, and university, allowing for more generalisable and inclusive findings. Longitudinal or qualitative approaches would also offer deeper insights into university students' lived experiences and provide a more nuanced understanding of how coping strategies evolve over time.

Conclusion

Focusing on an underrepresented population in local research, this paper examined how socioeconomic inequality affects stress and coping among university students in post-pandemic Singapore. Our findings suggest that while SES does not significantly influence stress levels, likely due to Singapore's competitive education system affecting all students equally, it is a key determinant of coping strategies. Lower SES students engage more frequently in maladaptive behaviours compared to their higher SES counterparts who benefit from greater access to external resources and support. While these findings should be interpreted with caution given their limitations, they nonetheless draw attention to a critical yet underexplored dimension of inequality that carries important implications for student well-being. Moving forward, there is an urgent need for institutional interventions that ensure equitable access to adaptive coping strategies for all students.

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Appendix

Appendix A

Demographics of Participants

Demographics of Participants

	Participants (n=81)	%
Gender		
Male	26	67.9
Female	55	32.1
Age		
18-20	27	33.3
21-23	47	58.0
24-26	5	6.2
Race		
Chinese	68	84.0
Malay	5	6.2
Indian	6	7.4
Japanese	1	1.2
American	1	1.2
University		
NTU	60	74.1
NUS	7	8.6
SUSS	6	7.4
SMU	5	6.2
SIT	3	3.7
Year of Study		
Year 1	17	21.0
Year 2	43	53.1
Year 3	13	16.0
Year 4	8	9.9

Appendix B

Quantitative Survey Questionnaire

Q1. What is your age?

18 - 20

21 - 23

24 - 26

27 - 29

30 or older

Q2. What is your gender?

Male

Female

Other:

Q3. What is your ethnicity?

Chinese

Malay

Indian

Other:

Q4. What is your citizenship status?

Singaporean

Permanent Resident

Foreign citizen

Q5. What university are you from?

NTU

NUS

SIT

SMU

SUSS

SUTD

Other:

Q6. What major are you studying?

Q7. What is your year of study?

1

2

3

4

Graduate school

Q8. What is your estimated monthly household income (in SGD)?

Below $3,000

$3,000 - $4,999

$5,000 - $7,999

$8,000 - $10,999

$11,000 - $14,999

$15,000 - $19,999

$20,000 or over

Q9. How many people live in your household (including yourself)?

1

2

3

4

5 or more

Q10. Are you a recipient of financial aid, bursaries, or scholarships?

Yes

No

Q11. What are your sources of personal income? Select all that apply.

Allowance from parents

Part-time job(s)

Scholarship allowance

None

Other:

Q12. How often do you feel stressed?

Almost every day

A few times a week

A few times a month

Rarely or never

Q13. How would you describe the change in your overall stress levels since the COVID-19 pandemic?

Significantly increased

Slightly increased

No change

Slightly decreased

Significantly decreased

Q14. How often do school demands (exams, projects, extracurriculars) cause you stress?

Almost every day

A few times a week

A few times a month

Rarely or never

Q15. How often do financial pressures (tuition fee, living expenses) cause you stress?

Almost every day

A few times a week

A few times a month

Rarely or never

Q16. How often do issues pertaining social life (friendships, romantic relationships) cause you stress?

Almost every day

A few times a week

A few times a month

Rarely or never

Q17. How often do issues pertaining family life (parental expectations, household responsibilities) cause you stress?

Almost every day

A few times a week

A few times a month

Rarely or never

Q18. How often do uncertainties about the future (career, further studies) cause you stress?

Almost every day

A few times a week

A few times a month

Rarely or never

Q19. Please specify other factors that cause you stress. If there are none, input 'NA'.

Q20. How do you usually cope with stress? Select all that apply.

Talking to friends or family

Engaging in sports

Playing video games

Consuming media (reading, watching shows, listening to music, going on social media)

Meditation, mindfulness, or relaxation exercises

Turning to religious practices

Seeking professional help in school (counselling services, student wellness programs)

Seeking professional help outside (therapist, doctor)

Engaging in self-destructive behaviour (drinking, smoking)

Other:

Q21. How often do you use these coping strategies?

Almost every day

A few times a week

A few times a month

Rarely or never

Q22. How effective do you find these coping strategies in reducing stress?

Very effective

Somewhat effective

Not effective at all

Q23. Have your coping strategies changed since the COVID-19 pandemic? If so, would you describe this change as mostly positive or negative?

Yes, the change was mostly positive.

Yes, the change was mostly negative.

Yes, the change was both positive and negative.

No, there was no change.

Unsure

Q24. If you selected 'Yes', please specify the ways in which your coping strategies have changed since the COVID-19 pandemic (e.g., starting new good/bad habits, changing who you turn to for support). If you selected 'No' or 'Unsure', input 'NA'.

The Power of Media Framing: Shaping Inflation Perception and Consumer Behaviour in Singapore

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Introduction

Mass online media plays a central role in how individuals consume and interpret information, often through message framing that presents content to emphasise specific benefits (gain-frame) or risks (loss-frame). We refer to gain-frame and loss-frame as positively and negatively framed messaging, respectively. Linking to existing studies, the media frames that individuals consume strongly shape their perceptions of inflation (Lamla & Lein, 2014), with higher levels of media coverage associated with reduced inflation bias among consumers (Ehrmann et al., 2017). Inflation bias, a component of inflation perception, reflects how individuals misjudge actual inflation. Consequently, these perceptions influence consumer behaviour and alter purchasing decisions about durable and non-durable goods (Burke & Ozdagli, 2023). As consumer behaviour impacts macroeconomic stability, it is important to understand the factors that influence an individual's purchasing decision-making process. This study hence aims to investigate the relationship between online media message framing, inflation perception, and consumer behaviour in Singapore.

Literature Review

Inflation perception, defined as how individuals interpret current inflation levels, influences consumer behaviour. Although inflation data and central bank announcements about economic outlook are publicly available, most consumers receive such information through online media (Blinder & Krueger, 2004). This literature review examines the influence of online media framing on individuals' inflation perception and subsequently, their consumer behaviour.

Inflation perception is shaped by how online media frames inflation and what is emphasised. In America, news coverage presents competing narratives about inflation. Inflation is framed either as a cost-of-living crisis affecting households ("Main Street") or a monetary policy issue regarding interest rates ("Wall Street") (Macaulay & Song, 2023). When the inflation rate exceeds the policy's target, exposure to "Main Street" narratives makes consumers more pessimistic, compared to "Wall Street" narratives. In Singapore, Clark et al. (2018) reveal a "perception gap", where domestic households usually overestimate the inflation rate compared to the official Consumer Price Index. Here, media emphasis on daily necessities spending magnifies this perception gap, making inflation feel more severe than

macroeconomic reality. These sources establish how different media framing and the aspects they emphasise about inflation's effects shape consumers' inflation perceptions. However, these studies do not consider if inflation is framed as explicitly positive (emphasising improving, or reduced costs) or negative (emphasising burden on households, or uncertainty), and how this emotional valence affects inflation perception.

Furthermore, perception and consumer behaviour are conditional on the type of consumable. Burke and Ozdagli (2023) highlight that U.S. college-educated individuals spend considerably more on durable goods such as cars, furniture, and household appliances when they expect inflation to rise. Meanwhile, for non-durable goods, including groceries, food, and other everyday necessities, spending remains unchanged regardless of shifting inflation expectations. The distinction between durable and non-durable goods is significant because it may reflect different consumer decision-making processes. Durable goods purchases are typically discretionary and can be postponed, making them more sensitive to shifts in inflation expectations. Conversely, non-durable goods are essential, routine expenditures that consumers cannot easily defer. Hence, their demand remains relatively inelastic to short-term inflation expectations. By examining both categories, this study captures the nuanced ways in which media framing may influence spending across different types of consumption. The distinction suggests that inflation perception may alter spending on big investment durable goods, but makes no difference to daily non-durable goods. Hence, changes in inflation perception do not always lead to changes in consumer behaviour.

Together, the studies reveal that media framing of inflation (Macaulay & Song, 2023) may cause individuals to overestimate inflation (Clark et al., 2018), but may not necessarily influence consumer behaviour (Burke & Ozdagli, 2023). However, these studies do not specify whether inflation news is framed positively or negatively, and how this valence affects consumer behaviour. Although Clark et al. (2018) examine Singapore, they do not address how inflation is framed. Furthermore, the remaining studies are conducted primarily in the U.S. context. This limits their applicability to Singapore, where the economy is highly open and import-dependent, causing domestic prices to respond more quickly to global inflationary pressures. In addition, Singaporeans rely heavily on online news and social media, alongside official government communication, when forming expectations about inflation. These characteristics may influence how media framing shapes inflation perceptions and expected consumer behaviour. Thus, it remains underexplored how positive versus negative framing in online news articles and social media posts shape inflation perceptions and subsequently expected consumer behaviour in Singapore. As actual consumer behaviour is difficult to observe, examining expected consumer behaviour as a proxy variable can provide insights into the effects of media framing. This study asks: "To what extent does online media message framing affect the individual's inflation perception and expected consumer behaviour in Singapore?"

Methodology

This study adopted a mixed-method approach, combining quantitative and qualitative methods in an online survey. The survey examines changes in individuals' inflation perceptions and expected consumer behaviour after exposure to positive or negative media frames of inflation. Respondents answered an online questionnaire consisting of rating-scale questions regarding spending decisions and open-ended questions to uncover additional insights. Though open-ended questions were included

to capture qualitative responses, responses were limited and non-substantive. Thus, only quantitative data was primarily analysed.

The survey instrument, including the embedded news framing stimuli, is provided in the Appendix. The positive and negative frames differ primarily in tone and language use, with the positive frame emphasising economic stabilisation and improvement, while the negative frame highlights rising costs and economic pressure. The stimuli presented consists of snapshots of real news headlines along with short excerpts, taken from popular news and media platforms that Singaporeans may encounter. To ensure that responses reflected the content rather than source credibility, the names of these platforms were intentionally masked. This allowed the study to isolate the effect of message framing itself, independent of how much trust or influence respondents might attribute to specific media outlets.

Quota and convenience sampling were employed to achieve representation across key demographic groups. Specifically, quotas were set based on age, with participants intended to be evenly distributed between university students and working adults. A target sample size of 80 respondents was established, with participants recruited primarily through personal networks. Seniors and retirees were initially considered but were excluded due to recruitment constraints and concerns regarding response quality. Participants were assigned to either a negative or a positive message frame. The survey comprised the following sections:

1. Pre-reading inflation perception and expected consumer behaviour,
2. Exposure to positively or negatively framed online media on inflation,
3. Post-reading inflation perception and expected consumer behaviour,
4. Demographic information.

Questions on inflation perception were measured with semantic differential scales (e.g., "Expected price increase/decrease", "No impact/Strong impact"). Questions on spending decisions were answered using price ranges (e.g., "301 - 600", "601 - 900"). *Caifan* (mixed rice) was selected as the proxy for non-durable goods due to its affordability and widespread daily consumption in Singapore. Consumers vary their spending levels by selecting the different quantities and types of dishes, making *caifan* a suitable benchmark to gauge non-durable goods spending behaviour. Washing machines were selected as the proxy for durable goods as they represent a common household appliance purchase that involves significant financial commitment and can be deferred. This makes them ideal to capture shifts in major, durable goods spending behaviour. The survey was conducted via Google Forms with personal connections and members of the public, from 27 to 31 March 2026. A total of 85 responses were collected, 42 negative-framed and 43 positive-framed.

Findings/Results

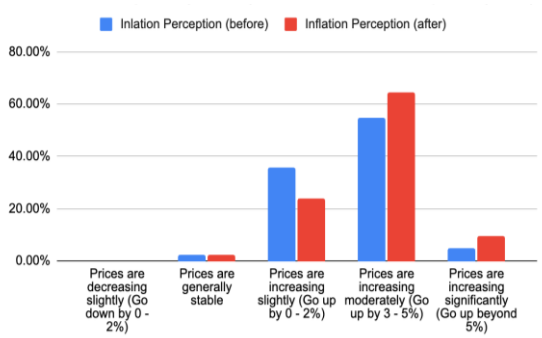
This section presents the results of the study by comparing respondents' inflation perceptions and spending behaviour before and after exposure to different media framing conditions. Descriptive statistics (percentages) are used to highlight key changes across conditions.

4.1 *Negative Framing:* A total of 42 respondents (18 working adults; 24 university students)

Figure 4.1.a shows respondents' inflation expectations before and after viewing the negatively framed media post. Before viewing the post, 54.8% of respondents believed that prices in Singapore would

increase moderately by 3-5% in the next 12 months. After viewing the post, this proportion rose to 64.3%, indicating prices to increase moderately by 3-5%.

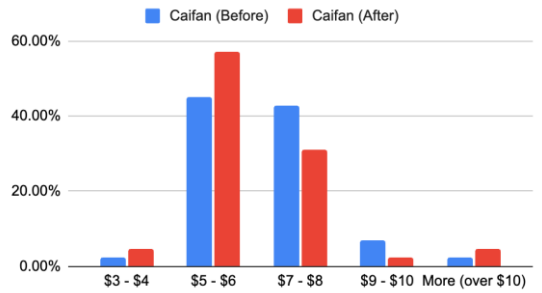
Figure 4.1.a: Inflation Perception Before/After Negative Media Post



Note: The x-axis represents categories of expected price changes, while the y-axis represents the percentage of respondents.

Figure 4.1.b shows respondents' acceptable price range for non-durable goods, using *caifan* (mixed rice) as an example, before and after viewing the negatively framed post. Before viewing the post, the largest proportion of respondents, 45.2%, were willing to pay ($5–$6), followed by 42.9% at ($7–$8); the remaining price categories accounted for relatively small proportions. After viewing the post, the largest proportion increased to 57.1% for ($5–$6), whereas the proportion selecting ($7–$8) decreased to 31.0%. The other price categories stayed relatively small. Overall, ($5-$6) and ($7-$8) were price ranges that showed the most changes.

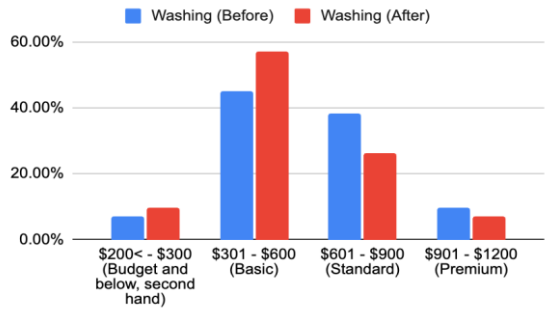
Figure 4.1.b: Non-Durable Goods Spending (E.g. *Caifan*) Before/After Negative Media Post



Note: The x-axis represents price categories for non-durable goods (e.g. caifan) in SGD, while the y-axis represents the percentage of respondents.

Figure 4.1.c shows respondents' acceptable spending range for durable goods, using washing machines as an example, before and after viewing the negatively framed post. Before viewing the post, 45.2% of respondents preferred spending ($301-$600) on a basic washing machine, while 38.1% were willing to spend ($601-$900) for a standard washing machine. After viewing the post, responses increased to 57.1% for ($301-$600), but responses decreased to 26.2% for ($601-$900).

Figure 4.1.c: Durable Goods Spending (E.g. Washing Machine) Before/After Negative Media Post

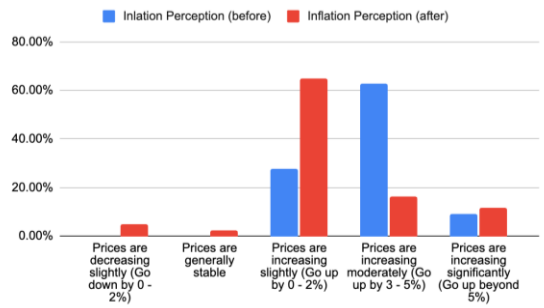


Note: The x-axis represents price categories for durable goods (e.g. washing machine) in SGD, while the y-axis represents the percentage of respondents.

4.2 *Positive Framing*: A total of 43 respondents (21 working adults; 22 university students).

Figure 4.2.a shows respondents' inflation perception before and after viewing the positively framed media post. Before viewing the post, 62.8% of respondents believed that prices in Singapore would increase moderately by 3-5% in the next 12 months. After viewing the post, this proportion fell to 16.3%, indicating prices to increase moderately by 3-5%.

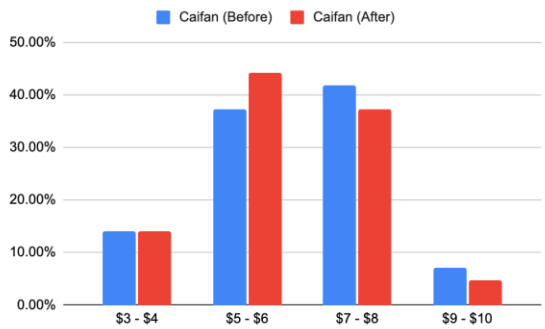
Figure 4.2.a: Inflation Perception Before/After Positive Media Post



Note: The x-axis represents categories of expected price changes, while the y-axis represents the percentage of respondents.

Figure 4.2.b shows respondents' acceptable price range of non-durable goods, using *caifan* (mixed rice) as an example, before and after viewing the positively framed post. Before viewing the post, the largest proportion of respondents, 41.9%, were willing to pay ($7-$8), followed by 37.2% at ($5 - $6); the remaining price categories accounted for relatively small proportions. After viewing the post, the proportion increased to 44.2% for ($5-$6), whereas selection dropped to 37.2% for ($7 - $8). The other price categories stayed relatively small. Overall, ($5-$6) and ($7-$8) were the most selected price ranges.

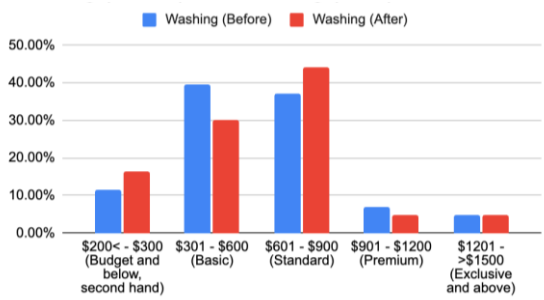
Figure 4.2.b: Non-Durable Goods Spending (E.g. *Caifan*) Before/After Positive Media Post



Note: The x-axis represents price categories for non-durable goods (e.g. caifan) in SGD, while the y-axis represents the percentage of respondents.

Figure 4.2.c shows respondents' willingness to spend on durable goods using washing machines as an example, before and after viewing the positively framed post. Before viewing the post, 39.5% of respondents preferred spending ($301-$600) on a basic washing machine, while 37.2% were willing to spend ($601-$900) for a standard washing machine. After viewing the post, responses decreased to 30.2% for ($301-$600), but responses increased to 44.2% for ($601-$900).

Figure 4.2.c: Durable Goods Spending (E.g. Washing Machine) Before/After Positive Media Post



Note: The x-axis represents price categories for durable goods (e.g. washing machine) in SGD,while the y-axis represents the percentage of respondents.

Discussion

Our study asks: "To what extent does online media message framing affect the individual's inflation perception and expected consumer behaviour in Singapore?"

According to our results, an individual's inflation perception is highly sensitive to the media frame they consume. This is supported by respondents correctly identifying the intended media messages' frame. Exposure to positively framed media messages reflects reduced inflation bias, a shift in responses from 62.8% to 16.3% who predicted a moderate increase in prices. Conversely, negatively framed media messages exacerbated inflation bias, with responses increasing from 54.8% to 64.3% who

predicted a moderate increase in prices. This reinforces existing studies on the relationship between online media message framing and inflation bias – a component of inflation perception (Ehrmann et al., 2017; Lamla & Lein, 2014). Subsequently, our data supports Burke and Ozdagli's (2023) claim that inflation perception has a greater impact on durable goods than non-durable goods, as parallels are observed across both positive frame and negative frame media messages. Specifically, non-durable goods (e.g. *caifan*) spending reflected an overall decrease in both framing conditions, suggesting that individuals generally reduce their willingness to spend when exposed to inflation-related media. Contrasting this, durable goods (e.g. washing machines) spending increased in positive-framing but decreased in negative-framing, indicating that spending is conditional on the individual's outlook about future economic conditions.

Interestingly, while Burke and Ozdagli (2023) find that among college-educated individuals, non-durable goods spending remains largely unchanged, our findings indicate that non-durable goods spending is also affected. Conversely, while Burke and Ozdagli (2023) find that durable goods spending increases with rising inflation expectations, our findings indicate that durable goods spending is conditional on both the media framing and inflation perception. Thus, our study examined this phenomenon with an additional lens, media framing, and found that consumer behaviour may be more conditionally sensitive to online media message framing.

These results provide new insights into the relationship between online media message framing, inflation perception, and consumer behaviour. As macroeconomic stability depends on consumers' spending, this relationship hints that media outlets may significantly alter future economic outcomes. With online media's wide reach, different frames may shift consumer behaviour, potentially leading to reduced spending and weaker economic activity. Therefore, media outlets should exercise great caution in framing inflation-related content in a more positive light or a neutral tone.

A key limitation of this study is its generalisability. First, our sample consists primarily of Singapore-based respondents who potentially exhibit low spending and high saving behaviour (Ye et al., 2021). Thus, a decrease in non-durable goods spending could reflect an innate cultural or regional saving preference rather than being solely influenced by online media message framing. Nonetheless, observed changes in durable goods spending hint that individuals still respond to media message framing by adjusting larger financial decisions. Second, since quota and convenience sampling were used, the respondents may not fully represent the wider population. Since many participants were recruited through personal networks, the sample may be biased towards individuals with similar backgrounds, reducing overall representativeness.

Conclusion

This study investigated how differing online media messaging frames affect an individual's inflation perception and the consequent impact on their expected consumer behaviour in Singapore. This paper demonstrates that exposure to positively or negatively framed online media messages reduces or increases inflation bias, respectively. This highlights a receptive shift in inflation perception according to the consumed media frame. In contrast, changes in consumer behaviour remain conditional on the type of goods. Non-durable goods spending decreased in both framing conditions, whereas durable goods spending was conditional on both the media frame and inflation perception.

These findings contribute to the understanding of consumer decision-making by demonstrating that media framing influences not only inflation perceptions, but also the extent to which these perceptions translate into spending intentions. Specifically, the results suggest that consumers do not respond uniformly to inflation-related information; instead, their behavioural responses are moderated by the type of goods being considered. This extends existing literature on media framing by highlighting the complex relationship between information framing, economic perceptions, and consumption decisions.

The analysis suggests that while online media message framing is responsible for shifts in inflation perception, changes in consumer behaviour differ based on the type of good, media framing, and inflation perception taken together. Nevertheless, the study's prime limitation is its generalisability. As the sample is largely limited to the Singapore-based demographic, who potentially exhibit strong saving behaviour, future research could explore how different demographic groups respond to different online media message framing.

Overall, this study sheds light on the dynamic role online media message framing has in shaping inflation perception and, subsequently, influencing consumers' spending behaviour. Thus, this paper advises media outlets to exercise great caution in framing inflation-related content in a more positive light or a neutral tone.

Acknowledgements

We would like to express our sincere gratitude to our tutor, Dr Hsieh Yi-Chin, for her invaluable guidance and support throughout this research project. Her advice on the research design, questionnaire development, data analysis, and academic writing greatly improved the quality of our study. We are especially grateful for her constructive feedback, insightful suggestions, and continuous encouragement, which guided us throughout the research process.

We would also like to thank all the respondents who generously took the time to complete our questionnaire. Their participation and valuable responses provided the foundation for this study.

Finally, we would like to express our appreciation for the teamwork, commitment, and mutual support shared among the three of us throughout this project. Through close collaboration at every stage of the research —from questionnaire design and data collection to data analysis and report writing— we were able to overcome challenges and successfully complete this study.

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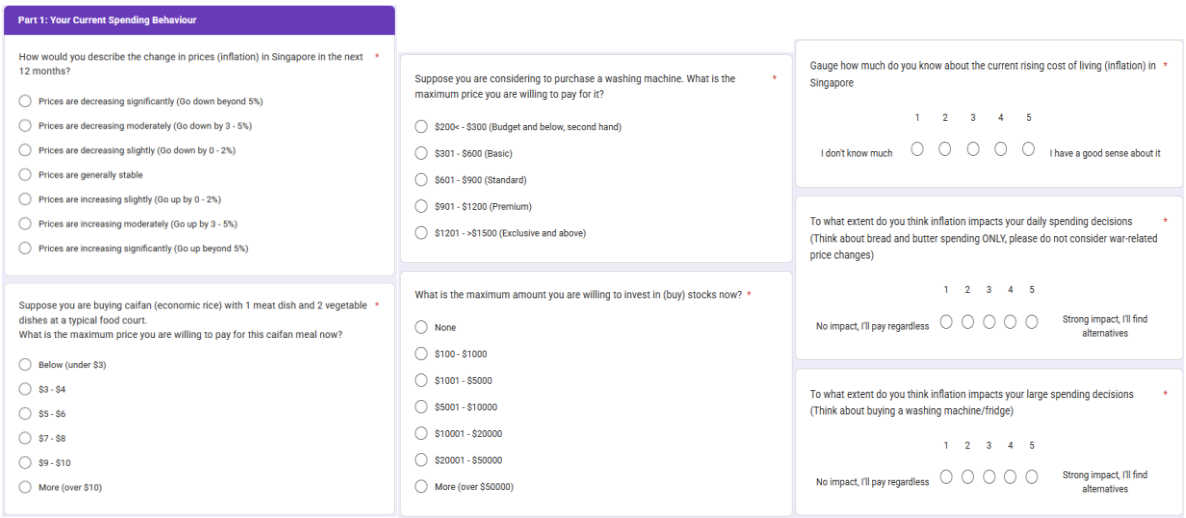
Appendix

Survey Links:

Negative Framing: https://docs.google.com/forms/d/e/1FAIpQLSdjDIX_rj5jSn1DR1nPJA3VI7gOM1GkOJmLorpABBiMHqqSrQ/viewform

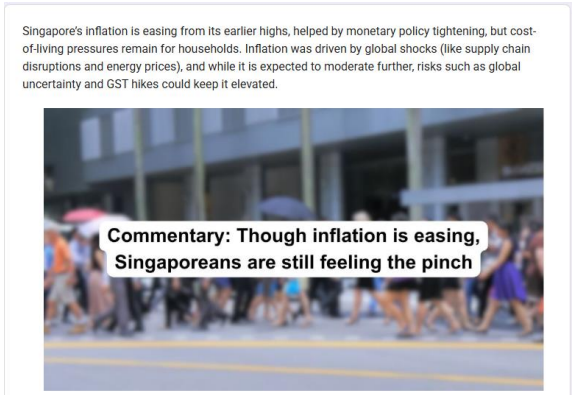
Positive Framing: https://docs.google.com/forms/d/e/1FAIpQLScosdR8NWUrqYLf0z7ejqaC3hEUsy5rOXcdti-nRZVBhoIJyA/viewform

Survey Questions (Part 1) [Same Pre-reading questions for both frames, from Left to Right]

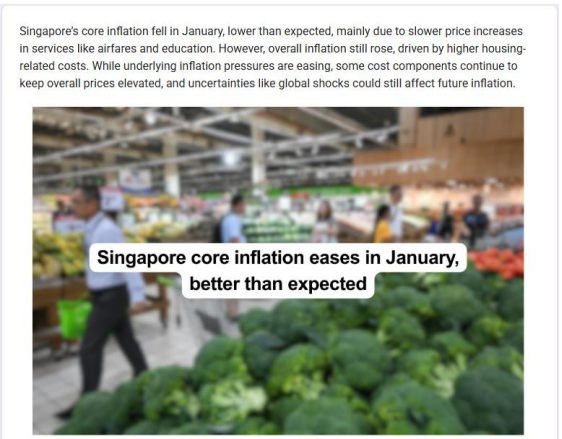


Survey Questions (Part 2) [Exposure to framed online media on inflation]

[Negative-Framing]



[Positive-Framing]



Singapore's core inflation dropped sharply in 2025, reflecting a broad easing of price pressures compared to previous years. However, this relief may be temporary, as inflation is expected to rise again in 2026 due to factors like higher labour costs, steady domestic demand, and slower declines in imported costs. Overall, while inflation has cooled significantly, underlying pressures suggest a gradual pickup ahead.

Singapore's inflation is showing clear signs of moderating, with slower price increases across areas like food and retail, and even declines in some categories. However, certain sectors—such as healthcare, tourism-related services, and government-administered costs—continue to drive price pressures. While progress has been made and inflation is moving in the right direction, risks from global events and structural factors mean it is still too early to say the problem is fully resolved.

After viewing these posts, select one option which best represents how do you think both these posts are framed/sounds like? *

- Negative framing, these posts suggest inflation is headed in the wrong direction
- Neutral framing, these posts suggest inflation is headed in a stable direction
- Positive framing, these posts suggest inflation is headed in the right direction

After viewing these posts, how do you feel about the future regarding your cost of living? *

- More worried for the future as cost of living is increasing significantly
- Slightly worried for the future as cost of living is increasing slightly
- Not so worried for the future as cost of living will remain generally stable

After viewing these posts, how do you feel about your spending behaviour in the next 12 months? *

- I will reduce my current spending behaviour significantly in the next 12 months
- I will reduce my current spending behaviour slightly in the next 12 months
- I will maintain my current spending behaviour in the next 12 months
- I will increase my current spending behaviour slightly in the next 12 months
- I will increase my current spending behaviour significantly in the next 12 months

Survey Questions (Part 3) [Same Post-reading questions for both frames, from Left to Right]

Part 3: Perception and Expected Behaviour

After viewing online media posts above, please select the response that best matches your feelings and expectations.

After viewing the post, how would you describe the change in prices (inflation) in Singapore in the next 12 months? *

- Prices will decrease significantly (Go down beyond 5%)
- Prices will decrease moderately (Go down by 3 - 5%)
- Prices will decrease slightly (Go down by 0 - 2%)
- Prices will remain generally stable
- Prices will increase slightly (Go up by 0 - 2%)
- Prices will increase moderately (Go up by 3 - 5%)
- Prices will increase significantly (Go up beyond 5%)

Suppose you are buying caifan (economic rice) with 1 meat dish and 2 vegetable dishes at a typical food court.
After viewing the post, what is the maximum price you are willing to pay for this caifan meal? *

- Below (under $3)
- $3 - $4
- $5 - $6
- $7 - $8
- $9 - $10
- More (over $10)

Suppose you are considering to purchase a washing machine. After viewing the post, what is the maximum price you are willing to pay for it? *

- $200< - $300 (Budget and below, second hand)
- $301 - $600 (Basic)
- $601 - $900 (Standard)
- $901 - $1200 (Premium)
- $1201 - >$1500 (Exclusive and above)

After viewing the post, what is the maximum amount you are willing to invest in (buy) stocks now? *

- None
- $100 - $1000
- $1001 - $5000
- $5001 - $10000
- $10001 - $20000
- $20001 - $50000
- More (over $50000)

After viewing the post, besides the mentioned changes in your spending behaviour change, do you have any additional comments? *

Your answer

Do you have any additional thoughts about the post? *

Your answer

Survey Questions (Part 4) [Same question about the respondent's demographic for both frames]

Part 4: We want to know more about you!

All responses are anonymous and used for academic purposes only.

Which of the following best describes you? *

- University Student
- Working adult

Survey Results (Negative) - Left = Pre-Reading results, Right = Post-Reading results

How would you describe the change in prices (inflation) in Singapore in the next 12 months?

42 responses

After viewing the post, how would you describe the change in prices (inflation) in Singapore in the next 12 months?

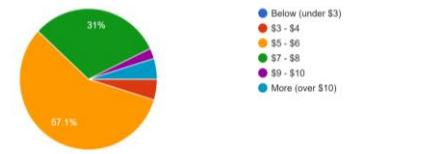
42 responses

Suppose you are buying caifan (economic rice) with 1 meat dish and 2 vegetable dishes at a typical food court. What is the maximum price you are willing to pay for this caifan meal now?

42 responses

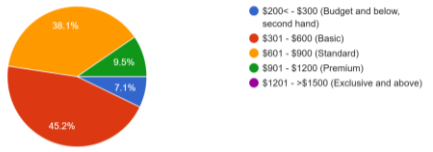
Suppose you are buying caifan (economic rice) with 1 meat dish and 2 vegetable dishes at a typical food court. After viewing the post, what is the maxi...m price you are willing to pay for this caifan meal?

42 responses



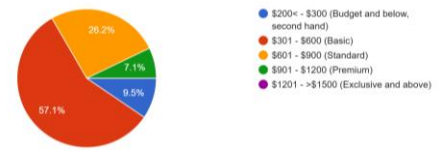
Suppose you are considering to purchase a washing machine. What is the maximum price you are willing to pay for it?

42 responses



Suppose you are considering to purchase a washing machine. After viewing the post, what is the maximum price you are willing to pay for it?

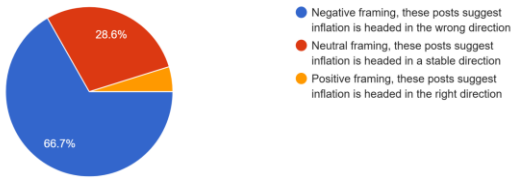
42 responses



Respondents correctly identified the intended media messages' frame.

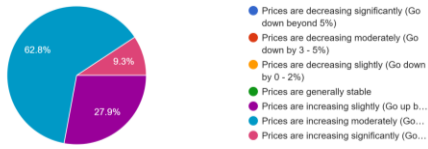
After viewing these posts, select one option which best represents how do you think both these posts are framed/sounds like?

42 responses

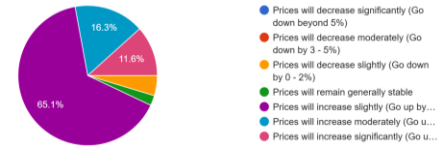


Survey Results (Positive) - Left = Pre-Reading results, Right = Post-Reading results

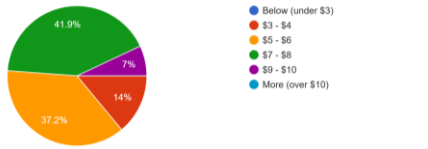
How would you describe the change in prices (inflation) in Singapore in the next 12 months?
43 responses



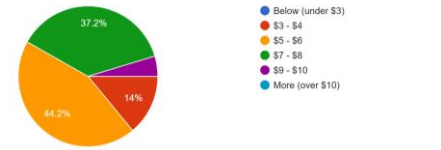
After viewing the post, how would you describe the change in prices (inflation) in Singapore in the next 12 months?
43 responses



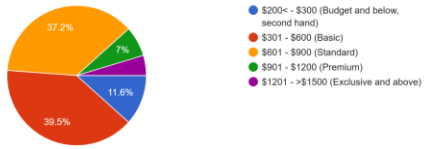
Suppose you are buying caifan (economic rice) with 1 meat dish and 2 vegetable dishes at a typical food court. What is the maximum price you are willing to pay for this caifan meal now?
43 responses



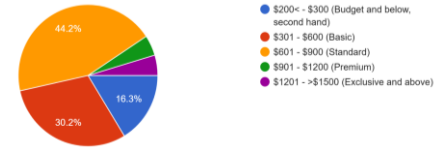
Suppose you are buying caifan (economic rice) with 1 meat dish and 2 vegetable dishes at a typical food court. After viewing the post, what is the maxi...m price you are willing to pay for this caifan meal?
43 responses



Suppose you are considering to purchase a washing machine. What is the maximum price you are willing to pay for it?
43 responses

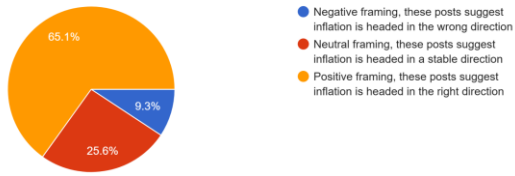


Suppose you are considering to purchase a washing machine. After viewing the post, what is the maximum price you are willing to pay for it?
43 responses



Respondents correctly identified the intended media messages' frame.

After viewing these posts, select one option which best represents how do you think both these posts are framed/sounds like?
43 responses



Assessing the Effectiveness of Financial Education on Financial Behaviour Among Undergraduates in Singapore

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Financial behaviour is defined as how one regularly manages money in practice, such as through budgeting and saving (Johan et al., 2021). Financial education, as defined by Brugiavini et al. (2020) refers to programs aimed at educating people on basic financial notions. While some research indicates financial education as the key to improving financial behaviour, other research casts doubt on whether such programmes are effective (Johan et al., 2021; Khalisharani et al., 2022). Examining this phenomenon has great relevance to the undergraduate population as undergraduates tend to form long-lasting financial habits during their years of study (Danahy et al., 2024). It is thus vital to identify methods to improve their financial behaviour during this formative stage. Most notably, there exists a dearth of research in the Singaporean undergraduate context. Our paper seeks to fill this gap and bring clarity to the extent in which financial education in undergraduate courses influences financial decision-making among undergraduates in Singapore.

This paper first reviews existing literature on financial education and its relationship with financial behaviour among undergraduates, before outlining the methodology used to study this phenomenon in the Singaporean context. The findings are then presented and discussed, followed by a conclusion on the implications for financial education policy and practice.

Literature Review

Existing literature has studied the impact of financial education on financial knowledge and behaviour among wide demographics such as the general adult population (Skimmyhorn, 2016; Song, 2019). However, findings from the general adult population cannot be directly generalised to university students, who differ in levels of financial independence, income, and financial responsibilities. Yet, literature on the undergraduate context is largely inconclusive on the extent that financial education improves financial behaviour. While Brugiavini et al. (2020) and Johan et al. (2021) found that undergraduates who received financial education tend to score significantly higher on standardised literacy assessments covering key financial indicators, they remain uncertain on the impact of financial education on financial behaviour. These studies also directly support Kaiser and Menkhoff's (2017) conclusion that financial education improves financial literacy, but they are not conclusive on whether undergraduates altered their actual financial behaviour positively. Therefore, there remains a significant gap in the literature, where the exact impact of financial education on improved

financial decision-making among undergraduates is still relatively unknown.

Studies have tried to uncover the impact of financial education on financial behaviour among undergraduates and have led to mixed findings. Khalisharani et al. (2022) found a positive association between financial education and behaviour from a sample consisting of Malaysian and Indonesian undergraduates, whereas Johan et al. (2021) found no significant financial behavioural change among Indonesian undergraduates despite measurable gains in financial knowledge. This difference may be explained by the different relationships examined in the two studies. Khalisharani et al. (2022) focused on the association between students' existing financial education and their self-reported financial behaviour, whereas Johan et al. (2021) examined whether participation in a formal financial education course resulted in behavioural change. Therefore, the positive association reported by Khalisharani et al. (2022) does not necessarily demonstrate that financial education directly caused better financial behaviour. Johan et al.'s (2021) findings further suggest that improvements in financial knowledge may not immediately translate into changes in students' actual financial practices.

In summary, these studies reveal a consistent but incomplete picture. Financial education reliably improves financial literacy (Johan et al., 2021; Brugiavini et al., 2020; Kaiser & Menkhoff, 2017), but no conclusions can be made on its impact on financial behaviour (Khalisharani et al., 2022; Johan et al., 2021). Studies on Malaysian and Indonesian undergraduates are not generalisable to the local Singaporean context due to different education systems and socioeconomic conditions (Cannistrà et al., 2024). Furthermore, there is no study in Singapore directly examining whether financial education is associated with changes in financial behaviour among undergraduates. This gap leads to the following research question: "To what extent does financial education in university impact financial decision-making among undergraduates in Singapore?"

Methodology

This study aims to examine the level of prudent financial decision-making among undergraduates in one Singaporean university and analyse the potential impacts of financial education on financial behaviour. For this study, we have decided to sample students from Nanyang Technological University (NTU). NTU offers formal, structured financial education in terms of bachelor's degrees and postgraduate degrees in economics and business courses (Nanyang Technological University, n.d.). Students may also access financial education through the NTU Investment Interactive Club which hosts large-scale events to promote financial literacy amongst students and provides foundational Invest Academy training to help students master budgeting, investing, and wealth-building (NTUSU, 2025). Our analysis focuses on three aspects: financial knowledge, decision-making and financial behaviour.

Our research adopts a quantitative approach through a survey that includes close-ended questions and short open-ended questions. This method was chosen to enable comparison of patterns and trends across different participant categories. The survey (see Appendix A) was split into 4 sections containing a total of 13 questions. The first section aimed to understand respondents' profiles, including year of study, financial education, and gender. The remaining 3 sections focused on testing respondents' understanding of financial concepts such as inflation and asset diversification as well as their application of financial knowledge through scenario-based questions.

The sampling method used was the purposive snowball sampling method. We first distributed the

survey to undergraduates from different schools then requested their assistance to send the survey out to fellow undergraduates in specific targeted majors in their schools. This ensured we had a diverse sample of undergraduates from different majors and prevented sampling bias.

Findings

Data from the survey was collected from a sample of 86 undergraduates across different academic majors and academic years, with 49 male undergraduates and 37 female undergraduates. When analysing the survey, responses were segmented into 2 groups: 33 undergraduates who received financial education from their major or external financial courses and 53 undergraduates who did not receive any financial education. This allowed us to investigate any relationship between financial education and prudent financial decision-making among undergraduates in Singapore.

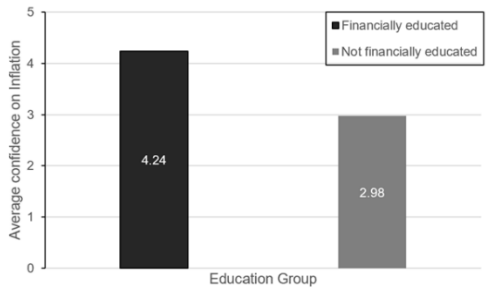
Conceptual Knowledge

Respondents were first asked to rank their confidence level in understanding financial concepts like inflation and asset diversification, then tested on their actual understanding of the concepts itself. This was to test undergraduates' genuine financial knowledge and prevent overconfidence or under-confidence from skewing the findings.

From Figure 1.1, financially educated undergraduates clearly reflect higher confidence (50%) than non-financially educated undergraduates in understanding inflation.

Figure 1.1

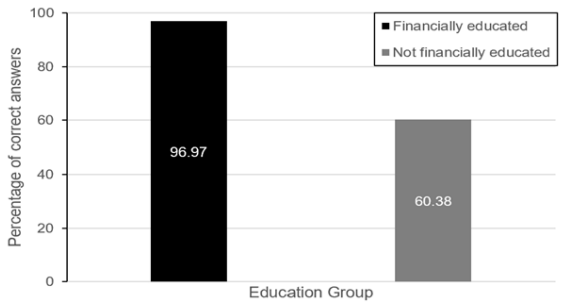
Average confidence level of students in understanding inflation with and without financial education



From Figure 1.2, respondents were asked about the impacts of inflation on purchasing power in a savings context (see Appendix A). Financially educated undergraduates have a better understanding of the concept of inflation as they answered about 36% more accurately than non-financially educated undergraduates.

Figure 1.2

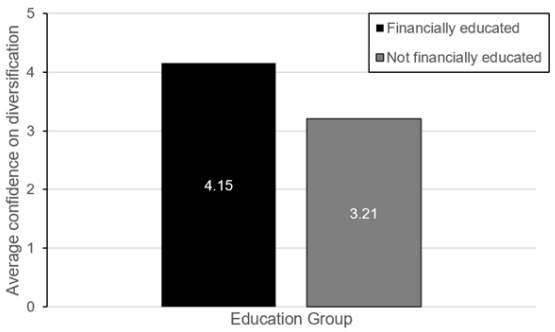
Percentage of correct answers regarding inflation among students with and without financial education



From Figure 2.1, financially educated undergraduates are more confident about the concept of asset diversification than non-financially educated undergraduates by an estimated 30%.

Figure 2.1

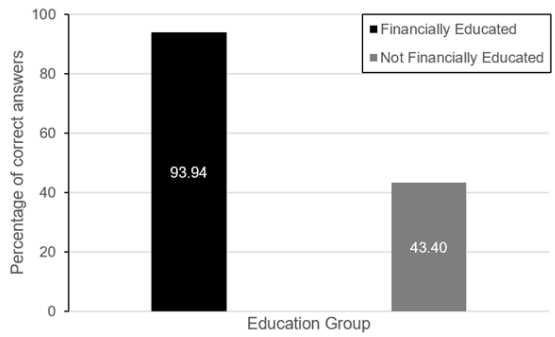
Average confidence level of students in understanding asset diversification with and without financial education



From Figure 2.2, respondents were asked to identify the most accurate statement regarding diversification and its effect on investment risk (see Appendix A). It is evident that financially educated undergraduates have a better grasp of the concept of asset diversification than non-financially educated undergraduates, answering the question correctly more than 50% of the time compared to non-financially educated undergraduates.

Figure 2.2

Percentage of correct answers regarding asset diversification among students with and without financial education



Overall, our findings demonstrate that financial education not only improves an undergraduate's confidence in their understanding of key economic concepts but also improves financial knowledge substantially.

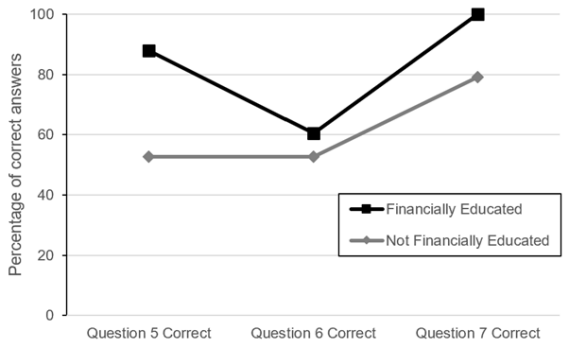
Financial Decisions

Beyond inflation and diversification, respondents were asked several questions regarding financial decisions when liabilities are considered to test their ability to apply their knowledge in practical situations (see Appendix A). Responses from questions 5, 6 and 7 were grouped and the proportion of correct answers was compared across those with and without financial education.

From Figure 3, the difference in accuracy of choosing the right answer narrows. Financially educated undergraduates answered correctly close to 70% of the time while non-financially educated undergraduates answered correctly close to 50% of the time.

Figure 3

Percentage of correct answers regarding prudent financial decision-making among students with and without financial education



Scenario-based Questions

In this section, respondents were asked several scenario-based questions to examine how respondents would make financial decisions in common financial scenarios (see Appendix A). Responses from questions 8 to 12 were grouped and the proportion of correct answers was compared across those with and without financial education.

Figure 4 presents the percentage of financially informed decisions among respondents with and without financial education across multiple scenario-based questions. Overall, respondents with financial education consistently achieved a higher proportion of more financially informed decisions across all questions. However, the difference in proportions between the two groups varies across questions. Most significantly, when asked about their typical response after overspending (see Appendix A), 93.94% of respondents with financial education demonstrated prudent financial behaviour by choosing to reduce spending, while only 47.14% of respondents without financial education displayed this same behaviour. Another interesting takeaway is that only 36.36% of respondents with financial education and 15.09% of respondents without financial education, were able to accurately answer how they should allocate excess cash (see Appendix A).

Figure 4

Percentage of financially informed decisions taken by students with and without financial education

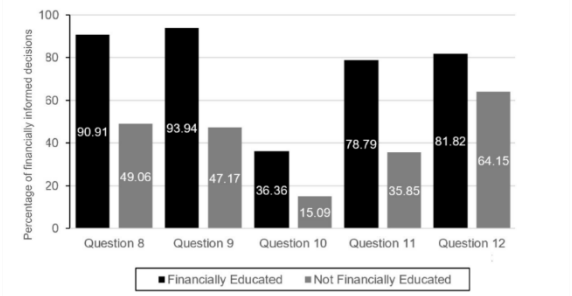
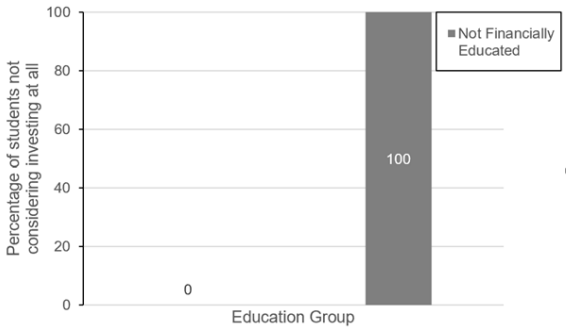


Figure 5 focuses on the results of question 11 of our survey about financial investments and highlights that non-financially educated undergraduates account for all responses which disregarded investing. This is particularly striking as it is the only question within the survey with polarising responses from both education groups.

Figure 5

Percentage of students disregarding investing among students with and without financial education



To summarise, our findings displayed a greater performance of financially educated undergraduates compared to non-financially educated undergraduates in their answering of conceptual and scenario-based questions. This observation remains largely true for all questions except question 10 which focuses on allocation of extra cash at the end of the month, where both groups answered poorly. At least 60% of students from both groups chose options other than paying off high-interest debt which is most damaging to financial health in the long-term (Turunen & Hiilamo, 2014). This pattern was consistent across all academic disciplines, with Nanyang Business School (NBS) undergraduates answering correctly only 17% of the time, College of Computing and Data Science (CCDS) undergraduates at 27%, and College of Engineering (COE) undergraduates at 28%, suggesting that poor performance on this question is not limited to any particular field of study.

Discussion

The results answer a few dimensions of our research question: "To what extent does financial education in university impact financial behaviour among undergraduates in Singapore?" When analysing the survey data, financially educated undergraduates demonstrated better understanding overall,

answering technical questions about 30% more accurately than those without formal financial education (Figure 1.2). This pattern is consistent across both inflation and asset diversification questions, indicating that the positive effect of financial education is not just limited to a specific financial concept. This finding also supports the results of Brugiavini et al. (2020), Johan et al. (2021) and Kaiser and Menkhoff (2017) that financial education improves financial literacy.

However, when respondents were required to apply their understanding to financial decision-making, the gap between the two groups in answering financial decision questions correctly became less pronounced to around 20% (Figure 3). This smaller gap suggests that the impact of financial education on undergraduates weakens when undergraduates have to apply their conceptual understanding to make informed choices. Consequently, this indicates that translating one's financial knowledge into correct financial decisions involves greater complexity, and that there may be other factors that shape one's decision. An example includes familial influences, which shapes an individual's financial behaviour and attitude (Gudmunson & Danes, 2011).

For scenario-based questions, financially educated undergraduates consistently displayed more prudent financial decision-making compared to non-financially educated undergraduates. This corroborates with above findings that financial education does indeed improve financial literacy. However, this pattern is not observed across all scenarios. Both financially and non-financially educated undergraduates were equally likely to avoid borrowing money from friends or family during emergencies and before big purchases, possibly demonstrating a certain social norm in Singapore against borrowing behaviour (Chong, 2023). A further breakdown by academic discipline reveals that NBS undergraduates demonstrated the strongest overall financial decision-making performance across scenario-based questions (71.7% accuracy), while CCDS undergraduates scored the lowest (48.0%). This pattern is consistent with the expectation that business-oriented curricula provide greater exposure to practical financial concepts. It should be noted, however, that sample sizes per school are small (NBS n=12, CCDS, n=15) and these findings should therefore be considered indicative rather than conclusive (see Appendix B).

A notable observation from responses to question 11 about financial investments was that non-financially educated undergraduates were more likely to completely avoid investing when it came to not having enough information about the topic. Financially educated undergraduates were more likely to research independently when faced with uncertainty or lack of knowledge compared to non-financially educated undergraduates. This displays that familiarity with financial education is important and exposure to financial topics can strengthen undergraduates' confidence and proclivity to search for more information when it comes to dealing with financial investing (Lind et al., 2020; Barua et al., 2018).

As aforementioned, all undergraduates regardless of financial education performed poorly when asked for their response in allocating extra cash at the end of the month. The small proportion of undergraduates that chose to pay off high-interest debt show a lack of understanding of how debt accumulates rapidly through interest. This may be a symptom of short-sightedness when it comes to financial decision-making as undergraduates might overlook long-term financial costs. Furthermore, a broader implication of this is that financial education alone may be insufficient in optimising one's financial behaviour. In this regard, other factors such as individual

preferences and prior experiences may need to be further explored.

A limitation of our study is it fails to consider the effect of informal financial education on non-tertiary level undergraduates such as high school undergraduates. The use of surveys could also lead to social desirability bias with respondents choosing answers that reflect better on them rather than accurate descriptions of their behaviour in certain financial situations. Hence, as responses to scenario-based questions reflect intended rather than actual behaviour, findings should be interpreted as indicative of financial decision-making tendencies rather than definitive measures of real-world financial behaviour. Future studies may consider studying a sample of non-tertiary undergraduates or consider non-formal financial education such as family education, social media or AI. Instead of using surveys, the use of experiments may also be a better measure of accurate financial behaviour.

Conclusion

In conclusion, our study analyses the extent that financial education in undergraduate courses influences financial decision-making among undergraduates in Singapore. We conclude that financial education has a positive effect on financial knowledge and is associated with more prudent financial decision-making among undergraduates. This could be attributed to financial education familiarising undergraduates with financial terms and confidence in making financial decisions. Consequently, institutions should promote financial education for undergraduates across majors to foster a basic understanding of financial knowledge to promote sound financial decision-making and greater confidence when making financial decisions. However, financial education alone is not sufficient in enabling undergraduates to make financially-sound decisions. Hence, alternative solutions such as hands-on financial managing experience may be possible complementary solutions in promoting informed financial decision-making amongst undergraduates.

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Appendix

Appendix A

Survey Questions

Section A: Demographic Information

Which school / college are you from?

- College of Humanities, Arts and Social Sciences
- Nanyang Business School
- College of Science
- National Institute of Education
- College of Computing and Data Science
- College of Engineering
- Other: _____

Gender

- Male
- Female
- Other: _____

What is your degree? (including double majors, second majors and minors)

- Open-ended response

Have you taken a finance-related course whether within or outside of NTU?

- Yes
- No

Which year of study are you in?

- Year 1
- Year 2
- Year 3
- Year 4
- Other: _____

Section B: Conceptual Knowledge

Q1. Rate your understanding of inflation, with 1 being least confident and 5 being most confident.

- 1 (Least confident)
- 2
- 3
- 4
- 5 (Most confident)

Q2. You have $1000 in a savings account accruing 2% interest per year. Inflation is reported to be at 4% per year. What happens next year?

- My purchasing power has decreased
- My purchasing power remains the same
- My purchasing power has increased
- My savings account appreciates in value and is worth more than $1000

Q3. Rate your understanding of asset diversification, with 1 being least confident and 5 being most confident.

- 1 (Least confident)
- 2
- 3
- 4
- 5 (Most confident)

Q4. Which of the following statements is the most accurate regarding investment decisions?

- I should put all my money into one single asset (e.g. stock) if I see that it is performing well
- Diversifying investments into different assets reduces overall risk
- Diversifying investments into different assets guarantees higher returns
- I should avoid investing altogether to eliminate any risk

Section B: Financial Decision

Q5. You have credit debt accrued with high interest. What is the best action you can undertake?

- Pay only the minimum to service the debt
- Take another loan to service the debt
- Repay as much of the debt as possible quickly
- Ignore it as long as there is no legal action involved

Q6. You are offered a student loan with low interest. What is the MOST important consideration?

- Monthly repayment amount
- Total interest paid over time

Q7. For emergencies such as a sudden loss of income, how should you prepare adequately?

- Invest all money in speculative assets for higher returns
- Keep at least 6 months of monthly expenses in savings
- Use credit cards to supplement spending
- Borrow from relatives and friends

Section C: Scenario-based Questions

Q8. You suddenly receive an unexpected sum of $1 million. What are you MOST likely to do?

- Go on a trip to reward yourself
- Save / invest most of it
- Buy more lottery tickets
- Reward myself or friends and family with gifts

Q9. At the end of the month, you notice that you have overspent. What do you usually do?

- Continue spending to maintain quality of life
- Spend less next month
- Cover extra expenses with credit cards
- Borrow from others
- Ask parents for more money

Q10. You have extra cash this month. What do you usually do?

- Spend it
- Pay off high-interest debt
- Keep it as cash for next month
- Invest in a stock

Q11. Your friends are investing in a stock you've never heard of before. What are you most likely to do?

- Invest because I trust my friends
- Research independently before deciding
- Don't think about investing
- Ask friends for advice

Q12. You are planning a big purchase (e.g. phone). What do you usually do in preparation?

- Buy and pay using instalments
- Save up before buying
- Wait for a discount
- Borrow money from friends
- Ask parents for money

Section D: Short-Open Ended Question

Q13. Have you ever been in debt? If yes, why?

Examples of participant responses (anonymised; for illustration only):

- No, I've always made sure to save up before making big purchases and deferring purchases until I can afford them.
- Yes, debt such as in payable amounts for purchases like phones but not in the red zone in terms of balance.
- Yes, student loans to pay off school fees.

Appendix B

Additional Diagrams

Figure B1

Percentage of financially informed decisions made across scenario-based questions by school/college